Heirs of Etheria

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29709180.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warnings:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Major Character Death, No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Shiri/Finn, Shiri/Alejandro, Zimri/Marmoris, Lexie/Calliope, Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), Musa/Ronen, Haevyn/Circe, Brio/Callista

Characters:
Shiri, Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Zimri, Marmoris, Halina, Nicaise, Shimmer, Archer, Flora, Sereia - Character, Haevyn, Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Castaspella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Calliope, Lexie, Musa, Ronen, Brio - Character, Callista, Eira, Razz (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Inspired by She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Original Characters - Freeform, Original Fiction, The Fright Zone (She-Ra), Musicia, Salineas, plumeria - Freeform, Etheria - Freeform, the heart of etheria, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Drug Use, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied Sexual Content, Dryl, Fluff and Angst, Fluff and Hurt/Comfort, Life in the Horde (She-Ra), Alternate Universe, Bright Moon (She-Ra), Crystal Castle, The First Ones (She-Ra), Useless Lesbians, Lesbian Disaster, Visions, Future Visions, Clubbing, Snows, Magic

Language:
English

Series:
Part 3 of The Lost Kingdom of Etheria

Stats:
Published: 2021-02-26 Completed: 2021-05-05 Words: 98,321 Chapters: 28/28

Heirs of Etheria

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29709180.

Rating:

Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warnings:

Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Major Character Death, No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:

F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M

Fandom:

She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:

Shiri/Finn, Shiri/Alejandro, Zimri/Marmoris, Lexie/Calliope, Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), Musa/Ronen, Haevyn/Circe, Brio/Callista

Characters:

Shiri, Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Zimri, Marmoris, Halina, Nicaise, Shimmer, Archer, Flora, Sereia - Character, Haevyn, Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Castaspella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Calliope, Lexie, Musa, Ronen, Brio - Character, Callista, Eira, Razz (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:

Inspired by She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Original Characters - Freeform, Original Fiction, The Fright Zone (She-

Ra), Musicia, Salineas, plumeria - Freeform, Etheria - Freeform, the heart of etheria, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Drug Use, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied Sexual Content, Dryl, Fluff and Angst, Fluff and Hurt/Comfort, Life in the Horde (She-Ra), Alternate Universe, Bright Moon (She-Ra), Crystal Castle, The First Ones (She-Ra), Useless Lesbians, Lesbian Disaster, Visions, Future Visions, Clubbing, Snows, Magic

Language:
English

Series:
Part 3 of The Lost Kingdom of Etheria

Stats:
Published: 2021-02-26 Completed: 2021-05-05 Words: 98,321
Chapters: 28/28

Heirs of Etheria

by Pisces_Princess

Summary

Three years after the death of her mom, Shiri is spiraling out of control. Her life has become a blur of clubbing, drinking, and sex to suppress her powers and her grief as she has become involved with a notorious gang leader.

Finn doesn't want to be like their family. They wants to travel the universe, no attachments and no worries, not since losing his long-standing crush, Shiri.

Fate has them reunite at a club years after they lost saw each other. Will they allow love back into their lives after losing so much? It seems there are forces stronger than them at play.

Notes

Thank you all for reading! This is the sequel to my first book, The Power in You, and takes place 27 years after the original story!

I also have a one-shot book that accounts for the lives of our favorite characters within those 27 years called The Power in You: One-Shots! Check it out, it goes into more depth about a lot of our characters!

Enjoy!!

Chapter 1

Chapter One

Shiri looked at herself in the tall mirror, tracing the bright red tube of lipstick around her lips until they popped against her pale complexion. She puckered her lips, leaning back to inspect her handiwork. Her black hair hung loosely around her face, a single white strand among the ebony waves, and stopped just below her chin. She tussled it, trying to give it a sexy, bad girl look. Her chocolate brown eyes were framed by heavy eyeliner and mascara.

She ran her hands down her sides, smoothing down the tight, sequined gold dress. It was held up by thin straps, accentuating her breasts, and stopped mid-thigh. She turned around, checking out the backless dress and enjoying the view of her ass in the skin-tight number. Of course, her heels matched. Strappy gold stilettos that gave her an extra five inches of height. She did one more pucker of her lips before she walked away from the mirror.

"Halina! Hurry up! We're supposed to be there by eleven!" she yelled, grabbing her clutch. She hissed softly as pain shot through her temples, a migraine starting to build from not having her injection in a few weeks. Thankfully, Alejandro would be there tonight.

"Relax, sis. Hallie wants to make sure she's perfect. It's not every day she turns eighteen," her twin brother, Zimri, said from the loveseat, his arm wrapped around his husband, Marmoris', shoulders. Zimri was gorgeously handsome, like his sister, with dark black hair that hung long down his shoulders and a white patch sitting on top of his head. Unlike her, he had beautiful blue eyes like their mama. He was strongly built from training with their mom.

His husband, Marmoris, was petite with lovely mocha skin, a short layer of blue hair over his head, and dark green eyes that always

seemed to bore into her soul. Zimri and Marmoris wore black slacks and long-sleeved gold shirts with the buttons partially undone, matching Shiri's gold dress.

"I know but Alejandro is waiting for us. I don't know what's taking her so long, I already did her hair and makeup, it should not take that long to put on an outfit!" Shiri exclaimed, walking over towards the walk-in closet, her heels clicking on the marble floor. "Get your ass out here, Hallie! My man is waiting!"

"I wish you would drop that bum, sis. He's bad news," Zimri warned her and Marmoris snorted beside him.

"Darling, you know she stays with him because of that dick. That is one fine ass man she got," Marmois said, earning a glare from his husband. "Of course not as fine as you, babe," he quickly added, giving him a peck on the lips.

"That's what a thought," Zimri grumbled as Halina finally stepped out of the closet.

Their sister was about seven years younger than them but did not resemble her older siblings as much. Instead of dark tresses, she had inherited her grandmother's white curls, which tumbled down her back one of her shoulders as it was pinned to one side, covering her scarred ear that no longer heard. Her chocolate brown eyes, much like Shiri's, were framed with eyeliner and mascara, and she wore a more muted mauve lipstick.

She nervously patted down her dress, more conservative than her sisters. It was gold, matching the theme of the group, sequined, and reached her knees, and had a halter neckline that wrapped around her throat, a small window exposing only the upper part of her dress. She had opted for some chunky black heels that only gave her a few extra inches but she didn't need them, she was already as tall as her siblings without them.

"Damn girl! Look at you, looking fine as hell! We going to be beating people off her tonight, Z," Marmoris said with a smirk and

Zimri rolled his eyes.

“Do I really have to wear this? I feel… exposed,” Halina said, squirming under everyone’s gaze.

“You look fabulous! Come on, live a little! You haven’t had fun since mama…” Shiri trailed off, the room glooming some over the mention of their mama. She cleared her throat quickly, clapping her hands. “Let’s get going! This club is totally hot! Alejandro said only the best for his girl’s little sister. Drinks are on him tonight, Hallie,” she said, grabbing her sister’s hand and pulling her towards the door.

“What if I don’t want to drink?” Halina asked, frowning as Zimri and Marmoris followed.

“Come on, sourpuss! At least one drink! Then we’ll dance the night away!” Shiri squealed, spinning around in a circle gleefully before reaching for the door. She pulled it open and nearly jumped out of her skin as their mom, Lexie, stood in front of it, her hands on her hips as she raised her eyebrow at them.

“Busted,” Zimri whispered as Marmoris gently elbowed him. Halina swallowed heavily.

“Where do you four think you’re going?” she asked and they all looked at each other, trying to silently communicate an excuse.

“We’re just taking Hallie out for her birthday, mom. We’ll be back in a couple of hours,” Shiri said and Lexie huffed.

“Where are you taking her?” she questioned and Shiri groaned.

“What is this, an interrogation? There’s a new club in Salineas that Sereia asked us to check out with her,” Shiri said, name dropping the princess of Salineas’. Lexie glared, not completely buying her story but not unable to disprove it either.

“Have her home by one, Zimri. One drink, that’s it. No funny business, Shiri,” Lexie warned and Shiri mockingly saluted, pulling

Halina past their mom and out into the hallway.

“Will do, captain!” she told her as Marmoris stepped by and Zimir stopped to give Lexie a kiss on the cheek.

“I’ll keep her in line, mom, you have my word,” he told her and Lexie relaxed a little, smiling up at him. The queen wasn’t as young as she used to be, twenty-seven years did that to a woman. Grey streaks had started forming through her black locks and wrinkles were forming around her brown eyes yet there was still a youthful fire behind her eyes that had never died away.

“Thank you, son. I know I can always count on you,” she said and watched as her children walked away, shaking her head. “You made some wild ones, Callie,” she whispered.

–

In Brightmoon, Finn was pulling their blonde hair back into a half-up bun, their black cat ears and tail twitching with nervous anticipation. They were wearing black slacks with a loose white tank top that exposed their sides, a black tube top showing underneath. They adjusted their red bandana around their neck and flexed their claws through the fingerless gloves they wore.

“Almost ready, Finn? We need to go before our parents find out,” Shimmer said, bouncing on the balls of her feet nervously. She had beautiful light brown skin and ombre purple/brown curly hair with sparkles in it. She wore a short, purple dress that came mid-thigh and had thick straps to hold it up. It was as sparkly as she was. Finn’s blue eyes met her dark ones.

“Yea, I’m ready. You know the plan. This club is a notorious hotbed for gang activity. We need to find the leader of the Desert Rose gang and gather as much information as possible. My moms have not been having any luck stopping the gang violence that’s been rising out of the Crimson Waste,” they explained and Shimmer nodded.

“We need to disguise you, though. Your ears will stick out like a sore thumb,” she explained, untying the bandana from around their neck and wrapping it around their head to pin down their ears. “Is there any way to tuck in that tail?”

“Yea, but it’s going to be uncomfortable,” they whined as they pushed their tail into their slacks. “Don’t forget our masks, this club has a masquerade theme for anonymity.”

Shimmer nodded, grabbing their masks as they heard a knock on the door. They froze, staring as a voice came from the other side.

“Shimmer? What are you doing there? I thought I heard Finn,” they heard someone say and relaxed as Shimmer opened the door to reveal her older brother, Archer. He was big and bulky, with similar features to his sister from his light brown skin to his omber pink hair. He looked past her towards Finn. “What are you two planning?”

“Nothing! Go away! You’re so annoying!” she squeaked as he pushed past her into the room, crossing his arms over his chest.

“Where are you two going dressed like that?” he asked and Finn sighed.

“We’re going to that masquerade club in the Crimson Waste,” they told him and he gasped.

“The one where the Desert Rose gang hangs out?! You guys can’t be serious!” he said.

“Please don’t tell mom and dad! We want to help them capture the gang leader and end the violence!” Shimmer proclaimed and Archer shook his head in annoyance.

“That is ridiculous! I’m coming with you two so you don’t get yourselves killed,” Archer decided with a nod and Shimmer squealed in delight.

“Let’s go then!” She yelled, grabbing both of their arms as she teleported them out of the room in a spray of sparkles.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> Everyone enjoys the club until She-Ra crashes the party. Finn recognizes Shiri but she doesn't recognize him.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 2

The club, known as the Scarlet Jewel, was pulsing with music when the group arrived. The Crimson Waste did not offer much but did have a great nightlife. The lighting was pulsing along with the loud music that drowned out everything, even thoughts. The dance floor was packed with patrons dancing, a platform stationed as an island in the middle where the DJ played, and the bar was full of people drinking. Booths and tables littered the walls, some roped off for the VIP guests. Shiri already felt her hips start to sway.

“Stick with me, guys! Some of these people will eat you alive! And don’t forget your masks!” she yelled over the music as she led them through the club, everyone slipping on their masks as they walked towards the biggest roped-off booth where people were already lounging about. A tall man stood in front of the table, talking with another man. He had blonde hair cropped short, steely gray eyes with a scar spreading over the left one, and a thick build, filling out his clothes nicely.

Shiri squealed. “Alejandro!” she yelled as she lurched herself into his arms, which he caught effortlessly. She wrapped her legs around his waist and kissed him passionately, running her fingers through his hair. When she pulled away, she was panting softly as he held her up by her ass, giving it a small squeeze.

“Damn, you should greet me like that more often,” he smirked, trailing kisses along her jaw as she giggled. Someone cleared their throats and she looked over to her siblings, sighing at the interruption as she unwrapped her legs and slid down off him.

“Alejandro, this is my baby sister, Halina,” she introduced, going over and putting her hands on Halina’s shoulders as she pushed her forward. “It’s her 18th birthday! We came to show her some fun!”

“And fun she shall have. It is a pleasure to meet you, princess,” he said, taking her hand and giving it a kiss that made Halina’s cheeks flare with embarrassment. “Whatever your heart desires tonight, it shall be yours. Anything for my best girl,” he winked at Shiri, who smiled brilliantly.

“Drinks! Carl, bring us a round of drinks, pronto!” she told the henchman standing close to her and he scurried off to the bar. Alejandro took her hand and led her to the booth, sitting down as he pulled her into his lap. Halina sat down beside him, tapping her foot nervously.

“We’re going to go dance for a while, hun,” Marmoris told them as he grabbed Zimri’s hand and pulled him onto the dance floor. She waved at them as Alejandro trailed kisses up her neck. Carl came back a few moments later, handing out the drinks, which Halina took, sniffing it curiously.

“Girl, it’s not going to bite you! Drink it!” Shiri encouraged, taking a drink from her own glass. “Oooh, why doesn’t Ricky go dance with Hallie, Alejandro? I’m sure he will keep her company,” she murmured against his ear and he nodded, snapping his fingers as another man ran over to join them.

“Ricky, this is Halina. I expect that you show her a good time tonight,” he told him and Ricky nodded, holding his hand out for Halina. She looked at her sister, who nodded encouragingly before taking it and being led away to the dance floor. When Halina was

gone, Shiri let her smile drop, sitting down her drinks to press her fingers to her temples as the migraine started increasing tenfold.

“Need your fix, sugar?” Alejandro said as he pulled a small pouch from his pocket, pulling out a small syringe with red liquid inside. Shiri nodded eagerly, moving to straddle his lap. He ran a cool hand up her thigh, giving it a light squeeze before pushing the syringe in, injecting her with the liquid. She hissed softly as he pulled the needle out, capping it and putting it back in the pouch as he handed it to her. Her migraine immediately faded as she took the pouch and stored it in her clutch.

“That’s a few months supply in there. Can’t have you finding an excuse not to see me,” he told her.

“I always want to see you, boss,” she murmured seductively in his ear, pulling him into another kiss.

–

On the other side of the club, Finn, Shimmer, and Archer had entered, taking in the scene.

“We should split up, we’ll be able to cover more ground that way,” Finna said as they put on their masks as well. Archer looked around, eyes stopping on a young girl who looked uncomfortable beside a taller man, who was leaning over her.

“Meet back here in an hour. No drinking, Shimmer,” he warned as he beelined towards the scene. Shimmer groaned, eyeing the bar.

“One drink won’t hurt…” she mumbled to Finn as she veered off towards the bar, leaving them alone to make their way to the dance floor.

As Archer approached the two figures, he was able to hear part of their conversation and he did not like it.

“Come on, baby, let’s dance. Stop being such a prude,” the guy told her, playing with one of her white curls. She jerked away,

frowning.

“I said I didn’t want to, leave me alone,” she told him again and he grabbed her arm, causing her to hiss.

“Listen here, you little bitch…” he started but was stopped when Archer came up beside him, putting his hand on his arm.

“If I was you, I would not finish that sentence. Scram, scum,” Archer told the man, who quickly let go of the girl and ran off. He turned towards her as she rubbed the arm that was grabbed and when her chocolate brown eyes met his dark ones, his breath hitched in his throat.

“I- um… a-are you okay?” he stuttered, blushing. She blushed too and he thought he had never seen a pretty shade of pink.

“Yea… Thank you. I’m Halina,” she said, extending her hand and he took it gently, smiling.

“Like Princess Halina of Musicia?” he questioned and she nodded. “I’m Prince Archer of Brightmoon. It’s been a few years since we’ve seen each other…”

“Oh! I remember you! It’s so nice to see a familiar face here. This has been the worst birthday so far. I really don’t want to be here,” she told him and he frowned.

“It’s your birthday and you’re out doing something you don’t like? That doesn’t make any sense!” he said and she nodded eagerly.

“It was my stupid sister’s idea! She just wanted to meet up with her boyfriend, Alejandro. Guys a real piece of work,” she told him and he mentally noted the name before focusing back on her.

“What would you be doing on your perfect birthday?” he asked and led her over to an empty table, pulling out her chair for her to sit down. She took the seat, smoothing down her dress, and started playing with the hair closest to her ear.

“I’d be back home, curled up in my window bench with a good book. There’d be tea and cake to eat. My baby brother would be curled up on my lap, sleeping… It would be quiet and peaceful,” she explained.

“That does sound perfect. That’s exactly what I would want to do on my birthday, minus the baby brother thing,” he chuckled and she laughed, placing her hand over his. He looked at her hand then back at her, smiling.

–

“Fucking hell, Alejandro! Your goon was supposed to be taking care of her, not pushing himself on her! I want his head!” Shiri snarled, sitting on the table as Alejandro stood beside her, Ricky trying to make up excuses for why he abandoned Halina.

“Is that what you want, princess? It can be arranged,” he told her, taking her hand to kiss it as Ricky gulped and started begging for his life.

“Naw, he doesn’t seem worth the trouble. Just get him out of my sight,” she said with a dismissive hand and Ricky was dragged away from her. “You sure do know how to spoil a girl,” she smirked.

Overhead, the music changed to something less upbeat and boring and Shiri groaned, hopping off the table. “Someone needs to teach this club what real music is,” she said, leaning up to give him a searing kiss before making her way to the dance floor. She found Zimri and Marmoris quickly and when Zimri met her eyes, he knew what they were about to do.

“Sorry, love. Duty calls,” he murmured, kissing Marmoris’ temple quickly before following Shiri up to the DJ platform. She stood eye level with the DJ, putting a hand on her hip while raising an eyebrow.

“You call this music? Beat it! We’re taking over the next track,” she told him as he scrambled out of the way and Zimri took control of

the soundboard as Shiri grabbed the microphone.

"What's up, Scarlet Jewel! Let's get some real music pumping up in here!" she announced as the crowd cheered. She stepped in front of the soundboard so that she was in full view as Zimri started working the new beat.

Open up your eyes

Take a look at me

Get the picture fixed

In your memory

I'm driven by the rhythm

Like the beat of a heart

And I won't stop until I start

To stand out

She started singing, swaying her hips to the rhythm of the song as all eyes were on her as the crowd cheered and danced to the new music.

_

Finn had been dancing through the crowd for a while, eyeing the booths of people along the walls for any sign of the gang members. They had danced with several different people, trying to get closer. They were growing frustrated with every new song. It wasn't until a new voice came out over the speaker, announcing new music that they turned their eyes towards the DJ platform, the voice as enchanting as the figure they saw.

She was swaying to the beat of the music as she sang, her hips were hypnotizing. She had beautiful legs, accented by total fuck-me heels. Their eyes traveled upwards, taking in the gold dress

that shouldn't even be considered clothing, it barely covered anything. Perfectly rounded breasts, pale skin, slender neck, a dark bob of curls, until they landed on her eyes. Warm, rich, and earthy, the most beautiful shade of brown they had seen before, years ago, before they had disappeared.

I'm under a spell

I'm in over my head

And you know I'm goin' all of the way to the end

To stand out!

Above the crowd

Even if I gotta shout out loud

Til mine is the only face you see

Gotta stand out

Til you notice me

And notice her they did. There was no way they could take their eyes off her. She had cut off all her curls since they last saw her, she had definitely filled out into her womanhood. The lighthearted girl they knew all those years ago didn't seem to exist in the voluptuous creature that stood before them.

She finished her song with a roar from the crowd, she took a small bow and passed the mic back off to the DJ as the man who was at the soundboard came around, taking her hand to lead her onto the dance floor. Finn made their way towards her, dancing and weaving through the crowd desperately. They had to keep their eyes on her, they didn't want to lose her again…

She was dancing to the new music that was blasting, enjoying the beat as it pulsed through the club. Finn slid up behind her, hands falling to her wide hips as they swayed to the music with her. She

paused for only a moment before grinding back into them, arms coming up so that they could reach behind her and place her hands on their neck. It was a slow, sensual dance they created together.

She spun around, hands going around their neck completely as she rested her arms on their shoulders, pressing her front into theirs. A smirk played on her lips as she leaned up, her breath tickling the side of their face.

"You're bold to dance with me. My man hasn't taken his eyes off us. He's not someone you want to test," she whispered and Finn glanced down at her, tilting their head. She didn't seem to recognize them the same way they recognized her. Probably because their ears and tail were tucked away. They glanced away to see a tall, blonde man glaring at them from a VIP booth, an angry sneer plastered on their face.

"You're bold to assume that I give a shit," Finn told her, allowing their hands to snake around from her hips to her lower back, pulling her impossibly closer. She let out a small squeak of surprise, giggling.

"I like a feisty partner. It's an absolute turn-on," she told them as they rocked against each other. "You remind me of someone I used to know," she whispered softly, almost too soft to be heard if they did not have amazing hearing.

Their heads leaned toward each other, noses almost touching when a scream sounded from across the dance floor and the room was filled with bright light.

"It's She-Ra! Run!" the voice screamed and the patrons started fleeing. Finn and Shiri jumped away from each other.

"She's after me!" they both yelled, eyes widening in surprise as they looked at each other. "She's after you?"

Shiri surged forward before Finn could react, grabbing their face and slanting her mouth against theirs in a searing, passionate kiss

that left them breathless. She pulled away too quickly, that playful smirk gracing her lips again.

"Sorry to kiss and run but I gotta bounce. She-Ra and I don't get along," she said, turning and disappearing into the crowd, leaving Finn to stand in the middle of the dance floor with the chaos surrounding them, mind blank. They didn't come out of their stupor until they felt large hands on their shoulders and turned to come face to face with their 8-foot tall mom.

Chapter End Notes

Song credits to Stand Out by Tevin Campbell

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Shiri and Halina get ready for bed; Finn comes up with a plan

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 3

Shiri collapsed back on her bed with a groan, struggling to kick off her heels. Halina shook her head, kicking off her own heels before going over and helping Shiri's with hers.

"Thanks, sis," Shiri told her as Halina collapsed beside her, both of them looking up at the overhanging canopy. They didn't share a room, there was plenty of space for them to have their own but they enjoyed being together so Halina often found herself sleeping beside her older sister, especially after their mama…

"I'm sorry we had to leave so early… you know how it is with She-Ra…" Shiri mumbled and Halina turned her head to look at her, taking in how much older her sister looked when she talked about their Aunt Adora, their mama, their kingdom, or anything that smelled like the past or responsibility.

"It's okay… it wasn't much fun anyway. I just wish you would forgive Aunt Adora already, it's been three years…" Halina told her, and Shiri's face twisted momentarily into anger before she sighed heavily, rubbing her hands up her face.

"I don't want to talk about it, Hallie. Drop it," Shiri told her sternly, the conversation immediately stopping there. Halina turned back to look at the canopy.

"I met someone tonight… You remember Prince Archer?" Halina asked and Shiri immediately rolled over to her stomach, propping

her head upon her hands as she gave Halina a shit-eating grin.

“Oooh, yes I do. You used to have the biggest crush on him!” she teased and Halina sat up, throwing a pillow at Shiri.

“No, I didn’t! Oh my gods you’re so embarrassing!” she squealed, her face turning red from the comment. Shiri laughed out loud, pulling herself to her knees to throw the pillow back.

“Admit it! You had a huge crush on him when you were fifteen! Looks like it didn’t go away! Awww, Halina and Archer, sitting in a tree!” she said in a singsong voice, causing Halina to hop off the bed.

“I’m sleeping in my own room! You’re such a pain!”

“Aww, Hallie! Don’t leave! You know I’m teasing you! Please stay!” Shiri pouted and Halina huffed before going over to the drawer to grab their pajamas, throwing Shiri’s pair over at her.

“Get ready for bed, you can’t sleep in that dress. And wipe that gunk off your face, your skin is going to break out if you don’t keep it clean,” Halina told her and Shiri rolled her eyes, grabbing her pajamas and heading towards the adjoining bathroom.

“So bossy. Who are you, my mother?” Shiri said as she closed the door, not hearing what Halina said afterward. She took to cleaning herself up, washing her face, and brushing out her hair. She slipped out of the dress, letting it fall to the floor as she pulled on her sleep shorts and a tank top.

Her clutch caught her eye on the counter and she picked it up, pulling the bag of vials out and stashing them underneath the counter in a small cubby she had installed so no one would find them. She finished up her stuff in the bathroom and walked out, Halina walking by to go in. Shiri took up her side of the bed, it was always the side that was to the right of Halina so that her sister could hear her throughout the night.

Halina came out after about ten minutes and turned off the lights, taking up her side of the bed. The moonlight gleamed through the floor-to-ceiling windows, illuminating the room.

“Should I invite him over…?” Halina whispered softly and Shiri snorted, turning to her side so she was facing her little sister.

“You should. Maybe he’ll start officially courting you. And he can ask you to Princess Prom in a few months,” Shiri whispered back, watching the outline of Halina’s figure.

“You think he likes me? I mean… he did save me from that awful man you stuck me with. What a pig.”

“I took care of him for you. I’m sorry that happened… I just wanted you to have a good birthday.”

“I did have a good birthday. I got to spend it with my family, that’s all I ever wanted. Shiri?” Halina mumbled, starting to drift off to sleep. Shiri patted around until she found Halina’s hand and took it into hers, squeezing.

“Yea?”

“You don’t have to try so hard… to make everyone happy… Everyone will understand if you’re not.”

“If I’m not what?”

“Happy… You put on a brave face but I sometimes see the cracks. You didn’t grieve for mama properly…”

Shiri sighed, closing her eyes. She didn’t want to hear about their mama, the past, nothing. It made it harder to keep everything in control if she dwelled on it too long. She gave Halina’s hand another squeeze, hearing her breath even out as she fell asleep.

“Sometimes that’s all I can do, Hallie… You wouldn’t understand,” Shiri sighed softly, gently moving a white curl from her face. “You grew up too fast… I’m so sorry I wasn’t there to protect you.”

_

Finn, Shimmer, and Archer all sat on the couch in the study at the Brightmoon Palace, their parents standing in front of them. Glimmer had a vein pulsing in her forehead, Bow keeping a hand on her shoulder so she didn't lurch forward to strangle their two. Adora was pacing, no longer in She-Ra form but still as intimidating while Catra lounged back against the wall, checking out her claws.

"What were you three thinking?! There better be a good reason why you were out at a Crimson Waste club, much less a notorious hotbed from gang activity, especially the Desert Rose gang! What were you guys thinking?!" Glimmer yelled, eye starting to twitch.

"We were trying to help! We're more than old enough to handle ourselves out there!" Shimmer argued. "You keep treating us like children, we're all in our early to mid-twenties. Not exactly babies here!"

"Just because you're not a child doesn't mean I can't still ground you!" Glimmer threatened, causing Shimmer to stand up.

"Mom! You're so embarrassing! We found out a lot of information tonight before Aunt Adora busted in!"

"What did you find?" Adora asked eagerly, stepping forward.

"Princess Halina was at the club," Archer stated, leaning forward to rest his elbows on his knees. "She said that her siblings had dragged her out for her birthday, which means that Princess Shiri and Prince Zimri were also there."

"I can vouch for that. I was with Princess Shiri but she didn't recognize me…" Finn said quietly, absently touching their lips where Shiri kissed them. "She mentioned something about a man not liking me dancing with her and I did see a blonde man with a scar staring at us."

Adora frowned deeply, coming to a stop from her pacing. "A man with a scar? Sounds like Alejandro, the Desert Rose gang leader. I've been tracking him for a while but he's good at hiding. If Shiri is involved with him, that's not good."

"Girl's got balls, I'll give her that," Catra commented, finally looking up from her claws. Finn frowned at their mama.

"He's probably blackmailing her or something. We have to stop him before he hurts her," Finn said.

"We are trying to stop him but we have no leads! We don't know where the gang camps out, they have no predictable patterns to their activity or violence, we've got nothing! If we had someone on the inside, it would be easier but it's just as hard tracking down members to talk to, much less get them to cooperate," Adora grumbled, rubbing her temples.

"Get Shiri's help," Finn suggested. Everyone just stared at them and their ears flattened on their head. "She's obviously close to Alejandro. She probably knows how to find him, get in contact with him, anything. Get close to her, you'll be able to get close to him."

"Adora, it's not a bad idea… If she's as close to him as Finn says, she could give us the information we need to end this," Glimmer told her and Adora shook her head.

"No. Absolutely not. Shiri hates me. I'm not allowed in the city, there's no way I'll be able to get information out of her. Not like she would talk to me even if I was allowed close enough," Adora told them.

"Why does Shiri hate you? She was never someone to hold a grudge," Shimmer commented and Finn nodded in agreement, watching as their mom's face fell into a troubled expression. Catra came up behind Adora, putting her hands on her arms.

"It wasn't your fault, no matter what she says," Catra murmured against Adora's ear, low enough that only Finn was able to hear

it.

“It doesn’t matter why she hates me. The point is, we won’t be able to extract any information out of her because of it.”

Finn thought for a moment before coming to a conclusion. “Let me do it.”

Everyone turned their attention back to them. Shimmer smirked, poking Finn.

“You just want to see her again! You always had the biggest crush on her! Finn and Shiri, sitting in a tree!” she sang out and Finn hissed at her, causing Archer to hide his laughter.

“You’re insufferable, Shimmer! Shiri used to trust me! Give me some time to earn that trust again, I’ll be able to get the information out of her,” Finn told them and Bow looked at Adora.

“They’re right. Finn and Shiri were very close when they were kids, even up until the last Princess Prom. You may be banned from the city but the rest of your family isn’t. It’s worth a shot,” he negotiated and Adora bit her lip, contemplating.

“Shiri will be pissed when she finds out about this,” Adora muttered and Finn nodded.

“Yea, if she finds out. Which she won’t.”

“She’ll blame me if she finds out, she’ll think I put you up to this.”

“She’s not going to find out, mom. She used to trust me, somewhere deep down, she still does. I can do this, give me some time. Six months tops. How does that sound?”

Adora looked to the rest of the Best Friend Squad, who nodded encouragingly and she sighed, putting her hands on her hips.

“Fine, six months. You report everything to me, every last detail she tells you. She takes you somewhere, you wear a tracker. You

have a conversation, you make sure it's recorded. We need to bring Alejandro to justice, quickly."

Finn stood up, saluting. "I won't let you down, mom. I promise."

"Now, how are we even going to go about getting to Musicia? It's not like anyone has been to the city in the last three years, the royal family has been pretty isolated from the rest of Etheria. We can't just show up on their doorsteps," Shimmer told them and Archer cleared his throat, causing the room to look at him.

"I uhhh… had a good talk with Princess Halina… I can get us into the palace, no problem," he mumbled.

"Oh my gods, you totally have a crush on her! Archer, you sly dog! You were getting all cozy to the princess while we were doing the hard work," Shimmer teased and Archer blushed.

"How soon can you get an invitation to the palace?" Adora asked.

"The next couple of days, probably. Just let me write her a letter and find her a birthday gift," Archer told them and Shimmer squealed.

"Make sure you get us all invited. Won't be cool if only you're invited and we end up tagging along," Finn reminded them.

"I'll get us in, no problem. I just hope you don't screw it up with Shiri. Heard from Sereia that she's gotten tough, they go out clubbing together."

"Let's see if we can get Flora to tag along. She used to be close to Shiri as well," Finn said.

The door to the study open and a small head poked in, brown mane and blue eyes staring inside at the group.

"Nala, what are you doing out of bed?" Catra chided, going over to pick up the ten-year-old, who wrapped their tail around her arm as they head their head on their mama's shoulder.

“I got thirsty and heard voices. Why was everyone yelling?” she asked, cat ears twitching.

“No reason, sweetie. You should go back to bed. I’ll come to tuck you in in a minute,” Adora said, going over to kiss the little girl's head. Nala nodded as Catra walked out with her.

“Good night everyone!” she yelled over her mama’s shoulders.

“Good night, Nala!” the group said back, the tension slowly leaving the room.

“Let me know how the meeting goes in a few days,” Adora tells them, heading out after her wife and child.

“You all should go to bed. It’s been a long night,” Glimmer groaned, rubbing her face as Bow waved goodnight to the group and led his wife out of the study.
Shimmer looked at her brother and her best friend, giving them a shit-eating grin. “Looks like we’re getting the group back together again!”

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for all the support I have gotten for this book! Slow updates, I am working on my one-shots as well! Check them out to meet these new characters in future chapters!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

A memory and a meeting

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 4

It had been a few hours since the funeral. Shiri sat on Calliope's throne, still in her black funeral dress, head buried into her hands. She doesn't know how long she had been sitting there. Probably since the end of the funeral. Everything felt cold and numb, she wanted to cry but she couldn't bring the tears forward. She had too much to do, no time to allow grief to cloud it.

She heard footsteps walking towards the thrones, they echoed loudly in the empty ballroom, where so many lively memories lived. She couldn't bring herself to look up, she didn't want to look up. But she had to because the footsteps stopped at the end of the steps that led up to the platform.

She glanced up, blinking away the fuzziness of her vision to see Adora and Catra looking up at her, pain and grief stark on their faces. The look on Adora's face made Shiri's blood boil, how dare she look so sad when she wasn't there to help!

"What do you want? I'm not taking visitors," *Shiri mumbled, trying to push the anger down, hoping that they leave quickly. Leave her to her own pain.*

"Shiri," *Adora said, stepping to the first step.* "I am so sorry about your mother. Calliope was an amazing woman. If there is anything you need from us, we're here for you. We're family."

Shiri let out a bitter laugh, rising from the throne to tower over them. The anger was building, her body thrumming with it. Her eyes flashed pure white, causing Adora to back down immediately.

"You weren't there. The powerful She-Ra, who could heal anything, wasn't there to help my mother when she needed it most. She had told you about the violence in the woods! She pleaded for help! You. Did. Nothing! You weren't even on Etheria! What was more important than helping our own planet?"

Adora fumbled for an explanation, unsure how to answer the angry girl as Shiri had descended some of the steps as she talked. She could feel the magical energy rolling off the young girl in waves.

"I'm sorry I wasn't there. I'm sorry I didn't help. Your mother needed me, and I was not there to help her, and that's on me. Please, Shiri… I'm here now. Where's Lexie? Where's your mom?" *Adora pleaded.*

"Did you know that they were soulmates? To halves of the same whole?" *Shiri mumbled, rocking side to side as the magical energy thrummed through her, thrummed out through the ballroom. She couldn't control it anymore. All those years of practice, out the window.* "She's been inconsolable. Can't even take care of her new infant son. Do you know who's been taking care of him? Halina. A fifteen-year-old, who just lost her mother and half of her hearing. She's the only one he responds to, given that he can't hear at all!"

Shiri let out a cackle, feeling herself crack and break under the realizations of what their life had become. "She watched our mother die. She had to deliver our brother in the middle of the woods and where were you again? Off helping everyone else but our own!" *A magical wave unleashed from her words, nearly knocking the two women back. Adora stood in front of Catra to shield her from the blast.*

“Shiri! Listen to me! This isn’t you! You’re angry and hurt, I understand that! Don’t push us away, we just want to help! Just let us talk to Lexie, she’ll understand!” *Catra pleaded with her, looking around Adora’s shoulder.*

“My mom is not meeting with anyone! With my mother dead and her debilitated, I am the reigning queen! This is my kingdom and you are no longer welcomed here, She-Ra! Get out of my city!” *Shiri screamed, her voice echoing in the room. Everything around her was flashing dangerously. She was on the verge of losing all the control she had built up over the years. She watched as Adora’s face fell.*

“Shiri… you’re our family… we love you. Please don’t do this…” *Adora begged and Shiri’s eyes flashed again, settling on the permanent whiteness seen on Calliope all those years ago. Catra pulled Adora back quickly, urging her to leave.*

“GET. OUT! She-Ra is no longer welcomed in the kingdom of Musicia! Your people have taken what is rightfully ours, siphoning magic from us for centuries! No more! I am the Heart of Etheria, I will wipe your existence from the history books! I will make sure no one ever knew you existed!” *Shiri screamed, the room pulsating around her as Catra managed to pull Adora from the room, the doors closing behind them. She let out a final scream of rage as she fell to her hands and knees, the glass windows shattering around her.*

Shiri opened her eyes, staring up at the canopy above her. She let out a deep breath that she did not know she was holding, her body relaxing back into the mattress, the dream/memory fading as the sunshine warmed her face. She hated remembering the past, it distracted her from the present.

She reached her hand out, feeling around beside her for Halina but coming up empty. That wasn’t unusual, Halina was usually up

by dawn to take care of Nicaise, much to their mom's displeasure. It had been a few days since their night at the club and they had finally gotten back into their normal routine.

Shiri didn't want to get up. She wanted to sink into the mattress and disappear. It was moments like this, in the quiet, in the loneliness, where she allowed herself to be… normal. Not happy, not bubbly, not sexy, not confident, but a ghost of her former self. A little girl who lost her mom too soon ruled a kingdom for six months and carried the magical abilities to stand toe-to-toe with the most powerful princess on Etheria.

It wasn't until she heard a knock on her door, Zimri's voice telling her to come down for breakfast, that she found the strength to get up and put her mask back on. It was just going through the motions for a while until she was in front of a crowd: put on dress, brush hair, wash face, slip-on shoes, breathe. When she found herself presentable, she gave her reflection a dazzling, carefree smile, everything slipping back into place as she exited her room.

She wore a yellow pantsuit romper with spaghetti straps and matching black heels that clicked down the hallway towards the dining room. She wore a matching brown belt that presented her mother's Horde Badge on her hip. She had fought Zimri for it after her death and had won it, triumphantly. She entered the dining room, going around to take her seat beside her mother.

Lexie sat at the head of the table, picking at her eggs. Shiri sat to her left while Zimri sat to her right, Marmoris sitting beside him. Halina was sitting beside Shiri, their younger brother, Nicaise, sitting on her lap as she fed him from her plate. He was three, a little ball of energy, and never left Halina's side if he could help it. They had a bond that no one could explain, they understood each other without words. Aunt Haevyn and Aunt Circe sat beside Halina, quietly discussing something while their godparents, Brio and Callista, sat opposite of them beside Marmoris.

Halina looked up from her plate as Shiri sat down and smiled, Nicaise blabbering in her lap. “Guess what!” her younger sister said excitedly and Shiri shrugged, serving herself some toast and fruit.

“What is it? Did they forget to bring out your favorite jam again?” Shiri teased.

“No! Archer wrote to me! He’s coming for a visit today with Shimmer, Finn, and Flora! Remember them? You guys used to be best friends!” Halina squealed and Shiri froze, knife hovering over her toast to add her butter. Her head snapped to her mom, who was busy sipping her morning tea.

“Mom… please tell me she’s joking. We haven’t had anyone visit the city in…”

“Years. No one that wasn’t a citizen hasn’t visited the city in three years, since your mom passed. Since you banned She-Ra from entering. I think it’s good that your friends have decided to come to visit, especially Zimri and Halina. We can’t keep living in isolation,” Lexie told her, looking up from her cup to gauge her daughter's reaction.

Shiri gripped her knife, taking a deep breath to calm down. “I don’t want to see them. If anyone needs me today, I will be in the garden, pretending that I don’t exist.”

“You’re always so dramatic, my song. It will do you good to hang out with people who don’t want to party and drink away their lives, like Sereia. I am demanding your presence today during their visit,” Lexie told her and Shiri stabbed her knife down into the wood table, causing all conversation to die at the table.

“You can’t demand anything from me! I will not be in attendance and you can’t make me!” Shiri seethed and Lexie stared her down, neither willing to back down from the challenge.

“Last I checked, I was still queen. Therefore, I can demand your presence anywhere I deem necessary. Like now, where you

should escort your sister and keep her company during this visit."

"Why can't Zimri do that?! He's her sibling too!"

"I'm requesting both of your presence during the visit. We need to re-establish and maintain relationships between the kingdoms and since either one of you will rule Musicia one day, you both need to make good with the future kings and queens of said kingdoms. End of discussion," Lexie told her and Shiri broke eye contact first, pushing away from the table.

"It seems I have lost my appetite. If I may be excused, *your majesty?"* she hissed and Lexie nodded, Shiri quickly leaving the dining room.

—

Shiri found herself in the garden like she had said. The flowers always made her feel calmer. She ran her fingers along with the blue petals of her mama's favorite roses, a gift from their Aunt Haevyn to her so many years ago. The garden always had a magical effect on her nerves, reminding her of the many afternoons she spent amongst the bushes with their mama, helping her create and grow the little lives.

That's how Finn found her that afternoon, standing amongst the flowers, looking absolutely radiant. She had abandoned her heels by the fountain that graced the middle of the garden and had buried her toes into some fresh dirt as she trimmed back some azalea bushes. Finn loved the peaceful expression on her face as she hummed to the flowers she worked on.

They felt a hand on their shoulder and looked up to see Flora standing behind them, smiling. She was the daughter of Perfuma and Scorpia, with curly white hair, dark eyes, and a scorpion tail. She was a larger woman, towering over Finn by a good foot.

"You know, it would help if you went and talked to her instead of just staring," she suggested, causing Finn to shake their head.

“I’m sure she doesn’t want to talk to me. Besides, we should wait for the others to join us before we go forward,” Finn suggested, looking back at Flor before realizing she had already run forward into the garden.

“Flora! Wait!” they yelled after her, running to catch up.

Shiri looked up to see what the commotion was about and was scooped up into strong arms, causing a squeal of a surprise to leave her as she was crushed against a large chest.

“Shiri! It’s been so long! I missed you!” Flora said as she spun them around. Shiri couldn’t help but laugh at the enthusiasm. She had missed this from the larger woman who was too gentle for her own good.

“I missed you too, Flora! Can you put me down now?” she asked and Flora nodded, sitting Shiri back down onto her feet. Shiri stumbled a little before righting herself, brushing the invisible dirt off of her romper.

“You’ve gotten bigger, I swear,” Shiri commented, leaning her head back to look up at the woman before her. Flora smiled down at her, nodding.

“That’s what happens when you disappear for ten years, Shiri. People grow and change. Besides, where were you?” Flora questioned but Shiri ignored her, a movement behind the larger woman catching her eyes.

Finn stood awkwardly behind Flora, rubbing the back of their neck as their blue eyes made eye contact with her brown ones. It had been a long time, that’s for sure. Finn had filled out their figure, grew into their ears. Tall, blonde, handsome… butterflies erupted into her stomach the same as they used to all those years ago.

“Finn…? It’s um… it’s been a while,” she murmured, knowing they would hear her. They nodded, coming forward so that they were standing beside Flora.

“You’re right. It’s been a while. You look… good,” they said and Shiri nodded, feeling underdressed in her yellow romper, feeling exposed. It was silent for a few moments as they stared each other down. Flora cleared her throat suddenly, breaking them from the trance as she clapped her hands together.

“Who’s hungry? I heard your mom say something about tea time being soon? The others will be joining us in a moment,” Flora told Shiri and she blinked before straightening her back, putting on a face of indifference.

“Yes, tea time is soon. It’s a lovely day, we can enjoy the garden while we eat,” Shiri said as she motioned for them to follow. She grabbed her heels on the way over to the gazebo, leaving a trail of dirt in her wake. When they made it to the steps of the gazebo, a maid scurried over, whispering softly to Shiri.

“Thank you, Artemis. Please inform her that we will be taking tea time in the garden and that I am not avoiding my duties, they seem to have found me,” she said out loud, glancing back briefly at Flora and Finn before ascending the steps to take a seat. Artemis hurried off to prepare their tea as the other two took a seat across from Shiri.

Shiri sized them up from across the table, taking a small remote hidden in a cubby, and played with the settings, turning on some light, instrumental music, and the fairy lights that were strung around the ceiling.

“Ooh, it feels so magical! This was always our favorite place to play, remember, Shiri?” Flora asked her.

“I suppose so…” Shiri mumbled, tapping her fingers on her leg nervously.

“Your mom would always make us cookies! I spent more time in this garden than my own back home, your mom had a magical touch with plants like mine. She would pick our favorites and

make our crowns and we would pretend that this was a kingdom! Aunt Calliope was the best-"

"Can we stop talking about her? She's gone. There's no need to dwell in the past," Shiri said sharply, causing Flora to flinch back and Finn to frown at her tone. Luckily, the rest of the group decided to join at that moment and Shiri's shoulders relaxed when she caught sight of Halina and Zimri.

She stood in greeting, putting back on her smile and Halina ran up, hugging her. She whispered softly into her older sister's ear. "He's been so sweet! It's going so well. Thank you for doing this, sis."

Shiri hugged her back, nodded very slightly before pulling away to greet the rest of the group. "Prince Archer, Princess Shimmer. It's so nice to see you both again. Tell me, how are Aunt Glimmer and Uncle Bow doing?"

Everyone sat down, Shiri scooting closer to Flora to make room for the newcomers. Halina sat beside her, Archer on her other side, then Shimmer, Zimri, and back to Finn, on the other side of Flora. Artemis and a few other maids came back, setting the table with tea and snacks.

"They're doing great! They really miss everyone here. I expect they will be thrilled at a reunion during Princess Prom in a few months?" Shimmer said as she served herself.

"Yes, everyone will be receiving an invitation, as is custom," Zimir chided in. "While mom is still reigning queen, she is having Shiri and I oversee the party logistics."

"Unfortunately, I am not in charge of invitations. Mom says I am too biased," Shiri commented, pouring her tea before passing the pot along to Halina.

"You are too biased, Shiri. If it was up to you, you would have excluded essential people and caused a civil war," Zimri chided, and Shiri frowned at him.

“I missed this! You two fussing like always! Awww, I’m so glad we got the group back together!” Flora commented, drinking her tea.

“The group isn’t back together. I am here out of obligation, otherwise, I would be spending my afternoon sleeping,” Shiri told her, not looking to see the crestfallen face on her former friend. Zimir scowled at her.

“So you could go out with Sereia again?” Halina questioned, breaking the tension that was starting to form between the twins.

“Sereia? Princess Sereia? She never attends meetings yet she’s going out with you?” Archer questioned and Shiri finally turned to examine him, noting that his and Halina’s arms were close together, probably holding hands under the table. Shiri gave him a once over before turning back to her cup, taking a sip.

“Yep. Seems like our nights out are more entertaining than your boring meetings,” Shiri commented and enjoyed watching his nostrils flare slightly at the jab.

“What do you do on your nights out?” Finn asked, trying to pull her attention away from Archer. Shiri turned to face them, cocking her head to the side with a smirk.

“Why? You wanna join? Can’t imagine your… mom would be too happy about that,” Shiri said, gauging their reaction. Nothing. She furrowed her brows.

“Last I checked, we were all grown and could do what we want. What do you say, Princess? Wanna take us out on the town?” Finn dangled temptingly over her and she contemplated the idea as she ate her scone. Unfortunately, her mom decided to make an appearance before she could give an answer, carrying a crying Nicaise.

“Sorry to bother you guys. Hallie? He wants you,” Lexie told her and Halina was at her side in an instant, pulling the toddler into her arms. He instantly calmed down, sniffling as she took his tiny hand and placed it on her throat, and started humming.

“What is she doing?” Finn whispered softly, looking at Shiri who was watching her siblings, a sad look gracing her features. It took Finn back for a moment and when she noticed him watching her, she slipped back on her mask of indifference.

“Nickey can’t hear but he can feel vibrations, it’s something she’s been doing since he was born. It calms him to feel her singing,” she explained as Halina brought him back to the table and sat down, offering him a cookie.

“Why can’t he hear?” Shimmer asked and all three siblings froze. Marmoris squeezed Zimri’s shoulder reassuringly and Shiri turned her head quickly to the girl, anger replacing the mask of indifference.

“None of your damn business!” she hissed and Lexie stepped forward, scowling at her daughter.

“Shiri! That is no way to treat a guest! Shimmer, it’s a touchy subject for this family, we would prefer not to answer,” Lexie told her gently and the princess nodded, sinking into her seat in embarrassment. Shiri was still seething, trying to regain control of her composure. She stood quickly.

“This meeting is over. I would like for you all to leave,” she told them, rounding the table to head down the steps of the gazebo.

“My song, you’re being unreasonable. You guys don’t have to leave, stay as long as you like. Our home is your home,” Lexie told them and Shiri kept her back to the group, grounding herself by counting the petals on a nearby flower. She flinched slightly when she felt a hand on her shoulder, having not heard anyone come up behind her, and turned to see Finn giving her a look of concern.

“You okay? You’ve… never really had a temper before,” they said softly and Shiri nodded, straightening her posture.

“I’m fine. I’ll be fine. And if you would like to join me tonight, I wouldn’t mind. It’s been a while since we got into trouble

together," she smirked, bumping her hip against theirs in a teasing manner. Finn's face flushed at the gesture before nodding.

"It's a club in Salineas called the Laughing Dolphin. I'll see you there around 11? Wear something… red. It'll match my dress," she said, giving them a quick peck on the cheek before leaving the garden. Finn touched the place she kissed gently before giving a fist pump in excitement.

Chapter End Notes

Ooooh! Things are getting heated!

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Shiri and Finn go to the club and things get spicy

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 5

Shiri entered the nightclub, feeling the music pulsate through her. She always felt in her element when in the clubs, completely surrounded by music and dancing. She wore silk crimson red dress that came mid-thigh and was strapless with a sweetheart neckline, exposing her back, shoulders, and chest. She matched it with sparkly black pumps that made her legs look miles long and a simple black choker. She was dressed to dance, not impress like the other night.

She made her way through the squirming bodies, heart racing as she kept an eye out for Finn. She wouldn't admit it out loud but seeing them again after so many years had made her feel all jittery inside, like when she was fifteen again and saw them in a tux at Princess Prom. Back then, she had been head over heels for them. Now… She didn't have time for infatuations like that.

"Shiri! Over here!" She heard a voice and turned to see Sereia waving her down at the bar. She beelined for the other girl and they embraced. When she pulled back, she took in the other girl's outfit. Sereia wore a navy blue pantsuit romper with a deep neckline, exposing all the way down to her navel, paired with black pumps similar to Shiri's. Her blue hair was pinned into a tight sock bun on top of her head, a couple of her curls pulled down to frame her face. She had the most beautiful, light brown skin, even prettier than Marmoris'.

“Bitch, you’re wearing my heels!” Shiri squealed and Sereia let out a fake gasp, putting a hand over her exposed chest.

“Bitch, I could say the same about you! Also, who the fuck you trying to impress tonight? Alejandro won’t be here,” Sereia told her, sitting back down at the bar as Shiri joined her, flagging down the bartender to order a drink.

“I’m not trying to impress anyone! This is my good dancing outfit! Besides, Finn is going to be joining us soon,” she said, mumbling the last part. Sereia’s eyes went wide as she put a finger in her ear, wiggling it around a little.

“I’m sorry, I thought you said that Finn was joining us. I must be mistaken, there ain’t no way your childhood crush is coming to a nightclub!”

“Sereia! That was a long time ago! They were at the palace today along with the rest of the gang and I invited them to join if they were up to it. I doubt they will,” Shiri took her drink from the bartender. “Besides, I’m here to drink until I puke and dance till I drop. Are you joining me or what?”

“Please! I can drink you under the table any night! I wager the next round that Finn will be joining us,” Sereia said as she ordered her next drink.

“I’ll take that wager. Bartender, keep them coming!” she told them as she finished her first drink of the night.

“Say, did you invite the whole gang or just Finn?” Sereia asked as she started on her next drink.

“I’m pretty sure just Finn, why?”

“Cause the whole gang just showed up,” Sereia told her and Shiri turned her head to the door. Shimmer, Flora, Archer, and Finn all stood there, seemingly searching the club. Shiri’s face flushed as she took in Finn, wearing a red long-sleeve button-up that was

half-undone and black slacks, their blonde locks pulled back into a half-up bun. Sereia elbowed her slightly, smirking.

"Girl, that is one fine ass tall drink if I have ever seen one," she teased and Shiri gaped her mouth open like a fish, at a loss for words. "Kitty already got your tongue and they aren't even over here!"

"S-shut up, stupid bitch! You're so embarrassing! No, don't wave them over!" she hissed as Sereia was already calling their attention. Finn locked eyes with Shiri, who ducked her head as she grabbed her third drink and the group made their way over.

"Chin up, girl! We're here to have fun! Loosen up already!" Sereia scolded her as the group came up and she jumped up to hug Archer, who looked uncomfortable. Finn went around them, ending up by Shiri's side as she finished her drink.

"Sorry, I tried to convince them not to come but you know how Shimmer is, and then she worked Flora up, and then Archer had to make sure they wouldn't kill themselves…" Finn whispered in her ear, causing her to shiver slightly as she put on a fake smile.

"It's whatever. The more, the merrier, I say. Bartender! Another round for my friends!" she snapped her fingers.

"Sereia! Let go of me! You have time to go to nightclubs but not attend Alliance meetings?" Archer scolded her, pulling out of the embrace. Sereia pouted, hanging onto his arm.

"Archie, don't be like that! Those meetings are soooooo boring! Why haven't you come out with me sooner? I'm loving you in this shirt," she purred, touching his chest.

"Sereia! Hands off! I'm… seeing someone," he told her, grabbing her wrists and pulling them away from him. Shiri choked on her drink, coughing. Finn patted her back as she caught her breath.

"You think you're seeing my sister? Are you out of your mind? Halina is like six… seven years younger than you and have you

been with Sereia? That tells me everything I need to know."

"Hey! Are you calling me a skank?" Sereia said, putting her hands on her hips as she faced Shiri. Shiri stood up, feeling the challenge.

"If the shoe fits, wear it. I know the kind of guys you deal with," Shiri commented and Sereia gasped.

"And what about you, Miss Perfect? You got some skeletons in your closet. Your sister would be lucky to be with my Archie! She definitely shouldn't be around the type you hang with or have you already forgotten about him? You know what he'd do if he found out you were here with someone else."

"Shut your fucking mouth before I shut it for you, Sereia," Shiri took a step forward and Finn stepped between them, putting a hand on Shiri's shoulder.

"Whoa! This has gotten out of hand! You two need to calm down," Finn told them and Shiri glared at Sereia before grabbing her fourth drink and Finn's hand.

"Let's go dance. It's starting to stink here," she said as she pulled Finn onto the dance floor, ignoring the rest of the group. Finn allowed her to pull them where she wanted them to go until they were hidden in the crowd.

Shiri turned, unleashing their hand as she took a swig from her glass and wrapped an arm around their neck, pressing up against them. Finn wrapped an arm around her waist, keeping her close as they rocked to the music and against each other. Shiri closed her eyes, allowing the music to pulse through her and Finn's heart to beat against her own.

"How many drinks have you had?" Finn whispered in her ear and she hummed softly, finishing her glass.

"Four and I'm just getting started. Why? You think you can outdrink me?" she smirked, opening her eyes to look at their baby

blue ones.

“I think you need to slow down or you’ll make yourself sick,” they told her and she frowned.

“I’m here for two reasons: to drink til a puke and to dance till I drop. You can either do it with me or get lost. I don’t have time for party poopers,” she told them, pulling away slightly. They grabbed her waist, pulling her back to them as she squeaked.

“I’m just worried about you but if that’s what you want, that’s what we’ll do. And yes, I think I could outdrink you,” they told her and she smirked.

“You’re on.”

_

Shiri was definitely wasted by the end of the night. Keeping up with Finn was hard, she would admit and by her fifteenth drink, she had to tap out before she did puke everywhere. They had continued dancing together, never once leaving the other for another partner as they grinded against each other to the pulse of the music.

She and Sereia made up by hour two in a drunken, tearful apology as they hugged it out, making Archer roll his eyes at the display. The two then decided to outdrink each other as well as Finn but Sereia tapped out earlier than Shiri. Flora didn’t make it past her first drink before being too tipsy to continue and Shimmer was out drinking them all, except Archer, who wasn’t drinking at all.

By 3 A.M, The group was efficiently drunk out of their minds and found themselves outside of the club as it closed for the morning. Sereia was stumbling and giggling and Archer picked her up, slinging her over his shoulder.

“Hey! T-take care of my girl, o-okay?” Shiri hiccuped as Finn held her upright.

“I’m taking her home now. Finn, you got her?” Archer asked, raising an eyebrow as Finn nodded. “Alright, We’ll see you back at Brightmoon. Shimmer, could you…?” he asked and Shimmer nodded.

“I’ll be right back to take you home, Shiri, okay?” she said as she grabbed her group and teleported away in a shower of sparkles. Shiri gasped, clapping her hands in delight.

“Sparkly! I love sparkles!” she squealed and Finn laughed at her childishness.

“You should be drunk more. This is the most relaxed I’ve seen you in a while,” they teased as she turned towards him, smiling lazily as she put a hand on their chest.

“I looooooove you in this shirt. You look so handsome,” she said, fingering the buttons. Finn blushed down at her. Shimmer appeared back, taking in the scene before clearing her throat.

“Am I interrupting something?” She asked and Finn shook their head quickly before she grabbed them and teleported them to Musicia. They landed in the garden and Shiri lost her balance. Finn quickly grabbed her, keeping her upright.

“I think I’m gonna stay behind and make sure she gets to bed safely. I’ll crash in a guest room, okay?” they told Shimmer and she cocked an eyebrow before shrugging and teleporting away. Shiri giggled in their arms and they sighed before scooping her up into their arms bridal style. She wrapped her arms around his neck, leaning her head against their shoulder.

“You’re warm. And soft. Pretty kitty,” she mumbled as Finn walked her inside and headed down the hallway to her room. They couldn’t help but unleash some purrs from the compliments and that sent Shiri into another fit of giggles as she pressed her hand into their chest to feel the vibrations.

“Kitty go purr!” she giggled, relaxing back into their embrace as they made it to her room. They opened the door, closing it behind

them as they made their way to Shiri's bed and gently laid her down. Shiri kept her arms firmly wrapped around their neck, whimpering.

"Time to let go, Shiri. I gotta go sleep somewhere else," they told her and she shook her head, pulling them onto the bed. They fell forward, on top of her and it went quiet as they stared into each other's eyes.

Shiri leaned up, a hand coming up to cup their face as her lips attached to theirs. Finn froze for a moment before leaning into her hand and kissing her back. They pulled away from each other gently, foreheads pressed together and noses brushing.

"Shiri…" Finn mumbled softly, hand cupping her neck.

"Finn… Don't leave, please…" she murmured, pressing her lips against theirs again, more forceful, more hungry. Finn knew they shouldn't but it felt so right to have her in their arms. It was intense as if it was something they had been waiting to happen their whole lives.

It became a blur of rough kisses and tender touches until Shiri flipped them to where Finn was beneath her and she pinned them down, straddling their hips. She trailed kisses along their jaw, sending shudders through their body.

"Shiri… we shouldn't…" Finn mumbled and Shiri sat up. Finn had never seen anything more beautiful. Her cheeks were flushed pink, her lips swollen and parted slightly. Her eyes gleamed and her chest heaved with deep breaths of anticipation.

"Please… Finn, please touch me," she begged softly and they refused to hold back anymore, flipping them back over so that she was pinned under them and those long legs were wrapped around their hips as they pulled her into a searing kiss as they removed every barrier keeping them apart.

—

Sun streamed through the windows the next morning, warming Finn's face as they woke up. They let out a tiny merp, curling around the warmth beside them. Warmth? Finn cracked an eye open. Shiri was curled up against them, buried deep into the blanket, with a peaceful expression on her face.

Finn sat up immediately, hissing at the pain in their head from drinking too much. They looked back down at Shiri, who just shifted slightly before settling back down.

"What the fuck did I do?"

Chapter End Notes

Dun! Dun! Dunnnnnnn!

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

A memory, the morning after, confrontations

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 6

Princess Prom was the highlight of the decade and Shiri was excited to attend her very first one as a teenager. The last Princess Prom, she had been a toddler and had been unable to attend but this year was different. She was fifteen, she was starting to come into her own, and she was ready to confess to her long-standing crush, Finn. She was going to do it tonight, during the last dance.

Zimri and her had a long-standing tradition of wearing matching outfits to social events and tonight was no different. All eyes were on them as they descended the staircase in white, just behind their mothers. Shiri wore an a-line halter top dress that flowed down to her feet and was completely covered in sequins. She wore matching white heels and silver bangles on her wrists, her long, black curls pulled back into an elegant bun, silver flowers decorating it. Zimri looked handsome in a white, three-piece suit with similar flowers adorning his lapel.

Shiri felt stunning, beautiful. Not unlike the awkward teenager she knew herself to be and they came to stop behind their mothers before the throne of Brightmoon, bowing as they were taught.

"Reverend Hostess, we come under the ancient rules of hospitality, bringing greetings from Musicia," *Calliope announced for them, standing up to look at Queen Glimmer, who smiled down at them.*

"You are welcome under the ancient rules of hospitality. Leave conflict at the door and please, enjoy the ball. We'll catch up with you later," *Glimmer whispered the last part and Calliope nodded before Lexie led her away, the twins following suit. Shiri heard someone calling her and looked up to see Sereia and Flora waving to her from the buffet table.*

"Mama, may I go join my friends?" *she asked and Calliope turned around, reaching over to tuck a stray strand of hair behind her ear.*

"Of course, my song. Stay out of trouble. Keep her out of trouble, my music?" *Calliope said to Zimri, who nodded and kissed her cheek gently. He turned and gave one to Lexie, who smiled and wrapped an arm around her wife's shoulders.*

"Don't do anything I would do, got it?" *she teased, leading Calliope away to join up with their friends as the twins joined their own.*

They spent the evening talking, laughing, taking bets, and dancing. Luckily, Shiri got to have the first dance with Finn, who looked super handsome in their mom's red and black tuxedo. It made Shiri's heart skip a beat when she saw them. She hated when they had to separate to dance with different partners but they always found their way back to each other.

The way they smiled down at her as if she was the only thing in the entire universe worth looking at… she had to tell them tonight, tell them how she really felt. After a particularly upbeat dance that left her dizzy and breathless, Shiri decided to go freshen up before the final moments of the evening. She excused herself from Finn, giving their hand a small squeeze of reassurance as she left.

She made her way out of the ballroom, down the familiar hallways of Brightmoon where she spent some of her childhood towards the restroom. She felt like she was burning up, felt heat flush through her body as she stumbled along. Her vision was

becoming fuzzy and she shot her arm out to grab hold of something, anything as the world spun around her.

She doesn't remember ending up on the floor but the next moment, she was staring up at the ceiling. That's when the pain hit, so intense that she couldn't even scream as her sight left her and she was pulled into a vision of the past. Her mother's, as children, running through the Fright Zone as they laughed together. Fights against bot simulations. Blood, tears, pain.

She vaguely heard what was happening around her as the visions took hold of her body, making it convulse and twist. A male voice calling to her, calling for help. Hands trying to still her. A female voice. Her mom? She couldn't tell. Her jaw locked, the pain intensified, her body burned.

More visions. Her mama, round with a child. Happiness. Love. Was this the past or a future? More blood. Screaming. Then… her body relaxed onto the floor, her sight came back to her and it wasn't just the ceiling she could see, there were faces around her.

Zimri, her moms, Aunt Adora, Aunt Catra, all looked down at her with concern, worry, and fear as she struggled to regain her breath. Regain her senses. Her mama, tears streaking down her beautiful cheeks as she held her hand. She could feel the pressure around her fingers.

"What the hell was that? Shiri, can you hear us?" *Aunt Catra said, moving her finger for Shiri's eyes to follow.*

"I thought we had more time… we need more time…" *she heard her mama sob. Everything felt sore, her eyes hurt trying to follow the finger so she closed them. She heard more footsteps coming towards them and a voice that she hoped she would not hear.*

"Moms? Is everything okay? Oh, gods, Shiri?!" *she heard Finn said as they got closer.*

"Finn, go back to the party," *she heard Aunt Adora say but felt Finn on the other side of her, grabbing her free hand.*

"What happened? She was fine ten minutes ago! She just needed to go to the bathroom!" *they told the group and she felt arms underneath her as she was lifted into the air. She let out a groan of protest and felt her mom shush her softly, cradling her to her chest.*

"It's okay," *Lexie whispered softly into her ear.* "Mom's got you. We're going home."

She felt her body tense again, felt the heat rising. She opened her eyes painfully, her brown ones meeting her mom's identical ones as they flashed white and she let out a gasp, back arching in her mom's tight grip. She vaguely heard yells, felt movement as her mom walked quickly down the hall before the world went black.

–

Shiri felt warm and safe, a feeling she had not felt in a long time. She could not remember the last time she woke up feeling so… content. She curled closer into the arms, nuzzling the fur softly, feeling the sunshine against her exposed skin. She never wanted to leave that bed again.

Her happy bubble was shattered when she felt the arms move and the body sit up and she heard the unmistakable sounds of regret. A whispered *what the fuck did I do* send her world crumbling down and the safety she had felt a moment before turned into an instinct to protect herself from the pain she could feel bubbling up.

She opened her eyes, closing them quickly as the light burned them and pain flared in her head from her hangover. A hiss escaped her lips and she felt them turn towards her. She opened her eyes again, slowly, and was rendered breathless by the sight.

Finn, illuminated by the morning sun, baby blue eyes gleaming as they looked down at her, the sheet wrapped around them. The

look was familiar, she had seen it all those years ago at Princess Prom. Like she was the only person in the world that mattered. But this time, she knew better. She knew she never mattered to them and she sat up slowly, stretching her limbs gently as she got ready to get out of bed.

"Shiri? I'm so sorry-" Finn started but Shiri held up a finger, rubbing one of her temples with the free hand as she grabbed a jar from the side of the bed, opening it up and pulling out a flower, tossing it in her mouth to chew before offering the jar to them.

"Helps with hangovers. Don't wanna go home to your perfect moms with one," she told them, keeping her back facing their way as she felt them dip into the pot for the plant. She put the jar up. "Can we talk? About last night?" Finn said after a moment and Shiri shook her head.

"What's there to talk about? We had sex, it was amazing and now you regret it. That's fine. Could you have your pity party somewhere else though? I have a long day ahead," she told them, hoping to compose her face before she faced them again. She felt arms wrap around her waist, a chin resting on her shoulder as she tensed, feeling their breath tickle her ear.

"I don't regret anything. I don't want you to regret it. You were drunk," they whispered softly in her ear, planting a kiss right below it. She shuddered, feeling the tension leave her body.

"I don't regret it. You were drunk too," she said, feeling them rub their cheek against her bare skin, scenting her.

"I was surprised when I woke up. I don't want to hurt you, ever. I'm sorry if I gave any impression that I regretted what we did," they mumbled as they gave her a quick nip on her shoulder. Shiri's resolve broke and she turned to face them, pouncing, pushing them back on the bed.

“You didn’t hurt me. It was… amazing. And I could go again if you’re up for it,” she whispered against their lips and was satisfied when she was pulled down to join them.

–

She finally rolled out of bed later that afternoon, after giving Finn a lingering kiss as they snuck out of her balcony window. She felt like she was walking on clouds, elated and giddy. There was a pleasant soreness in her legs and she admired the various hickeys and bite marks that marred her skin as her bath ran.

As she soaked, she thought about them. Their hands, their lips, their eyes. She even admitted to herself that the attraction she had felt for them had never subsided, not even after these many years. Truly, nothing could ruin her perfect day.

Not even her family, as she joined them in the library for a late, afternoon tea. Everyone noticed the shift in her demeanor, the normally withdrawn woman almost skipping in to take her seat beside Halina and Nicaise, who played at Halina’s feet. Zimri and Marmoris shared a concerned look as Lexie raised her eyebrow, watching her daughter fix her tea with a rare smile on her face.

“What’s gotten you so happy today, my song?” she asked, taking a sip from her cup as Shiri shook her head.

“Nothing, mom. It’s just a beautiful day and I get to spend it with my family, is all,” Shiri said with a smile, drinking from her cup.

“Bullshit! Something happened between yesterday and today to put you in such a good mood. Are you on drugs? Are you still drunk? Did you sleep with someone?” Zimri shot off in rapid-fire as Halina shook her head, handing Nicaise a cookie.

“It’s times like these that I’m glad he can’t hear and I barely can. Seriously, what’s wrong?” Halina asked, turning to her older sister, who frowned.

“Geez! Can’t a girl just be happy?! I wasn’t aware it was a crime,” she grumbled and Lexie laughed, placing a gentle hand over her daughters.

“It’s just a pleasant surprise, song. It’s rare that we have you so happy. It’s a nice change,” Lexie reassured her.

“Oh! Mom! Archer asked to escort me to Princess Prom this year. May I attend with him?” Halina perked up and Shiri snorted, sitting down her cup.

“No, you may not,” she told her sister and Halina frowned. Marmoris muttered a curse as he ducked his head, feeling the fight start to brew between the sisters.

“Last I checked, you weren’t my mom. I believe I was talking with her, sis,” Halina scolded.

“Why do you think Archer should not escort her? He’s a prince, he’s very polite, we’ve known him for years, ever since he was born. Give me one good reason why he shouldn’t,” Lexie asked Shiri, who grabbed a scone.

“First, I know the kind of people he’s been with. Second, I think there’s something going on between him and Princess Sereia. Third, he’s my age, at least seven years older than she is. It’s not a good match and I won’t allow it,” Shiri said matter-of-factly.

“You’re being unreasonable, sis. He’s a nice guy. He’s been nothing but sweet and caring, he even brought me a book for my birthday, A History of the Kingdom of Musicia. He likes me, maybe could even love me. I know I’m already head over heels. I think it’s true love, like what mom and mama had,” Halina smiled, a little dreamily and Shiri snorted.

“What do you know about true love? You’re just a child,” she told her and Halina glared at her.

“More than you! All you know how to do is push people away and keep up your walls. You don’t know anything about love because

you never allow yourself to feel it! All you ever want to feel is your next drug high and someone between your legs!”

“Girls! That’s enough!” Lexie said and Shiri stood abruptly, knocking over her teacup.

“Love makes you weak! There is no such thing as true love, Halina. Grow up. It is a silly tale they tell us when we are kids so we can have hopes for the future! Why tie yourself to someone only to watch them die?! Did you forget what happened to mom when mama died?!”

“I didn’t forget! I’ve never forgotten! I was there! Where were you?!” Halina said, standing up as well.

“I was running this kingdom while she wallowed in her “true love”! I was trying to protect you! I was trying to make sure you had some semblance of childhood again! I kept everything afloat because I didn’t let love make me weak!”

“You’ve done none of that for me! You’ve only ever kept me from what I truly wanted. I’ve had to indulge in your childish fantasies for far too long! You’re killing yourself and you won’t drag me down with you! Stay the hell out of my life!”

The glassware on the table shattered, causing everyone but Shiri to flinch away from the table quickly. Lexie quickly picked Nicaise off the floor. Shiri took a deep breath through her nose, keeping her gaze steady at Halina before turning and walking towards the library doors.

“Oh, yea! Runaway! That’s all you’re good at doing! Running from everything! You ran from the funeral, you ran from your duties as queen, you ran from your feelings and you’re running now since it’s too hard to face!” Halina taunted, Lexie, grabbing her shoulder angrily.

“That’s enough, Halina! What’s gotten into you?” Lexie demanded.

But Shiri had stopped, clenching her fists angrily as she tried to regain control of herself. The drugs were supposed to prevent things like this from happening but she could feel herself slipping, they weren't being as effective anymore.

"Shiri?" Zimir said softly, putting a hand on her shoulder. He felt the faint trembling, knowing tears were not far behind.

"You heard her. I'm to stay out of her life. When she gets hurt, it's your problem, not mine," she said softly before shrugging off his hand and walking out of the room.

–

Finn had tried their best to sneak back into Brightmoon, hoping to avoid detection. That was not the case since their mom Catra was just as sneaky as they were and had managed to corner them in the hallway as they slipped past the guards.

"Where have you been, Finn? We were worried sick!" she asked them, arms crossed over her chest as she glared at them. Nala peeked around, sticking her tongue out at them.

"I went out with everyone last night, I made sure Shiri got home safely and I crashed in a spare room. Geez, mom, I'm old enough to go out on my own," they told her, mimicking her posture. She narrowed her eyes.

"Oh, yea? What's that on your neck?" she smirked and they quickly rushed a hand up to cover their neck, eyes wide.

"Nothing! I got into a fight!" they lied and Catra laughed.

"There's nothing on your neck. But now I know something happened. Let me guess, you spent the morning keeping a certain princess company?" she suggested, wiggling her eyebrows and Finn flushed.

"You're so embarrassing! It wasn't like that!"

“Wasn’t like what?” they heard and turned to see Adora come up the hallway. Nala ran over to her mom, who scooped her up into her arms.

“Finn was keeping a princess company!” she tattled and Adora looked at Finn, eyebrows raised in question.

“I was making sure Shiri made it home safe and I crashed there. It’s no big deal! You guys are making it a big deal!” they argued.

“Your child was definitely doing more than making sure she was safe,” Catra supplied and Adora frowned.

“You need to be careful, Finn. Shiri is very powerful and dangerous if crossed. You say or do the wrong thing, this whole mission blows up in our faces before we even get started,” she warned and Finn rolled their eyes.

“Shiri wouldn’t hurt a fly. I’ve known her for years! I’m not in any danger, mom,” they told her and noticed the look their moms shared.

“I hope you’re right… I don’t like to think that she would purposely hurt you,” Adora told them.

“Mom? What happened to her? She’s… different. She’s always guarded, always careful, like one slipup could cost her everything. I remember something happened to her at the last Princess Prom but no one ever told me what. This Shiri is different from the Shiri I knew.”

“It’s not our problem to tell. I can say that she had managed it but then Calliope passed away… She has suffered a lot recently, she carries tremendous responsibility and we need to make sure she stays safe,” Catra supplied and Finn sighed, nodding.

“Nothings going on between us. She’s my friend and I care about her. Trust me?” they told their moms, who hesitated, obviously not believing them but wanting to trust them.

“If you say nothing is happening… then we’ll take your word for it,” Adora told them. “Now, are you hungry? We should grab lunch.”

Finn nodded, following his mom’s along through the hallways of Brightmoon to the kitchen to grab lunch.

Chapter End Notes

> What do you think of these revelations? What would you like to see happen?

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Shiri has some major talks with her mom and Finn, she misses her sister

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 7

Shiri laid in her window seat, wrapped up in a blanket and hugging an old, stuffed whale, back facing the room as she stared out over the city. She always loved this view, watching the bustle of activity was relaxing and she needed to relax right now. The morning bliss had faded away to tension and pain and she had wanted to take an extra dose of her drugs, to suppress the bubble of power she felt swelling within her but she resisted. She needed to make the vials last as long as possible.

She heard a knock at her door but didn't bother to answer, knowing whoever was outside it would come in either way. After a few moments, the door opened and footsteps padded through the room, very light, so it couldn't be her brother, brother-in-law, or godfather. She felt the body sit at the edge of the window bench and heard a soft sigh.

"Shiri… we need to talk about today," her mother said softly and Shiri shook her head, refusing to look at her.

"There's nothing to talk about. Everything that needed to be said was said. Just leave me alone," Shiri murmured, burying deeper into the blanket.

"We used to talk all the time. I miss those days. Where you would curl up on my lap after a hard day and I would brush your hair, like I would do your mama's… you had such beautiful hair…"

“Those days are over, mom. They’ve been over for years. I can’t trust you to pick me up when I fall, I can’t trust anyone.”

“It shouldn’t be like that. I should be the one person you trust with everything, you used to trust me with everything…”

“Until you abandoned us after mama died. We needed you… I needed you and you checked out. I had to run this kingdom, I had to take care of my siblings, it was all on me. I trusted you to take care of us and you let me down. How can I trust you now, mom?” Shiri asked and Lexie heard the pain, the vulnerability in her daughter's voice.

“Come here, my song. Please?” Lexie asked, scooting back so her back was to the window. Shiri sat up slightly, looking apprehensive. Lexie held out her arms and, like a small child, Shiri crawled over and rested her head in her mother’s lap, keeping the stuffed whale close. Lexie grabbed the blanket, pulling it over her daughter's body before gently stroking her hair.

“I’m sorry… for what I said earlier… I know you just missed mama…” Shiri said after a few minutes of silence, slowly relaxing under her mother’s touch as the older woman worked her fingers through the short, black strands.

“I should be apologizing. I don’t think I ever did after what happened. You were right, I let love make me weak… until I remembered a stronger love I had. She never left us. I see her in your smile, I hear her in Halina’s laughter, I feel her in Zimri’s music, I even smell on her Nicaise. I know a part of her lives on and that helped me remember that I could go on without her. It hurts, it will never stop hurting, but she would not want me to keep living in the past.”

“Mom… I don’t trust you and that’s been hurting me. Just… give me time? I learn to trust again?” Shiri asked and her mother paused, hand hovering over her head for a moment before resuming its strokes.

"Of course. Take all the time you need. Should we set up some therapy with Perfuma? I think it would help you a lot."

"Noooooo! I'm fine. I don't need therapy, just time."

"Alright! Alright! I won't push the therapy thing. How about we make sure to set aside some time for us to spend together? Just the two of us, like we used to do," Lexie told her and Shiri nodded, closing her eyes.

"I would like that… spending time with you. Hey, mom?"

"Yes, my song?"

"Can you sing to me? I miss hearing your voice…"

"Of course, my song. How about your mama's lullaby, hmm?" Lexie continued to stroke her hair as she started singing softly.

Sun goes down and we are here together

Fireflies glow like a thousand charms

Stay with me and you can dream forever

Right here in my arms, tonight

Shiri relaxed completely, allowing herself to start drifting off. Her mother's voice was always magic, just like her mamas.

It's magic when you are here beside me

Just close your eyes and let me hold you tight

Everything that I could ever need is

Right here in my arms, tonight

Shiri's breath evened out as she fell asleep and Lexie kissed her head softly, smiling.

“Give Halina a little time as well. She’ll come around in a few days and apologize,” she whispered softly.

_____

Except Halina never did. Anytime the two sisters saw each other in the hallways, Halina would walk the other way to avoid Shiri. A few days of this and Shiri thought she was just being a brat but after a week, she realized that Halina was genuinely pissed at her. It filled her stomach with dread.

The nights were lonely with Halina in bed beside her, lonelier than she had felt in years. She always left her sister’s side of the bed open, in case she changed her mind, but she never did. That side of the bed was always cold and empty come morning. After a week or so, Shiri broke down.

That’s how Finn found her one night as they climbed up the side of the palace using the vines, hopped onto her balcony, and slid into the room. Even in the dark, they could see everything clearly. They noticed the curled-up figure on the bed and heard the unmistakable sobs coming from the huddled form.

“Shiri?” they whispered softly as they approached the bed. Shiri buried her head in the pillow, stifling her sobs, trying to regain control.

“Are you okay?” they asked, touching her shoulder gently. She took a shaky breath, hiccuping as she turned her head to look at them. They noticed the red-rimmed eyes and immediately climbed into the bed behind her, wrapping their arms around her waist.

Shiri bit her lip, holding back her cries as Finn held her, curling around her protectively. Their tail came up and wrapped around her wrist.

“You don’t have to tell me what happened but I’m going to hold you until you are okay, however long it takes. This is your safe space, you can cry, you can scream, you can do whatever you

need to do to make yourself feel better but I will not leave you. It's okay to be vulnerable, Shiri. You don't have to be strong all the time."

This caused Shiri's sobs to come back full throttle, they racked her body, leaving her trembling. Finn just tightened their grip, held her close, buried their face into her hair as she sobbed. She fell apart in their arms and they held her together until the tears ran dry, her body stopped trembling, and the only movements they felt were her hiccups.

They laid together like that for hours, it seemed. Finally, Shiri flipped over, facing Finn and caressing their cheek gently.

"What are you doing here?" she asked, voice thick from crying. Finn stared into her eyes, placing a hand on her cheek similar to hers.

"I wanted to see you… I missed you," they murmured, glad she couldn't see them in the dark. She didn't say anything, instead closing the distance to kiss them gently. It was soft, mixed with salty tears yet sweet. They kissed her back, hoping beyond hope she could feel everything they couldn't say, shouldn't say.

"I know what you missed," she whispered softly against their lips, moving to hover over them as she started trailing kisses down their jaw, their neck, their collarbone. Finn frowned at what she said, gently pushing on her shoulders to move her away.

"Shiri… you're upset. We can't do this," they told her and watched as more tears glistened in her eyes.

"Please… Please, please, please," Shiri begged, hating feeling so weak and raw in front of someone. "I hate feeling like this. I don't want to feel like this anymore, I want to feel… Please, Finn… Please help me feel something else!"

Tears streamed down her cheeks, her cheeks heated up with embarrassment as she sat there, straddling their lap, feeling

vulnerable. Finn sat up, wrapping their arms around her waist and placing a gentle kiss on her sternum.

"Okay… whatever you need, I'm here for you," they conceded and Shiri let out a shuddering sigh of relief and pulled them back into a kiss, releasing a small hum from her chest.

–

They laid entangled in each other all morning, not knowing where one's limbs started and the others ended. Shiri kept her head on Finn's chest as they lazily stroked her back, occasionally sending shudders up and down her spine. They were quiet, just basking in the morning sun and the afterglow of sex.

"Shiri?" Finn said softly, eliciting a hmmm from their partner. "What is this? What are we?"

Shiri scrunched her eyebrows, drumming her fingers lightly on their stomach. "We're… friends… who do things together. We're destressing and… having fun… right?" She moved her arms to fold them on top of their chest and propped her chin up to look at them. They smiled at her, brushing some hair from her face.

"I'm having fun, I hope you are," they smirked and she blushed, nodding.

"I am. I never would have thought I would get the almighty Finn into my bed, though. How far you have fallen," she teased and Finn snorted.

"I fell into bed with you but I wouldn't say it was a bad thing. I would wager that it was something we both wanted to do for a while," they told her.

"I used to have a huge crush on you when we were kids," she admitted and Finn raised an eyebrow at her.

"Used too? Are you saying you don't still have a crush on me? I'm pretty awesome," they bragged and Shiri sat up, wrapping the

blanket around herself as she rolled her eyes.

“Who in their right mind would ever like you! You’re so embarrassing!” she said as she threw a pillow at their face. Finn caught it, laughing as they sat up as well.

“Admit it! You like me, Shiri! Maybe even loveeee me!” they teased and she groaned, hitting them with another pillow.

“I don’t like you! It was a stupid crush! Everyone had one on you! I had a lot of competition! Ugghhh, I’m so over it anyways!”

Finn raised an eyebrow, cocking their head to the side as they watched her. “Are you lying or is it because of the person you’re with now? You mentioned them at the club the other night,” they asked, referencing Alejandro. She stiffened, clutching the sheet tighter around her.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about. I’m not with anyone,” she lied and Finn snorted.

“You’re lying. You told me the other week when we were at the club in the Crimson Waste. Bragged about your man getting jealous at watching us dance.”

“What?! That was you?! Oh, my gods!” she hid her face in her hands, going red hot with disbelief and embarrassment.

“So… who is he? Seems like he’s my competition,” Finn teased her and she jerked her head up in horror, shaking her head.

“There’s no competition! You can’t compete with him. He’ll…” she bit her tongue to stop herself from continuing. Finn frowned, placing a hand on her shoulder.

“Hey, I was joking. There’s no competition if you don’t want it. I guess you can have your cake and eat it too? Or however, that saying goes.”

“I don’t want you to get hurt… Maybe this is a mistake, we should stop seeing each other,” she suggested and Finn scooted closer, grabbing her legs and pulling her towards them so that they wrapped, loosely, around their waist and they wrapped their arms around her.

“What do you want?” they asked, resting their forehead against hers so that they were staring at each other’s eyes. They could never get over how beautiful her brown eyes looked in the sunlight. “If we end this, it won’t stop me from being there for you. You can’t get rid of me again. I’m not afraid of anyone.”

She ran her fingers through their blonde locks, moving her hand down to scratching behind their ear, eliciting soft purrs. “I want… is it selfish that I want you but I can’t leave him?”

“Is he hurting you? Blackmailing you? If something is going on, you can tell me. I can help you,” Finn whispered against her lips and she closed her eyes, contemplating. She wanted to tell them. She wanted to come clean about Alejandro and the drugs hiding in her bathroom, about her powers, her fears, her mama.

“It’s not that simple… I put myself in this situation and I can’t leave. And I can’t tell you why. You’ll think differently of me and I want you to always see me like this. Just some silly girl who fell into bed with you.”

“You’re not some silly girl. You’ve never been just some silly girl to me. The night you left, at Princess Prom all those years ago, was the hardest thing I had to go through. I lost my best friend that night and I never knew why. I would not believe how happy I was to see you all those weeks ago at that club. You see… I used to have a crush on you too.”

“You did not,” she chuckled softly, planting a soft kiss on their nose.

“I did so. You were always the most beautiful creature to walk Etheria to me. You still are…”

“Finn… are you… trying to admit something to me?” she asked, feeling breathless. “Because if you are, you should stop. I’m not that girl anymore… I’m not someone you should waste your love and affection on. I can’t… give it back to you. I can’t love you the way you deserve to be loved. Besides, I kinda hate your mom.”

“Then I won’t confess completely. I’ll wait until the day you feel like you can give back love. I’ll hold out hope that you can feel for me the same way I can feel for you. Until then, we can stay like this. Wrapped up in each other, naked, happy, and definitely… not in love.”

“Yea… totally not in love.”

Chapter End Notes

Song Credits to Right Here in My Arms from Barbie and the Island Princess

Also! They are so totally NOT in love, right? Please don't hurt me!

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Halina recounts the events that led to her mother's death and reveals a secret about Shiri

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 8

Halina was refusing to talk to Shiri. She knew she was being childish, that this was something that they could work out together but Halina was beyond fed up with her. Shiri was selfish and didn't want Halina to be happy, which is what Halina had convinced herself. If Shiri had to be miserable, she was going to make everyone around her miserable.

It had probably been two to three weeks since their fight. This was the longest fight they had been in, even longer than the time Halina 'borrowed' Shiri's favorite heels when they were younger. Halina did miss sleeping beside her sister, they had a routine, Shiri always slept by her good ear cause her steady breathing calmed her down after nightmares.

The nightmares were the worst part of sleeping alone. She was exhausted from the lack of sleep, bags were starting to form under her eyes. Halina found herself dozing in the library one afternoon, curled up in a comfy, overstuffed chair with her legs tucked underneath her. Nicaise was with their mom, giving her the free time to do what she wanted.

She didn't even realize she had fallen asleep until she felt a blanket be tucked around her. She dropped her book, her eyes shooting up as Archer held up his hands, smiling. She hadn't heard him, her good ear facing down into the arm of the chair. She gave him a small smile back, lifting her head slightly.

"I'm sorry I woke you. Your mom told me you were in here and I was hoping to spend some time together but if you're tired, you can sleep instead," Archer told her and she shook her head, adjusting so she was sitting up better but keeping the blanket around her.

"No, it's fine. I wasn't planning on sleeping, I just got comfy…" she yawned and Archer laughed at her, taking a seat a chair opposite of her.

"You look like you haven't slept well in a while. Are you still fighting with Shiri? You should just make up already so you can sleep," he told her and Halina shook her head, frowning.

"No. She was wrong and being paranoid. She doesn't know anything and I won't apologize to her until she apologizes to me first."

"So stubborn, you remind me of my mom and sister. You need to take better care of yourself, Hallie."

"I am… I sleep just fine… when I don't have nightmares," Halina mumbled, placing a hand over her bad ear. She had worn her hair up today, which was rare since she didn't like people looking at the scarred lump of flesh that used to be an ear. Archer had noticed but didn't say anything. He didn't want to make her feel uncomfortable about the deformity.

"What do you have nightmares about, if you don't mind me asking?"

She gave him a sad smile, moving her hand away from her ear, giving it a little tap with her finger. "The day I lost this… and my mama. The day everything changed…"

"What happened… everyone has been so tightlipped about her… It's like they try to forget Aunt Calliope ever existed…"

"It's easier to forget than to remember something so tragic… It wasn't pretty what happened… I can still feel her blood on me…"

"If it's too hard to talk about, you don't have to. I won't make you," Archer told her and Halina scooted over in her chair some, patting the extra space.

"Just… stay by my side while I tell it?" she offered and Archer hesitated before coming over, taking up the available space. Halina wiggled around some before getting comfortable, her back against his front as they angled themselves. Archer wrapped a reassuring arm around her shoulder.

Halina took a deep breath before starting. "I was fifteen… we were heading to Brightmoon for the day to have tea with your mom and sister…"

/Flashback\

"I wish you'd wait until after having the baby, love. Glimmer and Shimmer will still be in Brightmoon until then *," Lexie tried to reason with Calliope, who was waddling around from her large belly as she helped the maids set up the skiff. Halina was bouncing on the balls of her feet, too excited to keep still.*

"I'm fine, my love. I've been telling Glimmer I would come to have tea with her for months, Hallie wants to see Shimmer, and I need to do business in Brightmoon anyways. This gang problem in the Whispering Woods is not going to solve itself," *Calliope told her, stopping to turn towards her wife. Lexie looked worried, biting her lip.*

"You've already told Adora about the problem. She's off-planet right now anyway, there's not much business to do. You should stay home, rest," *Lexie whispered, closing the space between them as much as she can with her belly in the way. She placed her hands on either side of the belly.* "Your ankles are swollen. I can run you a bath with your favorite bubbles, rub your back, maybe do a little more," *she whispered suggestively, kissing her neck softly. Calliope giggled, wrapping her arms around her wife's neck.*

"Mmm, that sounds so nice… Maybe tonight? Have the bath waiting for me?"

"Of course. And… your favorite cake as well," *Lexie teased and Calliope gasped, smiling.*

"Double chocolate with cookie crumble? You are too good to me, my wife."

"Anything for the mother of my children. Gotta make sure my son comes out fat and happy," *Lexie said as she got to her knees and kissed Calliope's belly.* "You hear that? You are going to be the fattest, happiest baby in all of Etheria. You take it easy on your mama while she's gone today."

"Mom! Can we go now?!" *Halina yelled from the skiff, taking a seat. Zimri shook his head, coming down the stairs to see his mama and sister off.*

"Yes, sweetheart. I'm coming," *Calliope said as Lexie stood up and led her over to the skiff. Calliope stopped in front of Zimri, caressing his cheek gently. He easily towered over her but always leaned down when she stopped.*

"Keep your mom from worrying about us, my music? We'll be back by nightfall," *Calliope asked him and he nodded, kissing her cheek.*

"I'll try, mama. You know how she gets. Don't forget I have a date with Marmoris tonight so I won't be here when you get back," *Zimri reminded her as he helped her get onto the skiff.*

"I hope you're going to put a ring on his finger soon. I like that man, he would make a great son-in-law," *Calliope teased as she took her seat beside Halina, resting a hand on her belly.*

"Soon, Mama. I promise," *Zimri told her, stepping back and wrapping an arm around Lexie's shoulders, who wrapped her arm around his waist.* "Give our best to everyone in Brightmoon!"

"I love you, Hallie. Be good for your mama. Calliope, I love you. Be safe, promise?" *Lexie said as the drive started up the skiff.*

"I promise! I'll see you tonight!" *Calliope blew her a kiss as the skiff took off out of the city.*

_

An explosion had sent them flying while they were in the Whispering Woods. It wasn't a normal explosion, the noise it had given off had been a sonic pulse and when Halina had come too, she only heard ringing in her ears. All she saw was the sky above her, it was spinning as she slowly sat up, her head pounding.

Halina saw smoke and flames, bodies moving around. She turned her head as the ringing slowly stopped and noise started coming back to one ear. She heard a scream and turned her head to see her mama, holding a large stick as someone ran at her with a spear, puncturing her side with it.

Halina screamed as the assailant pulled the spear up, turning towards her as they got distracted. It gave Calliope enough time to swing the stick, knocking the assailant off balance long enough to get them to the ground. Calliope got on top of the, grabbing a large rock, and bashed their head in. Halina proceeded to vomit at the sight, coughing.

When she looked back up, her mama was slumped onto the ground, heaving heavily. Halina crawled towards her, crying. Halina managed to roll her mama on her back and sobbed at the sight. She was covered in blood, it was pouring out of her ears, nose, and mouth. She was holding the side of her belly, where blood was gushing the worse.

" Mama? Mama, can you hear me?" *Halina asked her and got no response. Calliope gritted her teeth from the pain, everything silent around her as the ringing had stopped. She cried out as she felt a contraction hit her and looked up to see Halina's worried face above her.*

“Hallie…” *she whispered softly, reaching a bloody hand up to touch her daughter's cheek.* “I can’t hear anything so listen to me, okay? It’s going to be okay, my calmness. I need you to nod your head if you can understand me.”

Halina nodded her head quickly, keeping a hold of her mother’s hand on her cheek.

“I’m having contractions. Your baby brother is coming. I’m bleeding really badly too… Okay? Is the driver alive?” *Calliope said, trying to keep her voice steady and tears held back. She needed to stay calm and strong for Hallie. Halina looked around, spotting the driver. She gave her mother’s hand a squeeze before crawling away from her to check on him.*

She shook his shoulder gently and he instantly sat up, coughing. She waved her hand in front of his face, grabbing his attention.

“Can you hear me?” *she asked and he blinked at her before nodding slightly, pointing to one ear. She let out a small sigh of relief and then pointed to her mama.*

“The queen is badly hurt. She’s gone into labor, we need to get her back to the city. How far are we?”

“At least ten miles away… we’ll never make it,” *he told her and she stood up, staggering as pain shot up her ankle.*

“Let’s uhh… try to get her as close as possible… We can stop when she needs it… We need to get help,” *Halina told him and heard her mother cry out in pain. She went back over to her, hobbling, and knelt down by her side.*

“I’m here, mama. What do I do?” *she sobbed. Her mother was getting paler and Halina pulled off her shirt, moving her mama'ss hand to press it firmly against her side to help slow down the bleeding.*

“Hallie… I know this is scary… Please, save your brother. If it comes down to me or the baby, save the baby, please,” *Calliope*

cried, putting a hand over her mouth to stop her sobs. She didn't even see Halina shake her head vigorously. The driver came over, having created some sort of gurney from two large sticks and a spare blanket from the skiff.

"It's going to be easier if we drag her on this instead of carrying her…" *he told her and Halina nodded, watching as he adjusted it on the ground and took Calliope underneath her shoulders, slowly dragging her onto the blanket. She screamed in pain, sobbing until he got her down onto the gurney.* "I'm so sorry, my queen! I'm so sorry!" *He kept apologizing.*

"You're both going to be okay, mama. We're going home and mom will know what to do. Just hold on, please," *Halina told her and grabbed one of the sticks as the driver grabbed the other. It elevated Calliope up off the ground some and they slowly started dragging her in the direction of the city.*

_

They had to stop constantly. Halina's ankle was bad off, she knew she was making it worse by limping on it and Calliope would have another contraction that would cause them to pause so she could breathe through it. She was getting weaker the longer they went. They had been walking for hours and felt no closer to the city.

"Hallie? Hallie, stop… I have to push…" *she heard her mother call weakly and she and the driver set the gurney so she could circle around and be by her mama's side. She took her mama's hand and squeezed it reassuringly.*

"I need to push… You need to be down there to get him… okay? I'm so tired…" *Calliope mumbled softly and Halina nodded, moving down to her legs. She looked up at the driver.*

"Hold her hand? She needs the reassurance," *Halina told him and he nodded, kneeling down beside Calliope and taking her hand just like Halina did, squeezing it. Halina helped her spread her legs, thankfully she had chosen to wear a dress that day. She then*

tapped her leg one and made a pushing motion to tell her mama to push and then tapped the leg twice to tell her mama when to stop.

Calliope nodded in understanding, taking a deep breath as Halina waited for her next contraction. When she saw her mama's face contrast in pain, she tapped her leg once and her mama started pushing. Calliope gritted her teeth, grunting loudly as she squeezed the driver's hand. Halina counted to ten and then tapped her mother's leg twice, allowing the queen to relax back with a sob.

Halina rubbed her leg reassuringly and they repeated this process a few times until she could see the head crown. She squeezed her mama's leg, smiling.

"I see his head! Keep pushing!" *she yelled, tapping her leg twice and her mama let out a cry, pushing as hard as she could until Halina eased the baby out, immediately placing him on her mama's chest as his cries rang out through the woods. Calliope sobbed along with him, feeling his cries on her chest as she wrapped an arm around him.*

"Hey, baby," *she cried, looking at him.* "Oh gods, you're so beautiful. Beautiful boy," *she whispered, kissing his head.*

"I don't have anything for the umbilical cord…" *Halina told the driver, who frowned.*

"We either keep them attached or rip it… both are dangerous and we're still a good five miles away…"

Halina's breath hitched, mind reeling with what she should do. Keep them attached or rip the cord…

"Rip it… *" she heard her mama whisper and looked up hopefully. Calliope was staring down at the cord, eyes growing glassy.* "You need to rip it… I'm dying, it'll hurt him…"

“You’re not dying! Not on my watch!” *Halina gritted out, grabbing the cord and doing her best to rip it apart, detaching mother and son from each other. It was messy and hard but she managed to get it done. As she finished, she heard the familiar sound of an approaching skiff and looked up to see one heading in their direction.*

“Take the baby…” *Calliope told her as the driver waved down the skiff, screaming. Halina shook her head and Calliope held him out to her, arms shaking.*

“Please… take your brother… I can’t… I’m…” *her head lulled back and Halina quickly grabbed the baby, holding him tightly to her chest. The skiff stopped, two musicians disembarking as the driver explained what happened and they helped load everyone onboard. The baby started crying again and Halina hummed softly, keeping them pressed against her chest so they could feel the vibrations as the skiff headed back to Musicia.*

–

“Callie?! Calliope?! What happened?!” *Halina heard her mom scream as the skiff stopped at the palace and the two samaritans helped unload Calliope, carrying her inside. Halina followed after quickly, keeping the baby clutched to her.*

“We were attacked in the woods! Those gang members' mama was so worried about using some kind of explosive device that took out our hearing. She can’t hear at all, the driver and I have partial hearing. One of them stabbed her with a spear, she had to deliver early…”

“Where’s the healer?! Get them quickly!” *her mom demanded quickly as they led them into their bedroom, helping the samaritans settle Calliope down onto the bed. Calliope was too weak to even mutter out a complaint, completely caked in dirt and blood, her skin paler than Lexie had ever seen before.*

Lexie sat beside her, stroking her hair as tears streamed down her cheeks. "It's okay, baby. I'm here… you're home now. The healers are coming, they're going to help you."

Calliope stared up at Lexie, watching her lips move but not hearing anything. This felt familiar… She took Lexie's hand into her own, squeezing weakly.

"Nicaise… that's our son's name… He's going to need his mom now more than ever…" *Calliope said softly and Halina came over to the other side of the bed, gently making her way onto it with the baby and laying beside her mama. Lexie shook her head stubbornly.*

"You're going to be fine! You're fine, help is coming, my love," *she told her, kissing her softly. Calliope's breathing started to labor as Lexie pulled away, never letting go of her.*

"My Hallie… my calm after the storm… you were so strong today… I'm so proud of you. Help your mom… help your sister when she becomes queen…"

"I will, mama… I promise…" *Halina sobbed, burying her face into her mama's shoulder.*

"Zimri… tell my music I love him… and my song… my Shiri… she's going to become a wonderful queen… I'm so proud of all of you…"

"Callie… you promised," *Lexie cried, pressing her wife's hands against her lips.* "We were going to grow old together. Gray hair and everything… It can't end like this. Not after everything we've been through!"

"Lexie… my love… thank you… for the most wonderful life together… thank you for… loving me… for being by my side… as my wife… and queen… thank you… for our four… amazing kids… take care of them… promise me?"

"I promise! I promise! You were the best thing in my life. I love you so much, I love you more than every star in the damn sky," *Lexie whispered, watching as Calliope's body relaxed into the bed and her head fell to the side, looking out into the room with glassy eyes.*

"Daddy…? I'm ready… I love you…" *she whispered softly, her body completely going slack as her breathing stopped.*

"Callie…? Callie?! Callie, no!" *Lexie screamed and didn't stop screaming, sobbing violently as she held her wife in her arms.*

/End of Flashback\

Archer stared, wide-eyed, at the back of Halina's head as she finished her story, her body having tensed during the retelling. She had started playing with her bad ear as well, trembling gently.

"That's… oh gods, Halina… how did you…?"

"It was my mama's dying wish that I take care of my siblings… I took care of Nicky when mom lost herself for six months… I take care of Shiri, make sure she doesn't lose herself…"

"Where was Shiri during all of this?! Why wasn't she here?!" Archer asked, jumping up to start pacing. Halina stared at him, sad.

"Shiri… she was born with a powerful gift, something she had been learning to control… she was gone training when this happened…"

"A gift? Training? You're not making any sense, Hallie," Archer told her.

"It's not that it matters anymore… she doesn't have the gift anymore. She suppresses it with drugs she gets from her pimp," Halina told him bitterly, causing him to freeze in his tracks.

“Wait a minute… pimp? Drugs? What is your sister involved in?” Halina looked uncomfortable, rubbing her arms nervously.

“She… I caught her injecting herself with some red liquid once, about a year after mama died… she hadn’t had any visions, we didn’t think anything of it till I caught her. She’s with a very bad man, I don’t know what he does exactly but he supplies her. She’s suppressing her powers, she’s been doing it for about two years now and she swore me to secrecy! She keeps the vials hidden in a cubby in her bathroom!”

“Why are you telling me this…?” Archer asked, kneeling in front of her to take her hands, using a free one to wipe a stray tear from her cheek. She reached her hand up, touching her tear-stained cheeks, unaware she had started crying.

“I don’t know… I guess I’m tired of keeping secrets… and watching her kill herself… How is she going to rule a kingdom if she can’t keep herself together?”

“We’re going to help her… we’ll stage an intervention or something, get her off the drugs. She’s going to be fine, Halina. We won’t allow her to keep doing this to herself,” he reassured her and she nodded, feeling a sob build.

“I… I’ve kept all that in for so long… It feels good to say it…” she whispered before letting out a strangled sob. Archer leaned forward and hugged her gently, rubbing her back as she cried.

Chapter End Notes

.-. I cried writing this

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

A trip down memory lane, the group learns about Shiri's powers

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 9

Finn remembers when they and Shiri were seven. They had climbed up a tree in the garden at Brightmoon and Shiri, brave, fearless Shiri, had climbed up after them, trying to keep up. She had missed a branch and had fallen out of the tree, breaking her wrist. Finn hadn't been quick enough to catch her and she had gotten hurt.

They had carried her, crying, to their mom Adora, who had healed her. It had been scary, their moms had wiped away a lot of tears and given them cake as consolidation but Finn remembers having given Shiri a promise. A promise they intended to always keep.

"I'm so sorry I didn't catch you!" they had told her as they enjoyed their cake.

"Finn, it's fine! Auntie Adora fixed me up! See!" she had said as she showed off her healed wrist. "I'm all better!"

"But still… that's never going to happen again! I will always protect you, I promise."

She had just smiled at him, a twinkle in her eyes as she went back to eating her cake. Finn remembered this day as they stood by her vanity, fingers glancing over the silver picture frame of the two of them sitting in that very tree when they were seven. That picture had been taken sometime after she had broken her wrist.

They looked over the vanity, taking in all the picture frames that littered it among the various bottles and jars of makeup, perfume, and hair products. There was a photo of all the kids splashing in the ocean in Salineas: Them, Shiri, and Zimri holding baby Halina, Shimmer and Archer, Sereia, Flora, and her little sister, Aster.

Another was of Shiri and Zimri wearing matching outfits at a music festival. They were maybe twelve and wore identical smiles. Another was of the three siblings in Snows on Frosta and Eira's wedding day, the twins were about twenty, Halina was about thirteen. They were bundled up in fur coats, their Aunt Haevyn and Aunt Eira having arms wrapped around their shoulders.

There were so many memories sitting on her vanity, all of Shiri's friends and family smiling out into the room. The biggest photo was a family portrait. It had to have been taken right before Calliope had passed away because her belly was swollen in the picture. She sat on a chair with Halina sitting beside her. Shiri stood above Halina with a hand on her shoulder while Zimri stood above Calliope in a similar position. Lexie stood in the middle, holding hands with Calliope. They were all dressed in blues and purples, the colors of their runestone and everyone was happy.

"Finn?" they heard a voice and turned around to see Flora standing behind them, frowning. "Are you okay?"

Finn nodded, glancing back at the photos. They gave a small smile before picking up one of them, Shiri, and Flora wearing flower crowns and having a tea party. "Remember this? When we spent a couple of weeks of summer in Plumeria?"

Flora took the photo, eyes growing soft as she looked it over with a nod. "That was the best summer ever. We played in the Whispering Woods, mom would tell us scary stories from her days in the Horde… I miss this," she said sadly, placing it back where it was while looking over the vanity.

"She missed us… She wouldn't of kept all these photos otherwise. She's been in pain all this time and none of us were here to help

her! What kind of friends are we?" Flora said with a tremor in her voice and Finn patted her shoulder reassuringly.

"We didn't know," they heard behind them and turned, looking at Shimmer who stood in the middle of the room. "She shut everyone out after Aunt Calliope died. Actually, she disappeared for seven years and then shut us all out. How were we supposed to know?"

"We could have checked on her! We didn't have to let her shut us out! We could have demanded answers! The adults have kept too much from us!" Flora said with determination as Archer and Halina stepped out of the bathroom, Halina holding a bag.

"They wouldn't have told you anything. Shiri didn't want anyone to know what happened after the last Princess Prom…" Halina said as she opened the bag, pulling a vial of red liquid out.

"Are you sure she's not going to come bursting in here anytime soon?" Shimmer asked, inching closer to get a good look at the vial.

"She's in Salineas with Sereia. They're probably getting ready to go out for the night. She won't be back until early morning," Halina informed her as Finn took the vial from her, moving the liquid around.

"What is this stuff? Are you sure she's been injecting herself with this?" they asked, dubious. Halina nodded.

"It suppresses her powers. Some kind of drug, I'm not sure. She gets it from Alejandro, I know that much…"

Finn gripped the bottle, rage and jealousy filling them. They hated the thought that Shiri would depend so heavily on scum like Alejandro for something like this. They hated that she depended on this at all.

"What's her powers? Aren't they like everyone else in Musicia?" Shimmer questioned and Halina shook her head.

“It’s not that simple… Every Musician is born with a set of talents. Some are good at water music, others plant music, and so on… the royal family can manifest multiple talents since they are the most connected to the Heart. But Shiri… she’s not just connected to the Heart-”

The bedroom door opened and Lexie stood there, arms folded over her chest as she glared at the group before her. “She is a part of the Heart. Like… if the Heart was to take a human form, it would be her. She doesn’t draw power from it like we do because she already has that power. A child like that is born every… thousand or so years.”

The group winced at her glare, Halina and Finn hiding the vials as she stepped inside, closing the door behind her.

“What do you mean? She can’t be that powerful! That would surpass the power of She-Ra!” Archer exclaimed and Lexie nodded as everyone looked dumbfounded.

“How? What powers does she possess? Why is she suppressing them? What happened that night at Princess Prom?” Finn asked and Lexie motioned for everyone to take a seat as she pulled up a chair. Everyone took a seat on the floor, staring up at her. It reminded her of when they were all children and would listen to her stories about the war.

“She can perform most, if not all of the talents. The thing about children like this is that they usually possess a very special and unique talent that no one else does or very, very few people have. For Shiri… She has visions. She sees the past… the present… and the future. It’s like she has access to the planet’s memory file. But her body can’t handle the visions, they’re a lot for her to take in so her body tries to shut down. It did a lot the first few months, the first night being Princess Prom. She spent seven years down at the Heart of Etheria learning how to control and manage the visions. She had it under control, she was ready to rejoin us and then…”

“And then mama died… and Shiri had a vision of her death while she was at the Heart. She was too late to stop it from coming true. She had to take the throne for half a year while mom recovered from the loss and she was angry… her powers were out of control, she was out of control…” Zimri filled in, slipping into the room. “She got better after she met Alejandro and started using this drug. She wasn’t the Shiri we knew but she wasn’t magically lashing out anymore.”

“Had to replace all the windows in the ballroom after her yelling match with Aunt Adora…” Halina said, gripping the bag.

“Why was she so angry with She-Ra?” Shimmer asked, looking up at her Aunt Lexie.

“She blamed She-Ra for Calliope’s death. If She-Ra had been on the planet when everything happened, she could have healed her. If She-Ra had handled the gang problem in the woods, to begin with, there would have been no danger. To Shiri, if She-Ra had done her duty to Etheria like she was created to do, none of this would have happened,” Lexie explained as Zimri came up behind her, placing a hand on her shoulder.

“On that same note, since She-Ra didn’t perform her duty to Etheria, then there is no need for her. She believes that She-Ra siphons magic from the Heart to fuel her own magic and should return it,” Zimri told them and Finn frowned, shaking their head.

“But mom has her own runestone in the old sword! That doesn’t make any sense!” they argued and Zimri shrugged.

“Where do you think that runestone came from? It’s a part of the Heart that was taken by the First Ones. They created She-Ra as a key to the planet, trying to bypass the natural order the Heart had in place with the kingdom of Musica and the royal family.”

“How do you know all this? None of this information is in any of the history books!” Archer said, glaring up at Zimri in accusation.

“Shiri told me. She can describe it better but during her time at the Heart, she had access to the planet’s memories. She’s seen its past, its present, and its future. She’s like a walking data file for the Heart. There’s a reason our family is considered the guardians of the Heart! Do you know how much power she carries inside of her? Do you know what would happen if it got into the wrong hands if she was put into the wrong hands?” Zimri told them and Finn gasped, standing up quickly.

“That means that Alejandro and the Desert Rose are trying to control the Heart of Etheria through Shiri! She’s in a lot of danger! We have to help her!”

“We can’t!” Halina told him, standing up as well. “She won’t listen to us. This drug and her affections for him cloud her judgment! Besides, if we got her to detox, she would be out of control. She hasn’t had to practice controlling the visions or magic in years! It’s like a bomb, building up pressure. We could potentially do more harm than good.”

“We have to try! I promised to always protect her! We have to do something!”

“And we will,” Archer said, standing as well as Flora and Shimmer. “We confront her tonight when she gets back. We talk to her, convince her this is her idea. We can have my mom create a magical barrier for her to detox in. If she magically lashes out, she’ll be contained and won’t hurt anyone. We could pull her out from under Alejandro’s thumb once and for all.”

“I suggest you head back to Brightmoon and get ready. When she returns, I’ll send her your way with some notion about diplomatic relations or something. Please… you guys were her best friends. If anyone can get through to her and stop this, it’s you,” Lexie told them, looking ten years older than she was. The issue had been weighing heavily on her. “I’m getting old… It’s time that she assumed the throne but she can’t until she works through this…”

“Who knows if she ever wants to be queen anymore. She certainly doesn’t act like it,” Zimri commented, helping his mom stand as he looked at the group. “Please… help my sister.”

“We’re going to do everything in our power to help her! She’s our best friend, even if she doesn’t consider us hers anymore,” Flora told him and he nodded.

“Go on, now!” Lexie told them, shooing them away. “I’ll send her in the morning! You have a lot to do before then!”

The group scattered, Halina giving her mom a kiss on the cheek before taking Archer’s hand and following him out. Lexie sighed as they left, Zimri helping lead them out last.

“Do you think they’ll be able to help her?” He asked as they traveled down the hallway.

“I like to hope so… no one is beyond help. We were Horde soldiers before we found the Rebellion. If not… are you prepared to take the crown?” she asked him, looking up at her eldest son. Zimri nodded.

“I’ll do what I have to to protect Musicia, mom.”

“Thank you, my music.”

Chapter End Notes

Eeek! Climax is coming!

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

Shiri wants out of clubbing but Alejandro won't let it happen so easily

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 10

Shiri and Sereia shared a mirror in the Salineas' princess' bedroom, working on their makeup as the moon rose in the sky. This was like a ritual to them, they had done it so many times together in the last two years. Shiri puckered her lips, loving the bright red that stained them. She had chosen to go more conservative tonight, opting for a black halter top jumpsuit with a gold chair around the waist to contrast it, her mama's Horde pin attached. She matched it with black wedge heels and gold armbands on her upper arms.

Sereia went with a sexier look, wearing a strapless green sequin dress that stopped mid-thigh matched with strappy gold heels. She wore similar gold armbands and a gold choker, gold chains attaching the armbands to the choker. Her hair fell down her back, sticking straight as she had spent hours with it under the heat.

"Final touch," she said and they both stood up, facing each other as she grabbed the perfume bottle to spray them each. That was routine, they always put on the perfume last and they did it together.

"Girl, I think we look hot!" she squealed, dabbing at the corner of her lip with her pinky gently as Shiri smiled, feeling more reserved than usual. She didn't really want to go out tonight but Sereia had insisted. Shiri just wanted to spend the evening with Finn in her room.

“Yea, we look nice,” she commented gently, turning away from the mirror to find her clutch.

“Stop being such a party-pooper! What’s eating you, song? You never turn down a club night!” Sereia reminded her, turning to look at her friend with a hand on her hip. Shiri shrugged, starting to feel the start of the migraine build behind her eyes. She should have taken the drugs before she left home.

“Sereia… can I be honest with you?” she asked, looking at her friend, who frowned but sat down. They were never serious together, that was a rule they had established years ago to keep the pressures of royal life from squishing them.

“You know the rule… it must be bad if you’re breaking it.”

“I just… I think my clubbing days are over. I think this is gonna be my final night going out,” Shiri told her, and Sereia’s jaw dropped, floundering like a fish out of water (which she technically was).

“You can’t be serious, song. Clubbing is like our thing! It’s what keeps us relaxed and stress-free from royal life! Why do you want to stop?”

“I’m starting to realize I can’t keep going like this forever. I want… more. They expect me to take the throne one day, I need to clean up my act. Get married, have kids. No one wants to be with a girl who drinks her life away…”

“Okay, who have you been sleeping with?! Because there is no way that Alejandro has convinced you to settle down, not after all this time! Who is giving you such good sex that you want to get married and have babies?” Sereia scoffed and Shiri blushed, looking away.

“I’m not sleeping with anyone! Besides, it’s none of your business!”

“Oh my gods! You are sleeping with someone! Who is it? Is it someone I know?” Sereia shifted to a more gleeful demeanor,

jumping up to grab Shiri's arms and shake her. "Who is it?!"

"Let go of me, fish! You psycho! I'll take it to my grave!" Shiri squealed, pulling away but laughing.

"Come on, song! Oooh, is it Shimmer? That girl put a little sparkle in your step?" Sereia wiggled her eyebrows suggestively and Shiri snorted, shaking her head.

"Is it… Flora? She's had a total crush on you for like forever! Did you tap that? I bet she's great in bed with those powerful thighs."

"You're disgusting! Why am I friends with you? I'm not sleeping with Flora and there is no way she has had a crush on me!"

"Okay! Okay! Geez, you could have at least given the girl a chance. She's head over heels for you. Wait a minute…" Sereia gasps, putting her hands to her mouth as she stares at Shiri. "You're sleeping with Finn. You've been in love with them since we were kids, there's no way it's not them!"

Shiri went redder, looking down at the floor as Sereia screamed, jumping up and down in those flimsy heels. The door flew open and her father, Seahawk, rushed in with a staff, ready to take out whatever was causing his daughter distress.

"What is wrong, my gentle wave?! Who do I need to kill?!" he asked and both girls stared at him before laughing. He looked at them, confused until Sereia went up up and kissed him on the cheek.

"We're fine, daddy! Shiri was just telling me a scary story! Besides, we're about to go out on an adventure!" she exclaimed and could hear her mother groaning from down the hallway. She looked up to see a tear in her father's eye as he looked at her proudly.

"That's my girl! You two go have fun! There is so much adventure out there to partake in! May this be the greatest one so far!"

“Yes, sir!” Shiri saluted him as Sereia grabbed her arm and pulled her out of the room.

“We have a lot to talk about tonight!” she whispered as they left.

_

The club in Salineas was vibing, as usual. They had taken up residence at their usual booth and the drinks had started flowing immediately. Shiri was bobbing in her seat with the music as she downed her fourth drink, sighing.

“Finn must be really good in bed for you to give up club life completely! You know you’re going to miss this!” Sereia commented as she finished her fourth drink as well, waving down the bartender for another round.

“I’ll miss the music but I won’t miss this. The drinking till I’m sick and the god awful high heels that want to break my neck!” Shiri laughed.

“How is it going to work though? Aren’t you two just sleeping together? It’s not like it’s anything serious.”

“I know it’s not. But I hope it can be one day. Is it so hard to believe that I’m ready to turn over a new leaf in my life? I already set up therapy sessions with Aunt Perfuma, how gross am I?” Shiri snickered and Sereia shook her head in disbelief.

“What are you going to do about Alejandro? He is not going to be happy he’s losing his number one girl,” she said as she started in on her fifth drink.

“Yea… I’m dreading that one… I’m hoping to put it off as long as possible,” she said. Sereia looked up and nearly choked on her drink as she grabbed Shiri’s arm, looking frightened.

“I don’t think you can put it off any longer. Guess who just walked in,” she whispered, head motioning towards the door. Shiri looked up, internally groaning as Alejandro and a few of his gang

members walked into the club. He looked around before his eyes landed on them and made his way across the room to them. Watching him, Shiri started to remember why she had fallen for him in the first place. Tall, blonde, and handsome… reminded her of a certain magicat she lured into her bed

"Hey, darling. Fancy meeting you here," Alejandro smirked, sitting beside Shiri as he wrapped his arm around her. She smiled politely, feeling disgusted at the smell of cigarettes and alcohol on his breath. How did she ever find this attractive? That's right… she was desperate.

"Just the man I wanted to see, actually," she purred softly, moving to where she sat on the table in front of him, feet planted on either side of his legs as he manspread. Sereia cleared her throat, getting up and whispering to one of the men accompanying Alejandro before leading him to the dance floor.

"What can I do for you, doll? You know you have me at your beck and call," he told her, moving his hand up her leg and resting it on her thigh. She shuddered, feeling gross, but he took it as her feeling pleasure at his touch.

"Look… Alejandro… we've had our…. Fun… but it's time that I… slowed down. Take my duties at home more seriously. I'm ending my clubbing days and… what we have," she told him and he just blinked at her before laughing, throwing his head back. She laughed nervously as well, wincing slightly as the hand on her thigh tightened.

"I'm sorry, I didn't quite catch that. Could you repeat yourself, princess?" he said, staring at her intently and it made her shift uncomfortably.

"I'm done. I'm leaving you-" she didn't get to finish her thought before she was knocked back onto the table, reeling. He had slapped her, hard enough to throw her back and he was now on top of her, hands wrapped around her throat as she struggled to breathe.

“Nobody leaves Alejandro, you hear me?! You’re mine, princess!” he hissed as she clawed at his hands, shaking her head as tears sprung in her eyes. Nobody was going to help her, everyone knew of him and his gang, they were too afraid. Finally, he released her and she gasped loudly, coughing as his weight lifted off her.

She was pulled up roughly by the hair, to which she whined in pain and forced off the table, being dragged through the club into the night air. She heard Sereia shouting behind her, trying to get him to stop. She needed to stop, Alejandro would kill her too if she kept it up. She was thrown onto the ground, onto her hands and knees, and looked up at the man before her.

“Where did you think you were going to go, princess? Have you forgotten the deal we made all those years ago? You knew what you were getting yourself into when this started. Besides, who are you going to get your drugs from? No one will sell to you and you know what will happen if you don’t take them,” he smirked, kneeling before her.

She did know what would happen. She felt it every month when the drug started to fade out of her system. She felt it now, the growing migraine in her head, the uncontrollable magic through her veins.

“I have a couple of months left… I’ll find someone to sell to me before it’s over,” she said and it earned her another slap in the face, on the same cheek as before. That was going to bruise. She saw Sereia grab his arm to stop him before being tossed away, falling to the ground.

“You need me! We have a deal! You’re my bitch! Who have you let between your legs, you dirty whore?! Who have you let corrupt your thoughts like this?!” He yelled as he gripped her arms, lifting her to her feet and off the ground, shaking her like a ragdoll. She screamed, crying as she was tossed down again.

“I have given you everything your heart desired! You wanted to be rid of your powers, I did that for you. You wanted to forget

about your tragic past, I helped you forget. You got only the best drugs, best booze, best clubs from me and this is how I am repaid?" he sighed before looking behind him at one of his men. "Bring me a gun."

"No! You can't kill her! You'll start a war with the kingdoms!" Sereia screamed and Alejandro backhanded her, sending her sprawling.

"I'm not going to kill her, you stupid cow! I'm going to make her repay me in blood. What do you say, Shiri? How about a game of roulette?"

Shiri shook her head, tears and mascara streaking down her cheeks and he forced her to her feet. The man came around, holding out a gun with a six bullet barrel, and opened it, inserting one bullet before loading it and spinning the barrel.

"You're going to repay me with blood. We each get a turn shooting at the other. I shoot you, you're free to go. I'll even keep supplying you, you will have paid in pain. You shoot me, you don't leave. I make you my little housewife, you submit to me fully. Do we have a deal? I'll even let you go first, princess," he told her, grabbing her hand and placing the gun in it. Shiri's hand shook, she wouldn't have been able to aim at him if she wanted to. But, she tried and pulled the trigger. The gun clicked, no bullet.

Alejandro laughed, taking the gun from her hands and aiming at her. He pulled the trigger and it clicked again, no bullet. Shiri flinched at the click, sobbing as the gun was handed back to her.

"Four more rounds, one is a bullet! I'm either going to buy you with my blood or you'll repay your debts with your own! Aren't you having fun, princess?" he mocked at her sobs as she shakily aimed at him, nearly dropping the gun. She pulled the trigger, another click with no bullet.

He quickly took it from her, aiming at her shoulder. She stared at him, hyperventilating as he pulled the trigger. There was no click

this time, there was a boom and she felt pain rip through her shoulder as she screamed, clutching at it. She felt the blood seep through her fingers, pulled them away to see it coating her hand. She heard Alejandro laugh and Sereia cry as her vision darkened momentarily. She fell back onto her ass, hyperventilating as she moved her hand back to put pressure on the wound.

She looked up to see Alejandro standing above her and he knelt down, moving her hand from the wound only to push his finger into it. She screamed bloody murder at the pain before he pulled his hand away, putting the bloody finger into his mouth with a sick smile.

"Congratulations, princess. You bought your freedom with your blood. I'll see you in a couple of months for the trade-off," he told her, standing and re-entering the club with his goons, leaving her and Sereia outside.

Sereia crawled over to her, sobbing. "Song! Are you okay? Oh, gods, you're bleeding really badly!"

Shiri grit her teeth in agony, everything hurt, the migraine was pulsing by now. "Fish… your com-pad… do you have it?"

Sereia nodded, going through her clutch before pulling out the device. "What do I do?"

"Call… Shimmer… to come to get me…" she blacked out again, she doesn't know how long that time but when she opened her eyes again, Sereia was shaking her shoulders.

"Shiri? Shiri! You have to stay awake! You're losing too much blood! I just got off the call with Shimmer, she should be here in a moment."

There was a flash of sparkles beside them and Shimmer appeared, gasping as she took in the scene. "What the fuck happened here?!" she exclaimed as she knelt beside Shiri, who was darting her eyes around to keep herself awake.

“Brightmoon… take me… to Brightmoon…” she gritted out and Shimmer nodded, grabbing her and Sereia’s arm and disappearing in another burst of sparkles.

Chapter End Notes

Hey guys! Sorry for the short update, I needed to get this out of my system! I may be taking a few days to recoup from my COVID vaccine, my arm is hurting! Enjoy!

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Shiri is bleeding out and her powers start to reveal themselves

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 11

Finn was curled up in their bed, purring softly as they slept. Melog slept peacefully at their feet, their purrs synced with Finn's. Everything was peaceful until a burst of sparkles filled the room and Shimmer, Sereia, and Shiri appeared, collapsing to the ground. The sparkles startled Finn as they jumped up, grabbing the knife they kept under their pillow.

"Finn!" they heard Shimmer yell and they groaned in response, relaxing.

"Shimmer? What are you doing? It's the middle of the night…" they muttered, rubbing their eyes sleepily. Until the stench of blood hit their nostrils. That woke them up instantly as they bounded off the bed and towards the group of women before them. Shiri laid on the ground, blood starting to pool around her.

"What happened?! Shiri!" they asked, taking her hand as they tried to find the source of the bleed. She blinked up at them, a dopey grin gracing her features. Finn tried to hold back a growl when they noticed finger-like bruises along her cheeks, neck, and arms.

"Heyyyy Finn… why's there four of you? Wait… no two… four kitties… pretty kitty," she giggled, bringing her hands up to her face, frowning. "Whoa! Who's blood is this?"

Melog meowed beside Finn, nuzzling Shiri's side comfortingly. Sereia was crying as she put her hand over the shoulder where the bullet went through.

"She was trying to get out! She said that tonight was the last night she was going out, that her days going out and partying was over! She wanted to do better but Alejandro showed up and she had to tell him and he shot her! Oh, gods, he said she had to pay her way in blood!"

"I'm going to fucking kill him, I swear! Shimmer, go get my mom! She can heal her!" Finn yelled and Shimmer disappeared. Shiri stared at them before wincing, a pulse of magic penetrating the room.

"Fucking hell! Hallie? Where's Hallie? I need…" she cried out, clutching her head, forcing Finn and Sereia to move back as her eyes flashed white briefly.

"Sereia, Halina is in the next room. Go grab her. I'm taking her to the guest room, there's a rune circle there to help contain the magic," they told her, picking up Shiri gently as she gripped them with her good arm. Sereia nodded, leading the way out of the room as Finn carried Shiri down the hallway.

"I got you. You're going to be okay, I promise," they reassured her as they left a trail of blood down the hall. "How could you be so stupid? He could have killed you."

"I'm tired, Finn…" she said softly, closing her eyes as they entered the guest room. They immediately went into the rune circle when Shiri pulsed another wave of magic, nearly knocking them back. Finn gripped her tighter as Shimmer appeared with Adora and Catra and Sereia ran into the room with Halina, Archer, and Flora.

"Shimmer, activate the rune. It's getting stronger," they told her and she shook her head, taking a step forward.

"You need to get out of there. I'll activate it when you're out of the way."

“No, I’m staying. She needs me,” they told her, making a point to sit down, cradling the woman in their lap. She tensed, letting out another strangled cry as her eyes flashed again. “Do it! Now!”

“Finn!” Catra screamed as Shimmer knelt outside the circle and activated it, putting up the barrier as the third wave of magic pulsated out. “Adora! Help them!”

“What happened?! Why is there so much blood?!” The older woman demanded, stepping towards the barrier.

“Take one more fucking step towards me and I’ll wipe you off of Etheria…” Shiri murmured, eyes opening blearily up at Finn. “I don’t need her…”

“Alejandro shot her as she tried to leave tonight. She seems to be detoxing as well. That’s why the magic is behaving erratically. I need you to heal her, mom. Please,” Finn begged, taking Shiri’s hand gently as they looked down at her.

“Where’s Hallie? I want Hallie…” Shiri asked, trying and failing to move her head.

“I’m right here, Shiri,” Halina said, stepping up towards the barrier and placing her hand on it. “You need to let Aunt Adora heal you. You’re bleeding out.”

Shiri stubbornly shook her head, everything spinning. She closed her eyes to stop the movement, breathing heavily through her nose. Everything hurt but she could feel herself going numb. Finn got angrier the longer they stared at the bruises on her, the impressions of fingers touching her pale skin.

“Just wait until she loses consciousness then heal her. She won’t have a choice,” Halina told Adora, who nodded. Shiri scoffed, nuzzling into Finn’s neck with a soft hum.

“I’m going to bleed out and stay awake to spite you,” she whispered. Her hand, which was behind held by Finn, tightened around theirs painfully as her body seized. Finn let out a yelp as

her muscles tightened, tensing painfully as she was sucked into a vision, eyes glowing white.

–

She blinked, staring up at the sky as a gentle breeze moved her hair into her face. She brushed it back, surprised to find the long black curls as she sat up and looked around. She was sitting on a picnic blanket on a flower-covered hill outside of the city. She could see the outline of it from here and faintly heard music wafting up the hill.

"Mommy *!" she heard a squeal and turned to see a little magicat girl run towards her, her black locks flying behind her, small patches of blonde gracing the tufts around her ears. She giggled as her baby blue eyes shimmered with excitement and she pounced on Shiri, the older woman easily catching the wild kitten into her arms.*

"Amora! What did I say about running off?! *" she heard behind her as she cradled the toddler kitten and looked up to see Finn walk towards them, smiling. Her heart skipped a beat, looking at this older Finn. They were still handsome, with blonde hair pulled back into a bun and wearing the colors of Musica.*

"I wanted to surprise mommy! Guess what! Daddy let me chase a mouse! It was quick but I was quicker! *" Amora said proudly, puffing out her chest. Shiri laughed, taking a strand of the little girl's hair between her fingers and stroking it gently.*

"I'm so proud of you, my love. Say, why don't you go pick Aunt Hallie some flowers to take to the library?" *she told her and Amora quickly scrambled off her lap, racing down the hill. Finn chuckled, taking a seat beside her and wrapping an arm around her shoulders, affectionately kissing her cheek.*

"Did you miss us, my wife? *" they said softly and she nodded, leaning into them.*

"Of course I did. A mouse? Looks like we won't need pest control in the palace anymore, *" she laughed softly.*

"She's feisty, like her mama. And her grandmothers. Nothing we can do about it *," they told her, turning to watch their daughter pick the wildflowers. Shiri smiled, gazing up at the sky again. It was so peaceful, so relaxing.*

"You were always feisty as a kid, *" she heard a new voice on the other side of her and turned to see Calliope sitting beside her, looking youthful and happy.*

"Mama? *" she whispered, reaching out to touch the woman.*

"Just like your mom, Lexie. She was feisty too. Stubborn, headstrong, independent. I'm glad you always took after her," *Calliope said, taking Shiri's hand and placing it on her cheek.*

"This isn't a vision… you can't be in a future vision when you're…" *Shiri trailed off, tears in her eyes.*

"It's still a future vision, I just decided to interrupt it a little. It's not your time, my song. You still have so much to do. Our kingdom needs you," *Calliope told her and Shiri shook her head.*

"The kingdom doesn't need someone like me. Why can't Zimri do it? Why me?"

"Why not you? It's what you were born to do, what you've trained your entire life to be. Why would you not be someone we need?" *Calliope asked softly, standing up.* "It's time to go."

"Wait! I have so many questions!" *Shiri stood up quickly, the vision already starting to fade.* "Please… don't leave again!"

"I never left you, Shiri. I've always been with you. And when you're ready, I'll be waiting for you," *Calliope told her as the vision faded out.*

–

Shiri sat up with a loud gasp, hand gripping the place over her heart tightly. She felt bile rise up in her throat and she turned to her side, vomiting up everything in her stomach from the night. A light sheen of sweat sat over her body as she convulsed, crying. She released everything she held until nothing but bile coated her tongue, making her gag.

"Mama?" she whispered softly, tears blurring her vision as she lifted her head up weakly to survey the room. She noticed a light encircling her and figures on the other side of it but couldn't make anyone out. She could hear talking but it was almost muted as her senses tried to catch back up with her.

She sat back down and shakily reached for her feet, pulling off her heels that were covered in blood. She slowly unfastened both, kicking them away from her as she stared at her blood-stained feet. Where was that coming from? She felt up her legs, feeling the drying blood on her pants and up to her abdomen, wincing slightly at the tenderness. She felt up her sides and onto her shoulders, which felt stiff. Finally, down her arms until her eyes landed on her hands, caked and crusted in blood.

"What the fuck?" She said loudly, groaning as the migraine intensified.

"Shiri?" she heard a voice and turned to see Finn crouching on the other side of the light, staring in at her. She crawled toward them, reaching a hand out to touch them but had her hand repelled back from the wall of light.

"What is this, Finn? Where am I?" she asked, blinking as she focused more clearly on everything. She noticed her sister behind them as well as Archer, Shimmer, Sereia, and Flora. "What is this, a family reunion? Didn't we already have one of those?"

"Shiri… this is serious. You were severely injured tonight. What were you thinking?" Finn scolded, placing a hand on the barrier.

“I just… I find the nightlife boring, I guess. Thought I would liven things up a bit,” she joked but no one laughed. She caught movement out of the corner of her eye and jerked her head, wincing. She saw She-Ra and Catra standing on the other side of the room, looking wary and she growled, her hand coming up to the shoulder that had been wounded.

“You healed me… after I told you not to. Still using your stolen magic,” she hissed, standing up to make herself taller, hiding the tremor in her legs.

“You were bleeding out. I wasn’t about to let you die,” She-Ra told her, frowning.

“I’m dying, either way, it would have been less painful,” Shiri scoffed, turning her attention to Halina, who was glaring at the floor. “Hallie…” she reached out but doubled over, crying as magic pulsed through her small circle.

“Shiri!” Halina said, coming to stand beside Finn. “This is for your own good. Until you detox from the drugs you were on and are able to regain control of your magic, we have you in this circle so you won’t hurt anyone.”

“Detox?! You don’t understand, I can’t detox! It will kill me!” Shiri yelled after the pain subsided, straightening back up. “Go get my bag! I need it! I’ve already progressed farther than I would like.”

“I have your bag,” Halina told her, holding up the two glass bottles of red liquid. Shiri stared at them, pushing her hand out as if to take them but being repelled away again.

“Hallie… give those to me. I need them.”

“You’re being dramatic. Detoxing always feels like you're dying, from what I read. You’ll be fine once it’s cleared your system.”

Shiri growled, hitting at the barrier, causing Halina to flinch back at the aggression. “You dumbass! This isn’t a detox! It’s going to kill me!”

“Stop being such a drama queen! This stuff is repressing your powers and making you sick! I want my sister back! And this is the only way to get that!” Halina yelled back, taking one of the vials and smashing it to the floor. Shiri gasped, eyes flashing violently, threatening to take her under again as she sank to her knees, hand sliding down the barrier.

This one felt different, more… painful. She felt heat coursing through her veins, liquid hot as her vision went red momentarily before she regained her sight. Finn was trying to get her attention, saying something but she was focused on her hands. Her hands, which had horrible red veins pulsating against the surface and crawling up her arms. She looked up at Halina’s horrified face.

“I’m not being dramatic… I knew what I was signing up for when I started taking it. I wanted to forget, to be normal… That drug suppresses my powers at a cost. I have to keep taking it or I will die. I wanted to be rid of this power forever, I never wanted to hurt anyone else… The drug is meant to kill me before I lose control unless I take the next dose and suppress it again…”

Halina stared at her in disbelief, gripping the last bottle tightly. Finn slammed their fists against the barrier near Shiri, growling.

“Why the hell would you do something so stupid?!”

“I lost everything the moment these powers came to me! I trained for years to control them! I never got to see my family! My friends! I missed everything! I even missed my mama dying! I wasn’t there to protect her! I wasn’t there to protect Hallie or Nicky either! These powers are useless if I can’t control them or use them!”

“Your kingdom needs you! Your people need you! Your family needs you! Shiri, I need you!” Finn yelled.

“I never wanted to be queen!” she sobbed, hiding her face in her hands. “I never wanted any of this! I just wanted to be a stupid

fifteen-year-old who got to dance with her best friend at Princess Prom, not some prophetic recluse! I've seen… everything. The Heart showed me everything from its creation to a thousand years from now! I am a walking historical database! I never wanted that!"

The room went silent as she tried to steady her breathing, wiping at the tears on her cheeks. She laughed softly, feeling vulnerable and pathetic in front of everyone.

"I just… wanted to be a normal girl who wanted to confess her feelings to the person she loved without the overhanging doom and gloom of knowing the answers to everything. It kinda turns people off," she sniffled. "I was ready to die to have that and now that I'm on the cusp of actually dying… I want to live."

"Why didn't you tell me?" Halina cried. "I could have helped! Why didn't you trust me?"

"You were a child! You had just gone through a traumatic event, we lost mom, you trauma bonded with our brother, you already had enough going on without my existential crisis happening. I thought I could handle it… obviously not. This is why you're the smart one," Shiri joked, causing a small smile to grace Halina's face.

"You can't keep taking the drugs," Halina informed her and Shiri groaned.

"Yes, mom. I promise to stop taking the drugs as soon as you find a way to prevent me from dying. Geez, happy?"

"I don't know… did that sound convincing to you, Finn?" Halina smirked and Finn chuckled, shaking their head.

"Didn't sound too convincing to me. I kinda wanna hear more about a certain confession to a certain best friend."

"You guys are so embarrassing! You are getting nothing out of me, kitten. I'll just sit here and die first!" Shiri pouted, turning her

back to them. Her neck tensed and her head slammed back into the barrier, her body had gone rigid, as another vision gripped her.

She vaguely heard yelling as the barrier dropped, causing her to fall backward but never hitting the floor. Flashes of her life passed before her from when she was a baby, a toddler, a child, a teenager, an adult, and now. Everything pulsed red, violent, and angry until she felt a sensation in her leg.

Everything started to fade back to normal and she was dragged out of the visions again with a small gasp, staring up at Finn who had her head cradled in their lap. She looked down, seeing Halina pull the syringe out of her leg and she allowed her head to fall back with a sigh of relief.

"Could you please stop scaring me like that? If I have to see you convulse again, I may start pulling out my fur," Finn joked lightly but she could see the actual concern in their eyes. She gave them a weak smile, feeling her eyes droop.

"Sorry… I'll try to… remember…" she yawned softly, drifting off.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for putting off an update! I hope you're enjoying the book! Please kudos and comment!

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Another bathtub confession and some reconciliation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 12

"Mama! I don't understand why we have to sit through another family portrait! We have like twenty!" *Shiri complained as a pregnant Calliope reached up to adjust her eldest daughter's crown with a smile.*

"We don't have a portrait together with your baby brother," *she affectionately told her, playing with one of the stray curls before placing it back.*

"Then why don't we do the portrait after Nicaise arrives? I gotta get back to the temple soon…"

"Yea, mama. What's up with you and portraits anyways? We do have a lot made," *Zimri pointed out as he helped Halina get seated in the chair.*

"Your mama is nostalgic. We all know this," *Lexie told them, coming up to kiss Calliope's temple and rub her belly.*

"I just love seeing how our family is growing! When Nicky is born, we'll have one with him in it as well. Until then, we'll settle for this. Lexie, remember our first portrait? With just the two of us?" *Calliope asked her as Lexie led her to the other chair beside their youngest daughter, helping her sit down.*

"I do remember it, my love. And you're right, like usual. I love seeing our family has grown over the years," *Lexie told her,*

indicating to the portrait maker to get started as she moved to stand behind the two chairs in between the twins.

"Besides, one day… we're not going to always be together. I want to have these portraits so that we can look back and remember our family and the amazing love we share," *Calliope said, reaching a hand up to take Lexie's and squeezing it gently. The twins shared a look, Zimri placing a hand on their mama's shoulder.*

"You shouldn't talk like that, mama. We're all going to be together for a very long time," *Zimri told her and Calliope smiled sadly as she looked around at her family.*

"Yea… You're right, my music. I hope we're going to be together for a long time. I love you all so much. Don't forget to smile."

–

Shiri inhaled deeply as she woke up, feeling a weight on her stomach. She cracked her eyes open slowly, taking in the ceiling that definitely wasn't hers before looking down to see Melog's head resting on her stomach as they purred softly. She reached a hand out and scratched behind their ear gently, earning a soft merp as they looked up at her.

"Hey, Melog. Have you been taking care of me while I've been asleep?" she asked, earning another merp in response that brought a smile to her face.

"Melog wishes they could take the credit," she heard a voice and looked over to see Finn enter the room, carrying a tray with a steaming mug and bowl. "But they have kept you safe and warm while I was away."

"Finn…" she said, slowly sitting up so she could lean against the headboard. "How long was I out?"

"A couple of days. You needed the rest. We told your mom what was happening, she was planning on heading over as soon as you woke up," they told her, sitting the tray on the bedside table as

they sat down on the edge of the bed. Melog chittered at Finn, who affectionately rubbed them between their ears.

“Go tell the moms she’s awake, okay?” they asked and Melog nodded, jumping off the bed and disappearing out the door.

“Days? It’s usually never that bad…” she said and Finn grabbed the mug, placing it in her hands for her to drink. She sniffed it, instantly smiling.

“Ginger tea, your favorite, with a splash of-”

“A splash of milk. How did you remember this? It’s been years,” she said as she took a sip.

“I remember everything about you, silly. We were best friends, after all,” Finn reminded her with a smile that sent her blushing down into her hot mug.

“You should have let me sleep on the couch or something. I’m still covered in dried blood and stuff. I smell awful and I know it probably smells worse to you,” she told them, sitting the mug down. “Could I take a bath?”

“You don’t smell that bad but a bath won’t hurt,” Finn said, standing up and holding out their hand to her. She took it, swinging her legs over the side of the bed and went to stand up. Her legs buckled under her weight and she fell forward, Finn catching her before she could touch the ground.

“Guess I’m still weak… I’m sorry,” she said and Finn shook their head, reaching down to slide their arm under her knees and lift her up into a bridal hold. Shiri wrapped her arms around their neck and they headed into the bathroom. They sat her down on the edge of the in-ground tub and started the water, adjusting the temperature.

“I’ll leave you to it,” they told her and she grabbed their hand quickly, stopping them.

“Could you… stay? I don’t want to be alone…” she whispered.

“Of course. But don’t expect me to take a bath with you. I don’t like water that much,” they joked, causing her to laugh as she started to undress.

“No, I remember. I don’t expect you to join. Just stay and keep me company,” she said as she finished undressing and slowly slid into the water, hissing at the warmth.

“Is it too hot? I can fix that!” Finn exclaimed, going to adjust the knobs.

“I’m fine! Just getting used to the warmth, Finn. So attentive,” she teased, leaning back against the wall to soak it in. Finn blushed, going back over and sitting on the edge of the tub, allowing only their legs to sit in the water.

“Do you want me to wash your hair?” they asked and she nodded, moving so that she was in between their legs. Finn grabbed the pitcher they kept beside the tub and filled it with water, using it to wet her hair gently. They were silent for a few moments as they worked on her hair, grabbing the shampoo to start lathering it into her black locks.

“Shiri? Can I ask you a question?” they asked. She hesitated before nodding. “Why did you decide to leave the nightlife? That’s what Sereia said caused the… incident with Alejandro…”

Shiri bit her lip, bringing her knees up to her chest and wrapping her arms around her legs as Finn started to rinse out the suds.

“I… I was done. It’s time that I stopped… being a child, being selfish and do what’s right for myself and everyone around me. I did all that, the drinking, the drugs, the partying… so that I could forget the pain I was feeling from my mama dying… from the burden I carry around… from the kingdom they want me to rule… It was easier to hide it than to face it.”

“Why didn’t you ask for help? You have family and friends that could have helped you during this… you pushed us all away…” Finn murmured, rinsing out the second application of shampoo, going to condition the hair.

“I was scared and confused. I blamed a lot of what happened on your mom… and myself… I didn’t feel like I could ask for help. Mom was out of it for… six months with Zimri taking care of her. Halina was raising Nicaise and figuring out how to live with this new reality we had. I had to run the kingdom by myself and my godparents and Aunt Haevyn helped as much as they could but they don’t know how to run it. They’ve never had to run it. Also… I hadn’t talked to any of you in years because of my training…”

“Just because you hadn’t talked to us doesn’t mean we would not have been there. We’re your friends… I’m your friend, Shiri,” Finna said as he finished rinsing out the conditioner, watching the water start to turn dark from the dirt and blood.

“I know you’re my friend… but I always wanted more…”

“More?”

Shiri turned around to face Finn, cheeks red from the heat of the water. She gave a small laugh, eyes starting to glisten.

“Did you know my mom confessed her feelings to my mama in a bathtub as she washed my mama's hair? They had been best friends for years before then and… my mama thought she had lost my mom in a battle during the war…”

“Shiri…” Finn whispered, leaning down some towards her as she placed her hands onto their knees, leaning towards him some.

“I… I’m not good at this… I won’t be perfect. I have a lot of flaws and I am working through the trauma that I have forced down. But… I know that it’s always been you. I’ve always been in love with you, Finn, and the last couple months of us reconnecting… I want it to be more than just sex between us. I want more…”

“You love me?” they gasped softly, leaning in so their foreheads touched and both of their hands were cupping her face.

“I love you, Finn. I always have. I want to be with you if you’ll have me,” she whispered against their lips and they closed the distance, kissing her passionately. She groaned softly, moving to sit up on her knees to deepen the kiss, wrapping her arms around their neck. They pulled apart after a few moments, gasping for breath but not moving too far away.

“You’re the reason I left… I want a healthy life with you. I’ve seen a future with you and I want that more than anything on Etheria.”

Finn laughed softly, planting kisses all over her face that raised giggles from her. “I love you too, Shiri.”

“Show me… make love to me, Finn,” she whispered and Finn wasted no time pulling her from the bathtub, holding her in their arms and returning to the bedroom to fulfill her wish, her legs wrapped around their waist as a hum built in her chest.

–

They were wrapped up in each other’s arms hours later, basking in the afterglow of their love-making with Shiri’s head resting on Finn’s chest as they ran their fingers through her short locks.

“I never want this to end…” Finn mumbled softly and Shiri couldn’t have agreed more, letting out a gentle hmm as she snuggled closer to them.

“I love you,” she said, kissing their exposed skin gently. They rubbed up and down her back, smiling.

“I love you too. I never want to stop saying that.”

She leaned up some, looking at him with a smile. “You never want to stop doing anything, huh?”

“With you, time could stop and I would be the happiest cat on Etheria. You mean everything to me.”

Shiri pecked their lips softly, running her fingers up to scratch behind their ears, pulling purrs from them. “Hey… when we get some time, I want to show you something.”

“What do you want to show me?” Finn asked, sitting up some, pulling Shiri with them so she was draped across their upper half, their chests pressed together.

“I just… want to show you what I had been doing all those years before my mama died. You’re going to love it.”

“I thought you couldn’t use your powers?” Finn tilted his head in question and she shook her head quickly.

“I can’t, not to that extent. I want to show you the Heart chamber. Your mom and I spent years rebuilding the temple while I was training and meditating within it.”

“I would love to see it. And we’re going to find a way to stop this drug from hurting you, I promise,” they told her, cupping her cheek.

“I know… then we have forever.”

“Forever sounds too short.”

“You’re right… forever won’t be long enough to spend with you,” she said, leaning in and pulling them into a kiss. The door to the bedroom burst open and Shiri squealed in surprise, pulling the blanket over her as Finn pulled the sheet up towards them. Halina, Archer, and Shimmer stood there in surprise, Shimmer trying not to snicker.

“Haven’t you guys heard of knocking!” Finn scolded and Shiri peeked her head out from under the blanket. Archer went bright red as he turned around so that his back was to them and Halina cleared her throat, embarrassed.

“I was just coming to tell you that mom will be here soon and she wanted to meet in the garden…” Halina said, shuffling on her feet.

“I’ll be there in a moment, Hallie,” Shiri told her as Finn threw a pillow at Shimmer, who could no longer contain her laughter.

“Get out! Has no one heard of privacy?!” Finn grumbled and Halina moved forward, sitting some clothes onto an empty chair before retreating out of the room with the other two, Shimmer being dragged out by Archer as she made kissy faces.

Shiri looked up at Finn after the door closed and burst out laughing, followed by their laughter as well. “Did you see Hallie’s face?! That was so worth it!”

“Hallie?! Archer’s was even worse! I think we scarred him for life!” Finn chuckled, falling back against the pillows with her. Their laughter started to die down as their hands found the others and intertwined.

“I need to get up and go meet my mom…” Shiri said softly, staring up at the ceiling.

“Yea… I need to go see mine as well… give her some updates. I’ll meet you in the gardens after your meeting?” Finn asked hopefully, turning their head to look at her. She smiled back at him, nodding and they got up, getting dressed.

–

It had been years since Shiri had been at Brightmoon, much less it’s gardens. The gardens had always been her favorite place at the palace, thanks to her mama and Aunt Haevyn. They had taught her about plants and flowers, giving her a love for digging her fingers into the soft earth and bringing life into the garden. Her favorite had been the trees that Brightmoon kept. One, because the different fruit was always so appealing to munch on and two, because she loved chasing after Finn through the branches.

She rested her hand against the trunk of a large tree, the one she had fallen out of when she was a child chasing Finn up it and had broken her arm. There was a bench under this tree now, a wooden one with wrought iron legs and arms that curled into intricate shapes of flowers. She closed her eyes, remembering her years in the garden, almost making out the soft laughter of children when she heard footsteps approach her.

She opened her eyes, turning to see who was coming when a small figure collided into her, almost toppling her over. She looked down to see a small magicat girl with a brown mane and blue eyes staring up at her, wrapped around her waist. She smiled softly, the small child reminding her of Finn.

"Hey, what's your name?" she asked and the little magicat giggled, pulling away.

"I'm Nala! My mommy is She-Ra! Who are you?"

"I'm Princess Shiri of Musicia. It's nice to meet you, Nala. Where is your mom?"

"Oh wow! You're a princess? I wish I was a princess! Are you going to be a queen one day like Aunt Glimmer?"

"Maybe… I don't know if I want to be a queen," Shiri explained softly and Nala frowned.

"Why not? Being a queen would be awesome! I think you'll be great!"

"Nala! There you are! You can't keep running off like that!" Adora said as she entered the garden, taking in the scene before her as she tensed. Shiri straightened her posture as well, eyeing Adora wearily.

"Mommy! This is Princess Shiri and she's my friend! Aren't you?" Nala looked up at Shiri with a big smile, not sensing the tension building in the garden as Shiri broke eye contact to smile down at the little girl.

“Of course we’re friends. Now, why don’t you run along with your mom? I’m waiting for mine as well,” Shiri encouraged, nuding her towards Adora and Nala ran over, wrapping her arms around her mom’s waist. Adora tousled her hair affectionately.

“Go find your mama. I’ll be there in a moment,” she told Nala, who nodded and ran off into the palace. Shiri stayed silent, moving to sit on the bench underneath the tree. Adora stepped forward some, seeming to be at a loss for words as she eyed the tree Shiri sat under.

“You fell out of that tree when you were a little girl. I remember Finn carrying you to me to heal your arm. You’ve always been so brave…”

“What do you want, Aunt Adora? An apology? I don’t know if I can give it yet…”

“No, that’s not what I want…” Adora sighed, going and sitting on the other side of the bench, wringing her hands nervously. “I just want to talk. We’re family, I’ve always been here for you, even when you didn’t want me to be. We’re now starting to realize the extent you had to suffer through by yourself…”

“Why weren’t you here?” Shiri asked, looking at Adora, who frowned.

“What do you mean?”

“Why weren’t you on Etheria the day my mama died? Why didn’t you do anything? She had told you for months that there had been violent activity in the Whispering Woods and you did nothing. She was coming to Brightmoon to figure out how to stop it that day…”

“I was on another planet trying to bring back it’s magic. That’s what I’ve done for years, you know this. We hadn’t figured out a plan to control the Whispering Woods yet so I didn’t see any harm in leaving for a few days… it was all bad timing and circumstance.”

“You’re supposed to be Etheria’s champion and yet you spent your time helping other planets. You should have been here, she would still be alive!” Shiri started to raise her voice, feeling fear and anger bubble in her chest.

“Shiri… your mama knew she was going to die…” Adora said gently and Shiri whipped her head violently to stare at her, tears starting to glisten in her eyes.

“What…?”

“Your mama knew… that she was going to die before her eldest daughter’s coronation day… She knew she was going to die one day soon and she told us on the night before her wedding about the vision she had when she visited the Heart.”

“She knew…? Oh my gods, the portrait… that’s why she had so many portraits done…” Shiri said, putting her head in her hands as her body started to tremble. Adora scooted closer, hesitant but gently wrapped her arms around Shiri.

“Aunt Adora… I’m so… angry with you,” she sobbed, allowing the older woman to hold her. “I’m so angry that you weren’t here. I’m angry that she died, that she knew she would die. I feel so much… rage inside of me that I’m scared it’s going to crawl it’s way out of my skin.”

“You have every right to be angry. I should have been here, we should have done something about the Whispering Woods sooner. We should have been there for you and your family. We just thought it would be better for you if we stayed away, that you would feel differently after a few months and then it turned into years and… I’m so sorry, Shiri,” Adora explained, holding her close. Shiri sobbed into her arms for a while, trembling. That’s how Lexie found the two when she entered the garden and she was immediately by her daughter’s side, wrapping her arms around her.

“My song, what’s wrong? What happened?” Lexie asked frantically, checking her over for injuries and Shiri turned from Adora, settling into her mom’s embrace.

“I miss her! Oh gods, I miss her so much! I miss her smile and her laugh. I miss the smell of her hair, it always smelled like lavender. I miss her singing, the lullabies she would sing to us when we were small. Nicky never got to hear her sing,” Shiri sobbed into her mom’s arms. “I even miss taking those stupid portraits! I would give anything for her to nag me about taking one of those portraits again!”

“Shhh, it’s okay, baby girl. I miss her too. I miss her so so much,” Lexie told her, rocking them gently.

“How do you do it? How do you go on living in a world she doesn’t exist in anymore? She was your soulmate, how do you do it?”

Lexie blinked softly, pulling away some to cup her daughters face and give her a watery smile before singing softly.

She dedicated every day to you

She changed my life

She made my life worthwhile

And when you smile

I know a part of her lives on

I know I can go on

Lexie rubbed a thumb over her daughter's cheeks, wiping away the tears as her own started to fall. “I live with this pain because of you and Zimri and Hallie and Nicky. I had my one true love, she made living easy. She made every day an adventure. We made a vow on our wedding day that we would grow old together, see our grandkids and great grandkids. She’s not here to see that day but

I am. I'm going to keep my promise to her to live until I'm old and grey."

"I'm so sorry! I'm so sorry that I hurt you! I've been a selfish, spoiled brat! All you wanted was to step down from the throne to focus on us and the orphanage and I was too selfish to let you. I've been trying to forget and bury everything with the drugs and partying and I'm done. I'm done, mom. As soon as we fix this, I'm ready. I'm ready to take the throne," Shiri hiccuped, burying her face into her mom's shoulder as she felt Adora's hand rubbing circles into her back.

"I'm in no rush for you to take the throne. You have so much to work through. When it's time, you'll know. You are so brave, my song. You have always been my brave little girl. I'm sorry that I've hurt you. That I disappeared for all those months and left you to figure it out on your own. That was selfish. I was selfish."

"We've always clashed… haven't we?" Shiri sniffled, smiling some.

"You've always been too much like me. Your mama would always say-"

"She's feisty, like you. Independent, headstrong, and stubborn," Shiri finished her thought and Lexie blinked in surprise. "She came to me in one of my visions…"

Lexie gasped, putting a hand over her mouth as the tears fell faster. "You talked to her?"

"Yes… she was glad I took after you so much and that our kingdom needed me… I don't know what for yet."

"She's right, like always. We do need you but we need you when you are able… don't rush it."

She took a shaky breath, turning so she could see Adora as well, taking her hand in hers. "I'm not ready to forgive… but I will need your help when the time comes… I will need everyone's help when it's time."

Adora squeezed her hand back, smiling. “You have my help for whatever you need. I hope one day we can be back on good terms again.”

“Shiri?” she heard and saw Finn enter the garden, looking concerned as they took in her face. They quickly headed towards her and she stood up, releasing her grip on the two women as she ran towards them, being wrapped up in their arms immediately.

“Are you okay?” they whispered in her ear as they held her, scenting her neck with their cheek. She nodded, pulling her head back to kiss them gently.

“I’m okay… relieved really.”

Both of the moms gaped at them before Lexie smirked, punching Adora in the arm. “Guess we’re going to be in-laws soon! I told you so!”

“Nu-uh! I told you so! You owe me!” Adora exclaimed back, pushing Lexie some, who laughed. Finn and Shiri looked at their moms, shaking their heads in amusement at the exchange.

“To guess they were even competitive about us getting together,” Finn commented, resting their chin on her shoulder as she scratched their ears.

“Please, they are competitive about everything! You shouldn’t be that surprised! Cut it out, you two! We’re not getting married anytime soon!” Shiri told them, sticking her tongue out over her shoulder at the pair.

“I bet they get married by the end of the year!” Lexie told Adora, who gasped.

“No way! Six months tops!”

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the long chapter, I hope you enjoy it! Don't worry, we are nowhere near through! I have so much more up my sleeve! Don't forget to kudos and comment to boost my serotonin levels :)

Song Creds: Theodosia Reprise by Sara Bareilles

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

Shiri shows Finn the Heart of Etheria

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 13

Shiri led Finn through the Whispering Woods a few days after she woke up. She had spent the time recouping from the gunshot and detox ordeal in Finn's bed, enjoying their company as they reveled in their newfound love for each other. It was a light feeling, one that made Shiri want to sing out her feelings until everyone on Etheria knew her song. They had played games, made love, and got to know each other again.

That's how she found out that their favorite color was brown. "Not like any old brown color," they had said, backtracking to explain. "The shade of your eyes, earthy and warm, that's my favorite color." That had sent a blush spreading across her cheeks as she pushed them gently.

"That's so corny! You're so embarrassing!" she had laughed, going on to the next question.

"The temple is close, we're almost there," she said, turning to look at them as they walked beside her, their hands interlocked together. She would never get used to this feeling, having them by her side.

"You know this could have waited until you were better. I don't want you pushing yourself," Finn told her with a small frown that made her roll her eyes.

“I’m fine. I’ve been resting for days. Can’t get much better after being magically healed by your 8-foot tall warrior mother,” she teased, nudging them with their shoulder.

“Still…” they said as they entered the clearing, the renovated Crystal Castle standing proudly at the edge. Shiri stopped, having Finn stop along with her.

“You pushed me a lot the last couple of days and I didn’t complain,” she smirked, causing Finn to blush from the innuendo.

“You know that’s not what I meant!” they yelled as she stepped away from them, taking in the castle with skepticism. She hadn’t been back in here a couple of years and she was worried about what would await her inside. Finn came up behind her, placing their hands on her shoulders gently. “We don’t have to do this.”

“I want to show you… I guess I need you to understand what happened all those years I was gone. Besides… I’m proud of the work I put into the temple,” she explained, finally stepping towards the entrance and putting her hand on the triangular pad. “Eternia.”

The doors slid open with a hiss, a gentle breeze blowing out past them, ruffling their hair. Shiri took hold of their hand again, giving it a gentle squeeze before leading them into the temple. “Your mom helped me refurbish the Crystal Castle after I came into my powers and found myself living here. With Light Hope gone, it’s a lot safer and we were able to reboot the system to disable the traps she had set up.”

“You lived here? What, for seven years?” they asked in disbelief as they walked down the winding hallways, looking at the different murals that lined the walls.

“Yea… my grandmother thought it best to be completely immersed in my training. When I wasn’t meditating or going through the planet’s archives, I was working on rebuilding the

temple with your mom. We wanted this to be a place of tranquility for anyone who needed it and a historical landmark."

"Your grandmother? As in Queen Musa?" they asked as they took a turn and Shiri nodded, running her fingers along with the murals.

"She's stuck in the Heart along with previous queens. She's been helping me in the way that she was unable to help her daughter, my mama. She's very wise, she saved our kingdom during the war, or as much of it as she could and wiped Etheria's memory to protect us," Shiri explained, stopping at a mural.

Finn looked up and was taken aback when they saw She-Ra, sword raised towards a woman with the Musicia insignias on her robes and tiara. The woman seemed to be wielding fire in her hands as she stood towards She-Ra, hands raised as if to attack.

"Who is this?" they asked in wonder and Shiri placed a hand at the bottom of the mural, running her fingers over the grooves in the wall.

"Princess Bedelia of Musicia. She was born with the power of the Heart… the last one before I came along. You see, the Heart bestows different gifts unto its chosen based on what the planet needs. While we can master many if not all of the musical talents, we are given extra powers. You know mine is visions, hers was fire. She lived during the time of Mara, the last She-Ra before your mom."

"What happened to her? I've never heard this story before…"

"The gifts are meant for the good of Etheria. But they don't always go that way. Princess Bedelia came to the same conclusion that I did during my time here… that the First Ones stole part of the Heart to create She-Ra and embedded the runestone into the Sword of Protection. She became… consumed with restoring the missing piece. And she wasn't going to let anyone stand in her way so she used her powers on civilians. She-Ra protected the

people and ended her… but at a cost. There was mistrust towards Mara after this and then she pulled us into Despondos… let's just say that the Heart had to do major damage control on the people afterward to erase this memory."

Finn placed their hand over hers on the mural, wrapping it around to hold it in place. "You're not like her. Your powers are meant to help the people, to help Etheria. You're not going to hurt anyone as she did."

"But she wasn't wrong, Finn. The runestone is a part of the Heart, it was stolen from Etheria. It's something that could be overlooked if She-Ra served Etheria solely as it's champion. But she doesn't… I understand where Bedelia was coming from. She did it the wrong way but I understand, I've felt that pain and rage towards She-Ra. But we are connected because of this."

"Mom does serve Etheria. She saved us from Horde Prime and brought balance to the planet. What happened with your mama was an accident, a freak accident where she was at the wrong place at the wrong time that happened to coincide with my mom being off-planet," Finn told her gently, moving to place their hands on her shoulders.

"I'm… trying to come to terms with that. Deep down, I know this but…" she bit her lip, wrapping her arms around herself.

"It still doesn't change the fact that it happened and it's easier to shift the blame onto someone than to face it yourself. I understand. Let's continue?" they told her and she nodded, moving to continue down the corridor.

They walked for a while, Shiri pointing out different murals along the way. Most of them were about She-Ra through the ages but there were some about Etheria, the different kingdoms, and Musicia. She was most proud of the murals she created herself and Finn could feel that pride radiating off her as she showed them the mural of Calliope standing under the Heart and above the city of Musicia, hands outstretched towards the kingdom.

“An important part of our history, where the lost princess of Musicia returned to bring balance and rebuild her destroyed kingdom. We live under large shadows,” Shiri commented, pressing her fingers to her lips before placing them on the mural as a sign of respect and love.

“How will we ever live up to such large parents? Queens and war heroes, legendary warriors, and commanders of armies. I think everyone expects me to become the new She-Ra because I’m the firstborn but I think Nala will be She-Ra,” Finn told her as the continued past, causing her to turn her gaze towards them.

“What makes you think it will be Nala?”

“She’s more magically inclined than I am. I never felt a connection to the Sword or the magic. I’m more like my mama Catra than I am like mom Adora. I want to have an adventure, to explore Etheria and the galaxy. I don’t want the burden of anyone on me,” they explained, causing her to nod her head in understanding.

“I get that. Not wanting the burden of everyone else on your shoulders. I think you should go exploring, travel the universe. We should do that together.”

She squeezed their hand, stopping at a large archway with stairs that descend downwards, a glowing light could be seen at the bottom. She released them, bending over to remove her sandals, leaving herself barefoot.

“We’re entering the Heart chamber, I consider it kinda sacred. I’ve spent a lot of time working on the chamber and I don’t want anyone to destroy the plants with their shoes,” she explained when they raised an eyebrow of question at her and she descended down the stairs, Finn following behind, not having any shoes to take off.

They made it to the bottom of the stairs and Shiri didn’t hesitate as she moved forward into the large room. Finn, on the other hand, paused to take in the room. It was huge, the Heart

shimmering brilliantly above the room. They noticed five objects floating around the Heart, tilting their head to figure out what they were when Shiri made her way back, having realized Finn had stopped. She followed their gaze and smiled.

"The five elemental runestones. Plumeria, Salineas, Scorpion, Snows, and Brightmoon. Took a lot of convincing to be given a small part of the original runestones to keep near the Heart but I felt that this was the best way to keep the kingdoms united. Come on, there is a lot more to see," she told them, taking their hand to pull them into the room.

Finn looked down when they felt grass underneath their feet, surprised at the plant life that grew around the room. It was almost like a meadow, with grass and wildflowers everywhere. In the center of the room, right under the Heart, was a shallow pool of water shaped like a crescent moon, the small inlet on the other side containing two large trees. Along the edges of the pool were statues of ice, shaped as different women that Finn didn't recognize.

"The pool is saltwater from Salineas, it's about as deep as my knees. The trees are cherry blossoms from Plumeria, it's beautiful during the spring when the blossoms fall onto the water," Shiri started explaining as they got closer to the pool.

"What about the statues?" they questioned, pulling away to approach one and examine it.

"Ice sculptures from Snows. They're based on Musician Queens of the past. They act as guardians of the Heart, watch," she said, approaching one and touching its face, red sparks of electricity crackling out, causing Finn's tail to puff out in surprise. "Electricity from Scorpion. To ward off unwanted intruders."

"All the kingdoms are represented… except Brightmoon," Finn observed as they smoothed out their tail.

“How do you think the temple is lit? Light from Brightmoon to keep out the darkness. Doesn’t do much good here since the Heart gives off its own light,” she said, hiking up her dress above her knees as she waded into the pool.

“Shiri! What are you doing?” Finn asked in surprise, standing at the edge of the pool.

“Come on! It’s not deep! We’re going over to the inlet!”

“Why can’t we just walk around?!”

“It’ll take longer and is not as fun! Don’t tell me you’re a scaredy-cat, kitten,” she smirked as Finn’s face hardened from the tease. They took a deep breath, wading in after her, hissing slightly at the water as Shiri laughed. She continued across the pool, using an underwater staircase on the inlet to climb back onto land, holding her out a hand for Finn. Finn took it, allowing her to pull them out as they shook out their fur at their legs.

“That wasn’t so bad, huh?” she teased, giving them a light kiss on the cheek.

“It was horrible. Don’t ask me to do it again” they huffed but smiled as they took in the inlet. There was an open area that they were standing in before it gave way to the two cherry blossom trees, where Finn finally noticed a hammock strung up between them.

“You used to sleep in here?” they asked, horrified as Shiri stepped forward, taking a seat on the hammock, causing it to sway.

“Yea… it’s always bright. I got used to sleeping under it. The trees block out the brunt of it,” she said, running her fingers over the fabric of the hammock then the blanket and pillow that still sat inside it. She held out a hand as an invitation. “Come lay with me?”

Finn stepped forward as Shiri swung her legs over into the hammock, adjusting to make room for them. Finn climbed in

beside her, pulling her into their arms as they stared up into the cherry blossoms. They were silent for a few moments, taking in the silence of the room.

"How did you live like this for seven years? It seems… lonely," they commented after a few moments. Shiri cuddled closer, nodding in agreement.

"It was lonely. I mean, I guess I have the queens of the past to keep me company but it's not the same as someone alive. Your mom would come occasionally to help me work on the temple but they never lasted long. I spent a lot of time meditating by the water and seeing the planet's past and future. The water actually has healing properties, by the way," she said offhandedly, twisting her fingers into their shirt.

"I just can't believe it took seven years to learn how to control your powers. I don't understand," Finn frowned.

"It wasn't just learning to control my visions. It was more complicated than that. I was learning about the planet, the history, the kingdoms, everything. I can't just see everything in one night, it literally took years to see through all of Etheria's memories. It took a while before that to control the visions enough to make sense of what I was seeing and not convulse every time I had one. I had to learn to stop and meditate when I felt a vision happen. And then I learned to summon the visions myself. The past visions are easy to summon, it's the future one's that I can't control well."

"You've seen the future. What happens?" they asked and she shook her head.

"I'm not allowed to reveal future visions. If people knew their futures, they would take measures to prevent them from happening and cause unnecessary damage to themselves or others. It's better to not know what is going to happen. Besides, the future isn't set in stone, I see many different futures that always change from different decisions made."

“I guess that makes sense. I just wish I knew if we stayed together,” they explained, taking her hand to lace their fingers together.

“I don’t need visions to tell me that,” she smiled up at them. “You love me and I love you. We’ve always loved each other and I think we will always love each other. I see a future with you, do you see one with me?”

“Of course I see one with you. Were you serious about us traveling together? What about your kingdom?” they questioned.

“I told my mom I’m ready to become queen but… there’s still much I want to do. So much I want to see and experience. It’s my duty to serve my kingdom and I know mom is tired. She wants to leave Musicia and spend time at the orphanage in Scorpion. I think the memories of mama are too much for her.”

“Why can’t Zimri and Marmoris take over the kingdom?” Finn asked and Shiri frowned.

“Because I’m the eldest. I was born first therefore it’s my birthright to take the kingdom. I’m sure Zimri would be fine but I know he doesn’t want to rule the kingdom.”

“Archer is the firstborn yet Shimmer is taking the throne when she is ready,” Finn stated.

“Archer doesn’t have a connection to the runestone like Shimmer. Besides, isn’t he taking over the library as a historian?” Shiri asked and Finn nodded.

“Why is it so important for you to take the throne when you could give it to your brother or even your sister?”

“I don’t know… I guess because it’s what I was taught? Or it’s what mama would want? Or because I was born with these powers so it’s only natural that I would be the one to rule? I can’t really give a good answer.”

“But it’s obvious you don’t want to rule. You don’t want to be burdened with the responsibility of a kingdom. Like me. We could run away together, steal a ship and find a far off planet to hideout on.”

Shiri laughed, rolling onto her stomach and propping her head up on their chest to look at them. “Because that will go over so well with our moms. She-Ra would definitely hunt us down to the edges of the galaxy if we ran off together.”

“Running away for true love will surely keep her off our backs for a while. It would be fun, exploring the stars together,” Finn offered with a grin and Shiri considered it for a moment. To run away to a far-off planet where nobody knew who she was or who Finn was. Where they didn’t live under large shadows of the past or were burdened with the responsibility of others.

“That would be amazing… if I was a normal princess. But I’m not, I was born with a gift that I don’t know what to do with. I don't know my purpose for Etheria or the people yet. This has always felt like a curse, not a blessing and I’ve come to terms with the fact that I can’t run from it, no matter how much I want to. I will never ask you to give up your dreams for me but it would be nice if I had you by my side as well…” she bit her lip, looking down at her hands.

Finn lifted her chin gently, giving her a chaste kiss on the lips before smiling. “Do you not understand that you’re the only dream I care about? Everything else doesn’t matter, really. As long as I have you by my side, I don’t care what we do. Runaway, run a kingdom. As long as we are together.”

Shiri smiled, sighing in relief as she nuzzled into their neck, feeling them do the same as they scented her. “Thank you for understanding.”

“It makes sense now. I never knew the extent of what you went through and it was hard not having you there anymore. But you never have to do this alone again. You’ll always have me by your

side. Besides, you basically asked me to marry you," Finn teased and Shiri shoved them, scoffing.

"I did not! Stop being stupid! I don't even like you!"

"You're right! You love me! How embarrassing for you!" they laughed, pulling her into a hug that she happily snuggled into, laughing along with them as they laid under the cherry blossom trees, in love and ready for the future together.

Chapter End Notes

How happy! It's like nothing bad could happen! (sorrynotsorry)
Be sure to kudos and comment! I'll be sure to ruin the tooth-rotting fluff soon!

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

A musical number, a family dinner, a note, and Finn asks Lexie a question

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 14

It was hard to remember the last time Shiri had felt this happy and content with her life. She also couldn't remember why she had denied herself this happiness for so long and everyone around her noticed the changes immediately. She was bubblier, reverting back to the girl they knew before the tragedy, before her powers, before everything became complicated.

Family dinners had become more pleasant, the conversations lighthearted and humorous. More and more people had started joining them for dinner each week until the majority of the Etherian royal families were sitting at their dinner table. That's where they found themselves a week before Princess Prom, surrounded by their family and friends.

They were currently residing in the lounge, waiting for everyone to finish arriving as conversation and laughter filled the air. Lexie was in deep discussion with Adora, Catra, Glimmer, and Bow, gesticulating wildly with her hands while the others nodded along. Zimri and Marmoris were lounging on a couch with Shimmer, Archer, and Halina, all of them crowded together but enjoying the company as they laughed at the dramatic story Marmoris was telling them.

Callista and Brio were entertaining Nala, who had taken to the older couple as soon as she stepped through the door. Catra had

tried to steer her away but Nala refused to detach herself from the couple as Haevyn and Circe watched on with amusement.

“I don’t know what it is but kids really like them. I should know, they had to adopt me cause I wouldn’t go away,” she had teased, Brio affectionately ruffling his oldest daughter's hair.

Shiri watched everyone with a smile, cradling a sleeping Nicaise to who she had made an effort within the past month to become more attached to. It’s not that she blamed the toddler for what happened but it had pained her to see him after their mama had died. He looked exactly like her, with his heterochromia hair, split right down the middle between white and black and his pretty blue eyes. She was trying, Halina had nearly cried when she saw her older sister holding their baby brother.

“Aunt Eira! Aunt Frosta!” she heard Halina yell as she turned her head towards the doors where the two women entered. Their Aunt Eira was seven months pregnant with her first child and she looked about ready to explode with how large her belly was. Halina headed towards them quickly, Frosta getting a little protective over her wife, but Eira smiled happily, bringing her into a hug.

“Baby sis!” Haevyn said, going to pull her into a hug as well, creating a mini group hug with the three of them before they pulled apart. Haevyn put a hand on her sister’s belly with a huge smile. “How’s my nephew?”

“Huge, he’s running out of room to grow and killing my back and feet. Thank gods I have a wife who specializes in ice for the swelling,” she laughed, placing a hand on Frosta’s arm. “Where’s the rest of my family?! Only one niece greeting me? And before my own parents?” she said dramatically, causing more laughter to erupt in the room as Brio and Callista made their way over.

“You know we wouldn’t have been able to get anywhere close with Haevyn here,” Callista teased as she hugged her youngest, kissing her cheek affectionately. Brio kissed her other cheek.

“I’m just happy we’re finally getting another boy in this family! I’ve been stuck with all girls for decades!” he told her, Lexie coming up to greet Frosta and Eira.

“Stop being so dramatic, old man. You loved every minute of it,” Lexie playfully scolded, patting Frosta on the shoulder. “I don’t feel sorry for you for being stuck with him as a father-in-law.”

“You wound me deeply, hotshot! But you are also right,” Brio commented as Zimri popped up.

“You had me, pops,” Zimri smirked, hugging Eira. “And you’re practically glowing, Aunt Eira. I can’t wait to meet him.”

“Thank you, Z. I knew you were always my favorite,” she joked as she looked around. “Where’s Shiri and Nicky?”

“Over here, Auntie,” she said, readjusting Nicaise before heading over towards her family, having enjoyed watching the familiar interactions between them. She had also been entranced by Eira’s large belly, she had always loved pregnant women. She hadn’t seen one since her mama.

“Ri-Ri! Why were you hiding from me?” Eira pouted as Shiri handed Nicaise off to an awaiting Halina and was pulled into her aunt's embrace. It lasted longer than the others had, the two had grown up together and were very close. Shiri could almost feel the tension leave her body as Eira hugged her.

“You’re glowing too,” Eira whispered very quietly into Shiri’s ear so that only she could hear, causing the young princess to shoot out of the embrace quickly, eyes wide.

“No, I’m-” she was at a loss for words, unsure of how to respond to this statement. There was no way, was there? Eira squeezed her hand gently, a silent promise to talk more about it later as she turned to finish greeting the rest of the room, joining her wife where she had gravitated towards the group of older adults.

“You okay, Shiri?” she heard someone ask behind her and turned to see Finn look at her questioningly, having slipped into the room as everyone was distracted. She blinked before smiling, pulling them into a hug they reciprocated.

“I’m fine. I’m just glad you’re here. What took so long?” she asked against their shoulder, letting the noise of the room fade out as she concentrated on their soft breathing and purrs.

“Just had to take care of some last-minute errands. Aunt Glimmer had an idea on how to reverse the effects of the drugs and had me go grab some of the ingredients. It took longer than I thought it would,” they explained, pulling away just enough to kiss her softly.

That was the only thing that put a damper on her happiness: her stupid choices. Everyone had been working diligently in finding a cure for this failsafe drug she had been poisoning herself with but nothing had seemed to work yet. Which reminded her that she was going to need to get another dose soon if they didn’t find anything.

“I forgive you, taken that I can actually enjoy being around our chaotic family again,” she teased, kissing them again before whispering. “Besides, I know you’ll make it up to me later,” she smirked, causing a soft groan to leave Finn’s lips.

“You’re a tease. We can skip dinner and head straight towards dessert if you want,” they suggested quietly, causing a soft giggle to escape her lips.

“Our moms will kill us if we skip dinner and probably barge in on us.”

“Ri-Ri! Z! Please play us a song before dinner!” Eira begged, interrupting the moment the two lovebirds were having. Shiri looked over at Zimri, who smirked as they nodded and headed towards the piano.

“Of course, Eira. Mom, can you sing with me?” Shiri asked, pulling away from Finn with a final kiss and heading towards the piano.

“I don’t know why you want me to sing with you. You know I’m not that great,” Lexie argued before Brio gave her a slight nudge towards the piano.

“Come on, hotshot! It’s been a while since we heard your duet! Sing for us!”

“Yea mom! Please sing!” Halina said, sitting back on the couch with Nicaise settled on her chest, Archer’s arm wrapped around her shoulders.

“You know this song, mom! Come on! Don’t be a scaredy-cat!” Shiri teased as she stood beside the piano, nodding her head towards Zimri, who started playing. Shiri cleared her throat before she started singing.

I wanna hold ‘em like they do in Texas, please

Fold ‘em, let ‘em hit me, raise it; baby, stay with me

Love the game intuition, play the cards with spades to start

And after they’ve been hooked, play the one that’s on their heart

Oh, oh-oh, oh, oh

Oh oh oh oh, oh oh

I’ll get them hot, show them what I’ve got

Oh, oh-oh, oh, oh

Oh oh oh oh, oh oh

I’ll get them hot, show them what I’ve got

Lexie had gravitated to the piano, standing on the other side as she watched her daughter sing, loving the soft melody of the piano her son played before singing her part.

Can't read my

Can't read my

No, she can't my poker face

(Shiri) She's got to love nobody

(Lexie) Can't read my

Can't read my

No, she can't my poker face

(Together) She's got to love nobody

P-p-p-poker face, p-p-p-poker face

P-p-p-poker face, p-p-p-poker face

Mother and daughter harmonized well together as they smiled at each other from across the piano. Lexie started into the next stanza.

I wanna roll with her

A hard pair we will be

A little gambling is fun when you're with me

Russian Roulette is not the same without a gun

And, baby, when it’s love, if it’s not rough, it isn’t fun

Oh, oh, oh, oh, ohhhh, ohh-oh-e-ohh-oh-oh

I'll get her hot and show her what I've got

(Together) Oh, oh, oh, oh, ohhhh, ohh-oh-e-ohh-oh-oh, I'll get her hot

Show her what I've got

Can’t read my

(Shiri) Can’t read my

(Together) No she can't read my poker face

She's got to love nobody

Can't read my

Can't read my

No she can't read my poker face

She's got to love nobody

Lexie rounded the piano as they sang, coming to stand beside her daughter. Lexie sang out the next part, Shiri singing out some of the words in the stanza along with her.

I won't tell you that (I love you)

Kiss or (hug you)

Cause I'm (bluffin') with my (muffin)

I'm not (lyin')

I'm just (stunnin' with my love-glue-gunnin')

(Shiri) Just like a chick in the casino

Take a bank before I pay you out

(Lexie) I promise this, promise this

Check this hand 'cause I'm marvelous

I'm marvelous

(Shiri) I'm marvelous

(Together) I'm marvelous

So marvelous

She's got to love nobody

Can't read my

Can't read my

No she can't read my poker face

She's got to love nobody

Zimri finished playing as everyone in the room exploded with applause, the mother/daughter pair holding hands as they bowed, laughing happily as they straightened and hugged each other. Zimri came around, pulling the two into a hug as well.

"I can't remember the last time we got to play like that together. I've missed this," he told them.

"Your mama chose the right names for you two," Lexie told them affectionately, kissing their cheeks as a servant opened the doors.

"Dinner is ready, Your Majesty."

"Everyone! Let's continue our festivities in the dining room over our meal!" Lexie announced as everyone convened to the dining room.

—

It was nice having the table full again. Everyone was enjoying their meal, continuing their chatter from earlier. Halina had taken Nicaise to bed when dinner started and sat with Shimmer and Archer, talking with Shimmer. Zimri was engaged in conversation with Bow as Marmoris talked with Glimmer, laughing.

Shiri sat between Finn and Nala, the younger magicat chattering happily to her about her school, her tail wrapped around Shiri's wrist. Finn had their hand resting on Shiri's thigh as they talked with Eira and Frosta. Shiri was fully engaged in Nala talking about one of her friends in her class when she felt a tap on her shoulder. She looked up and behind her to see a servant standing behind her, holding an envelope.

"This was just dropped off for you, Princess," the servant told her and Shiri took the envelope, a small frown gracing her lips as some of the chatter died down. She flipped it around, only seeing that it was addressed to her.

"If you all will excuse me for a moment," she told the table, pushing away from the table, giving Finn a reassuring squeeze on

their shoulder when she noticed their worried expression before walking away from the table. She stopped a few feet away and opened the envelope, reading the note inside.

Midnight tonight. Our usual place.

Come alone.

-A

Shiri stiffened as she read the note, breath hitching. She didn't want to meet him, she didn't want to have to depend on him ever again. After the last incident, she was scared to see him again. But she knew she needed more drugs. And he had promised to supply her. She really hated this, especially that he wanted her to come alone.

Shiri looked up, motioning to the servant to come forward as she stuffed the note back into the envelope. She handed it back to her, whispering as lowly as she could.

"Destroy this. Please."

The servant nodded, scurrying away as Shiri took a few deep breaths, trying to calm herself before she faced her family. She felt hands on her shoulders, causing her to flinch violently. She turned around to see Zimri standing there, holding his hands up in a peaceful gesture as he registered the panic on her face.

"Hey, it's okay. It's just me. Let's take a walk?" he said quietly, gently taking her arm to turn her around so she wasn't facing the table anymore. "Keep it together till we get out."

"Shiri? Are you okay?" she heard Finn call and Zimri waved his hand towards that direction with a smile.

"She's just a little flush from the wine. We're going to go walk around for a moment. We'll be right back," he told everyone as he led her out of the dining room and down the hallway, moving them far away from prying ears.

They stopped by a window overlooking the gardens and Zimri turned her back to face him, taking in the glistening tears in her eyes as she wrapped her arms around herself.

“Was the note from him?” Zimri asked and Shiri nodded, biting her lip.

“I have to go meet him… I don’t have a choice…”

“You do have a choice. Don’t do it, he’ll hurt you again,” Zimri begged her.

“I don’t have a choice, Z. No one is close to finding a cure and I know he’ll supply me, he gave me his word.”

“Yea, as he shot you in the shoulder! He’s not someone you can trust and I’m worried he’s going to suck you back into this game he’s playing.”

“He won’t. I won’t let him. I’m in a better place now, I can see through his lies and manipulation a lot easier than I used to. Just cover for me, please?” she asked, scraping her nails against her arm in worry.

“You’re scared. Let me come with you. You don’t have to do this alone,” he told her, pulling her hands away gently and holding them between his own.

“He said to come alone. If I don’t, he could kill me or you or whoever goes. Just trust me, okay? Until we find a cure, this is what I have to do.”

Zimri huffed, not liking this one bit. “I trust you but I don’t like this.”

“That’s okay. As long as you trust me. I don’t think I can go back in there…”

“You should go lie down. If you go in there looking like this, you’re going to put everyone on high alert. I’ll tell them you weren’t

feeling well."

"Thanks, you're the best twin ever. You can let Finn and Eira see me, Eira needed to speak with me about something."

"I'm your only twin but will do," he told her and hesitated before pulling her into a hug, surprising her. They hadn't hugged in a while and she returned it after her initial surprise wore off.

"You really are the best. I've missed this, I've missed you," she whispered as he just held her tighter.

"I've missed you too. I'm glad I have my sister back. Let's keep it that way," he told her before releasing her and disappearing back down the hallway.

_

Zimri re-entered the dining room, only to be met by multiple pairs of staring eyes at him, some with confusion, others with questions, most with concern. He didn't dare meet Finn's gaze, the magicat was too perceptive for their own good as he made his way over to his husband.

"Where did Shiri go?" his mom asked, frowning.

"She wasn't feeling well. Too much to drink probably, you know how she gets. She decided to lie down for a while," he told her nonchalantly as he took his seat, Marmoris squeezing his hand gently.

"She didn't even drink that much. Barely a glass, she doesn't like messing with alcohol too much," Finn responded, suspicion leaking in their voice as they glared at Zimri.

"It affects her differently now. You know, since she started sobering up and meditating more," Zimri said cooly, maintaining his composure but still refusing to meet Finn's gaze.

“She would have told me if she wasn’t feeling well. Besides, she only seemed affected after she received that note. What was the note about?” Finn continued, waving off a small hiss from Catra to knock it off.

“Aunt Perfuma was scheduling their next therapy session. I don’t know why you feel the need to question me about everything your girlfriend is doing. You would think that you would know about it already,” Zimri antagonized, receiving a pinch on the leg from his husband.

“Stop antagonizing them, Z. They're worried about their woman and you’re being an ass. Sweetie, she’s probably just tired. She’s been more exhausted lately, what with Princess Prom right around the corner, the sobriety thing, therapy sessions, and more. Just let her rest and go check on her in a little while,” Marmoris told Finn, giving Zimri a scolding glare.

“She has been more tired lately,” Halina piped up. “She naps a lot but that wasn’t so unusual before. She tended to sleep during the day to stay up at night but now she sleeps more constantly. Actually, last week I found her in the garden curled up on a bench when it was sunny out. I tried to get her to move cause I was worried about her getting a sunburn but she brushed me off.”

“I should go check on her if she’s been that exhausted. She may be getting sick,” Finn said, pushing away from the table at the same time Eira did.

“No, don’t worry about it. I’ll go check on her. I needed to talk to her about baby names anyways. Won’t do no one any good if you make yourself sick worrying about her,” Eira told them as Frosta grabbed her hand.

“Maybe you shouldn’t go if she is sick. I don’t want anything to happen to our son,” she told her with some worry and Eira bent down somewhat to kiss her wife on the forehead.

"I doubt she's sick. Just overworking herself. It'll be good to have some family time together. I'll be right back," Eira reassured her before heading out of the dining room. Afterward, the room started to go back to normal as everyone resumed their conversations. Finn didn't look satisfied but didn't push anything as they got up and headed towards Lexie at the head of the table.

"Aunt Lexie, can I speak with you for a moment?" they asked as the other adults raised eyebrows at them before Lexie nodded, getting up and moving away from the table so they could have some privacy.

"Is there something I can help you with? Is it about Shiri? Have you noticed anything?" Lexie asked when they were away from the table, worry and concern overtaking her. Finn held their hands up, shaking their head.

"It is about Shiri but she is fine as far as I can tell. She's perfect, actually…" Finn mumbled, a dopey smile starting to grace their features as Lexie tilted her head, smiling.

"Then what is it you need to talk with me about?"

"Well… I've been thinking and I know it's soon and quick but… we've known we've loved each other since we were kids, that's something that is never going to change. I want to always be by her side, to always love and support her through everything. She is going to be queen soon and it's not a job anyone should do alone. I want to show her that I support her and love her so… with your blessing… I want to marry her."

Lexie squealed loudly, pulling Finn into a bone-crushing hug that caused the conversation at the dining table to completely die off. Finn gasped in surprise as the older woman lifted them off the ground, swinging them around.

"Of course you have my blessing! Oh, this is so great! She's going to be so excited!" Lexie sat them down as they bent over, taking

in a breath. She turned towards the table with a triumphant smile. “In your face, Adora! I won this bet!”

“Betrayed by my own child?! What a cruel world I live in!” Adora said dramatically, a snort coming from her wife as Lexie turned back to Finn.

“Do you have a token yet? Wait, I know the perfect thing!” she told them, reaching up to unclasp the treble clef necklace from around her neck. Everyone gasped as she pulled it off, holding out towards Finn.

“Lex… that’s…” Glimmer said, at a loss for words as Finn stared down at the necklace.

“This was her mama’s that she gave me as a token of our marriage. Well, more of I took it and she never asked for it back. It actually helped her find me when I was on death's doors all those years ago… she saved my life. And now, I can’t think of anything better than for you to ask for her hand with it. Refurbish it as you see fit, I just ask you to keep the original charm.”

“Aunt Lexie… I can’t take this. It’s too generous, it’s one of the only things you have from Aunt Callie…” Finn told her, eyes glistening. Lexie shook her head, taking their hand and placing it in their palm, closing it.

“I have so much more from her. I don’t need a necklace to remind me of our love. She would want this, I know it. I just ask that you never stop loving my daughter and that you will protect her with everything you have. Promise me? That you will be there for her the same way that her mama was always there for me.”

“I promise that and more. Thank you so much.”

“Unofficially, welcome to the family. Not that you haven’t always been,” Lexie told them, hugging them again but a lot more gently. “You hear that, Adora?! We’re going to be in-laws!”

“I can’t think of anything better!” Adora said, coming over to join the hug, which then promoted a large group hug from everyone at the table.

Chapter End Notes

Song Creds: Poker Face Cover by Glee, Idina Menzel; absolutely obsessed with the show right now and thought this was a great little duet to include!

Long chapter, ended up having to break it up into two so stay tuned for part two before Princess Prom!

Be sure to kudos and comment! I absolutely love all the support I have received for this book and my series as a whole! :)

Chapter 15

Chapter Summary

Shiri has a good talk with her aunt and sneaks out to meet with Alejandro

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 15

Shiri found herself sitting in the window seat of her room, staring out at the lit-up city below her. This was always her favorite view, the city that she grew up in, glowing brightly under the star-lit sky. It was hard to believe that there had been a time where there were no stars.

She also found that the window was a great place to try to meditate. She had been trying to meditate as Aunt Perfuma had instructed. It had been hard, she didn't like meditating after spending years doing it under the Heart but it was also natural and comforting. But her nerves were also too wired, she felt on edge about tonight, about everything and she couldn't relax enough to actually have a successful meditation.

She jolted slightly when she heard a knock on her door and turned to see Eira enter her room, waddling slightly with her large stomach. The sight of her aunt relaxed her as the large woman came over to the window, pulling herself up to sit beside her. It was silent, a comfortable silence that they could only have with the other. They grew up together, they were practically like sisters if Shiri ever needed an older sister.

Eira reached a handout, her fingers tracing through the short locks she had not seen on Shiri before, her hand falling limp before it even reached her shoulder. "You know… love looks beautiful on you, Ri-Ri."

“You think?” Shiri asked sincerely, cheeks flushing. Eira nodded with a smile.

“Yea… I’ve never seen such a look about you before. It’s… soft and gentle. This is the first time I can genuinely say you look like Aunt Callie.”

She doesn’t know why but that comment made her burst out into tears, gentle sobs erupting from her chest as Eira held out her arms, adjusting so her legs were thrown over onto the bench and she was propped up against the wall. Shiri climbed into them, resting her head on her chest as the tears, big fat ones, rolled down her cheek and onto her aunt's pregnant stomach.

“You’re even crying like her! Oh, honey,” Eira cooed, stroking Shiri’s hair as the younger girl cried.

“What's wrong with me? I-I don’t c-cry like this,” she hiccuped, unable to stop the onslaught of sobs. “I’ve been so tired lately! I fell asleep on a marble bench in the garden the other day! Everything hurts, especially my breasts! And I can smell everything! You smell like the chicken we had for dinner!”

Eira couldn’t help but laugh at the outburst. “Honey, you sound pregnant.”

Shiri sniffled, wiping her tears away, trying to push down the sobs, leaving small whimpers escaping her lips. “I… I can’t be…”

“Maybe you aren’t and you’re just very hormonal. Just a thought.”

It was a horrifying thought. A thought she hadn’t wanted to have for a few more years. It was bad timing if it was true. She had just started getting her life on track, she had stopped clubbing and hanging around bad people. She mostly stopped drinking, she was in a healthy relationship… She had too much on her plate to worry about a baby right now.

“I can’t be. I have this drug in my system and I have three options at this point: take another dose and buy myself another

month, hope that they came up with a cure, or die. None of those options involve or are friendly to a baby. And I'm not mommy material, a baby deserves much better than what I have to offer," Shiri told her, wrapping her arms around herself.

"Ri-Ri, you would be an amazing mommy. Your child would be so loved by you and everyone around them. Don't shortchange yourself. If it's true, and we're not saying it is, you have time to figure it out. You can have everything you've ever wanted and more," Eira told her, placing her hands on her arms in a comforting gesture. Shiri smiled sadly at her, shaking her head.

"That's the problem… I can't have everything I want. It comes at too high a cost. Ra-Ra… I'm tired of fighting…" Shiri told her quietly, shoulders sagging with the weight she has been carrying around. Eira knew it was serious because Shiri had not called her Ra-Ra in years, decades really.

"Then stop fighting and just rest. We can figure everything out later," Eira said, moving to get off the window cubby and help Shiri up, guiding her to her bed. Shiri sighed but crawled in, allowing Eira to tuck in the blankets around her. As she went to leave, Shiri reached out, grabbing hold of her hand and looking up at her with pleading eyes.

"Don't leave… I sleep better with someone nearby…" Shiri mumbled sheepishly and Eira nodded in understanding, sliding into the bed beside her but propping up to sit up. Shiri curled against the older girl's lap, throwing her arm across it before closing her eyes, slowly drifting off to sleep.

—

Finn knocked softly on Shiri's door about half an hour later before entering, noting that the room was dark but able to see the two figures in bed. Eira blinked awake, having drifted off alongside her niece, and squinted to see who the figure in the doorway was. Finn held up their hands as they walked in, closing the door gently behind them.

“I’m just checking on her. How is she?” Finn whispered as they approached the bed, looking at Shiri’s resting form.

“Exhausted but fine. She didn’t want to be left alone. On a scale of 1 to 10, how mad is my wife?” Eira whispered back jokingly, causing Finn to smile.

“Definitely going frosty down there. You should reassure her that you’re safe,” Finn told her, helping the pregnant woman get up from the bed and escort her to the door. Eira stopped as she cracked it open, looking at the magicat with a soft smile.

“Take care of her, Finn. She’s… struggling right now. There is a lot on her and she’s putting up a good front. Don’t get me wrong, I think she is genuinely happy, the happiest we’ve seen her in a while, but she is tired and fragile. Just watch out for her.”

“I plan on doing just that and more… I’m hoping to ask her to marry me during Princess Prom,” Finn whispered with a smile that caused Eira to beam excitedly. She pulled the magicat into a hug, or as much of one that her belly would allow, which they returned happily.

“Our family is crazy, I hope you’re ready,” Eira told him, pulling away to give their shoulder a squeeze before disappearing into the hallway. Finn sighed happily, turning to go back over to the bed.

They crawled in behind Shiri, being gentle not to wake her, before curling around her sleeping form, wrapping their arms around her stomach. She moved slightly, sighing as she settled back down in her sleep as Finn nuzzled into her neck, scenting her. They enjoyed watching her sleep the most because she couldn’t hide. Her body relaxed, there was no tension or anxiety on her face and she was calm. It was always a relief to see her sleep. It didn’t take long for Finn to settle down and drift off alongside their mate.

–

Shiri woke up feeling warm and safe. It was a feeling she always had when Finn was with her and she was tempted to snuggle deeper into the bed and the embrace but judging by the position of the moon, she needed to get going. But she had no idea how she was going to pull out of Finn's embrace without waking them. Very slowly, she eased out of their arms, trying her hardest not to jostle them too much. She didn't succeed.

"Shiri?" she heard them grumble as they blinked up blearily at her, still half asleep. She smiled and cooed softly at how adorable they were, leaning forward to scratch behind their ears gently. Finn started purring softly, leaning into the soft touch.

"I'm just going to get some water and take a walk. I'll be back soon," she explained softly and Finn started to sit up.

"I can go with you."

"No, I'll be fine. It's just a walk. Go back to sleep, my kitty," she whispered, kissing their forehead as they slowly laid back, looking up at her.

"Are you sure…?" they mumbled, already drifting off, causing her to smile.

"I'm sure. I'll be home soon."

–

Shiri made it to the Crimson Waste with little time to spare, making her way into the club that was blaring loudly enough to be heard from outside. She winced at the loudness, rubbing her temples as she weaved her way through the crowd. How she had managed to endure this for so many years, she will never understand. The smell of alcohol and sweat permeated her nostrils, making her want to gag.

She easily found her way to the familiar booth she had spent so many black nights reclining in, feeling on top of the world and unstoppable. The sight of the booth had brought her elation but

now brought her fear. Alejandro sat, reclined, in the booth, drinking brown liquor from a glass as he surveyed the room. His eyes landed on Shiri's figure, a crooked smile gracing his features as he beckoned her forward.

Shiri shuddered in fear as she stepped forward, her shoulder aching slightly from the memory of the bullet piercing through it. Alejandro thought the shudder was of excitement as he grabbed her wrist, pulling her down into his lap. He ran his nose up her neck, taking in her scent as his hand found its way to her covered thigh. She hadn't bothered to dress up, still in the loose green dress from dinner. She felt like she wanted to vomit from the contact, it didn't make her feel good like Finn's did.

"You didn't bother to look nice for me, princess. I'm kinda disappointed, I always enjoyed those skin-tight dresses you'd show off for me."

"This is a brief interaction. I'd prefer if you'd take your hands off of me," she told him, pushing away until she was sitting beside him instead of on top of him. He gave her a fake pout.

"You're no fun anymore. We used to have a lot of fun together. Don't you remember those long nights we'd spend in the back…?" he whispered in her ear, nibbling it lightly. She put her hands on his chest, pushing him away lightly.

"I'm not interested. I'm in a good relationship. I'm only here for you to hold up your end of our… arrangement…" she muttered, unconsciously touching her shoulder. He smirked at the movement, putting his hand in his pocket and producing the vial with red liquid in it. She went to grab it but he held it out of her reach.

"You're a very eager little princess. Stay awhile, have a drink with me. Just like the good old days."

"I'm not interested, Alejandro. I want my vial so I can go home to my partner and sleep. I'm done playing these games with you,"

she told him, reaching forward again to get the vial. He frowned, grabbing her jaw harshly and pulling her forward into a searing kiss. She grabbed his arm, trying to pull away but he kept her in place. Shiri bit down onto his lip, causing him to jerk away, blood pooling. He growled, backhanding her violently, sending her hand whipping back into the seat of the booth.

"Ungrateful bitch. I gave you everything and this is how you repay me? By shacking up with some furball? When you were at your lowest, when you had nothing, I was there for you. I gave you everything you could ever want: control, power, sex. You could have ruled this wasteland with me!"

Shiri cupped her cheek, knowing it was going to bruise as she looked at him with watery eyes. How did she put up with this for so long? He reached forward, taking her face into his hands gently.

"I forgive you, Shiri. We can forget all of this ever happened if you would leave the furball and come back to me, the one who truly understands you. You know I don't want to hurt you but you leave me no choice. I had to, it's for your own good. Now, be a good girl for me like you used to."

Tears leaked out of her eyes. She had heard him say that so much over the years and only now recognized the bullshit behind them. This is not what a healthy relationship looked like, this is not what love felt like. It wasn't fear-driven or manipulative. Finn never did this. She started singing softly while staring into his stormy eyes.

You are a drug

You are a poison pill

I've got to kick this habit now or else I never will

I love the rush

When you would hold me close

But you will not be satisfied until I overdose

T his is it

Hit the brake

I am finally awake

Let me be

Let me go

You need help

I can't provide

I am not qualified

This troubled me is getting clean

I say no

She managed to pull away from him, standing up and moving away from the booth as he followed after her, sneering angrily as he grabbed her arm. "Shiri, who else is-"

"No, No, No!" she yelled, jerking her arm away as she put her hands to her chest.

Don't say a word

You speak and I cave in

You'll twist the truth again

And drill deep down beneath my skin

You said you'd change

And I believed in you

But you're still using me

To justify the harm you do

This is it

Hit the break

Call it all my mistake

Long as you let me go

You need help

I can't provide

I'm not Bonnie, you're not Clyde

It's not too late, I'm getting straight

I say no

"You can't say no to me! I own you! You're mine! You're everything to me!" Alejandro screamed as people started watching the scene unfold. She hadn't noticed that Finn, Archer, Shimmer, and Halina had made it into the club, Finn having woken up about half an hour after Shiri had left and known something was wrong. Halina had coaxed the truth out of her older brother and they had rushed to the Crimson Waste as quickly as possible. Shiri trembled but stood her ground, taking in a shaky breath.

Blame your childhood

Blame your dad

Blame the life you never head

But hurting people

That's your choice, my friend

'Cause I believe that love will win

And hate will earn you nothing in the end

This is the end

Alejandro grabbed her arms desperately, a wild look in his eyes as he stared at her. Finn growled when they saw the contact, stepping forward before Archer placed a hand on their shoulder to stop them.

"But I love you!" Alejandro yelled, causing a look of disbelief to cross Shiri's face as she jerked her arms away.

"Dude," she whispered softly.

This is it

I won't cry

Starting now

I will try

To pay back all the karma I owe

Start again, somewhere new

Far from cool guys like you

So goodbye 'cause now I

I say no

Shiri gave him a pitying look, turning her back to walk away. She heard him growl, felt his body come towards her, and tensed but never felt the blow to her back. She slowly turned, gasping as she

saw Finn standing there, holding Alejandro's raised fist in his hand, claws digging into the skin.

"You lay a hand on my girl again and I'll make you regret it," they told him, pushing him away from them. Alejandro stumbled back, glaring angrily at them as Shiri stepped forward, wrapping an arm around Finn's waist.

"They're using you, Shiri," Alejandro said, backing up slowly. Shiri scrunched her eyebrows in confusion, feeling slight tension radiate off Finn. "They're using you to get to me. You'll come begging on your knees for my forgiveness one day."

"Get the fuck out of here before I change my mind and make sure you rot in a prison cell," Finn snarled, flashing their claws as Alejandro narrowed his eyes and retreated back into the crowd. Shiri moved away from them slightly as the rest of the group joined, Halina pulling Shiri into a hug.

"What were you thinking?! You said you gave up the club life! You idiot sister!" Halina scolded her older sister, who laughed slightly at the worry.

"I did. I'm not a liar. We had a deal, I should have known he would be up to his old tricks."

"You nearly gave me a heart attack," Finn said, pulling Shiri away from Halina and into a bone-crushing hug that she melted into. This felt right, this was safe. They rubbed their cheeks against her neck and cheeks, rubbing away Alejandro's scent to replace it with their own. They growled slightly when they noticed the bruises on her cheek and along her jaw.

"I should have killed him for touching you," they said and Shiri took their face gently into her hands, pressing their foreheads together.

"I'm fine. It doesn't even hurt, he's done worse…" she whispered, causing Finn to growl more loudly.

“I hate to break up the lovefest but we really should go,” Archer told them, looking around nervously. Shiri nodded in agreement, leading them out of the club and over to her skiff, where Finn helped her board as the others followed suit.

“Did you guys teleport here?” Shiri asked in disbelief as she started up the skiff and maneuvered it out and back across the desert. Shimmer nodded, leaning back, exhausted.

“It was the quickest way, also my longest teleport to date so I’m going to take a nap,” she said, closing her eyes.

“Aw, you guys love me, that’s so embarrassing!” Shiri teased, causing Shimmer to stick her tongue out at the older girl and Archer to roll his eyes, wrapping an arm around Halina.

“Dummy, you already knew I loved you! We’re related!” Halina told her, scowling.

“But still…” Shiri laughed, setting up the coordinates and the automatic pilot before going to sit with them, Finn automatically wrapping their arm around her. Their tail was thrashing angrily, soft growls still emitting from their chest. She leaned against them, wrapping an arm around them and reaching up to scratch at their ears.

“Honey, what’s wrong?” she whispered as they looked down at her, a scowl on their face.

“How could you be so stupid? Why didn’t you ask for help?” they asked. She bit her lip, looking down at her lap.

“Because… I didn’t want to worry you or anybody else. I’ve dealt with his bullshit for years and while it took me a while to open my eyes and realize that I was being manipulated and used, I get him. I understand him better than everyone else does therefore I can… deal with his personality.”

“He’s still manipulating you if you believe that you understand him. You can’t reach him or change him. He’s dangerous and you

should have told us that you were meeting him. Why were you meeting him, anyway? Do you still love him?”

“What?! No! I don’t think I ever loved him, it was an arrangement of convenience for the both of us. Finn… I love you. It’s always been you, okay?” she told them, moving to sit in front of them and caress their face gently. Finn leaned into the touch, relaxing slightly before looking at her with big, blue eyes.

“Then what possessed you to risk your life like that?”

“We aren’t any closer to finding a cure. We’re running out of time, the drug only lasts a month at a time. We had a deal, that he would keep supplying me if I paid with my blood and that’s what I did. The night I was shot… He owes me a vial and I have to keep taking it until you guys come up with something different. I’m sorry, I should have told you, that was stupid of me.”

“I forgive you but you really need to stop scaring me like that. The fear alone is making me lose one of my nine lives,” Finn joked lightly, pulling her close so she straddled their lap. They wrapped their arms around her back, holding her close to inhale her scent.

“I will try not to do that again. I don’t want to burn through your nine lives since I want to spend every one of them with you,” she giggled and Finn snorted, looking at her.

“That was super cheesy, even for you.”

Chapter End Notes

I'm getting to the juicy bits by the next chapter, I promise! Kudos and comments, please!

Song Creds: I Say No from The Heathers, sung by Carrie Hope Fletcher

Chapter 16

Chapter Summary

Princess Prom part 1!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 16

Finn stood in front of the full-length mirror in their room, allowing their mom to adjust the bowtie she insisted they wear. They wore their mama Catra's old red suit, blonde hair brushed to the side. Adora finished adjusting the bowtie, moving away to stand behind them, hands on their shoulders.

"You look extremely handsome, Finny," she said affectionately, kissing their head lightly.

"Thanks, mom. But I don't understand why I have to wear the bowtie done up. Why can't I leave it undone as mama did?"

"Because you're not cool enough for that," Catra said from the doorway, moving forward into the room as Nala ran inside, sporting a matching red dress similar to her mom's old one, hair was done up in an elegant bun.

"Finn! Finn! Mama did my hair! Do you like it?" she bounced around the two eagerly while Finn smiled.

"I love it. You're going to be the prettiest girl at Princess Prom," Finn told her, causing the young magicat to giggle.

"No! My best friend Shiri is going to be the prettiest girl there! Have you noticed that she smells better lately? Very sweet, like strawberries!"

“You know, now that I think about it, her scent has changed recently. It does smell sweeter,” Catra commented, going to undo Finn’s bowtie and unbutton the first few moments that made them raise an eyebrow.

“Thought I wasn’t cool enough to pull off the look?” they smirked at their mama, who rolled her eyes.

“You’re not but Shiri will enjoy the look,” Catra smirked back as Adora rolled her own eyes, going to grab the red roses to pin on Finn’s jacket and place it in Nala’s hair.

“How is Shiri doing? She wasn’t feeling well earlier this week during dinner,” Adora said, fixing the rose. Finn tapped their foot on the floor impatiently, remembering that they hadn’t told her about the incident in the Crimson Waste.

“She’s fine. I haven’t seen her since then because she’s been helping with final preparations for Princess Prom but we've chatted a little on the com-pads and her migraine is starting to build. Seems like we only have a few days left before she starts detoxing again and we’re still no closer to finding a solution.”

“Then we need to get our hands on some of the drugs to tie her over and buy us more time. Has she said anything else about Alejandro?”

“He’s manipulating her. She may not be around him anymore but she definitely has the idea that he’s just some misunderstood baddie with a bad past. She thinks she understands him and can get through to him.”

Adora frowned, contemplating this information as Catra placed a hand on her arm. Finn looked at their mom, worried.

“We need to bring him to justice and quickly. Especially if they’re still connected like that, has that much influence over her. He’s proven that he’s not afraid to dispose of her when he feels like it and that makes him a danger to the throne of Musicia and all the other kingdoms. Do you have any leads? Where he camps out?”

“None. She won’t say much more about it. The interactions we’ve seen them have have been in the Crimson Waste but that’s all we know. He could be hiding anywhere there.”

“I hate to say it… but we may need to pull Shiri into this operation and convince her to oust him,” Catra said and Finn shook their head.

“She won’t do it. She won’t betray him like that. She’s… she’s scared of him. She won’t do anything that will cause retaliation in any form.”

“We have to figure out something. I don’t want our future daughter-in-law to live under this dark cloud longer than she has to,” Adora said, Catra and Finn agreeing wholeheartedly.

“Which, are you excited about? You’re going to ask her tonight,” Catra asked.

“I’m beyond excited. Halina and Zimri will be performing and the other princesses will be helping clear the dance floor. I got the pendant to reset into a new necklace,” they told their moms, going to grab a box off their nightstand and bringing it over, opening it to show them. The treble cleft pendant was attached to a black leather strand, six glass beads of different colors set along the strand, three on either side.

“Wow Finn, that’s beautiful. She’s going to love it,” Adora told them, smiling.

“What do the beads stand for?” Catra asked, touching them gently.

“The six elemental runestones. I found a glassmaker who could make them quickly. You really think she’s going to love it?” they asked, feeling nervous and unsure.

“If she doesn’t say yes, she’s a damn fool. But there is no chance in hell she’ll say no after everything you two have been through.

Oh, I can’t believe we’re going to be planning a wedding!” Adora said eagerly, bouncing slightly on her heels.

“Remember when we announced our engagement at the music festival to Calliope and Lexie?” Catra asked Adora with a fond smile, nuzzling against her arm.

“Oh, yea! Calliope squealed so loudly, she actually broke Mermista’s wine glass. She was more excited about planning the wedding than we were. And then you two wrote our wedding song, it was absolutely beautiful,” Adora said with a far-off look, a sad smile playing on her lips. “I miss her.”

“I miss her too… besides you, Glimmer and Bow… she was my best friend,” Catra said, looking over at Finn who was getting misty-eyed.

“I miss Aunt Callie too… She was always so full of life, always happy and bouncy. It’s like she lived on a cloud and nothing could ever bring her back down to earth.”

“She was truly one of a kind. She was like glue, keeping us all together. Keeping her family together. This wedding was her dream, seeing her daughter marry the person she loved. Let’s make it one to remember,” Adora said.

—

Shiri was practicing her vocal range as she pinned her short locks to the side of her head, using a diamond hairpiece to pin it back. They had a big opening number for Princess Prom that she had spent weeks practicing for and it needed to go perfectly. But she had too much on her mind, she couldn’t calm down her thoughts long enough.

She hadn’t been able to stop remembering the last words Alejandro said to her. *They’re using you to get to me.* She had tried to ignore it, tried to push it down deep within her because she couldn’t believe him. Everything he said was a lie, was a manipulative tactic to get under her skin. But she had a bad

feeling, a deep down gut feeling that it wasn't a complete lie. And that hurt more than any manipulation or gunshot he would make her endure. But she didn't know how to get Finn to confess, she didn't know if she even wanted them to.

It also didn't help that she had gone to the royal physician that week after a vomiting episode early one morning. They had confirmed what Eira had predicted: Shiri was pregnant, about three or four weeks to be exact. That made her nervous and… excited. She was excited about having a kitten with the love of her life but also horrified at the fact that they may have been using her for months and this entire situation started based on lies.

"You went quiet, sis," Halina said, stepping out of the closet in her prom dress. The entire royal family was wearing royal blue and gold, the colors of Musica. She wore a strapless blue dress that fit against her body, with a sweetheart neckline and a low plunging back. The skirt swept down to her feet and the entire thing was covered in shimmery fabric that sparkled when she moved. She had paired it with gold heels and a gold collar with multiple chains that sat across her shoulders and up her neck. Her white curls were pinned up into intricate braids, small flowers adorning the look.

"Wow… Hallie… you look beautiful," Shiri said, turning around to face her sister after seeing her appearance in the mirror. Halina blushed happily, twirling around to show it off more as Shiri wolf-whistled, standing up to go to her sister. "Absolutely breathtaking."

"You're beautiful too, sis," Halina told her, examining her older sister. Shiri wore a floor-length gown in the same color as Halina's, with an off-the-shoulder neckline that left her shoulders bare and a long slit up the side of her dress that ended mid-thigh. It was sleek and elegant and she had paired it with similar gold shoes to Halina. Shiri went to put on a necklace but Halina stopped her.

"Don't wear a necklace. It'll mess up the look you're creating," she told her sister. Shiri frowned, touching her throat softly.

“But my shoulders and neck are completely bare. I need to wear something.”

“I have an idea!” Halina said, going to the vanity and grabbing the jar of gold shimmer and brush, working on creating a light sheen across her sister’s shoulders and neck. Shiri put on her earrings when her sister was done and turned to look in the mirror, admiring Halina’s work.

“It looks nice but I wish I could wear a necklace. I feel kinda naked,” Shiri admitted and Halina laughed as they heard a knock before the door opened, revealing Zimri and Marmoris. Both wore matching black slacks and deep blue button-up shirts with a few buttons undone and black jackets. Marmoris had his makeup done, thick eyeliner framing his dark green eyes. Zimri smiled when he saw his sisters and went over, kissing both of their cheeks.

“You both look amazing. I’m the luckiest guy on Etheria, being surrounded by so many beautiful ladies,” he teased as Marmoris rolled his eyes, stepping forward to kiss the girls as well.

“You look wonderful, Mari,” Shiri told him, squeezing his shoulder gently. She had really neglected her relationship with her brother-in-law. Marmoris smiled happily, accepting the compliment as the door opened once again, Lexie stepping inside.

The queen wore a large ballroom gown in royal blue with gold designs weaving around the skirt and bodice. It has a straight across neckline with no sleeves, a jewel-encrusted collar resting against her neck. She wore her tiara across her brow, the gems in the failsafe ornament gleaming brilliantly in the middle of her forehead.

“I bring tiaras!” she announced, the young adults noticing the pillow she carried in her arms. She stepped forward, holding it out for all of them to take their tiaras. Halina and Marmoris had simple gold bands with a single gemstone in the middle, one the replicated their runestone that rested on their heads similarly to

Lexies. Zimri and Shiri's were identical and sat on top of their heads with three prongs, large rune stones inlaid in them and surrounded by clear colored gemstones in an intricate design. They had insisted years ago that their crowns had been identical to each other and had designed them themselves.

"Wow… You all look so wonderful! Tonight, I am the proudest mom on Etheria. You all have worked so hard on this Princess Prom and the work is not over yet but I know that this is going to be a party that they talk about for the next decade. Let's go out there and start greeting our guests," she told them, rolling back her shoulders and leading her small army out of the bedroom.

_

Princess Prom was being held in the ballroom and it was decorated in Musicia's colors, shimmering beautifully in the setting sun. The thrones sat upon a dais, two staircases on either side leading up and into the palace, another in front leading down onto the dance floor. Above them sat the last portrait the royal family had taken together, Queen Calliope smiling down on the crowd.

Lexie sat on her throne, she had never had the heart to take Calliope's after her death even though she was the active reigning queen. There were two thrones on either side of the two big thrones, totaling six. Zimri and Marmrois sat beside Lexie's throne, Zimri right at her arm to reach up and touch his mom when need be. Shiri went to go sit on her that was beside her mama's old throne but Lexie stopped her.

"Sit on your mama's tonight," she told her, causing Shiri's eyes to go as wide as saucers.

"But… I'm not the reigning queen…" she argued, biting her lip.

"You will be one day, this is the perfect chance for you to practice and for the other kingdoms to see you in a position of power. This is your kingdom and this will be your throne. You might as well get used to it," Lexie informed her, patting the armrest of the

throne in invitation. Shiri turned to Halina, who had started towards her at the far end of the row, away from everyone else as Shiri's usual seat was beside Calliope's.

"Hallie, take my seat tonight?" she asked Halina, who smiled in relief and nodded. Both girls took their seats and guests started filing in and soft music started playing.

"Okay children. Backs straight, bright smiles. Let's greet our guests with all the courtesy our kingdom has," Lexie told them as everyone straightened their backs, putting on their best smiles as the first couple came up to bow.

Through the course of the hour, Shiri could start feeling the migraine build in her temples. She gritted her teeth slightly through her smile as she greeted each guest, the other kingdom representatives finally showing as well. First was Plumeria and Scorpion, Queens Flora and Scorpia greeting them along with Princess Flora and Princess Aster.

"Save me a dance for later?" Princess Flora had asked excitedly, to which Shiri agreed wholeheartedly, having missed her friend.

Next was Salineas, with only Queen Mermista and King Seahawk greeting them. Princess Sereia was nowhere in sight, which caused the smile Shiri was trying to maintain to slip for a moment.

"Princess Sereia will be along shortly, Princess Shiri. She is running late, as usual," Seahawk reassured her and Shiri nodded slightly.

Snows came up, Queen Frosta and Queen Eira sporting huge grins as they bowed, Eira having to hold onto her large belly to do so. Shiri smiled back in greeting, promising her aunt a dance later in the evening. It went like that for a while with the other kingdoms such as Dryl, Nets, and Winds until Brightmoon finally showed.

Queen Glimmer and King Bow bowed before the thrones in greeting before Glimmer spoke up. "Reverend Hostess, we come

under the ancient rules of hospitality, bringing greetings from Brightmoon."

"You are welcome under the ancient rules of hospitality. Leave conflict at the door and please, enjoy the ball," Lexie told them as they bowed again and moved aside for Prince Archer and Princess Shimmer to greet the hostess in the same fashion. Shiri chanced a glance over to Halina, who was watching Archer with a blush on her cheeks. Shiri smiled then leaned over to her mom, whispering softly.

"May Halina be excused to join Archer?" she asked and Lexie looked at her, thinking for a moment before nodding in agreement.

"Princess Halina, why don't you escort the Prince of Brightmoon and make him feel comfortable?" Shiri asked her, watching as her sister's eyes lit up and she stood from her throne, turning to bow before her family before going to take Archer's outstretched arm, being led away into the crowd. Shiri smiled as she watched them go, turning to greet the next guest.

Adora and Catra stepped forward, bowing to greet the royal family before Adora spoke up. "Reverend Hostess, we come under the ancient rules of hospitality with greetings from She-Ra, the legendary warrior."

"You are welcome under the ancient rules of hospitality, She-Ra, Princess of Power. Leave conflict at the door and please, enjoy the ball," Lexie said with a wink that was missed by her eldest daughter. Adora smirked, leading Catra to the side as Finn and Nala stepped forward. Both bowed and greeted the royal family, Nala stumbled over her words slightly.

Shiri's heart fluttered as she watched Finn, hand ghosting near her stomach. There was still that small seed of doubt in the back of her mind but looking at them, watching that cocky smirk grace their features and their ears twitch with the noise of the room,

Shiri knew she was completely and undoubtedly, stupidly, painfully in love with them.

She was so lost in thought that she didn't realize that they had their handheld out to her with silent intention. She gave her mom a quick glance, who nodded in encouragement.

"Just be ready for the opening number," her mom whispered softly, reaching over to squeeze her daughter's hand gently. Shiri nodded in acknowledgment, squeezing her mom's hand back before standing, straightening her back as she descended the stairs, taking their outstretched hand with a smile. They pulled her close, clasping their hands between them as they pressed their forehead against hers. The world melted away around them and it was just the two of them.

Finn smiled, kissing her hands gently. "Have I told you that you look absolutely breathtaking?"

Shiri giggled softly, gazing up at them happily. "You just did. You're so handsome. How did I get so lucky?"

"I ask myself that every day," they told her as they heard a voice clear behind them and turned to see Zimri giving them a look.

"As beautiful and touching as this is, we still have guests to greet. Move along, lovebirds."

Shiri laughed, Finn, taking her arm and leading her away from the thrones and into the crowd.

—

They spent the next twenty minutes making their rounds to their friends, Flora squishing Shiri into a bone-crushing hug. Shiri squeaked at the contact, causing Shimmer to laugh. This was nice, being surrounded by her friends at a party, just like the good old days. Flora finally sat her down, smiling happily. Shiri turned her head away from her friends as she felt the migraine spike violently, hissing softly as her fingers flew to her temples.

“Shiri? Are you okay?” Finn asked with concern, placing a gentle hand on her shoulder. Shiri turned back to them, forcing a smile.

“I’m fine. Just my migraine. Don’t worry so much, kitty,” she reassured them, seeing that they weren’t buying her excuse. That’s when she looked up and met Zimri’s eyes as he nodded towards her. It was time. “I have to go. Duty calls. Save the first dance for me?”

Finn nodded, kissing her softly before letting her go. “Always.”

Shiri moved away from her friends, going towards the back of the ballroom as she watched the waiters for the evening usher everyone to their tables. The tables scattered around the edges of the large dance floor, which would give her plenty of room for the number. The stage was set up on the dais where the thrones were held, the chairs having been moved back to make room for the musical instruments and microphones.

She opened the doors and stepped outside, closing them behind her and leaning against them heavily. She needed a moment, she needed to breathe before she started to perform. She could feel the migraine trying to intensify, pushing farther through her brain. She had a couple of days, max until it killed her if she didn’t fix it.

She heard the music start playing and she turned, schooling her expression as she counted the beats. She straightened her back, putting on her best smile as she heard her cue, and opened the doors back up with a flourish, the room dark saved for the spotlight that shone on her.

Don’t tell me not to live

Just sit and putter

Life’s candy and the sun’s

A ball of butter

Don’t bring around a cloud

To rain on my parade!

Don't tell me not to fly

I've simply got to

If someone takes a spill

It's me and not you

Who told you you're allowed

To rain on my parade!

She had rushed forward into the middle of the room as she sang, spinning around gracefully as the beat changed and she started tapping her heels against the floor, the clicks echoing through the room. Zimri and Marmoris were on the dance floor as well, spinning around with her in tandem.

I'll march my band out

I'll beat my drum

And if I'm fanned out

Your turn at bat, sir

At least I didn't fake it

Hat sir, at least I didn't make it

But whether I'm the rose

Of sheer perfection

Or a freckle on the nose

Of life's complexion

The cinder or the shiny apple of its eye

I've gotta fly once

I gotta try once

Only can die once, right, sir?

Oh, life is juicy

Juicy, and you see

I gotta have my bite, sir!

She twirled between the two men, each taking turns grabbing her and spinning her, the room blurring around her quick movements as she got closer to the stairs.

Get ready for me, love

Cause I'm a commer

I simply gotta march

My hearts a drummer

Don't bring around a cloud

To rain on my parade!

I'm gonna live and live now

Get what I want

I know-how

One roll for the whole show bang

One throw, that bell will go clang

Eye on the target and wham

One-shot, one gunshot, and BAM

She made it to the stairs after dancing with her two brothers and quickly stepped up a couple til she was in the middle, both men flanking her as she turned to face the audience, smiling. A few dancers that had been hired to help with the number stepped forward in front of the stairs, forming a cancan line as the music started to slow and so did her singing.

Hey, Mister Armstein

Here I am!

I'll march my band out

I'll beat my drum

And if I'm fanned out

Your turn at bat, sir

At least I didn't fake it

Hat, sir, I guess I didn't make it

The dancers dispersed as she neared the end of the song and made her way completely up the stage, standing at the top, arms outstretched to her sides.

Get ready for me, love

'Cause I'm a commer

I simply gotta march

My hearts a drummer

Nobody, no, nobody

Is gonna

Rain on my

Parade!

She held the last note for seven seconds as the music played on before concluding, her chest heaving excitedly as the room exploded in a roar of excitement, everyone standing and clapping at the performance. She smiled brilliantly as Zimri and Marmoris came to stand beside her, all three of them clasping hands and bowing, urging the crowd into louder applause.

Lexie came up to the microphone as the three basked in the praise, smiling proudly at her children before turning towards the crowd.

"Welcome to the Kingdom of Musicia's first Princess Prom since our reconstruction thirty years ago! Let's give another big hand to the Crown Prince and Princess for that amazing performance! Weren't they awesome?!"

The crowd cheered in agreement as everyone started to take their seats again.

"We would like to thank each and every one of you for coming out tonight. This day had always been my late wife's dream from the moment she found out we would be hosting. Unfortunately, she is not here to see her dream come to fruition but I know that she would be so proud of the hard work and dedication that our children put forth into making tonight absolutely magical. While we have a band to perform songs for your dancing pleasure, we encourage everyone to try their hand at performing tonight! As Calliope would always say, music is a universal language and if someone like me, a trained soldier with zero musical background, can learn to play the piano, then anyone can understand music. Now, without further ado, enjoy the ball and we will be announcing the first dance shortly!"

The crowd clapped for Lexie’s speech as the band started playing soft music. Lexie went over and hugged her three kids, who returned the affection happily.

“Your mama would be so proud of you. You did amazingly tonight. That performance was absolutely breathtaking. Enjoy the dance for a while, okay?” They nodded as Lexie stepped away, going to join the crowd and the other queens on the dance floor. Shiri looked around eagerly for Finn, eyes finally finding them talking with Flora.

She started down the stairs until she heard the doors open. Her head lifted up and froze as she saw who entered. Blood was pounding in her ears as Princess Sereia entered the room, holding onto the arm of Alejandro.

Chapter End Notes

> Dun, dun, dun! Any predictions on what you think will happen? Kudos and comment!
>
> Don't Rain on My Parade from Glee (I'm super obsessed with the show atm)

Chapter 17

Chapter Summary

Princess Prom, A proposal, a twist

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 17

Chaos ensued as Princess Sereia and Alejandro made their way across the room to the dais. Finn had made their way to Shiri's side instantly, growling at the approaching couple, Archer and Shimmer had started arguing with Lexie who had stepped forward to the top of the stairs. Sereia bit her lip nervously as she stopped at the bottom of the stairs and swooped down into a bow along with Alejandro. Adora was on the edge of the crowd with her wife and the rest of the Best Friend Squad, glaring at Alejandro.

"Reverend Hostess, we come under the ancient rules of hospitality, bringing greetings from Salineas and the Crimson Waste," Sereia told Lexie as she straightened up, looking up at the Queen Consort but not quite meeting her eye.

"Reverend Hostess, you cannot allow this man to attend the All Princess Ball! He's a threat to Etheria!" Shimmer exclaimed, gesturing wildly. Alejandro stepped forward, causing everyone to go into defense mode as he raised his hands in silent surrender.

"Reverend Hostess, I come under the ancient rules of hospitality. I am the Princess' plus one and I understand the rules of Princess Prom. You have no legitimate reason to not allow me entrance."

"You're plotting something! Sereia, why are you with him? You haven't talked to any of us in weeks and then you come in with the one person who has caused so much misery? Did you forget what he did to Shiri?" Archer demanded, Sereia not bothering to

answer him. Shiri gripped Finn's arm, it was the only thing holding them back from attacking.

"My hands are tied. I have to allow them entry. You are welcome under the ancient rules of hospitality. Leave conflict at the door and enjoy the ball," Lexie told them with a nod. Princess Sereia bowed along with Alejandro and they turned to walk away. Shiri let go of Finn and rushed down the stairs, grabbing ahold of the Salinean Princess's shoulder to turn her around. Sereia turned around and stared into each other's eyes, Shiri searched for something in those dark eyes, but Sereia broke the eye contact quickly.

"What does he have on you? What do you have on her?" she demanded quietly, turning her gaze to Alejandro. He smirked down at her, placing a hand on her shoulder that sent ice down her spine.

"I don't have anything on her, love. Can't you believe that we're an item?" he told her, wrapping his free arm around Sereia's shoulders. "By the way, how are those migraines setting in?"

Shiri jerked her shoulder away, glaring at him as she clenched her fists to her side. "Fuck you. You're up to something and you're not going to get away with it."

"Oh, darling," he tsked, leaning forward so his lips were right back her ear and whispered very softly so only she could hear him. "I've already gotten away with it."

Shiri froze, fear spiking in her stomach and heart, causing the migraine to spike violently and her eyes flash slightly. Alejandro smiled triumphantly, turning Sereia away and walking her into the crowd. Sereia threw back one last look, her expression unreadable before disappearing. She doesn't know how long she stood there until she felt hands on her cheeks. She blinked, focusing on Finn's worried expression. She leaned into their touch, reaching up to place her hands over theirs.

“I’m okay, kitty. I’m okay,” she reassured them, placing her forehead against theirs.

“What did he say to you?” they growled softly and she shook her head.

“It’s not important…”

“It’s important to me. You’re mine and you’re hurt,” they told her and she looked into their eyes. It was in that moment she made up her mind, seeing the sincerity and love in those baby blues. Alejandro had been lying to her about Finn using her and she was stupid for even considering it. She leaned forward the few inches that separated them and kissed them deeply, happily, hopelessly, and helplessly in love. They kissed her back in surprise before they pulled away slightly.

“What was that for?” they asked, confused but happy, tail swishing around.

“I love you. I just… didn’t realize how much till now. You’ve got me helpless,” she whispered. Finn smiled, kissing her softly again.

“Be helpless and soft, vulnerable and childish with me. I want to be the softest place you fall and our love to be the wildest place you run to.”

“Wow… that was so cheesy,” she giggled, allowing them to lead her off the dance floor and over to the side where their families were waiting. Adora was the first to greet her, gently placing her hands on Shiri’s shoulders with a small smile. Shiri gasped softly, holding down a small sob before flinging herself forward, engulfing Adora in a hug. Adora stood there, shocked as she looked around the group, silently asking for help. She could feel Shiri trembling against her and hesitantly wrapped her arms around the younger woman.

“Hey, it’s okay. You did great. You were very brave,” she reassured her future daughter-in-law. Shiri pulled away slightly to look at her aunt, her lower lip trembling and tears brimming in her eyes.

“He’s planning something. Something big. Keep an eye on him… please. And Sereia, he has something on her but she’s not talking.”

“We’re going to stop him, I promise. We may need your help, if you’re up for it,” Adora suggested.

“I don’t know…” she muttered, eyes flashing quickly, causing Adora to take a step back. “It’s already starting, I’m not on top of my game right now.”

“Why didn’t you tell me sooner?” Finn asked, concern and panic lacing their voice.

“It always takes a couple of days for the effects to fully set in, I have some time but the stress is making the migraine worse. I want to help but unless you want me to go nuclear tonight, I need to avoid him as much as possible.”

“Understood. Finn?” Adora said, glancing at her child.

“Already all over it, mom.”

“Well… with all that, let’s try to enjoy the ball as much as possible,” Lexie suggested, kissing her daughter’s cheek gently. “I’m about to announce the first dance. Try to relax, my song.”

Shiri nodded but couldn’t shake the feeling of dread she felt in the pit of her stomach. Lexie walked away to the stage to announce the first dance and Finn took hold of Shiri’s hand, squeezing it.

“Not like I need to ask but it would be an honor if you would give me the first dance of the night?” they asked with a cocky grin, causing Shiri to roll her eyes.

“I don’t know, maybe I should dance with Nala. She’s a much better company and she doesn’t step on my toes,” Shiri smirked. Finn growled softly, ears twitching. “Awww, is the kitty jealous?”

“I am not!” they pouted and Shiri kissed their temple, grabbing their hands to drag them out onto the dance floor for the first dance.

–

They danced together through most of the evening, only occasionally moving onto different partners. Shiri had promised Flora a dance and Nala would not be dissuaded from dancing with the Princess either. They spun each other around the dance floor during a more lively tune, laughing loudly and bumping into everyone. Finn loved watching their mate interact with their little sister, it made them wonder how she would be when they had kittens of their own.

Whoa, that’s a dangerous thought. Not something they have thought about much but not a completely unpleasant thought either. The look on Shiri’s face as she gazed down at the little girl was maternal and loving. It was no surprise that when the next song started, a slow song, that the little girl reached up to be held and Shiri went along willingly. The young magicat was surprisingly light for a ten-year-old as she wrapped her legs around Shiri’s waist, her arms wrapping around the older woman’s neck as she laid her head on her shoulder, feeling safe and content. Gentle purrs erupted from her chest, warming Shiri’s heart.

Shiri gently spun them around, keeping a tight grip around the younger girl's back as she hummed, her own version of purring. Is this what it will feel like to hold her own child? Will they dance around the palace like this? Will they purr gently against her as she rocked them to sleep? Never before had her heart felt so full for someone she had not met before. She hoped they had Finn’s ears and tail.

“What are you thinking about so hard, love?” she heard, turning to see Finn smiling at her, reaching forward to pet his little sister’s ears affectionately.

“The future… our future,” she smiled back, noticing that Nala had drifted off during the dance. She laughed softly, nuzzling the little girl's hair.

“Let me take her to my mama. I’ll come back for the next song,” they offered, gently pulling the younger magicat out of Shiri’s arms and into their own. They leaned forward to kiss Shiri gently before walking off the dance floor. Shiri sighed happily, watching after them as the music changed. She looked up at the stage, seeing Halina and Zimri there, smiling at her as Zimri started singing.

I'll swim and sail on savage seas

With never a fear of drowning

And gladly ride the waves of life

If you would marry me

No scorching sun nor freezing cold

Will stop me on my journey

If you will promise me your heart

(Halina) *And love me for eternity*

My dearest one, my darling dear

Your mighty words astound me

But I've no need for mighty deeds

When I feel your arms around me

The melody was soft, relaxing. Shiri was confused, she didn’t remember this song being a part of the setlist they had practiced for the ball.

(Zimri) *But I would bring you rings of gold*

I'd even sing you poetry (oh, would you?)

And I would keep you from all harm

If you would stay beside me

(Halina) *I have no use for rings of gold*

I care not for your poetry

I only want your hand to hold

I only want you near me

(Together) *To love and kiss to sweetly hold*

For the dancing and the dreaming

Through all life's sorrows

And delights

I'll keep your laugh inside me

I'll swim and sail a savage seas

With never a fear of drowning

I'd gladly ride the waves so white

And you will marry me!

Shiri felt hands on her as something wrapped around her neck and she looked down in fright, only to be surprised by a necklace being clasped around her neck. It had her mom’s treble clef

pendant on it but was designed differently than her original necklace. Shiri turned around quickly to see Finn grinning before they dropped down on one knee. Shiri gasped, covering her mouth with her hand.

"Princess Shiri, we have been best friends for as long as I can remember. I have not known a life where you were not there. You are truly amazing, gorgeous, funny, brave, and brilliant. I know we have only been officially together for a short amount of time but I know that this is right and that I want to spend the rest of my life together with you if you'll have me. You are the love of my life."

Shiri choked on a sob, smiling. "What about your dream? To travel the universe?"

Finn took a hold of her hands, gripping them tightly. "You have always been my dream. I want to share my dreams with you and for you to share yours with me. Besides, I may or may not have gotten special permission from the queen to take you away for a while to fulfill those dreams."

Shiri turned to see her mom, who nodded in affirmation and encouragement. She smiled happily, looking back down at Finn, who was anxiously awaiting her reply.

"Yes. Yes, yes, thousand times yes!" she shrieked, wrapping her arms around their neck as they stood up. Finn laughed, picking her up and spinning her around happily as the crowd cheered. They kissed happily, basking in their love for each other as their families quickly surrounded them, congratulating them.

Shiri sobbed happily, she couldn't help herself as she hugged her aunts and her sister. Halina was babbling excitedly about planning the wedding, going a million miles a minute but Shiri couldn't focus on her. She could only see her mom coming towards her, smiling brilliantly as she opened her arms and hugged her daughters close.

“Mom… this is mama’s pendant…” Shiri stated, looking up at her mom with watery eyes. Lexie nodded, caressing her daughter’s cheek.

“She would want you to have it. I wanted you to have a part of her for your big day. Oh, this is so exciting! Your mama has a binder stored somewhere for your future wedding, we can look through it later,” Lexie said.

“We’re planning a wedding! I’m thinking gold and navy! Ooh, your wedding dress is going to be fabulous! I’m going to start sketching designs!” Halina rambled on.

Shiri was starting to feel overwhelmed, turning to find Finn, who wrapped their arms around her, pulling her close. They nuzzled against her neck, scenting her as purrs erupted from their chest. Adora and Catra made their way over, Catra carrying a sleeping Nala. Adora was the first to pull her into a hug.

“We’re so happy that you’re going to be a part of the family! Catra, we’re going to have another daughter!”

“Not like we don’t have enough of those,” Catra rolled her eyes, smiling and giving Shiri a side hug with one arm.

“I’m so happy to officially be a part of the family. Not that we haven’t always been family,” Shiri said, laughing softly. “I just… I can’t believe this is happening. I must be dreaming or stuck in a vision.”

“This is real, we’re spending the rest of our lives together,” Finn told her, resting their forehead against hers. She looked into their eyes, smiling happily.

“We’re sharing our dreams together. You’ve always been my dream as well. I don’t care where we are or what we do, as long as it’s together.”

—

They spent more of the evening celebrating with their friends and dancing more. Shiri felt like she was floating, she was elated with happiness. She never wanted this feeling to end as people came up to congratulate the newly engaged couple. She wanted to tell Finn about the baby, they were about to spend the rest of their lives together but she could never find the right moment to tell them. She didn't want to make it too public either, she wanted to share that special moment with them when they were alone.

They were currently slow dancing, her head resting on their shoulder as they pressed as close as they could to the other. They didn't want to part and no one had tried to separate the couple for any more dances that evening. But her stomach started rumbling, causing Finn to laugh softly, kissing her head softly.

"Let me grab you something to eat. You must be starving, you've been performing and dancing all night."

"But I'm so content here. Do you have to go?" she pouted, looking up at their baby blue eyes.

"It'll only be for a moment, I promise. I love you," they told her, pulling away gently, giving her a lingering kiss on the back of her hand before disappearing into the crowd towards the buffet table. Shiri swayed softly to the music, completely out of sorts until a shadow towered over her. She looked up as they took her hand and waist, spinning her across the dance floor. Her heart clenched as she saw Alejandro's smiling face stare down at her.

"I have to say, you look absolutely stunning tonight, darling," he told her, spinning her around. The dread in her stomach only mounted as she stared up at him, terrified.

"What do you want? I'm finally happy, why do you insist on ruining this for me?" she asked him.

"There's only one thing I have ever wanted and that has been you. You can't tell me that you don't feel anything for me anymore? What does that furball have that I don't?"

“They love me and haven’t done anything to hurt me, unlike you. You do everything to hurt me and that is not love. I never knew love could feel this good until Finn reminded me it could. Besides, you know you’re putting yourself at risk by being here. You have every kingdom's representative here that wants to take you down.”

“Am I? Or have I put myself in the perfect position to bring Etheria to its knees?” he asked, stopping their dance and taking a step back from her. She stared at him, he stared back, a silent fight of wills until he smirked and started whistling. It was a low whistle, drawn-out and melancholy as it weaved together a melody.

I know you

I’ve walked with you

Once upon a dream

She heard the screaming startup as a fine powder dusted up into the air around her, sparkling in the light of the candles. Alejandro reached into his pockets as people started dropping to the floor, holding some of the powder in his hand and using the other to put a nose plug on. Shiri couldn’t move, she couldn’t will herself to run away as the sounds of screaming died down to the sound of bodies hitting the floor. She heard someone scream her name frantically but she was too fixated on Alejandro to determine where it was coming from.

“Oh, Shiri. You should have done this the easy way, that night you thought you could escape this life. I’m going to make sure you know that you are mine,” he told her, blowing the powder into her face. Shiri coughed, swatting at the flying powder before her vision started to fuzz and go dark, causing her to fall to the ground and blackout.

Chapter End Notes

Song Creds: For the Dancing and the Dreaming cover by Evynne and Peter Hollens

It's getting juicy! Question: Would anyone like to see a third installment to this fanfic? I have an idea swirling in my head but don't want to go with it unless there is some interest.

Be sure to kudos and comment!

Chapter 18

Chapter Summary

Plans are revealed, Shiri starts detoxing, and Finn is captured

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 18

It was a few hours before Finn came to, groggily opening their eyes as they could hear shuffling and murmurs coming from around them. They squinted, trying to focus their vision as they heard a yell and saw a flash of light that could only be their mom transforming into She-Ra. Why would she be transforming in the middle of their room? Wait… Finn shot up as the memories came flooding back to them.

They had left Shiri to grab her something to eat during Princess Prom. They had only been gone five minutes, Flora had held them up at the table to gush and congratulate them on the upcoming wedding. They had picked up on the whistling, started hearing the screaming when they turned to see Alejandro in front of Shiri. Then they saw the bodies falling to the floor and they weren't even across the room, yelling for their mate when they inhaled the powder and fell unconscious with the rest of the room.

"Nala? Nala! Where's my daughter?!" they heard their mama screaming, which sent them bolting to their feet to find her. Everyone was disoriented, some people sitting on the floor while others started standing, trying to gather their bearings. They looked around quickly, spotting Catra on her knees on the other side of the room, She-Ra standing protectively over her with the Sword of Protection. They started making their way over when they heard more screams.

“Shimmer?! Where’s Shimmer?!” Glimmer yelled as Bow helped her up.

“Eira?! Where’s my wife?!” Frosta screamed, ice starting to form on her hands.

“Hallie?! Shiri?!” Lexie searched frantically as Zimri helped her up off the floor, pulling his mom to him in a comforting hug.

“Sereia is gone too! That bastard had this planned from the start!” Archer growled, having made his way to Finn but Finn couldn’t focus on him. Shiri was gone. So was their little sister and one of their best friends. They needed to get to their mama, they needed to comfort her. They stumbled away from Archer, who was ranting about the situation and made their way to Catra, who was crying as She-Ra tried to comfort her.

Finn sat beside Catra, facing opposite of her, and rubbed their cheek against hers as a sign of comfort, a soft purr emitting from them to help her calm down. Catra rubbed her cheek back, wetting Finn’s fur with her tears. She-Ra looked between the two, torn between comforting her family and helping everyone else.

“I’ve got her, mom. You need to help evacuate the palace and make sure there are no injuries,” Finn reassured her, not turning to look at her. She-Ra nodded, planting a gentle kiss on Catra’s head and whispering a soft promise to return before making her way to Lexie.

“They have Nala… why would they want a little girl?” Catra asked rhetorically to no one in particular. Finn shook their head in response, resting their head on her shoulder as she laid her head down over theirs.

“They have Shiri… He’s going to kill her…”

“Hey, we need to get up. We’re going to have a meeting once everyone is evacuated,” Glimmer said, kneeling beside Catra and wrapping her up in a hug. Catra hugged her back, trembling.

"They have our daughters… why would they take our daughters, Sparkles?" Catra murmured, allowing Glimmer and Finn to help her to her feet. Glimmer just shook her head sadly as she led them over to the dais where the rest of the Princess Alliance had gathered.

"It's a power play, they're going to try to use the kids as leverage to get what they want… like what Shadow Weaver did when I was taken to the Fright Zone."

Frosta was pacing angrily, spikes growing out of the ice encasing her hands as Brio, Callista, and Haevyn tried to console her. Perfuma and Scorpia sat on either side of Lexie, who was sitting on the stairs with her head in her hands, both wrapping her in a hug. Zimri and Archer were talking animatedly with each other, probably already coming up with a plan. Glimmer helped Catra sit down on the step in front of Lexie, the magicat bringing her knees to her chest and hugging them closely.

"We'll get them back, wildcat! If I know the girls, there's no doubt in my mind that they are protecting Nala from everything!" Scorpia reassured Catra, placing a claw on her shoulder.

"I need to help with the evacuation…" Lexie said softly, going to move but being kept in place by Perfuma and Scorpia.

"You need to let She-Ra, Bow, Mermista, and Seahawk oversee the evacuation and try to relax. You just lost two daughters, you need to focus all of your energy on them," Perfuma told her.

"Why Hallie? I understand Shiri but Hallie…?"

"She's leverage for Shiri," Archer spoke up, causing the adults to look at them. "If he threatens Hallie, Shiri will do whatever he wants. That's for all of them. They're leveraged against Shiri. Eira is her aunt and she's pregnant, Halina is her sister, Nala is her fiance's little sister, and her friend, Shimmer and Sereia are two of her best friends. He can get her to do whatever he wants."

“Wouldn’t it make more sense to use them as leverage against the kingdoms? He has hostages he can use to negotiate whatever terms he wants,” Glimmer commented, furrowing her brow as Archer shook his head.

“He could but the kingdoms are useless without the Heart of Etheria. He has control over Shiri, he has control over the other kingdoms. The hostages are just an added bonus to help the rest of the kingdoms fall in line with his demands. It’s genius, actually…”

“What’s he planning to do though? Why control the Heart? It’s not a weapon anymore,” Lexie said.

“But Shiri is. She has a part of the Heart within her and if he can harness her powers to his advantage, he could take over Etheria,” Archer said.

“But that doesn’t make any sense!” Finn snapped, causing everyone to turn their heads to them. “He’s been feeding her drugs to suppress those powers! Unless he has an antidote, her powers are useless, she can’t control them when she detoxes, and she’ll die!”

“But why have a drug that powerful if there wasn’t a failsafe or antidote for it? That wouldn’t make sense either if he had been planning to take control of the kingdoms,” Zimri argued, stepping into the conversation. “Think about it. Why give the most powerful princess a drug that strips her of her powers and kills her if she doesn’t keep taking it if you didn’t have a backup plan? He… Gods, this was probably his plan from the very beginning! From the first time, he met her all those years ago!”

“He holds all the cards right now,” She-Ra said as she, Bow, Mermista, and Seahawk approached, the ballroom empty except for the Princess Alliance. “He knows we have no information, no leads, and no clue to where he’s hiding. It’s a power play and he has all the power.”

“So, what? We wait around for him to make the first move? Our kids are in danger!” Mermista argued, crossing her arms over her chest.

“Not just that, Shiri is detoxing. Her magic is unstable and we only have a few days til it overloads and kills her,” Finn explained.

“Maybe not even a few days. The stress of everything could have expedited the process some. We’re on a time crunch but our hands are still tied!” She-Ra said angrily.

“Our hands aren’t tied! We can’t wait for him to make the first move! We know the Desert Rose gang is based in the Crimson Waste. Check every nightclub and bar there! Raid every business until we find something!” Lexie demanded, standing to her feet. “Our kids are in danger, our kingdoms are in danger. We have to show him we still have some cards in play.”

“When I find him, I’m going to make him regret the day he was ever born!” Frosta hissed, ice forming under her feet.

“We can split up and take quadrants of the Crimson Waste. I’ll contact Huntara to help us. We start hunting at first light, everyone should rest while they can. We won’t be for the next few days,” She-Ra suggested, shrinking back down into Adora and going to her wife, wrapping her in a comforting hug. “We’re going to get Nala back, I promise.”

Finn watched the dejected and heartbroken looks on their mom’s faces as they held each other. They looked around, noting the overall gloom and anxiety of everyone present. They couldn’t wait for the first light, they needed to start hunting for their mate, now.

–

Shiri hissed as she opened her eyes and the light burned her pupils. She closed them quickly again, taking an assessment of her physical being. Her arms were above her head and they ached from being there for a while. There was something biting into her

wrists, it felt cool and metallic. She wiggled her body around some, hearing the clanking of metal as she moved. Her knees also hurt, she had been on them for a while as well, she could tell.

"Shiri?" She heard someone say and she cracked her eyes open again, finally taking in the room. It was small, there were no windows and only one door, the walls and floors were brick and uncomfortable. On the far side of the wall, away from her, were four figures huddled together, chains keeping their wrists and ankles bound to the wall and all still in their prom dresses.

First was Halina, who was staring at Shiri with relief and fear, a silver collar around her neck. Her mouth was moving but no words were coming out. Next was Nala, who was curled into Eira's side, whimpering softly with her ears flattened against her skull and her tail wrapped around her waist. Eira held her tightly against her side, as well as she could with her large belly, a similar silver collar around her neck like Halina. Finally, Shimmer sat beside Eira, looking the worse of the four with a busted lip and blood coming from her forehead.

Shiri went to speak, trying to comfort her family but nothing came out. She tried again, not even a whisper as she felt fear coursing through her veins and she started struggling against the chains that bound her to the ceiling.

"It's no use. He thought of everything…" Shimmer muttered, closing her eyes and leaning her head back against the brick wall. "You three are wearing collars that prevent you from talking. Really prevents you from singing and using your power to blow him a new one. The bastard has me in some kind of chains that prevent me from using my own magic, I can't teleport us out of here. And Nala… well what's a baby magicat going to do to him?"

Shiri let out a silent scream, pulling angrily at the chains before struggling to get to her feet. She noted that her heels had disappeared but she didn't care. She needed to reassure them that she was fine. That they were going to be fine. Nala started to cry, reaching her hand out towards Shiri desperately. Shiri tried to

get as close as she could, which wasn't close at all. She even reached her leg out, foot outstretched for some kind of contact but it wasn't enough. Halina just shook her head at Shiri as she pulled Nala back gently, holding the crying magicat.

"I want my mama! I want my mommy!" she wailed into Halina, Eira wrapping her arms around her as well. Shimmer sighed softly, shuffling in her spot to get comfortable. Shiri paced, occasionally jerking at the chains to see if they would give any. The migraine was tenfold and she was terrified of what would happen to everyone being so close to her in this state.

They heard a lock click and everyone turned their heads to see the door open and Alejandro stepped inside, smirking wildly as Sereia stood in the doorway, head down to avoid everyone's angry glares. Alejandro's smirk quickly turned into a sneer as he heard Nala's crying, going over to the group of women and crouching in front of the trembling magicat.

"That is so damn annoying. Do you ever shut up? Always bitching and moaning, just like your mom's. I'll give you something to cry about," he growled, grabbing the hair at the top of her head and jerking her up. Nala shrieked, grabbing at her head as Eira and Halina grabbed her, trying to pull her away. Shiri rattled her chains violently, trying to get his attention away from the young magicat.

"Put her down! You put a mark on her and She-Ra will kick your ass! As well Commander Catra and Queen Glimmer and the entire Princess Alliance!" Shimmer yelled, causing the man to drop the little girl down in a heap of sobs, Eira holding her protectively to her and rubbing her ears soothingly. Alejandro made his way over to Shimmer, nudging her leg with his foot.

"I'm getting real sick and tired of your smart mouth, little girl. Maybe I should shut you up permanently?" he snarled, pulling out a large knife from his boot. Shiri rattled the chains harder, wanting desperately to scream out to him to leave her family alone.

“You promised you wouldn’t hurt them!” Sereia said from the doorway, drawing his attention away from Shimmer. He flashed a smile in her direction, moving away from Shimmer and flipping the knife in his hand.

“Fine, babe. I wasn’t really going to hurt her, just roughen her up a bit. She does have an annoying habit of talking too much,” he tsked, turning his attention to Shiri, who cowered away from him.

“Princess, what’s that face for?” he said, stalking towards her as she backed herself into the wall, jerking painfully on the shackles. He pressed into her, taking her jaw in his hand and turning a knob on the silver collar.

“Why are you doing this?” she was able to whisper softly, staring into his cold gray eyes. He traced his thumb across her jaw, pressing a soft kiss against her temple.

“I told you, I love you, Shiri. And it hurts me to think that the other Princesses have brainwashed you into thinking that I’m the bad guy. I’m not, I’m trying to make Etheria a better place for all of us. I want you by my side when I do that.”

“No one has brainwashed me but you… Etheria is already a better place since the war ended almost thirty years ago. You’re the one making it unsafe again,” she hissed quietly and he jerked her head, slamming it back into the wall.

“If I have the Heart of Etheria at my side, I will be unstoppable. It’s about time we disbanded the monarchies and created a new Etheria, the United Republic of Etheria under one ruler, me. With you, the other kingdoms will fall in line with my demands.”

Shiri was breathing heavily, vision blurring slightly as she could feel the visions trying to pull her under. “You seem to forget… I’m dying. The Heart of Etheria is worthless without me. I’m the only one that harnesses its full power. Even if I was at full capacity, what makes you think I would ever be with you and let you control me?”

“Because you don’t have a choice. You defy me, I kill off one of your family members. Why do you think I have so many of them here now? You’ll do what I want or I’ll make you watch as I torture them until their dying breath, starting with that pretty little magicat you’re so fond of. I’ll also make sure to record it to send to her pretty little mommies and that troublesome sibling that thought they could take what’s mine. Is that really what you want, princess?”

“You wouldn’t dare…” she whispered, horrified. His lips curled into a sadistic smile and he backed away slightly from her, grabbing her shoulders and forcing her roughly back onto her knees, making the chains taunt again.

“I have the antidote for your problem. You agree to rule by my side, to help me bring the other kingdoms to their knees and be an obedient little girl, I’ll cure you of your affliction and leave your family in peace. The choice is yours, darling,” he told her, going to turn the volume back off her collar as a scream ripped through her and the visions overtook, magic pushing out through the room.

–

Finn didn’t know where they were going, just that they had to find Shiri before anything worse happened. They had a hunch, just from the interactions they had witnessed in the last few months, and it led them to the nightclub they had reconnected with Shiri that first night. It was the early morning hours, daylight barely breaking over the horizon, still leaving the sky a bleak gray.

The still cover of darkness gave Finn the advantage they needed to sneak close to the abandoned club. With it being so early, the club had closed down for the day in order to rest and prepare for the night that would come. They were hoping their hunch was right as they hid against a wall on the street opposite of the club, watching it. They had left a note for their moms in case they didn’t come back before the mission started.

They weren't sure how long they stood there, watching the empty building, waiting for any sign of life to appear. It was long enough that the first ray of light peeked out, turning the sky from dull gray to soft pink as the sun rose. Their ears twitched as they felt movement behind them and turned quickly, slugging the person in the face with a sickening crunch that had the following to the ground, groaning.

"What the hell, Finn?!" A familiar voice hissed from the ground and Finn blinked, moving over to see Archer clutching his nose, groaning softly in pain. "You may have broken my nose…"

"Archer?! What the fuck?! I could have killed you!" Finn hissed, helping the prince up to his feet. "What are you doing here?"

"I followed you. Why did you leave without telling anyone? Are you trying to get yourself killed?" Archer replied, dusting himself off and tenderly touching his nose.

"I left a note for my moms in case I didn't come back. I had a hunch and we couldn't waste any more time, our families are in danger. Our sisters, our girlfriends, they're in danger and we can't wait and search the entire Crimson Waste for them."

"You have a good point but you could have told me. You know I want to find them as desperately as you do. Shimmer is my sister and Hallie… I don't know what I would do if anything happened to either of them. So, what's your hunch?"

"The nightclub where we first saw Halina and Shiri on Hallie's birthday. We also found Shiri there a couple of weeks ago with Alejandro during that confrontation. I think it's the best place to start," Finn explained, eyes glancing back over to the nightclub. Their ears twitched, thinking they heard movement nearby. They paused, holding up a finger to Archer who was about to speak as they listened. Their eyes darted around, it was silent.

"What did you hear?" Archer whispered after a minute, eyes darting around as well.

“Nothing… Just a trick of the wind,” Finn whispered back, finally focusing back on Archer. They went to start explaining the plan but felt a pinch on their arm, causing them to hiss as they looked down. A feathered needle pierced their skin and they pulled it out quickly, Archer removing a similar one as their vision went blurry. Finn stumbled away, falling down into the sand and blacking out.

–

Everything was white and fuzzy, Shiri couldn’t focus on anything. It was like static in her head, something trying to break through and speak to her in snippets.

“The Heart of Etheria-... Purpose-... Visions-... Powers-...”

She couldn’t hear the complete sentence, it kept going in and out as she clutched her head. What was it trying to tell her? Why was everything static?

“Shiri-”

She looked up, a fuzzy vision of Calliope stepping forward, frowning, and reaching out to her. She didn’t look real, nothing looked real. Shiri reached back, fingers barely brushing her mama’s fingertips.

“Shiri-... Heart-... Purpose-...” Calliope said, trying to string together a cohesive sentence but unsuccessful as Shiri was jerked out of the vision…

… And doubled over, retching violently. She coughed, trying to catch her breath as sweat dripped down her body. She felt dirty, sticky, and gross, the visions were relentless. Her arms had gone numb hours ago from her position on her knees, she couldn’t feel her fingers no matter how hard she tried to twitch them. She didn’t have much energy to put forth anyways, all of it was put towards the visions and keeping her alive. The skin she could see on her exposed legs showed red webby veins crawling upwards, no doubt towards her heart to stop it.

“Shiri? Are you okay? The magic is getting worse…” Shimmer said nervously, biting her lip. The door creaked open and Shimmer jerked her head to see Sereia come in, closing it softly behind her. Shimmer snarled, jerking on her own chains. “What are you doing here, traitor?!”

Sereia ignored the purple-haired princess, going over to Shiri and kneeling in front of her. She pulled out a cloth and gently dabbed the sweat away, frowning at her friend’s state. Shiri lolled her head against her arm, staring at Sereia with a question.

“I don’t have a choice…” Sereia whispered softly, wrapping an arm around her stomach. “I’m pregnant… I’m so sorry, Shiri… I never wanted any of this to happen.”

“You should have thought of that before spreading your legs for the enemy!” Shimmer yelled. Shiri’s eyes widened a fraction, too exhausted to react any more than that. Sereia bit her lip, tears in her eyes.

“I hope you can forgive me one day. Shiri, you’re my best friend and I hurt you. I was so jealous of you, you were always better than me: prettier, smarter, stronger. I thought if I could get Alejandro to notice me… I could finally be better than you. But he only liked me because I could get to you… I’m so sorry…”

Shiri shook her head softly, giving her a pitying look. Sereia reached forward, turning the volume on the collar.

“Get… Nala… out…” Shiri whispered softly, hissing as a pulse of magic radiated through her.

“He’ll kill me… I can’t…”

“If… you want me… to forgive… you… save her…” Shiri groaned, her head pounding.

Sereia went to say something but the door opened again. She scrambled away from Shiri quickly as Alejandro waltzed in, two goons following carrying two bodies.

“What are you doing, Sereia? Didn’t I tell you to stay away from here?” Alejandro snarled when he noticed the princess, grabbing her by her arm and dragging her to her feet. Sereia gulped, legs trembling in fear.

“I… she’s sick, I thought…”

Alejandro backhanded Sereia, sending her back sprawling to the ground. Sereia cried out, cowering on the ground as he placed his boot on her leg, pinning it down.

“You don’t get to think! You just do as I say! What can’t you be an obedient little bitch?!”

“I’m sorry!” she sobbed and Alejandro removed his boot, going to kick her in the back that caused her to scream out horribly. He snapped his fingers and the two goons laid the bodies down against the way opposite of Shiri and the other girls, shackling them to the wall. That’s when they noticed who was there.

“Archer! Finn! What did you do to them?!” Shimmer cried out, shrieking as she tried to teleport and the magic of the restraints kept her in place. Halina tried to move forward, chains rattling as she tried to call out to Archer. Shiri stared at Finn, a shiver going down her spine as she realized that this was it. Alejandro had all the cards and if he threatened Finn, Shiri was going to give in to his demands.

“Wakey! Wakey, kiddos!” Alejandro cried out, kicking the two of them in the legs until their eyes shot open. Finn immediately surged forward, trying and unsuccessfully trying to reach Shiri.

“Sweetheart, are you okay? Are you hurt? Nala?” they turned their head, searching until they found their baby sister curled against Eira, who was protecting her. They let out a sigh of relief when they found her safe and turned their attention back to their fiance. Shiri looked awful, there was a light sheen of sweat coating her skin and sickly red webs running up her legs and down her arms.

She looked exhausted, she could barely acknowledge their presence as they felt the magic pulsing slowly in the room.

“Now that we have the whole family together, let’s begin!” Alejandro said excitedly.

Chapter End Notes

It's getting juicy! Don't worry, there is still plenty of this fanfic left to write! I have a lot left in store for y'all!

Be sure to kudos and comment! :)

Chapter 19

Chapter Summary

Shiri learns the truth about Finn and her powers

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 19

Shiri hissed softly in pain as Alejandro adjusted the chains above her head, allowing her to slump down, needles shooting up and down her arms as blood started returning to them. She still couldn't feel her fingers but she definitely saw the red webs creeping up her arms, past her elbows now. She had been forced to kneel on her knees but with the extra room, she was able to fall sideways onto her butt, slowly stretching her legs out to give them some feeling as well.

"Aww, are you in pain, princess?" Alejandro sneered down at her, causing her to hiss at him. She doesn't know where it came from, she didn't even know she could produce a noise like that and it wasn't quite an animalistic hiss like what Finn could do, it was human but still an impressive noise. Alejandro jerked back in surprise before bursting out into laughter.

"You have been spending so much time around an animal that you've started to become one yourself, darling!" He crouched in front of her, tracing a finger down her cheek and across her jaw.

"Don't fucking touch her!" Finn hissed at him.

"What are you going to do about it, pussycat?" Alejandro turned towards the magicat, raising an eyebrow. "You seem to forget that before she was your girl, she was mine. I know everything about her, everything she ever was and ever wanted to me. Tell me, where were you after her mama died? Hmm? Because I don't

remember seeing you around. Guess who was the one to comfort her in the dead of night when the pain was too much for her to handle and she needed to drown herself in something else?"

"Stop…" Shiri whimpered, shame washing over her. She couldn't meet Finn's eyes, she was embarrassed about how she acted before they met, how she acted while they were together before they confessed to each other. Finn glared at Alejandro, ears pressed flat against their skull and nostrils flaring.

"But I know where you were, buddy. You were out trying to stop me. How did that work out for you? Not well, it seems like. Are you going to tell her the truth or am I going to?" Alejandro probed.

"Finn, he's baiting you. Don't say anything," Archer told Finn, glaring at Alejandro as well. Shiri shared a look with Halina, who looked as confused as she was but when she looked at Shimmer, all she saw was guilt as the younger girl averted her eyes.

"Finn? What's he talking about?" Shiri whispered, unable to bring her voice any higher than that due to the collar. She finally met their gaze and their blue eyes looked away, glaring at a fixed point on the wall. "Finn?"

"Come on, Finn. Tell her the truth. What kind of marriage will it be if it's not built on a foundation of trust? Why won't you tell her that the only reason you two got together was that you were hunting me and you knew she was my girl. Tell her how you were using her to get information about my gang and me to give to She-Ra," Alejandro grinned, noting the eye twitch in the magicat.

Shiri lost her breath, not wanting to swallow this information. She had doubted Finn for a while but had managed to shut the doubts down during Princess Prom. Yet here they were, full throttle, threatening to consume her again as she stared her fiance down, silently demanding them to look at her to tell her the truth. She hoped the truth was that Alejandro was lying and baiting them

but by the way, Finn refused to look at her… she felt her heart sank to her stomach.

“Come on, Finn. Tell her. She’s waiting,” Alejandro probed again.

“It wasn’t like that, Shiri! Finn loves you! They wanted to protect you!” Shimmer blurted out as Archer started to shush her and that was all the confirmation Shiri needed. She surged forward violently, the chains digging into her wrists, causing the already raw skin to break even more and blood starts trickling down her arms. Alejandro laughed, going over to her and turning to knob up some. The chains prevented her from reaching Finn, luckily.

“Tell the truth!” She said more loudly, magic pulsing through the room. “Did you use me?! Was everything we had a lie?! You… Did you sleep with me to get to him?”

“No, it wasn’t like that! I… We were at the club the night of Halina’s birthday for reconnaissance, trying to find out more information about Alejandro and the Desert Rose gang. We did not know you were going to be there, I swear! When we reported back to my mom, we mentioned your presence and that you seemed close to him. I did suggest getting close to you again to see if you would tell us anything but I did not sleep with you to get information! I did not fall in love with you to get information!”

Shiri let out a sob, feeling her heart shatter as Finn talked. “You used me. The only reason you came back to Musicia was to get me to spill information for you. You didn’t come back for me! You…” Shiri tried to breathe, anxiety crawling through her skin along with the magic that was threatening to take her. Alejandro came up behind her, putting a hand on her shaking shoulder.

“You thought I was lying to you but I would never lie to you, my darling. He only wanted you so he could take me down, the only person who ever understood you and stayed by your side through all the pain you’ve had to endure.”

“Shiri was never alone! She had her friends and family around her if she had only reached out for help!” Archer argued, Finn, staring brokenhearted at his mate’s broken state.

“She might as well have been alone! Why did she have to reach out when you knew she was in trouble, that she was in pain? What kind of friends are you? I have always been your friend, darling. I was there for you when no one else was. I helped you forget your pain and your troubles, I gave you back fun and joy. I can give that to you again if you agree to rule by my side,” Alejandro told her, running his fingers through her hair gently. “I can make you forget all of this pain, all of this heartache. Along with the antidote, I’ll conjure you an amnesia potion as well. I’ll give you whatever you need to purge the filth from your mind.”

Shiri shuddered at the contact, shaking her head softly. “I would rather die than be with you. Death releases me from this pain, not your lies. If you had an antidote and you needed the Heart of Etheria that badly, you would have already given it to me. You plan on using my powers while I am like this for as long as you can before giving me another dose of drug, subduing them. But you need me to agree to help you in order for the plan to work, which is why you’re trying to manipulate me instead of just dragging me off to use the magic as you see fit. I see right through you, Alejandro. And I would rather die than let you use me ever again.”

Alejandro snarled, grabbing her hair and jerking back across the concrete floor. She cried out, kicking out her legs as he threw her back into her previous spot and grabbed the chain. He pulled it until she was elevated again by her arms but she didn’t even get the reprieve of her knees on the floor. The chains dug deeper into her wrists, blood trickling down her arms, hitting her shoulders and face, dripping on the floor. The only thing touching the ground was her shins and feet.

“I can still take over Etheria without your magic. I keep you in here long enough, your magic will become unstable and you’ll die, taking out everyone in this room as well. Now it’s just a waiting

game. I hope you rot in the afterlife, bitch," he hissed, leaving the room, Sereia following after him quickly and quietly. The room was silent for a few minutes as everyone processed what had happened.

"Shiri? Shiri, are you okay? Sweetheart, I'm so sorry, I never wanted you to find out like this. I promise it sounds worse than it actually is-" Finn started but Shiri interrupted him.

"Shut up. Just shut up. I don't want to hear it. Can't we all just die in silence?"

"We're going to die?" Nala whimpered as Halina and Eira went to comfort her.

"We're not going to die. We're going to get out of here, all of us. We just need to come up with a plan," Archer told everyone.

"Don't you get it, Archer? There is no way out. He thought of everything, every last detail to ensure that he won. There's no escape from this and the sooner you accept our fate, the easier this will be for all of us," Shiri told him, lolling her head back to stare up at her bound hands and the ceiling.

"Not all of us are resigned to let whatever happens, happen, Shiri. If we put our heads together, we can escape this. All of us. You need to learn to be a little more optimistic."

"Optimism doesn't do shit! It doesn't save lives, it doesn't make days brighter, and it doesn't bring the dead back! I am a ticking time bomb right now and optimism is not going to stop me from exploding! Actually, your annoying ass voice is probably going to speed up the process."

"Guys, stop! We can't argue with each other right now! It's scaring Nala and we're friends. Don't let the little bit of time we have left be spent in anger!" Shimmer told them.

"Shiri… you're going to survive. We're all going to survive. You're going to live and grow old, we're going to get married and have

kittens and explore the galaxy together. Just don't give up on living yet," Finn begged and Shiri let out a bitter laugh, tears streaming down her face.

"I gave up years ago. Part of me died the day she died and never came back. At least now I can see her again…"

She felt it before it happened, the familiar tremor creeping up her spine as her body jerked. She gasped, crying out softly as her eyes flashed into the familiar whiteness as the vision dragged her under, the magic pulsing out more violently.

_

Images flashed before her, a kaleidoscope of memories from Etheria encircling her. She saw her life, her friends, her parents zooming by, laughter filling her ears. She saw her grandmother and grandfather before the destruction of Musicia, dancing at Princess Prom. She saw every queen to ever rule Musicia, every kingdom to rise and fall.

Every Musician princess to carry the blessing of the Heart of Etheria stood around her. She recognized some of their faces, like Princess Bedelia, the fire summoner, Princess Aria, the shapeshifter, and Princess Sonata, the memory eater. But others, she knew them but couldn't recall them. There were so many surrounding her.

"You have always questioned your purpose, Princess Shiri. You have always questioned the gift the Heart bestowed upon you, *" the voices echoed around her in unison.* "While you spent years training to harness your powers, you never fully tapped into them. *"*

"The only thing I can do is have visions! There is no real power behind it! What can visions do to help Etheria? To save my family?" *she asked them, twirling in a circle to see them all.*

"You think it's just visions but it's much more than that," *they said, eyes staring blankly ahead.* "You can reach into the visions,

like reaching into the past and take another princess' powers as your own. The visions help you understand the past, understand the powers and the gifts bestowed to those before you. You can use your power to save Etheria if you learn to master it."

"I don't have time to master it! Why didn't I know about this before? Why didn't I spend years training for this instead of searching through the planet's database?!" *Shiri demanded.*

"You were scared. You weren't ready to accept the burden of your full powers. You pushed away your responsibility, you pushed away your gifts and tried to bury them. Only now that you have started accepting who you are, the love you deserve, and the future you will have you can access your powers completely."

"I need to access them now. How do I escape and save my family? I am chained in a concrete room currently!"

Princess Bedelia stepped forward, holding her hands outward with a ball of flames nestled in the palms. " Just call upon the princess whose power you need. Just say their name, focus on their energy, and use your past training of controlling your visions to control this."

Shiri hesitated before stepping forward to Princess Bedelia, taking a deep breath. She held out her hands as she closed her eyes, concentrating on the princess in front of her.

"Princess Bedelia, lend me your fire" *she whispered softly…*

And her eyes flew open as she felt heat spread through her body. She took a deep breath, focusing on the heat and forcing it up her body. She felt it enter her wrists and hands, intense and scalding as she pushed it out of her wrists and against the metal chains.

"Shiri?! What the fuck is that?!" Finn gasped, watching the chains around her wrists turn red hot. She gritted her teeth and forced it out more until the metal melted, falling away from her wrists and causing her to collapse forward to the hard ground.

“Holy shit! Shiri! Are you okay? How did you do that?” Archer exclaimed as Shiri forced herself to sit up, jerking the collar off of her neck. She retched softly, arms trembling before crawling forward slowly, grabbing the shackles holding Archer to the wall.

She focused the heat into her hands, heating up the metal as Archer hissed in pain, the hot metal burning his wrists until it melted away. He slowly stood, flexing his wrists before going over to the wall with the girls, pulling the collars off of Halina and Eira.

“Oh, thank gods! We need to get out of here!” Halina said when she got her voice back, rattling the chains above her as Archer grabbed a bobby pin from her hair, picking the locks. Shiri made her way to Finn, working on their shackles as well with her hot hands until they melted away from them. Finn went to touch Shiri but she jerked away, the red webbing making its away across her shoulders, dangerously close to her heart.

“Shimmer, take everyone and teleport them to safety. She-Ra and the rest of our parents should be close by, knowing them,” Shiri told her, slowly pulling herself to her feet.

Shimmer nodded, standing up and stretching, helping Eira to her feet as Nala ran to Finn, jumping up and wrapping herself around her older sibling.

“Shiri, what about you?” Halina said, stepping towards her older sister.

“I’m going to finish this. I’m going to make him pay.”

“Not alone! You don’t have to do this alone,” Finn told her, hugging their sister tight. Shiri looked up and held out her hand, flames dancing between her fingertips before she clenched her fist, extinguishing it.

“I can handle him. It’s my fault we are in this situation, to begin with. Hallie…” Shiri whispered, going over and wrapping her little sister in a tight hug. Halina hugged her back, sniffling. “Don’t let mom disappear again, okay? You make sure she pulls through

this. You shouldn’t have to raise Nicky as your own, you’re only a child. You had to grow up too quickly. I want you to fall in love, get married, and grow old with the one you love, okay?”

“Why are you saying goodbye?” Halina cried softly into her sister's neck. “You’re going to be okay. You’re going to kick his ass and come back to us.”

“Zimri will be the perfect king, he’ll lead our kingdom into prosperity and peace. Support him, be by his side when he needs someone. Please don’t be sad for me, Hallie,” Shiri told her, pulling back slightly to give her a small smile. “I’m going to see mama again.”

“Shiri! You don’t have to do this alone! Please, don’t end it like this!” Finn begged, tearing up as Shiri turned to them, gently caressing their cheek.

“Kitty… move on, okay? Don’t spend your life grieving for me. What we had was beautiful and special but don’t let it rule the rest of your life,” she told them before moving back from everyone, closing her eyes.

“Shiri, wait. Shiri, don’t!” Finn said, lurching forward as she took a deep breath and opened her eyes, them shining the brilliant white.

“Princess Aria, lend me your powers,” she whispered, a glow emanating from her and lighting up the room. Everyone turned their heads, closing their eyes to block out the light. When they opened them again, Shiri was gone.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the short update! There is so much that needs to happen that it felt better to split it up like this otherwise the chapter would have been too long!

Remember to kudos and comment!

Chapter 20

Chapter Summary

Shiri goes nuclear, a revelation is revealed and a threat is eliminated

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 20

Shiri had transformed into a small fly to escape the room, flying out of the crack in the door as she left her friends reeling from her disappearance. She couldn't let them help her end this, this was something she needed to do on her own. When she was far enough away, she transformed back into her human form, stumbling slightly from the use of energy. The drug was close to her heart, too close, and it was getting harder to focus and control herself. She needed to finish this quickly.

Luckily, she knew this building like the back of her hand. She had spent years here with Alejandro, spending sleepless nights in its hallways, drinking away her problems. Her heart ached painfully from the memories, from the betrayal of someone she trusted with everything, and from knowing that she wasn't going to make it out of these hallways alive and neither would her child.

Her child… She and Finn's child created out of the love they felt for each other. She had to stop walking, losing her breath slightly at the thought and pain. A love based on lies. She was glad that she had not been able to tell Finn, it would make the loss more bearable since they would not know that they lost more than just her.

"I am sorry, my kitten. I am sorry that you will never know anything but me…" she whispered softly as she gathered her strength and stared back down the hallway. She navigated the

twisting maze until she found her way into the main club room. It was dark and silent, in stark contrast to the normal buzz of nightlife she had grown accustomed to.

Alejandro stood in the middle of the room with Sereia and a few of his goons, talking as he kept a tight grip on Sereia's upper arm. Sereia kept her eyes downcast during the conversation, keeping silent as to avoid being hit again. She caught the movement out of the corner of her eye and she lifted her head slightly, catching Shiri's eye.

Shiri put a finger up to her lips, indicating for her to keep silent as she stuck to the shadows, trying to find an opening. She nodded her head towards the door, trying to tell Sereia to escape while she could. Sereia lifted her head more, looking up at Alejandro who stopped talking when he noticed her movement.

"What is it, pet?" Alejandro asked, frowning as Sereia's heart rate spiked. She bit her lip nervously.

"I… um… I need to use the restroom… please?" she whispered, downcasting her eyes again. It took a moment but then Alejandro laughed before releasing her arm.

"Hurry up, pet. We have important business to take care of," he told her and Sereia scrambled away as quickly as possible, going to the back hallway to find a different escape route.

Shiri relaxed as her friend got away and she closed her eyes, breathing in deeply as she steeled her nerves before stepping out into the open.

"Alejandro!" she yelled and he looked up, gaping in confusion at the princess standing before. He growled and the goons stood on either side of him protectively, guns drawn and aimed at her. "This ends today!"

"How did you get out?! No matter, you're right. We are going to end this, Princess," he snarled, motioning for the goons to stand down and getting in a fighting position. Shiri closed her eyes,

concentrating as she transformed into a large cat with bared fangs and large claws. The goons screamed, backing away in horror as Alejandro laughed and they started circling each other.

"Seems like you learned a new trick, darling! No matter, I'm going to end this quickly!" Shiri snarled at him before lunging forward.

–

Shimmer got everyone outside the nightclub before collapsing to the sand, completely out of magical energy. Archer helped her sit up as Halina helped Eira settle down in the sand, the Snows princess cradling her pregnant belly with a pained expression.

"We need to go back, Shiri needs our help," Finn told them, sitting Nala down on the sand beside Eira.

"You heard her, she has it handled. We would be making it worse by interfering," Archer told him, rubbing his younger sister's back soothingly. Halina glared at Finn.

"This is your fault! You used her and made her feel like she had to fix everything!"

"My fault?! All I have ever done is try to protect your sister! I didn't see you trying to do it!"

"Guys! Let's sort this out later! Right now, we need to focus on contacting our parents and getting Shiri out of there!" Archer told the two of them as Sereia rounded the corner of the building, holding a com pad. Everyone stopped to look at her as she froze, blinking before Halina charged, tackling her to the ground. They went rolling in the sand as the com pad went flying. Halina pinned her to the ground, fist raised to strike.

"Give me one good reason not to beat you bloody, you bitch," Halina hissed, Sereia cringing back into the ground.

"Damn, I have never been more attracted to her than I am at this moment," Archer told Finn.

“Because I called She-Ra and your parents should be here at any moment! Also, I’m pregnant, you wouldn’t hit a pregnant girl!” Sereia told her as a flash of sparkles appeared with Glimmer, Bow, Adora, Catra, Lexie, Frosta, Mermista, Seahawk, and Haevyn.

“Hallie!” Lexie screamed, running over to pull her youngest daughter off of Sereia as Mermista and Seahawk ran over to help their daughter up. Lexie hugged Halina close, the younger girl crying into her mom’s shoulder.

“Mama!” Nala yelled, bounding over on all fours and pouncing on Catra, sending them sprawling into the sand. Catra hugged her daughter tightly, wrapping herself around her protectively as Adora got down on her knees to hug her family.

“Shimmer! Are you okay?” Bow asked as he knelt beside his daughter and wrapped her in a hug. She whimpered softly, hugging her dad back tightly as Glimmer went up to Archer and smacked him upside the head.

“How could you run off and scare us like that?! We were worried sick!” she yelled before pulling him into a hug.

“I’m sorry, mom. I just wanted to make sure Finn didn’t do anything stupid,” he told her.

“Eira!” Frosta yelled as she ran over to her wife, falling to the sand and hugging her tightly. Haevyn got on her other side, hugging her as well.

“Don’t scare us like that, little sister,” she whispered. Eira hissed softly in pain, causing both girls to pull away from her, Frosta looking over her to find any injury.

“Are you okay? What’s hurting?”

“The baby… I think I’m having contractions… Frosta, I am not having our baby in the hottest fucking kingdom on Etheria!”

“Glimmer! We need to get to Snows, now!” Frosta yelled, Glimmer teleporting over and grabbing the three girls, teleporting away.

“Hallie, where’s Shiri?” Lexie asked her, pulling away from her youngest.

“She’s still inside. She said that she needed to take care of this on her own,” Halina told her as they heard an explosion, the group flinching back as smoke started rising from the nightclub. Lexie’s eyes widened as she surged forward towards the building, Bow running after her and grabbing her as she screamed.

“Shiri! No! Let me go, Bow!”

Finn ran forward, bypassing Lexie and Bow to try to make it to the building. They had to get to Shiri, they had to save Shiri. They didn’t even make it halfway across the street before the doors flew open and Alejandro flew out, landing in the sand and rolling before coming to a stop a few feet away with a groan. He looked worse for wear, blood, and claw marks covering him.

Shiri stormed out after him, gliding down the stairs as she made her way to Alejandro, who held his hands up in a placating gesture. She didn’t look right, the red veins completely webbing across her skin, inches away from the middle of her chest where her heart was located. Her eyes were pure white as she stalked towards him, flames engulfing her hands, her dress tattered and torn.

“Please… Shiri… I’m sorry… don’t kill me…” Alejandro begged as she grabbed him by his shirt's collar, lifting him up into the air. He kicked his legs out desperately, grabbing hold of her wrists.

“You will pay for the crimes you have committed against Etheria,” she said, her voice doubling. She didn’t sound like herself and she definitely wasn’t acting like herself. She removed one of her hands from his collar, raising her flaming fist to punch him. And hesitated. How could she hesitate? With the full power of every Musician princess to grace Etheria’s surface coursing through her

veins as the power of Heart struggled to overcome the power of the drug, she was invincible. She could wipe Alejandro from the face of existence, she could wipe Etheria from the face of existence if she was so pleased. She was the strongest princess, even stronger than She-Ra, who stared horrified at her now.

And she was hesitating… She felt sorry for this man who had caused her and her family so much misery. The flames extinguished, her eyes returned to their normal brown as she released him and he fell to the sand, gasping for breath. She knelt down in front of him.

"You're not worth it. You're nothing but a sad little boy who never had anyone there to love him properly. You were never spoon-fed love so you learned to lick it off of knives but I'm neither a spoon nor a knife… I'm a gun and I have chosen not to shoot," she told him, standing up and turning her back, starting to walk away.

He coughed before sitting upon his knees, laughing softly. "I killed your mama, you bitch!"

Shiri froze, blood running ice cold through her veins as she slowly turned back towards him. Lexie gasped softly, hand covering her mouth in horror at the confession.

"What the fuck did you just say to me?"

"You heard me," he spat in her direction. "The Desert Rose was the gang occupying the Whispering Woods the day your mama died. It was too perfect, I sent your kingdom into ruins for years to get to you! The kingdoms ruined my life and Queen Calliope was the first of the rulers to fall! I will not stop until every last kingdom falls! Until every last ruler is dead! And you're next, Princess!"

He didn't have a chance to react before the sand around him grabbed hold of his arms and legs before hardening, keeping him stuck in place as Shiri's eyes lit up again, anger and power

overtaking her tenfold. Alejandro struggled, fear evident in his eyes as she approached him again.

“Shiri, wait!” Adora said, surging forward before being thrown back, having run into a forcefield that Shiri threw up.

“Don’t you dare interfere, She-Ra! I’m going to erase him from memory,” she said, grabbing a hold of his face between her hands, forcing him to look up at her. “I am Sonata, the memory eater. You better start praying, not everyone survives when I’m done.”

“No! No, please!” he screamed as she slanted her mouth across his in an open mouth kiss as the screams started to die away. His eyes started to glow as brightly as her own.

It was only seconds but to Shiri, it felt like a lifetime as she watched his life flash before her eyes. She saw a small boy in the Scorpion Kingdom's orphanage, once known as the Fright Zone. She saw her mom cradling him, whispering softly in his ear as he cried into her shoulder. He couldn’t have been more than four. And then the scene shifted and he was nine, standing in the doorway of the orphanage as he watched Lexie and Calliope leave, Calliope round with child, his lower lip trembling at the rejection. There had been talking of getting adopted. The Queen had decided against it due to her third child. Then he was thirteen, running away from the orphanage and to the Crimson Waste. No one comes looking for him. No one realizes he is gone.

At eighteen, he has taken control of the Crimson Waste with his gang, he has risen to power, and he is hurting. The pain of rejection from the Queens of Musicia ran deep and he started plotting and waiting. At twenty-three, he has the gang establish an outpost in the Whispering Woods. The day comes, he receives word that the Queen is moving through the forest towards Brightmoon. He takes the opportunity to eliminate her, unfortunately not being able to take out the daughter who she chose over him.

At twenty-four, he meets Shiri at the nightclub. They drink, she cries, he comforts her, he offers her an escape from her pain and her responsibility. She accepts. And he continues plotting until Shiri tries to leave.

Shiri pulled away from him slowly, a light emanating from his mouth as she sucked in a deep breath, her mouth still agape. The light is pulled from his mouth, a white sphere suspended between the two before she sucks in again and it enters her mouth. She releases him completely, the sand returning to its natural form and falling away as he collapses to the ground, completely unconscious, maybe even dead, Shiri isn't quite sure as she swallows the sphere of light.

Everything goes silent. The powers fade and the forcefield drops. Her eyes return to their normal earthy brown, and she stands there, unmoving, unblinking, for several long seconds. The morning sun beating down on her exposed skin as she finally turned her head upwards to look at it, eyes squinting. It was beautiful, everything around her was so bright and beautiful.

"Shiri?" She heard and she turned slowly to her family and her friends, Finn having stepped forward. She blinked, a small smile slowly gracing her lips as she took a step towards them, forgetting about her troubles for just a moment. They smiled back, a look of relief crossing their face and as Shiri went to take another step, she felt a large pulse within her.

She gasped, clutching her chest where her heart was located as it pulsed violently again. Her throat felt like it was closing, she couldn't catch a breath as the magic violently pulsed through her. She couldn't even bring herself to scream as her heart rate quickened and her vision started darkening.

Finn screamed her name as they surged forward, watching as her eyes rolled in the back of her head, magic pulsing off her. She collapsed backward, falling to the ground before Finn caught her, falling to their knees to cradle her. She went completely limp as

the pulsing magic slowed then stopped. She let out a small exhale of air before… silence.

“Shiri! Shiri! Sweetheart, wake up!” Finn yelled, patting her cheeks with their free hand, tears starting to fall down their cheeks. They went to find her pulse but couldn’t find it neither could they feel a breath coming from her. They heard a bloodcurdling scream behind them, turning slightly to see Lexie collapsing to the sand, sobbing.

“No… No, No, NO! SHIRI! Please!” they begged, holding the corpse to them, sobbing into her chest.

Chapter End Notes

Oops :(Sorry guys! Please don't kill me!

Kudos and comment! or I won't post an update! ;)

Chapter 21

Chapter Summary

The group has a plan to try to bring Shiri back
Shiri reunites with her mama

Chapter Notes

TW: some mentions of gore

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 21

No one was sure how long they sat there in stunned silence. Finn refused to release the body, keeping it clutched closely to their chest as the sobs subsided to make way for emptiness. They couldn't stop rubbing their cheeks against her skin, trying and failing to scent their dead mate, who had gone cold in their arms. Lexie had taken up sitting with them, keeping Shiri's hand clutched in her own as her own sobs refused to cease. It was the only noise in the silence of the Crimson Waste.

Glimmer and Bow had checked on Alejandro, who was surprisingly still alive, and tied him up while he was still unconscious. Mermista and Seahawk held their daughter, who was trembling with unheard sobs. Catra sat with Shimmer and Nala, her daughter still tightly wrapped around her as she stared blankly ahead, smelling the grief on her other kit but unable to comfort them. Halina hadn't been able to stay still, brimming with rage and grief as Archer tried to calm her.

"I don't understand why Aunt Adora can't just use her She-Ra magic and bring her back! The longer you wait, the harder it's going to be!" Halina yelled, hands gesticulating wildly as Adora stood back, watching Halina pace.

“I can’t bring her back. This isn’t some normal injury or sickness that I can heal, this is magic from the Heart that even I can’t interfere with. Hallie, trust me, I wish I could, but I can’t!”

“You haven’t even tried! Aren’t you supposed to be a part of the Heart as well?! Do something!” Halina screamed, clenching in fists in anger.

“Love, please… if Aunt Adora says she can’t do anything then there’s nothing we can do… we need to go, there’s a lot that needs to be done now,” Archer told her gently, going to touch her shoulders but she jerked away violently, heading over to Finn and her mom. Archer sighed, rubbing his face tiredly. Halina placed a hand on her mom’s shoulder after she approached, squeezing it lightly.

“Hey… we need to go. We can’t stay here, mom,” she spoke softly and Lexie looked up at her youngest daughter… now her only daughter with glassy eyes. “We have a funeral to plan…”

“No…” Finn said softly, grip tightening on the body. Everyone looked at them, having not heard them talk for a while. Their voice was hoarse and broken. “No, you’re not taking her. You’re accepting that she’s gone, she can’t be gone…”

“She’s gone, Finn. She knew what was going to happen and she used the last of her time to protect us. She died a hero… let her have that,” Halina told him and Finn’s eyes flashed with anger, baring their fangs.

“Why are you acting like this?! Aren’t you upset that she is gone?! She’s your sister!”

“I can’t afford to break down right now, my family needs me! Don’t you dare accuse me of not being upset! I am beyond upset! But I can’t afford to grovel like you! I have to keep us going!”

“Guys, stop!” Adora yelled, going up to the two of them. “Arguing is not going to bring her back! Arguing is not going to do anything but hurt us more! Finn, sweetie… it’s time to let go…”

“No! She… we were supposed to get married… we were supposed to start a family together… we were supposed to travel the universe… I thought the Heart was supposed to protect her?!” they argued, looking at their mom with tear-filled eyes.

“I don’t know why… maybe the drug was just stronger than the influence the Heart had on her? She fought it til the end but it wasn’t enough… maybe she took the offer to be joined with the other queens in the Heart so we could still see her,” Adora suggested, putting a hand on their shoulder.

“The Heart… The Heart!” they exclaimed, getting up with Shiri still cradled in their arms. She hung limply in their arms, Lexie still holding onto her hand. Adora raised an eyebrow at them. “The Heart could bring her back… the Salinean waters in the Heart chamber-”

“Has healing properties!” Adora finished, coming to the same conclusion as Finn. For the first time in a while, she could see hope blooming over her child’s face. “We could take her to the Heart chamber and submerge her in the water! If anything, we can appeal to the queens of the past to bring her back!”

“Aunt Glimmer!” Finn said, turning to his aunt who was instantly at their side. “Please… take us to the Crystal Palace?”

“No problem!” Glimmer told them as Halina helped Lexie to her feet, the queen stiff and silent. Catra came over with Shimmer and Nala as well as Bow. “Mermista, Seahawk, can you take care of our prisoner?”

“You got it, Glimmer,” Mermista responded as Glimmer took a hold of Finn and Adora, everyone else grabbing a hold of someone as they disappeared.

–

They made their way into the Heart Chamber, Glimmer having teleported to the outside of the building. Everyone was in awe as they walked through the winding hallways and even now stopped

at the entrance to admire the room. Finn didn't stop and Adora had to tell everyone to take off their shoes. Finn made their way down to the crescent-shaped pool of water, slowly wading into the cool water as the Heart glowed brilliantly above them. Adora wasn't far behind them as well as Lexie as everyone else settled on the banks of the pool, silent and in awe of the room around them.

Finn slowly sunk down to their knees, the water coming up below their chest as they settled Shiri into the water, making sure she was fully submerged save for her face. She floated, her hair moving wildly around her head as she remained unmoving on her own accord. Adora and Lexie settled across from each other, easing Shiri out of Finn's arms so that her head would settle by them and they could take a hold of her as well.

They waited a few minutes, not sure what was supposed to happen next. Finn stared down at their beloved's face, thumbs tracing the curves of her cheeks. They froze as the reflection of the Heart in the pool turned a sinister red. Adora and Lexie looked up at the Heart, which pulsed angrily before they heard a voice.

"The Heart is angry," it said and Lexie looked over Adora's shoulder to the inlet where Queen Musa stood, frowning at the scene before her. Lexie stood quickly, sending ripples through the water.

"Queen Musa, please… my daughter, your granddaughter-"

"Is gone. I don't know what you expected to accomplish by bringing the body here," she said as she stepped forward into the water with them.

"The Heart could heal her! The Salinean waters could heal her! We came here hoping to bring her back!" Finn argued, frowning at the ageless queen.

"No. The Heart will not bring her back. The Heart is angry at her disrespect and carelessness. In fact, so angry that it did not off

her a place amongst her family. So no, I don't think the Heart will be bringing her back," Musa told them, stopping by Shiri's feet. Finn's face contorted in anger as they sneered up at her.

"That's not fair! She made a mistake! She's been trying to do better! She was accepting her role, her powers! Why can't it give her another chance?! She doesn't deserve this!"

"She put Etheria at risk. Look, the Heart bestows gifts to those it deems worthy and what Etheria needs. Etheria needed a visionary, someone who could lead it into the future and away from the shadows of the past. Shiri didn't understand her purpose and didn't try to understand it. She was bitter and angry about her role and she did everything she could to push back. She got what she wanted: freedom from her responsibility."

"Is there nothing we can do? Nothing we can offer? Please! I already lost your daughter! I can't lose my own as well!" Lexie begged, falling to her knees before the queen, grabbing onto her robes as her body started to rack with sobs. Musa knelt to take her daughter-in-law into her arms, holding her.

"I am so sorry… there's nothing we can-" she stopped, eyes glowing briefly before she came back, pulling away. "It… The Heart says that it will bring her back if she is willing to come back on one condition."

"What is it?!" Finn asked, holding Shiri's head.

Musa turned towards Adora, cocking her head to the side. "Do you still have the previous Sword of Protection, She-Ra?"

"Of course… It's in my wardrobe in Brightmoon… I don't understand why you're asking…"

"We need the runestone. And a representative from every elemental kingdom to pull this off," Musa told her, remaining vague in her instructions as Adora looked to Glimmer, who nodded and teleported away.

“What are you going to do? How are we pulling this off?” Finn asked as Musa turned her attention to them.

“The Heart wants the runestone returned, it is a part of it and it has been too long since it has been separated. It plans on using the runestone as a way to reconnect Shiri to itself and the living world, like a tether. Also… you’re not going to like this…”

“Tell me! Tell us!”

“It’s also a punishment. For her disregard to her powers and her role in Etheria. This way she is forced to be bonded to the Heart but also… to remind her about her failure and disobedience. The runestone will replace one of her eyes.”

The silence in the room was deafening as the news sunk in. They were going to have to disfigure her to save her. It made Finn sick to their stomach as they looked down at her unmarred face, bending over to press their forehead to hers. They couldn’t imagine disfiguring the face they loved so much, the woman that had completely stolen their heart. But if it meant bringing her back… they would do any means necessary to see her smile one more time.

At some point, Halina had waded into the pool by her mom’s side, holding the older woman as she shook, sending small tremors through the water. Finn had not seen their aunt look so distraught before. When their Aunt Calliope had passed, they had not been able to see their Aunt Lexie much during or after the funeral so they didn't know what she was like. If this is any indication, Aunt Lexie did not take the death of her wife well either.

Glimmer finally reappeared, carrying the hilt of their mother’s broken sword, the runestone gleaming brightly in the middle. She also had brought along Flora, Aster, Sereia, and Frosta, who did not look pleased with being there. Flora gasped when she saw Finn in the pool and immediately ran forward.

“Oh my gods! What happened?! Shiri?!” she exclaimed as she started wading into the pool. Finn’s lip trembled as she made her way over, wrapping her arms around her friend as Glimmer handed the sword hilt over to Adora.

“We need She-Ra,” Musa said matter-of-factly, making her way around towards Shiri’s head. “We need the five elemental princesses in the pool as well as a Musicia representative. Everyone else needs to vacate the water.”

“I’ll stay, mom. Go sit with Aunt Catra,” Halina said, helping her mom up and gently pushing her towards the bank. Lexie nodded slowly before climbing out, Catra holding a comforting arm out for her. Lexie settled into Catra’s side, her head falling over to rest on her friend's shoulder. Shimmer, Sereia, Aster, and Frosta all entered the water, going to encircle the body as Adora transformed into She-Ra. The water started to faintly glow a bluish hue as the princesses united under the Heart.

“Finn, you should go…” She-Ra said softly but they shook their head, keeping hold of Shiri’s head as their forehead continued to rest against hers.

“I’m staying. She’s my mate, I’m staying till the end.”

She-Ra turned towards Musa, a silent question on whether or not that's okay. The ageless queen nodded.

“It’ll be fine, they are bonded. Now, I need you to remove the runestone from the sword and hand it to me,” Musa told her as she sat by Shiri’s head. “This will not be pretty. Look away,” she warned the others as she reached forward over Shiri’s left eye, prying the lid up. Her usual warm brown eye was glossed over with a white film, cold and lifeless as Finn watched the queen dig her fingers into it to pull it out. Flora looked away, gagging softly as Shimmer shuddered.

She-Ra dug her own fingers into the hilt of the broken sword, removing the blue runestone, tossing it to the remnants to the

side and handing the stone over to Musa. She took it in her bloody fingers, having discarded the eyeball into the water. She proceeded to place the runestone in the empty socket, maneuvering it so that it fits in perfectly. Finn watched for a moment as everything seemed to pulse before the socket seemed to accept the replacement as its own.

"I need each princess to be touching her. We need the power of the five elementals to make this work," Musa told them as each princess grabbed a body part. Halina grabbed one of Shiri's hands as Flora grabbed the other. Shimmer and Aster both held onto a knee as Frosta grabbed hold of a foot, each princess starting to glow with their runestones power as the Heart above them starting glowing brighter, making the room vibrate with power.

"How long will this take?" Finn asked Musa softly, watching it unfold before them.

"It depends on Shiri now. It will only work if she is willing to come back. I sense her here now and she is not alone…"

–

Shiri felt peaceful. This was the most peace she had ever felt in her entire life. There was no weight of the crown, of her power, of her appearances on her shoulders. Everything was bright and when she inhaled deeply, she could smell a summer breeze and lavender. It was warm as if the sun was pressing against her skin.

"Shiri!" she heard someone yell and opened her eyes to see Calliope waving at her, smiling brilliantly. She looked younger, no wrinkles or weariness gracing her beautiful face or gray hairs occupying the black curls Shiri had inherited from her. She seemed livelier, happier, just as peaceful as Shiri felt. This is why she ran over as quickly as she could and flung herself into her mama's arms, inhaling the familiar scent of lavender and vanilla that had always comforted her as a child.

“Oh, my song, I’ve missed you so much,” Calliope told her, kissing over her face happily, sending Shiri into a fit of giggles.

“I’ve missed you too, mama! I have so much to tell you! But first… where are we?”

Calliope shrugged, taking her daughter's arm as the two walked towards a familiar-looking gazebo in a familiar-looking garden. A place Calliope had cultivated for years, where Shiri had grown up and loved just as dearly.

“Heaven? An Afterlife? Limbo? I’m not quite sure what they would call this place but I like to think of it as paradise. It’s beautiful, isn’t it?”

Shiri nodded in agreement, noticing a figure sitting at their tea table, holding a bundle. The older man looked up, smiling as Calliope and Shiri came over and sat down. The man had dark black hair that was pulled back into a ponytail and dark, deep-set eyes that crinkled around the edges from years of laughter.

“My song, this is your grandfather, King Ronen. Daddy, this is your granddaughter, Shiri,” Calliope introduced them, taking the wiggling bundle from her father’s arms, cradling it against her chest.

“I have heard so much about you, Shiri! I am so happy to finally meet my granddaughter!” Ronen exclaimed, getting up to hug her. She hugged back happily.

“And this is your baby sister… my first baby that I lost years before I had you and Zimri. Your grandfather has been taking care of her all these years so that I could be reunited with her when I finally came back,” Calliope explained, Shiri leaning over to examine the tiny baby girl, no bigger than a banana.

Shiri’s hands instinctively went to her own stomach, something seeming to pulse through her as she could hear vague voices around her. There was crying, heartache, and pain. What was

this? She remembered her baby… Finn… what was she doing here?

"My song? Are you okay?" Calliope asked with concern, causing Shiri to blink out of whatever stupor she had sunken into.

"I… I'm dead… and my baby is dead… I didn't survive the drug…"

"You didn't… I'm so sorry. But it's not too late. You have a choice now."

"A choice?" Shiri asked and both Calliope and Ronen nodded.

"You can stay here with us forever. There's no pain or suffering here. It's always warm and peaceful, we can be happy together," Ronen said with a smile.

"Or you can go back… You have people waiting for you. There's a baby you can have, a kingdom you can rule, a love you can cherish. It will be hard and painful, you will suffer and cry, but there is also much joy to be had there," Calliope told her, handing the bundle back to her father and standing, taking Shiri's hand.

Shiri stood up and they walked away from the gazebo and the scene melted into the Heart Chamber. They stood on the inlet under the cherry blossom trees, watching her family and friends work diligently to bring her back. Her mom, Lexie, was sobbing on the banks with Aunt Catra and Nala. Her sister was holding her limp hand, glowing with magical energy. Finn… Finn held her head, pressing their forehead against hers and whispering softly, almost praying over her.

"You can come back. They all miss you," Calliope told her as they turned to face each other, holding each other's hands. Shiri looked back out at everyone before looking at her mother's gentle blue eyes, biting her lip.

"I don't want to feel that anger anymore… that pain or longing or loneliness… I don't think I want to go back…"

Calliope shrugged, continuing to smile. "That's completely up to you, my song."

–

It had to have been ten minutes since they had gotten started and yet…

"Nothing's happening! Why isn't anything happening?" Finn exclaimed in a panic, looking around desperately. The five princesses seemed to be growing exhausted as their powers were being exerted.

"I don't think Shiri wants to come back…" Musa mumbled softly, rubbing her forehead softly. "What are you doing, Calliope?"

"She has to come back! She wants to come back! Isn't there any way we could convince her? I need to speak with her!" Finn told the ageless woman, ears flattening against their skull.

"If she doesn't want to come back, she doesn't have to. Again, it's completely her choice…"

"Dammit! I don't care! I need to speak with her! I can convince her to come back! You said you could feel her here?! Reveal her!" Finn demanded. Musa bit her lip, taking a deep breath before nodding. She turned away towards the inlet, waving a hand. It was as if a veil dropped and under the cherry blossom trees stood Shiri and Queen Calliope, holding each other's hands and talking. They seemed transparent, obviously spirit-like, not completely there. Lexie gasped from the bank, standing up quickly as she saw her wife standing opposite her.

"That's completely up to you, my song," Calliope told Shiri softly and Shiri turned her back to the water, going to take a step forward but hesitating, completely freezing.

Calliope tilted her head, smiling sadly, already knowing the answer to her question. "Why do you hesitate?"

"I don't know…" Shiri whispered. Calliope took a step towards her daughter as she started to sing.

I know a girl from a kingdom

She stands apart from the crowd

She loves to sing and her people

She makes her whole family proud

Sometimes the world seems against you

The journey may leave a scar

But scars can heal and reveal just

Where you are

The people you love will change you

The things you have learned will guide you

And nothing on Etheria can silence

The quiet voice still inside you

And when that voice starts to whisper

"Shiri, you've come so far"

Shiri, listen

Do you know who you are?

Shiri turned back around, in full view of the others, tears in her eyes as she looked at her mother, biting her lip. “Who am I?” She whispered before she started to sing.

I am a girl who loves my kingdom

And the girl who loves to sing

It calls me

I am the daughter of the kingdoms queen

We are descended from warriors

Who fought their way across the world

They call me

Everything started to grow brighter, faint voices harmonizing around the room as the queens of the past flashed into existence. Everyone gasped softly at the display as Shiri stepped closer to the bank.

I’ve delivered us to where we are

I have journeyed farther

I am everything I’ve learned and more

Still, it calls me

And the call isn’t out there at all, it’s inside me!

It’s like the tide

Always falling and rising

She turned back to Calliope, who held her arms open for her. Shiri ran forward, hugging her tightly. She pulled away after a moment, pressing their foreheads together as tears streamed down her face, the harmonizing echoing loudly through the chamber.

I will carry you here in my heart, you'll remind me

That come what may

I know the way

I am Shiri

She pulled away completely as the queens of the past started to disappear, the harmony echoing through the room. Shiri stepped forward quickly towards the bank, descending into the water and towards the group. As she made her way towards her body, the last of the queens disappearing, Calliope looked up, meeting Lexie's stunned eyes from across the room.

"I am waiting for you, my love. I've made sure I got what I always wanted… for you to have more time," Calliope told her as she slowly disappeared as well.

Shiri walks through her body, turning her back towards Finn, and slowly lowers herself down, her body absorbing her spirit back into it. Everything goes completely silent as the light dies, the princesses stop glowing, the last of the queens disappear, including Musa. Finn stares down at Shiri's face, holding their breath. One moment, two moments…

And she sits up, gasping desperately for breath as she jerks her hands out of her sister and her friend's grips to claw at her throat. She feels hands patting her back as she finally manages to draw in a deep breath, gulping down the air into her lungs that had not held breath in hours. She felt her heart beating erratically, trying to find its rhythm again. It was then that she finally felt the pain searing through her limbs and her skull, one hand flying up to clutch her missing eyes. She felt heavy again, the weight of

everything that had happened crushing down on her as she fell back into Finn’s arms, vaguely hearing yelling around her.

“Shiri?! Thank the gods! We lost you! We thought we lost you forever!” they told her, kissing her cheeks happily. She felt wetness on her face as their tears rubbed against her cheeks. They immediately went to scent her, purring happily. Halina was sobbing, wrapping around Shiri’s waist as Lexie rushed forward, gripping her daughter's hands and kissing them.

“You’re alive! Thank the gods, you’re alive!” she sobbed. Shiri groaned softly, eyes closing.

“Tired… noisy… sleep…” she mumbled, blacking out immediately.

Chapter End Notes

Song Creds: I am Moana (Song of the Ancestors) from Moana by Auli'i Cravalho and Rachel House

Yay! Shiri's back! But there is still more drama to unpack! Did you like seeing Calliope again? I honestly feel kinda bad for killing her :(

Don't forget to kudos and comment!

Chapter 22

Chapter Summary

They interview Alejandro, Shiri wakes up, there's a big confrontation in the war room

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 22

Finn entered the spare room of the Brightmoon Castle. Even after almost thirty years, a proper holding cell still had not been built for prisoners. Then again, there had not been much need for a holding cell after the war, most crimes not hard enough to require a sentence from the Queen. Their eyes focused on the center of the room where a circle of light sat with Alejandro sitting on a chair in the middle of the circle. Queen Glimmer, She-Ra, Catra, King Bow, and Queen Lexie all stood around the circle as Glimmer held up a runestone: a truth spell.

"You're telling me that you have no recollection of why you attacked the kingdoms at all? You don't even know who you are?" Glimmer questioned him, face scrunched up in anger and confusion as Alejandro simply shook his head.

"I don't know who I am or where I am. Did I do something wrong?" he asked, looking around at the five faces before him, scared and confused. It was like his mind was a blank slate, there was nothing there to draw from. No memories, no identity, nothing.

"You're in Brightmoon. Do you know what Brightmoon is?" She-Ra asked, stepping forward with her arms crossed over her chest. Alejandro shook their head again.

“My daughter. Do you remember my daughter, Princess Shiri?” Lexie asked, clenching her fists. Alejandro knit his eyebrows together, thinking. The five adults leaned in, holding their breath.

“Shiri? Shiri… No, doesn’t ring a bell. Is she someone I’m supposed to know?” he asked, wringing his hands together nervously. The five adults groaned in frustration and Glimmer shook her head, releasing the truth spell.

“No. That’s all for today. Thank you for your cooperation,” she told him. He nodded, leaning back in his chair as they made their way out of the room, Catra throwing an arm around Finn’s shoulders to lead them out with them. They all stood out in the hallway in a loose circle, Glimmer closing the door behind her before sighing and leaning against it heavily.

“How can we convict someone who has no recollection of what they’ve done? Shiri did something to him and his memories… Do you think she’s still trying to protect him?” Glimmer asked no one in particular but Finn shook their head.

“No, I don’t think she did it to protect him, whatever she did. That would be something you would have to ask her,” they told her and She-Ra transformed back to his mom Adora, who kept her arms crossed over her chest.

“How is she doing?” she asked softly and Lexie bit her lip.

“She’s exhausted. She’s been in and out of sleep the past twenty-four hours in the infirmary. The doctors have her on oxygen and are keeping her monitored. She was gone for a long time…”

“And how are you doing, Lex?” Bow asked gently, placing a comforting hand on her arm. She smiled sadly at him.

“I’m hanging in there. I’m just glad we got her back… I don’t know what I would have done if we couldn’t have gotten her back… but I keep thinking about Callie. What did she mean, I need more time?”

“You obviously still have something important to do. Calliope was never one to say something she didn’t mean,” Catra said, squeezing Finn’s shoulder gently.

“Yea, you’re right. She never liked to mince her words, she spent so long keeping them to herself… I should get back to the infirmary to check on my girls, Zimri will be here shortly,” Lexie told them, allowing Bow to pull her into a quick hug.

“Don’t forget we have an Alliance meeting in a couple of hours,” Glimmer told her and Lexie nodded before pulling away and walking down the hallway towards the infirmary. When she was out of earshot, Glimmer turned to the rest of the Best Friend Squad plus Finn with a frown.

“This is not how we imagined any of this would go… Shiri is a lot more powerful than we could have predicted. We need more information about her powers.”

“Not happening,” Finn told them, his mom turned to him with a frown. “Shiri and Halina found out about us infiltrating their castle to gain more information about Alejandro while we were trapped in the club. They were pissed… Halina won’t let me in the infirmary to check on Shiri…”

“Fuck,” Adora said, pinching the bridge of her nose. “And you weren’t able to fix this yet… we’re going to have a problem when she wakes up, aren’t we?”

“Yea…” Finn sighed, leaning into their mama. “I don’t want to lose her…”

Catra kissed their forehead gently. “You’re not going to lose her. I’m sure once you explain everything, she’ll forgive you. Your mom did me.”

“At least you’re not a criminal warlord,” Bow suggested with a smile, causing a small laugh to echo through the group as they headed down the hallway to get ready for the meeting.

—

When Shiri woke up, she felt warm and groggy. She blinked, noticing she only had half of her visionary field as a hand reached up to touch her left eye. She felt cloth bandages wrapped around it and the side of her head and let her hand fall lower to feel the oxygen mask covering her nose and mouth. She took in a deep breath as her wrist came into view and she noticed bandages around them as well. Right, the shackles…

She went to try to sit up but felt her legs were pinned down to the cot. She lifted her head gently and her heart melted at the sight. How they all managed to fit on the small cot with her, she was unsure but Halina, Nala, and Melog were all curled up around her, Melog taking her up legs completely and resting their large head against her stomach as Halina gripped her free hand, snoring softly. Nala clutched onto her leg, purring softly in her sleep. It was calming and Shiri was tempted to fall back asleep again.

She would have if it hadn't been for the doctor that came over to check on her vitals. She met their eyes and pointed to her mask with a question. The doctor nodded, going to remove the oxygen mask and checking her heartbeat.

"Doc… I was pregnant… Is my baby okay?" she whispered softly and the doctor looked at her with confusion.

"We weren't aware of your situation… I can run a blood panel to make sure you are still pregnant if you would like?" they asked and she nodded. The doctor went off to go grab the supplies and she felt Melog stretch, letting out a questioning mrrp as she let her free hand fall over to give them scritches.

"Hey, Melog… I missed you too," she told them as they meowed at her. The doctor came back over and got to work on drawing some blood as Nala awoke, letting out a loud purr as she blinked her blue eyes up at Shiri. She crawled up farther, being careful not to disturb the arm that the doctor was working on to nestle herself into Shiri's side.

“You’re awake, I was so worried. Everyone was, even Finn. Are you okay?” She asked and Shiri nodded, moving her hand away from Melog to scratch behind Nala’s ears instead. Melog made a noise of disapproval before jumping off the bed, waking Halina up. Halina shot up from the cot, looking around for danger before her eyes settled on Shiri. The doctor finished up drawing her blood, wrapping up her arm before heading away.

“You’re awake! How long have you been awake?” Halina asked, settling back down into a chair by her bed, gripping her hand again. Shiri squeezed her hand back with a smile, having to turn her head all the way to see her sister.

“Just a few minutes… How long have I been asleep?”

“About twenty-four hours, give or take. Apparently dying is very exhausting? Who knew,” Halina joked lightly, sighing softly.

“I’m so sorry about that… I promise not to die unexpectedly anymore,” Shiri told her before sitting up, making Nala bound off the bed as well. “Where is everyone?”

“A Princess Alliance meeting. Apparently, Alejandro doesn’t have any memories of who he is or what he did…”

“I guess I need to explain what happened… help me up,” she held her arms out and Halina stood, helping her sister to her feet.

“Are you sure you’re up for it? You need to rest and… Finn will be there…”

“I can handle Finn,” Shiri told her.

–

The War Room was packed with every kingdom's royal family, minus the Kingdom of Snows. Everyone was chatting with each other as the meeting had not officially started yet, Zimri staying close to his mom as she led him around the room, talking with each of her friends. The younger royals had formed a circle of

their own, talking amongst each other quietly as Zimri finally broke away from his mom with a promise to return. He walked towards his friends, feeling a little strange not having his twin by his side, and was able to catch a small snippet of their conversation before they stopped talking.

"They don't know what they're going to do with him. He doesn't remember a thing. Whatever Shiri did has now made it impossible to convict him," Archer said softly and Shimmer huffed, crossing her arms over her chest.

"She's still protecting him. Finn, you can't be okay with this," she argued and Finn mimicked her stance, tilting their head to the side.

"She's not protecting him. She did what she had to do to protect Etheria and I trust her judgment," they defended their fiance and the conversation went quiet as Zimri came up beside Finn.

"I'm glad to hear that. I know my sister and whatever she did, it was to protect Etheria, not to protect him. He can still be convicted, it will just be harder," Zimri told them, raising an eyebrow for anyone to object. He was someone who commanded respect from any room he entered, a man of very few words, and people listened when he did speak. Obviously, no one objected. He turned his attention to Finn.

"How is she doing? I didn't get a chance to stop by the infirmary to check on her," he asked and Finn huffed softly, causing Zimri to give him a confused expression.

"Your younger sister won't let me see her. Your mom said she's fine, just resting but I haven't seen her either."

"Why won't she let you see her? Halina loves you…" Zimri squinted his eyes in suspicion as Archer and Shimmer looked anywhere but at them and Finn shifted from foot to foot. "What did you do?"

"I-" before Finn could say anything, the war room doors opened and Halina stepped inside, holding onto Shiri's hand and guiding her into the room. Shiri looked tired, Zimri noted and paler than usual. Her hair was a nest of knots, half of her face was covered with bandages to cover her eye along with bandages to cover her wrists. She wore a simple white dress and he could see bruises on some of the exposed skin.

Nala bounded past them and into Adora's arms, snuggling into her mom happily. Zimri walked away from the group and towards his sisters, meeting them halfway into the room and embracing his older twin gently, pressing her into his chest. Her arms trembled as she wrapped them around his back, taking in a shaky breath.

"I'm so glad you're okay… I thought we lost you. Who else would duet with me?" he teased softly, producing a smile from her as she glanced over his shoulder, meeting Finn's blue eyes across the room with her one brown eye.

Zimri pulled away, moving as they stood apart from each other, staring the other down. Finn gave her a small smile and she saw red. She had hoped she could forget what they did, to move past this and be with the one she loved but… the depth of betrayal she felt boiled through her veins as she quickly stepped towards them, purpose in her steps. Finn mistook her quick stride for eagerness, moving forward to meet her. Imagine their surprise when they found themselves knocked to the ground. Shiri had straddled them, her forearm pressed against their throat as she gritted her teeth.

The room erupted into chaos as she glared down at them. Finn gripped onto her forearm but made no move to remove her, ears flattening against their head as shame and guilt boiled within them. They could see the anger flashing in her brown eye, the sadness, the betrayal, and pain as her nostrils flared.

"Give me one good reason not to break your nose," she hissed, clenching her free hand into a fist, itching to punch something.

Finn's eyes softened as they watched her and they gave their head a tiny shake, unable to move it much more.

"You're beautiful… even when you hate me…"

A soft sob raised out of Shiri's throat as she moved off of them, backing up a couple of feet as the room went silent, watching the scene unfold before them. Archer and Shimmer helped Finn to their feet but they made no move to get closer to Shiri as she clenched both of her fists, face scrunched up in anger, tears threatening to spill over.

"Tell me it's not true… you lied down in that basement to save the others, right? You didn't betray me and my trust…?" she gave them a desperate look, a pleading looking, hoping beyond hope that what she had heard was a lie. That hope faded as she saw their faces fall, their ears and tail go limp as they rubbed their arm.

"Finn did what they had to do to bring Alejandro to justice. It was not ideal but they never meant to hurt you. They genuinely love you and that is not something you can fake," Shimmer interjected, trying to defend her friend but Shiri threw her a sharp look, not wanting to hear from the sparkly princess.

"It really isn't what it looks like-" Archer started and Halina scoffed, causing the statement to die in his throat as he realized that this operation affected his own relationship.

"You… what? Was hoping I could give you information? You thought that if you tried to be my friend again, I'll spill my guts about my life and his operations to you? I hadn't talked to any of you in years and you thought you could come into my kingdom and use me?! You only reached out to me when you needed something, not because you genuinely cared or had feelings for me! I was just a means to an end!" Shiri's voice started rising as she spoke, her chest heaving as panic was starting to set in. Finn shook their head, taking a step forward that sent her a step back.

“It wasn’t like that! I swear! I have always been your friend! My feelings for you are genuine, I truly do love you! Yes, when we first entered the palace, my intentions were not purely to reconnect for old time's sake but it happened that way! I gained my friend back, I came to realize my feelings for her, and I fell in love with her! I fell in love with you, Shiri!”

“You slept with me… when we first reconnected, we started sleeping together. Did you do that to gain information?! Did you think getting into my bed would gain you access to him?!”

“Of course not! I did not sleep with you to gain information! I swear! I would never do that!” Finn looked hurt, ears flat against their skull and tail starting to swish with agitation.

“You’re lying…” she accused, wiping away tears from her eye.

“What do I have to gain from lying to you?”

“You had everything to gain from lying to me before?! What makes it different now?!”

“Because I love you! Because being with you is like walking into a house and realizing you are home! Why else would I propose to you?! I want to spend my life with you! Why can’t you believe me?!”

“Because you spent months lying to me…” she said softly, shoulders slumping with defeat and exhaustion. “I need a break…”

“You’re tired… take a break and we can continue this later, preferably in private…” Finn told her, taking another hesitant step towards her. She lifted a hand as if to shield herself from them.

“No… from you. I need a break from you… actually…” she reached up, unclasping the necklace from around her neck and holding it in the palm of her hand. Finn’s eyes lit up with absolute panic as they crossed over to her, grabbing a hold of her forearms gently.

"No… please. I didn't mean it. We just needed to stop him, I never wanted to hurt you. I was going to tell you when we got him. Everything I said is true, I am absolutely and stupidly in love with you…"

"And I can't trust you!" she yelled, jerking her arms away and throwing the necklace at their chest, which they caught numbly as tears streamed down the right side of her face. "You broke my heart… And if you had just asked me to help you, I would have! But you didn't… you led me on for months. I spent years isolated without my friends… none of you came to check on us!" She accused the rest of the room, turning her gaze around. "None of you cared about our kingdom after my mama died! None of you cared about us! We were always just a means to an end… No more," she turned away, going to walk towards the door but was stopped when she felt arms around her waist. She turned her head to see Finn on their knees, arms wrapped around her, gripping desperately onto her dress, just over her stomach.

"Don't leave… please… I am so sorry… I should have been a better friend to you… We wanted to help but didn't know how… please, Shiri… please please please…"

"Let go of me, Finn."

"Please, don't go… Please, stay…"

"Let go of me, Finn! I can't stay here!" she sobbed, grabbing a hold of their hands and jerking them off of her. "Mom…"

Finn released her as Halina got in between them, glaring at them as Zimri made it to Shiri's side before their mom, wrapping an arm around her shoulders and leading her towards the door. Archer looked at Halina, giving her a pleading look as she turned her glare to him, going to her sister's other side and wrapping an arm around her waist, and helping Zimri lead her out of the room.

Lexie looked shell-shocked as she stepped towards the door that her children walked out of before looking to Finn. Her face

hardened as she held out her hand silently and they relinquished the necklace over to her, where she proceeded to remove the treble clef charm from it and give it back. She turned to face the rest of the room, her friends and family she had made over the years.

"They did not act alone. I know you were involved," she said, directing the statement towards the Best Friend Squad, who looked ashamed. "You used my kingdom… my daughter… without consulting me or her. She's right. None of you were there for us during our darkest time. Our kingdom has only ever been called upon when the other kingdoms needed something. You seem to forget that Musicia is the largest and most powerful kingdom in Etheria. We don't need you. This is why I am formally pulling out of the Princess Alliance. You hurt my child, which is unacceptable and you jeopardized years of friendship we had together. I will send formal documentation by the end of the week," she concluded.

"Lexie, please… Don't do anything rash. We can talk about this, sort this whole mess out," Glimmer told her, taking a step forward as Lexie threw her a hard look. It was a look no one had seen in years, not since the war.

"I'm protecting my family, which is what I have always done and always will do. And that is Queen Lexie to you until the day my daughter takes the throne. You are no longer free to speak casually to me, Queen Glimmer."

"This has been a complete misunderstanding. We can work this out, you're our friend," Adora said gently, stepping beside Glimmer. "More than that, you're our family."

"I see no family amongst this group. Calliope would be ashamed of what you have done," Lexie told them, taking a step back as she glanced around the room before turning to follow her children out of Brightmoon.

Chapter End Notes

Andddddd... I destroyed your OTP ._. sorry not sorry

but wait... there's more!!

Be sure to kudos/comment!

Chapter 23

Chapter Summary

Shiri grieves and announces her pregnancy to her family; Brightmoon comes to some realizations

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 22

Three days. That's how long Shiri laid in her bed. Three days. That's also how long her family rotated laying with her, refusing to leave her alone for a moment. She spent the first day sobbing uncontrollably, her sister holding her tightly as she ruined her dress with her tears and snot. The second day was numb, she couldn't bring herself to do much but stare at the wall or the canopy of her bed. Halina, Zimri, and Marmoris took turns laying with her, making sure she had company if she wanted to talk. They also took turns making sure she ate, hydrated, bathed, slept, and was checked on by the doctor.

Luckily, her test results had been transferred over to Musicia from Brightmoon and it confirmed that she was still pregnant, which made this situation even worse. It made everything her siblings wanted her to do easier. She needed to eat, drink and rest for her little one, to help them grow and keep up her strength for them. The doctor came in twice a day to change her dressings, check her vitals, and give her medication as needed. She and the doctor were the only two who knew she was pregnant and she planned on revealing it to her family soon… when she was done sulking and grieving.

On the third day, she found herself lying face to face with Marmoris, observing her brother-in-law with such intensity that it was making him squirm. Halina sat up behind her with her back against the headboard, working on a tablet and ignoring the

stare-off. Zimri and their mom were off working on the Princess Alliance redaction and the upcoming Music Festival. Shiri just wanted to sleep but she couldn't shut her brain down. After two days of sobbing and numbness, her brain had decided to kick into high gear and was going a hundred miles a moment and she needed to ask a question only Marmoris could answer.

"Mari?" she asked softly, watching as he stopped squirming, finally meeting her gaze and observing her expression, trying to gauge what she needed or wanted.

"Yes?"

"How did you know you were in love with my brother?" she whispered, hand clenching softly in front of her. He paused for a moment, knitting his eyebrows as he processed her question and thought about his answer before answering.

"It… was the small things. Tiny things that I didn't even realize were there until one day, I just saw him and knew. It was slow and then, all at once. It was the clumsy way he tried to waltz and the way his fingers moved so nimbly over the piano keys. How his blue eyes reminded me of the sea where I grew up and the little snores he makes when he's dozing. What really sold me was the way he loved his family so fiercely. The closeness you two share, as if you can read the other's mind. Or how he would drop everything to be by Halina's side when she was having a bad day. And the way he loved his moms… I fell in love with the way he loves others and I wanted him to love me like that… are you still in love with them?"

Shiri nodded slowly as Marmoris took a hold of her clenched hand, smoothing it out gently. "You don't have to say anything, I completely understand."

"But you don't… cause I'm pregnant and I don't know what to do…"

Marmoris sat up quickly and Halina dropped the tablet, both staring down at her in disbelief.

"You're pregnant?" Halina asked softly and Shiri nodded.

"I'm about a month and a half… almost two months…" she confirmed softly and had to cover her ears as both Halina and Marmoris shrieked in excitement, both wrapping her up tightly in a hug. She was squished between the two as they bounced in excitement.

"I'm going to be an auntie! This is so exciting! We haven't had a baby in years since Nicky! Oh, is it a boy or a girl? Do you even know yet! Ahhh! I can't believe it! I'm so happy for you!" Halina squealed, going to put her hands on Shiri's belly.

"And I'm going to be an uncle! A baby is a blessing! This is a blessing! Wait, does Finn know? Who all know?!" Marmoris asked, pulling away slightly to look at her.

"Only you two and the doctor knows… I haven't had the chance to tell them… I don't think I can tell them…"

"We support whatever decision you make cause your child will want for nothing! It will have so much love that it won't even miss having its other parent around. You hear that little one?" Halina said, speaking to Shiri's belly. "You are so so loved by everyone around you. Your auntie, your uncles, your grandmother, and cousins, we all love you so much."

"I think you should tell them but I will support your decision in whatever you choose. Do you know the gender? Are we getting a little niece or a little nephew?" Marmoris asked, still clutching Shiri's hands as she relaxed and teared up.

"The doctor hasn't confirmed anything but I keep having visions of a little girl. Oh, she's so beautiful…"

The door to her bedroom opened and Zimri and Lexie both entered, taking in the scene on the bed with confusion as Halina

jumped up and down in excitement, barely able to contain herself.

“Mom! Mom! Guess what?!”

“Hallie! Let Shiri share the news!” Marmoris scolded her, causing her to pout as Shiri wiped her eyes, looking up at her mom and twin. She took a deep breath, straightening up.

“Mom… you’re going to be a grandma and you’re going to be an uncle, Z,” she told them and Lexie blinked a moment before shrieking as loudly as Halina did, rushing over to the bed and engulfing her eldest in a bone-crushing hug.

“Do you hear that Z?! I’m going to be a grandma! Oh, I wish your mama was here for this! She would be so proud of you!”

“Of all the things she could be proud of, she would be most proud of being a grandma?” Zimri asked with confusion, taking a seat at the edge of the bed, where Marmoris crawled over to get into his lap.

“Your mama loved babies. She loved you guys but she could not wait to be a grandmother and spoil her grandkids. This is just the first of many I will have to spoil for her. Wait…” she pulled away, eyebrows knit together. “Who’s the other parent?”

“Finn is, mom. They’re the only one I’ve been with…”

“Do they know?”

Shiri shook her head, wrapping her arms around herself sadly. “No… and I plan on keeping it that way for now. I don’t want anyone outside of this family knowing… I need to protect us, me and my child. When I am ready, I will tell them but not know, not after everything that has happened… besides, I have more news.”

“Even more than me being a grandma? Nothing can top this, I promise,” Lexie told her, smiling.

“I’m not trying to top it… I’m just letting you know that I’m ready.”

“Ready?” Lexie asked, tilting her head in confusion.

“I’m ready… to take the crown. No more delays, no more broken promises. You deserve to spend your golden years spoiling your grandchild and spending time at the orphanage. Let’s plan for a month after the Music Festival?” Shiri told her.

“Are you sure? I don’t mind waiting till you’re ready. So much has happened recently, I will understand if you need more time, especially during this time when you need to focus on your child.”

“No, no more waiting. I’m ready to take the throne and rule our people. It’s my duty and I am tired of running from my responsibility. I need to show my child that I am someone of their word. I don’t expect to do it alone…”

“Of course you won’t be alone,” Halina said, squeezing her free hand gently. “We have your back.”

“It’s a tradition that the new queen usually marries on her coronation day… I had hoped that would have been the case… but you deserve better than someone who only cares when they need something. But the council is going to want someone by your side…”

Shiri turned her head to Zimri, meeting his eyes as he sucked in a breath. “Z… will you be my co-regent? I can’t imagine doing this with anyone else but you…”

“Of course I will,” he smiled, holding his arm out for his sister to crawl into his side, tucking herself into him. “It’s always the two of us.”

“This is temporary, I promise it won’t be forever. Co-Regent until the day I decide to marry or give over the crown. On my heart,” she swears to him and he just squeezes her shoulder in reassurance.

“I will be your co-regent for as long as you’ll have me. You won’t do any of this alone. Our kingdom will have two rulers and your baby will have two parents. They will want for nothing and they will have so much love, they will be sick of it,” Zimri promised her, the rest of the room agreeing as Lexie and Halina joined the group hug. Shiri let out a soft sob, overwhelmed with the love and support she was receiving from her family.

“I love you guys so much! Oh, gods, I have become just like mama! What would she think of these tears?!” she cried, eliciting a laugh from everyone.

“She would probably cry as well and you two would just be a sobbing mess on the bed by now. You know how she was,” Halina told her.

“Your mama was a crier. Remember when she was pregnant with Halina and we went to the music festival,” Lexie told them, an arm wrapped securely around her eldest daughter.

“And the citizens were giving her different gifts for the baby and she couldn’t stop crying long enough to thank everyone and Aunt Catra actually had to escort her back to the palace because she couldn’t see clearly to walk by herself,” Zimri finished, a fond smile gracing his features.

“And I think Flora started crying as well because mama was crying so hard,” Shiri offered, rubbing the tears from her eyes.

“She was always easily overwhelmed, your mama… but after you were done crying, she would have held you in her arms and sang you to sleep. She had such a big heart…” Lexie mumbled softly as Halina squeezed her arms around her mom.

“I can’t wait to sing my little one to sleep… This is going to be hard but… I can do it as long as I have all of you by my side. You guys are the best family I could have ever asked for. Thank you…” Shiri whispered, sniffling.

"You are most welcome, my song," Lexie squeezed her daughter once more before standing up from the bed. "We have a lot to prepare then. But first… I need your statement about what happened in the Crimson Waste… and what you suggest we should do with Alejandro…"

Shiri bit her lip, contemplating. Alejandro deserved justice for what he had done but… he was a hurt child who had no one to teach him properly… it broke her heart thinking about the childhood he grew up in and the life he never had. He was supposed to have been her brother and he harbored resentment over not being adopted for so long. She looked up at her mom, determination in her eyes.

"Let's head to the office so I can give my official statement and first decree," she said.

–

" *Princess Shiri, the Visionary, of Musicia unlocked her full powers while held captive under the nightclub in the Crimson Waste,"* Glimmer was reading out loud in the war room to the entire Princess Alliance by the end of that week, brows furrowed in concentration. *"While it is known that Princess Shiri was gifted with visions of Etheria's past, present, and future, it had remained unclear as to what her true purpose was. Along with visions, Princess Shiri is able to reach into the past and obtain the powers of any previous Musician Princess and Queen and use them as her own.*

While confronting Alejandro, leader of the Desert Rose Gang, she was able to use multiple powers to detain him. She was to show him mercy until he attacked her while outside of the club. This is when she obtained the powers of Princess Sonata, the memory eater, and-" Glimmer paused, sucking in a breath as she absorbed the next part of the official statement. " *She devoured his memories. Alejandro has no recollection of who he previously was and is no longer a threat to Etheria or any of its citizens.*

Only she knows of his true motivations since she has full access to his memories but will not disclose this information. We ask that no punishment be administered to Alejandro and that he be turned over to the custody of the Kingdom of Musicia to be rehabilitated and integrated back into society, per request of Princess Shiri, soon to be Queen of Musicia, and her Co-Regent, Prince Zimri. In best regards, Queen-Consort Lexie of Musicia, Crown Princess Shiri of Musicia, and Crown Prince Zimri of Musicia."

Glimmer sighed heavily, rubbing her face as she concluded the letter, setting it down beside the formal letter of resignation from the Princess Alliance and an invitation to the annual music festival. There were low whispers around the table as everyone was conflicted about the situation at hand and the loss of their friends.

"We can't just turn him over to their custody," Adora argued, frowning. "He needs to be brought to justice for the crimes he has committed towards Etheria. Besides, he publicly admitted to murdering the Queen of Musicia! How could Lexie want someone like that under her roof?!"

"It's Shiri. She still harbors feelings for him and is showing him mercy and favor despite what he has done. He has her wrapped around his finger," Glimmer said, equally upset.

"I don't think it's that. There's more to this that we don't know about. We shouldn't jump to conclusions," Bow argued, Catra nodding in agreement.

"Ugh! Why did they have to go?! It would be so much easier if we could just ask her what her motives are!" Adora yelled, slamming her fists against the table.

"We shouldn't question her motives, just accept them. Their kingdom is the one that has been hurt the most by him, it's only fair that they are allowed to gain custody and do what they deem necessary to find peace from this," Catra soothed her wife softly.

“She’s working through her pain,” Perfuma piped up, causing the table to look at her. “Shiri and I have worked through some guided meditation for her pain and anger towards her mother’s death. One way to do this is to confront those who have wronged you and forgive them. Most of you know this process, we’ve gone through it together as well. I can only assume that Shiri and her family are working through their pain and trying to accept this loss by forgiving the person who caused it. I think we should allow them to take custody.”

“I second my wife. If this is what it takes for them to find peace in their situation, I support them one hundred percent!” Scorpia said, taking Perfuma’s hand in her claw.

“I’m in favor of whatever keeps him away from my daughter,” Mermista said with a bored expression.

“I know Frosta would agree with this as well, seeing as Eira is their family and would want them to do whatever they need to do,” Bow piped in, causing his wife to frown.

“It seems that the majority wants to surrender him over to Musicia. Fine. We will send him tomorrow. But I will be discussing this with them at the music festival in a couple of weeks! Meeting adjourned,” Glimmer told them, most of the princesses getting up to chat amongst themselves or leave the room. Catra turned her attention to Glimmer, giving her a pat on the shoulder.

“How is Archer doing?” she asked softly and Glimmer and Bow gave her grimaces.

“He’s sulking. Halina is not answering her com-pad or his letters and he’s being turned away at the gate of the palace. How about Finn?” Bow asked, seeing a wince on the older magicats face as Adora wrapped an arm around Catra.

“They’re miserable. The grief rolls off them in waves and they’re refusing to eat. Shiri also refuses to answer them but they haven’t tried as hard, wanting to give her space. This whole thing was

stupid! We should have never allowed them to do this!" Catra hissed, wrapping her arms around herself, pulling away slightly from Adora, who frowned.

"They suggested it. They wanted to help the investigation…"

"They wanted to see Shiri again! They have been in love with her since they were a kid! We should not have allowed this! My kitten is grieving over their mate! This is not like Archer who is just sulking cause a girl won't call him back, these two are bonded! They were getting married! This is hitting them really hard and I'm worried I'm going to lose them!"

Glimmer took Catra's hand, squeezing it lightly. "Shiri can't stay mad forever. Neither can Halina. They will come around when they have calmed down. Hopefully, they can start talking again at the music festival. Everyone is invited to that and the royal family has to be involved. Encourage Finn to speak with her then, as we will Archer."

"What if she can though? She is Lexie's daughter and Lexie is known to hold a grudge. Remember when you two got into that fight?" Glimmer winced at Catra's words, nodding in shame at the memory.

"Seems like we're in another one now… Aren't we too old for this?"

"She's protecting her family the only way she knows how. We would all do the same if we were in her position," Adora said softly, causing the group to fall silent.

"We should have been there for them…" Bow whispered. "They were our friends… we lost one of our best friends and we weren't there for them… I would be pissed too."

"Shiri took on the responsibility of her family for six months while Lexie grieved. She had little to no help. Why didn't we help her? Why didn't we help them?" Catra growled softly.

“We thought that space was what they needed… especially after Shiri lashed out at me the way she did…” Adora said.

“We took her lashing out at you as she lashing out at all of us. She was just a scared child who lost her mom… as I did… Oh, gods, we’re horrible friends. And aunts and uncles. No wonder she felt like she had to do all those awful things. I hope we can fix this…” Glimmer murmured, putting her head in her hands.

Chapter End Notes

Hi guys! Sorry for the filler! This was going to have the music festival attached to it, but I felt like it deserved a chapter on its own! Keep an eye open for that chapter! We are still far from done with this!

What do you think about them wanting to rehabilitate and integrate Alejandro back into society?

As always, please kudos and comment!! :)

Chapter 24

Chapter Summary

Shiri talks with Alejandro; The Music Festival is in full swings; Halina and Shiri both talk with Archer and Finn

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 24

Alejandro was the last thing she expected to run into in the garden when she decided to take her afternoon stroll. It should not have been a surprise, Shiri was the one to insist that they take him in and work on rehabilitating him but it had been a couple of weeks since he arrived and she had managed to avoid him for the most part. He was harmless now but she still feared him, still felt rage inside her when she heard his name. She knew her family had been feeling the same way but that her mom was taking steps in trying to forgive him for ripping their family apart.

He looked so peaceful, sitting on a bench hidden amongst the lavender flowers, eyes closed and enjoying the breeze through his blonde locks. It was the most peaceful she had ever seen him, at least. He did not look like the domineering gang leader she had grown to know and fearfully respect. He didn't' look like the little broken boy whose dreams had been crushed the day he found out he wasn't being adopted. He looked like a whole new person, someone who was neither of the people he used to be. This is why she could not stop staring at this transformed person before her, not even noticing him crack open an eye to watch her, the eye that had a scar running over it.

"You can come to sit, Princess Shiri," he mumbled softly, causing her to flinch out of her reverie and shake her head. She did, however, move closer to him, going to lean against a tree not too far from his position. She had started gaining weight from the

pregnancy and had opted to wear looser dresses to accommodate the gain and to hide the swell of her stomach. She did not need all of Etheria knowing her condition. She had also started wearing silk gloves over her hands and wrists, hiding the ugly scars that marred them as well as a silk eye patch over the Runestone of Protection.

They stared at each other silently, both taking the other in as Shiri wrapped her arms around her self consciously. His grey eyes were still as piercing as before but there was a softness there she had never seen, a curiosity as he raked his eyes over her before clasping his hands together in front of him.

"I remember you," he said softly, causing her to snap her head towards him in disbelief. "I don't remember much… I remember you saying that most don't survive when you are done before everything went dark…"

Shiri breathed out a soft sigh of re\lief when she realized he was talking about Princess Sonata and not actually her. She sent him a smirk, raising an eyebrow towards him.

"That wasn't me. I have a very special set of powers. You were talking to someone else who happened to be using my body," she explained and he knit his eyebrows in confusion but said nothing more, twiddling his thumbs nervously.

"I know you all hate me but I can't recall why. It seems I did some bad things before…"

She nodded, going to slide down the trunk of the tree until she was sitting by its roots. "You hurt people. Especially, my family, you hurt them the worst. I'm sure you have talked with my mom, Queen Lexie?"

"Yes… she slapped me when she entered the room. Did I deserve it? And then she cried a lot. I took someone important away from you all?"

“My mama, Queen Calliope. You told us before I ate your memories that you were responsible for her death. This means you’re also responsible for my sister having half her hearing and my baby brother being completely deaf. You’re also responsible for my eye, my wrists, and all the emotional scars you can’t see.”

“Oh…” he breathed softly, looking ashamed and regretful. “I don’t remember any of this. But I am sorry, for everything I did. I know that doesn’t bring your mama back or restore any hearing or heal scars but it’s all I got. If I hurt everyone so badly, why am I walking free? Why haven’t I been punished yet?”

Why hadn’t he been punished yet? Why hadn’t she allowed him to be thrown in a dungeon to rot away or be exiled to a Beast Island or an inhospitable planet away from Etheria? She closed her eyes, remembering the broken little boy she had seen within his memories. She felt the hurt and longing, the pain of abandonment and rejection. The mother in her, the mother she was going to be, yearned to comfort that child.

“I’m pregnant… with my first child and… I felt sorry for you. I can’t imagine growing up without someone who loved me as you did. You don’t remember it anymore, I took those memories from you, which is probably for the best. My maternal instincts are telling me to protect you. You deserve a second chance at happiness and love… even if you did horrible things. It would not give me peace or satisfaction to see you punished because you're right. It won’t change anything, it won’t heal scars and it won’t bring my mama back.”

Alejandro’s shoulders relaxed slightly, a small smile gracing his features and he looked handsome when he genuinely smiled.

“But don’t take our mercy for granted. And don’t cross our paths too much. We are still learning to forgive you and that won’t happen overnight. Use your second chance to do better and be better than who you were.”

He nodded gratefully, inhaling deeply the floral smells of the garden. "You won't regret it. I promise. I'm going to be someone you can trust. I hope to earn your friendship one day, Princess Shiri, if you will allow it."

Shiri stood back up from her spot on the ground, going to dust off the dirt from her dress before throwing him a challenging smile, her brown eye twinkling with mischief.

"I would like to see that happen, Alejandro. It would be… interesting to see how you plan to accomplish this impossible feat. Please, enjoy the garden. It was my mama's creation, after all," she told him before turning and heading back inside. Not before she saw the glint of apprehension and wonder cross his features as he reexamined the garden around him.

–

Within a few hours, the city was packed for the first day of the annual music festival. Street vendors had their wares on sale, each cafe and restaurant had delicious smells wafting out of their open doors and every available space was either covered in flowers or had a musical instrument placed there. But unlike most years, the royal family opted out of exploring the city before the opening ceremony, choosing to take their seats above the Dias instead to avoid interacting with others.

The kingdoms and citizens gathered around the marble dias that had been the epicenter for major events held in the city throughout the years, it was already decorated with fairy lights, the band setting up for the performance. In the center stood a statue of Queen Calliope made out of bronze and decorated with flowers. It had been commissioned by the citizens as a gift to the royal family and was the centerpiece for the opening ceremony.

Shiri squealed and waved as Eira and Frosta made their way over to them, the only kingdom who was exempt from their wrath thus far, Eira cradling the baby close to her chest. Shiri made her way

down to them with a bounce in her step, hugging Frosta happily before kissing Eira's cheeks, not wanting to crush the baby.

"I'm so glad you guys could make it! How is my newest cousin?" she cooed down at the infant boy, who gurgled up at her with dark blue hair and large gray eyes. The perfect mixture of his two moms.

"He is absolutely perfect. Shiri, this is Bylur. Bylur, this is your cousin, Shiri. She saved our lives," Eira smiled and Shiri leaned forward, kissing Bylur on the head gently.

"We are forever grateful to you, Shiri. You saved her life and our son's life. No matter what happens, the kingdom of Snows is always by your side," Frost told her, wrapping her arm around her wife's waist and pulling her family close.

"I appreciate that tremendously, Aunt Frosta. Please, enjoy the festival. I will catch up with you guys later for dinner? I need some more baby time with this cutie," she said the last part towards him in a baby voice, causing him to gurgle happily as the couple said their goodbyes and made their way to their seats.

Shiri started heading back towards her family but her eye caught a familiar mane of blonde that drew her attention. Their eyes met across the Dias, her brown eye locking with intense blue ones and the world melting around them. Finn looked tired, bags clear under their eyes, their ears flat against their skull and tail limp behind them. They only perked up when they locked eyes with her, tail twitching with anticipation.

Shiri looked healthier, Finn noted as they watched her. She looked like she had put on some weight from what they could see on her face and arms. She was wearing a loose blue dress, the traditional Musicia colors they were obligated to wear to every formal event but instead of a tiara, she wore a crown of flowers atop of her head. She was glowing, she looked radiant and, for a moment, they even thought they could see a flicker of longing in her brown eye before she turned away, heading back up the stairs.

“She looks healthier,” Catra commented, wrapping an arm around Finn’s shoulders to comfort them. Finn nodded, leaning into their mama. “Chubbier… and glowing…”

“She seems happier and that’s all that matters,” they mumbled as Catra scented them gently.

“Just talk to her later when she has a moment. I’m sure she is ready to talk, now that she has had a few weeks to calm down,” Catra encouraged, turning her attention back to the dias as the murmur of the crowd died down.

To everyone’s surprise, Alejandro stepped forward to the center of the dias, standing in front of the statue of Calliope before bowing respectfully. When he raised off his knee, he stepped forward, lighting the incense sticks that were stationed at the feet of the statue before turning to face the crowd. The music started playing, a soft stringed instrument that played the tune for about forty seconds before he started singing.

Leaves from the vine

Falling so slow

Like fragile tiny shells

Drifting in the foam

Little soldier girl

Come marching home

Brave soldier girl

Come marching home

These leaves did fall

From branches overgrown

Drifting slowly down

Resting all alone

Little soldier girl

Taken from a home

Forced to fight a war

That is not her own

Leaves from the vine

Falling so slow

Like fragile tiny shells

Drifting in the foam

Little soldier girl

Come marching home

Brave soldier girl

Come marching, come marching-

Come marching, Come marching home

Everyone was silent as the song came to an end, speechless from the touching performance they had witnessed until Lexie stood from her throne, tears dripping down her cheeks as she clapped.

The rest of the royal family followed her lead and then, the entire city was standing to clap and cheer for the performance. Alejandro blinked at the praise before giving a hesitant bow and exiting the stage. Lexie stepped forward to the microphone, wiping her cheeks.

"Good Afternoon, and welcome to the 28th Annual Music Festival. Can we give another round of applause to that performance?" she said and the crowd cheered again for a moment before settling back down. "That was the most touching performance I have witnessed in my years overseeing this festival. It does not make up for the heartache and pain we have suffered but your tribute to my late wife touches my heart. I just want to take a moment to welcome everyone here today, especially each royal family from the different kingdoms of Etheria. I just want to leave you with a few words of encouragement and a big announcement before you leave to enjoy the rest of the festivities."

The crowd settled back into their seats, their attention solely focused on the Queen in front of them as she took a deep breath.

"It has been a hard few years for our kingdom since the passing of Queen Calliope and while she is sorely missed every day, I know she is watching over us and is happy to see music radiating throughout her kingdom. I am announcing that this will be my last year overseeing the festival," she said and a shocked murmur rumbled through the crowd. She raised her hand to gather the crowd's attention again before continuing. "Don't worry, you will still see me enjoying the festival. No, I am proud and honored to announce that in one month's time, we will be celebrating Princess Shiri's coronation as Queen of Musicia! I will be retiring to continue my life's work at the orphanage. So please, feel free to encourage her over the next few days when you see her around the city and, as always, enjoy the festival!"

—

"Shiri! Shiri!" she heard a voice behind her as she started walking down the steps of the dias to the city and turned to see Queen

Glimmer teleporting to her, landing beside her with a tight smile on her face. Shiri straightened, Halina automatically tensing beside her as she grabbed her hand.

“Oh, Queen Glimmer. It is a pleasure to see you, as always,” Shiri said in her most diplomatic voice and smile. “What can I do for you?”

“I was just wondering how Alejandro was settling in?” she questioned with a raised eyebrow. Shiri pursed her lips, considering her response carefully.

“He is settling in well. It has been an adjustment period for everyone.”

Glimmer made a thoughtful noise, causing Shiri to rain an eyebrow at her before crossing her arms over her chest defensively.

“Is there something you would like to say, Queen Glimmer?”

“I was just wondering why you would put your family through something so painful when you could have allowed Brightmoon to handle the situation and enact swift punishment for his crimes.”

“Are you questioning the decision of the Heart of Etheria?” Shiri’s eye flashed, causing Glimmer to take a step back with her hands up in surrender.

“Of course not. I would never question its decisions… or yours…”

“Hmm… good. If you would excuse me, I have another performance to attend,” Shiri told her, nodding her head respectfully towards Glimmer before descending the stairs completely, Halina close behind her. They made it to the bottom of the stairs before they heard Glimmer hiss softly at someone and footsteps descend the stairs towards them. Halina turned around, sucking in a breath as Archer stopped at the last step, looking at her desperately.

“I’m going to step away for a moment…” Shiri told Halina, who shook her head, glaring at Archer.

“No. Whatever he has to say can be said to the both of us,” she said, crossing her arms over her chest. “Speak.”

“Hallie… I miss you. I miss your smile and your laugh. I miss our talks and your passion for the things you love like your family and your books. Mistakes were made, I admit and I am sorry that we got caught in the crosshairs of these mistakes but I promise you that what we have is genuine and I did not come here to mislead you ever.”

“Are you saying what my sister and Finn had wasn’t genuine?” Halina asked with a raised eyebrow, causing Archer to vigorously shake his head.

“No, of course not! I’m sure what they had was genuine. This isn’t even about them, it’s about us!”

“No, this is about them. You were involved with the plan to use my sister to gain information on a deadly gang without consulting her. As far as I am concerned, you are directly involved in everything that has happened to us since our first meeting and now, my sister is hurt because of you and everyone else.”

“What happened between her and Finn should not affect our relationship! I did nothing wrong to you! You shouldn’t sacrifice your own happiness, our relationship because of what happened between them!”

“Sacrifice?” Halina let out an emotionless laugh, taking a step back.

I know my sister like I know my own mind

You will never find anyone as trusting or as kind

I love my sister more than anything in this life

I will choose her happiness over mine

Every time!

Shiri is the best thing in my life

For the rest of my life

Every sacrifice I make is for my sister

To give her the best life

Shiri choked back a small sob at Halina's song, going over to hug her baby sister tightly to her. Halina hugged her back just as tightly, rubbing her back.

"I pick you, every time. Boys come and go but sisters are forever!"

"What did I ever do to deserve a sister like you? You don't have to sacrifice your happiness for mine. You deserve to be happy too."

"Not until you're happy. When you're happy, I will be happy. You hear that, Archer?" Halina turned back to him. "Until my sister is happy, I can't be with you. Which means you're responsible for her happiness as well. Now, if you'll excuse us, my sister has a performance to attend to," Halina finished, looping her arm with Shiri's and dragging her away. Archer watched after them, crestfallen.

"That didn't look pretty," Shimmer commented as she stepped up beside her brother, Finn standing by her side, silent.

"She's still pissed. Look at that!" Archer said angrily, gesturing over to where Halina and Shiri stopped to talk with Alejandro, both of them smiling as he blushed and rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly. Finn growled, tail swishing violently behind them and Shimmer squinted her eyes, letting out a loud cackle.

"Oh, gods! Do you guys not see the irony in this? They left literal princes for a former gang member! Oh gods, you guys really

fucked up if they are more excited to see him than you!" She cackled louder, hunching over in pain at her laughter. Finn and Archer glared at her, Archer taking to putting her in a headlock and rubbing his knuckles into her skull. She squealed, teleporting out of his arms and to her mother's side.

"She's right though… it's a bad day when my ex-fiance chooses her abuser over me…" Finn mumbled, watching as Shiri and Halina took up either side of Alejandro, taking his arms and allowing him to escort them down the street.

"We're going to win them back. Maybe Shiri will be easier to talk to than Hallie. Give it shot after her performance?" Archer encouraged, Finn, nodding apprehensively before they made their way down the street as well.

_

Shiri wrung her hands nervously backstage, pacing back and forth. Seeing Finn had thrown her off her game, her heart had skipped a beat when they locked eyes. They looked so sad, so tired and Shiri wanted nothing more to comfort them, take them into her arms and forgive them of everything that has happened. But then she remembers the lies, the deceit, and her blood boils and she wants nothing more than to punch them in the nose.

"Song, we're about to go on. What's wrong?" Lexie asked, standing in her daughter's path to stop her pacing. Shiri stopped, looking up at her mom sadly before wrapping her arms around herself.

"Finn… I miss them…" Lexie sighed at the admission, pulling her into her arms.

"That's okay. You're allowed to miss them. You love them and you're pregnant with their child. Do you want to talk with them? Clear the air? Forgive?"

"I… I don't think I'm ready to forgive yet. I don't even know if I'm ready to talk to them. It still hurts, their betrayal. I feel it deeply

in my heart and I don't know if I will ever be able to forgive them…" Shiri admitted, playing with her fingers.

"That's okay. You don't have to forgive them immediately. You can take as much time as you need. Did I ever tell you about the time I said something horrible to your mama while she was pregnant with you? She was so mad that she did not talk to me for almost six months."

Shiri's eyes widened in disbelief. "Six months?! You must have really pissed her off!"

"I said something horrible to her and it took her a while to forgive me. I didn't deserve the forgiveness but we had decided that you two and her health were more important than any fight we were having. So don't rush it, okay?"

Shiri nodded, both of them hearing the cue to enter the stage. Both stepped out onto the stage, a single grand piano taking up one side with Zimri sitting at it. Lexie hung back as Shiri stepped forward to one of two microphones that graced the middle of the stage. She met Finn's gaze, their eyes locking against for the second time that day, trying to silently communicate with the other.

She broke the gaze first, turning back over to meet eyes with Zimri. He nodded in silent confirmation before turning back to the piano, fingers starting to dance over the keys as the soft melody started playing and the crowd went silent. Shiri closed her eyes, crossing her arms over her chest as she started to sing.

I dreamed a dream in time gone by

When hope was high and life worth living

I dreamed that love would never die

I dreamed that God would be forgiving

Then I was young and unafraid

And dreams were made and used and wasted

There was no ransom to be paid

No song unsung, no wine untasted

Lexie stepped forward to the other unused microphone, face solemn as she looked out over the crowd. Shiri opened her eyes, looking at her mom as she started the next stanza.

[Lexie & (Shiri)]

But the tigers come at night (But the tigers come at night)

With their voices soft as thunder

As they tear your hope apart (As they tear your hope apart)

As they turn your dream to shame... (To shame...)

Shiri locked eyes with Finn, tears starting to pool in her eyes as she felt the emotions of everything that had happened over the past few months bubble to the surface of her song, to the forefront of her mind. She was singing her grief, her pain, her longing, her hope into her song.

And still I dream they"ll come to me

That we will live the years together

But there are dreams that cannot be

And there are storms we cannot weather

[Lexie & Shiri]

I had a dream my life would be

So different from this hell I'm living

So different now from what it seemed

Now life has killed the dream I dreamed

Shiri was holding back sobs by the end of the song, her whole body trembling with the weight of her emotions as Lexie wrapped her arms around her daughter's shoulders, squeezing her to her side as the crowd clapped and cheered. She met Finn's eyes again, concern lacing their features. She couldn't take it. She pulled away from her mom, giving a quick bow before exiting the stage, hand over her mouth as soft sobs escaped her lips.

She was hyperventilating by the time she got out of view, tears spilling down her cheeks. She pressed her hands to her heart, it beating erratically in her chest, trying to quell her sobs. Hands landed on her arms and she flinched back softly, looking up through her tears to see Finn watching her, ears pressed flat against their skull and small whimpers escaping their lips. She surged forward, wrapping her arms around them, and proceeded to sob into their chest.

Finn hesitated, surprised but wrapped their arms around her, holding her close. They pressed their face against the top of her head, inhaling her familiar, slightly sweeter scent that they had missed so much. They had missed her, everything about her and they didn't mind that she was currently soaking their shirt with her tears. They were just happy to have her back in their arms again.

They stood like that for a long time. It could have been minutes, it could have been hours, neither cared as they enjoyed the feel of the other. Shiri didn't realize this is what she had been craving above all else over the last few weeks. The feel of their arms around her, comforting her and loving her like they always had.

"I'm so sorry…" Finn whispered softly into her hair after a while, planting a soft kiss there. Shiri pulled away slowly, keeping her

arms wrapped around their back so she could look up at them, sniffling. They wiped the tears away with one hand, refusing to release her with their other as it remained wrapped around her waist. Their tail was also wrapped around her arm, clinging to her desperately. “I missed you.”

“I’ve missed you too… so much…” she admitted as well, placing her hand over theirs as it cupped her cheek.

“Please come back… please forgive me. We can start over, do better… I don’t want to lose you…” they whispered, pressing their forehead to hers. She closed her eyes, basking in the closeness. She really missed this. She really wanted this. But…

“I can’t…” she whispered, pulling away. Finn tried to pull her back, desperately wanting to keep the contact between them but she moved out of their grasp, wrapping her arms around herself.

“Why? Why can’t we work through this?” they begged. “You miss me and I miss you. I want you in my life, I want to spend the rest of it with you. Why can’t you stay?”

“Because it would be a lie. I’m still hurt, the betrayal is still fresh and my heart hurts every time I think about it. I’m not ready to forgive you or be with you yet…”

“When will you be?” they asked, tail drooping low. She paused, considering her response.

“I don’t know… There is so much happening now, so many changes… I will understand if you’re not willing to wait for me. I want you to live your life to the fullest, you still have dreams to fulfill, right?” she sniffled and they shook their head.

“There will never be anyone like you. And my dreams aren’t worth living without you by my side. You’re my dream…”

“And you were mine… but I’m learning that I need to figure myself out first before I can properly love someone else. I hated

myself for so long… who I was, what I did… You deserve so much better. I am… willing to be friends?”

“Friends… after everything we’ve been through together, I only get to be your friend?” Finn’s fur bristled in indigitation and Shiri sighed.

“I’m sorry…”

“No… No, I’m sorry. I’m sorry that I broke your trust and hurt you but I was trying to protect you and Etheria. I regret hurting you but I don’t regret what I did trying to protect you. And I’m not going to allow you to make me feel bad anymore for it. Take all the time you need but don’t expect for me to still be there when you get it together,” Finn said, sighing heavily before turning and leaving. Shiri watched them go, arms wrapped around herself as she watched the love of her life disappear around the corner.

Chapter End Notes

Song Creds: Leaves from the Vine by Nathan Nix (from Avatar the Last Airbender)
Congratulations from Hamilton the Musical
I Dreamed a Dream cover by Glee (From Les Miserables)

Be sure to Kudos and Comment!

Chapter 25

Chapter Summary

Finn reveals their plans; the Musicia Royal family receiving some new information

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 25

Finn's sulking was different this time. Unlike before, when they were sulking and grieving over the loss of their mate, this time they were sulking at the latest encounter with her. They still missed her, they still loved her dearly, but they refused to hang around and watch her get on with her life as they stood by as just a friend. The fact that she would even offer that made their fur stand on edge every time they thought about it. It caused irritation to course through them and on more than one occasion, they had snapped at the people around them: their moms, their little sister, their friends.

It had been a couple of weeks since the encounter at the music festival and Finn, no matter how hard they tried, could not push these feelings away. They were conflicted with respecting her decision or cutting her off completely. They did not know what else could be done to remedy the situation. They had apologized, they had begged, they had tried to communicate with her, they had given her space, and for what? For them to just be friends? After everything?

Finn was playing with their food at the dinner table that evening, rolling the peas around on the plate with their claw as everyone ate and chattered quietly around them. They knew better than to try to engage them in conversation after the last time they

snapped. They were contemplating a future without Shiri, a life where they lived for only themselves and fulfilling their dreams of travel when the dining room doors opened and a guard stepped in, carrying two envelopes that they proceeded to hand to Glimmer and Adora.

Both women looked at the envelopes, recognizing the familiar writing before opening them and reading the contents inside. Nala, who was sitting beside Adora, leaned over to peek at the words written inside the invitation before a wide smile graced her features.

"It's an invitation to Shiri's Coronation! Oh, mom, are we going?!" the young magicat asked excitedly, tail swishing around. Adora gave her daughter a fond smile, ruffling her mane affectionately.

"Of course we are going. I am obligated to attend as She-Ra but I know Shiri would love to have you there."

"Because she's my best friend! I can't wait to see her again! Why don't we get to see her anymore?" Nala pouted, causing Finn to roll their eyes as Archer made an awkward noise at the back of their throat.

"In any case, we all have to attend. They need the younger royals for the ceremony. Shimmer, you will be accepting the new queen of Musicia on behalf of Brightmoon," Glimmer told her, ignoring the tension that had settled at the table.

"Will you be asking her about their stance with the Princess Alliance since it will be a new queen you have to form a treaty with?" Shimmer asked, raising an eyebrow in question.

"Of course. We both will try to smooth the tense relationship Musicia and Brightmoon share at the moment. Forming a new treaty with the new queen will be the right step forward," Glimmer said, sitting the invitation down to go back to her dinner.

"Do I have to attend?" Finn asked, drumming their claws against the table in agitation. Catra and Adora shared a look before Adora

cleared her throat.

“Well… it would be rude if you did not attend, seeing as you are a part of this family… but I also understand your desire to… not see her again. I will not force you to go but I do ask you to consider the implications of you missing it first,” Adora informed them in her most diplomatic voice. Catra rolled her eyes, leaning over to look at Finn.

“No one will blame you if you are uncomfortable going. No one expects you to attend and that is completely your choice.”

“Good… I was planning on leaving the planet for a while anyway,” Finn informed the table, finally taking a bite of their food as everyone froze, giving them a confused look.

“Oh?” Adora said, frowning. “When did you come to this decision?”

“Just now. I need… space,” they sighed, sitting their utensil back down. “She told me to fulfill my dreams right before she told me she just wanted to be friends… it hurts and I need to get away for a while. Now would be the perfect opportunity to go explore the universe, learn new cultures, have an adventure. If she doesn’t want me around, I will make sure I am not around to be found,” they said, explaining their logic behind the decision.

“Well… I think it is a great idea,” Catra said, causing Adora to jerk her head to her wife. “They’re right. They need space and now is the best time to fulfill what they always wanted to do which is to travel. I do, however, ask that you wait till after the coronation to travel. At least inform her of your intentions to leave so that she is not surprised.”

“They’re not obligated to tell her anything. If they want to disappear for a while, they should be allowed to,” Glimmer piped up with a frown.

“Are you asking for a meltdown? I am saving us all the trouble of Shiri being blindsided and going nuclear on Etheria. You guys had

such a close relationship, I believe it is only right that you let her know."

"Like she let me know that she would be accepting the position of queen and having a coronation within two months of us breaking up? I don't owe her an explanation but if it will make you feel better, I will let her know at the coronation that I will be leaving. May I be excused?" Finn asked, standing up before anyone said anything else and exiting the dining room, losing their appetite and already planning out their travels in their head.

—

"The coronation is going to be so beautiful! I remember your mama and mines. It had also been our wedding day. She looked absolutely stunning!" Lexie was gushing as Shiri slumped in a chair, the seamstress pulling out different dresses for her to try on but none of them felt right. She didn't want just any dress to wear to her coronation, it had to be perfect and none of these dresses screamed perfection to her.

"Shiri? Are you even listening to me?" Lexie chided, pulling Shiri out of her trance as she straightened in her chair, her hand moving to caress her baby belly. It wasn't too big, she was only about three months along, but it was larger than a normal three-month pregnant belly. It had prompted her to do some research on magicat pregnancies. Come to find out, they were only pregnant for six months instead of nine, which explained her rapid growth. It also put her on edge, since she now had less time preparing herself and was already about halfway through.

She had started feeling the tiny kicks a week ago and they had sent her heart aching with grief at the thought that Finn was not experiencing this with her. They could… if she was not so damn stubborn. She knew she needed time to heal and forgive but time seemed to not be on her side currently as she felt her child flutter against her. She knew she should tell Finn but that meant seeing more of them than she was ready to see. She was stuck between her and her child's needs.

“I’m sorry, mom. I’m tired and none of these dresses scream “Queen” to me. Can we take a break? Have tea?” Shiri asked and Lexie nodded, shooing the seamstress away and informing the maid it was time for afternoon tea. Shiri stood, stretching slowly, hearing the satisfying pop of her joints as she made her way over to the table. She had also noticed that along with an accelerated pregnancy, she was showing magicat symptoms as well. Lounging, stretching, long naps in the sun, a craving for fish, and sharper instincts. She couldn’t produce the exact sounds that Finn and his family could make but she would sometimes find herself attempting to purr or hiss. She tried her best with the purring though, because she noticed that it settled her little one when they felt the rumbling in her chest.

“What’s wrong with the dresses? They were all very beautiful,” Lexie said, settling down across from her. The maid scurried back in with a cart carrying the tea set and trays of food, Halina skipping along behind her as she snagged an apple tart from the cart.

“I heard it was tea time! How’s the dress picking going?” she asked, taking a seat in between the two women as the maid set everything out on the table before them.

“None of them feel right. And I know I need to pick something because we’re a week away and I’ve been putting it off but they don’t feel right,” Shiri said, picking up one of the apple tarts as well.

“I mean, what are you looking for? Maybe we can narrow it down that way. I’m sure you want something looser to conceal the baby bump but do you have any idea on neckline? Waistline? Hem? Sparkly or lacey or plain? And color, I know you can probably only pick like blue, white, gold, or silver but there are some nice dresses in those color schemes,” Halina said, pouring everyone’s tea.

“I don’t know! This is so frustrating! I don’t know what I want!” Shiri exclaimed, slouching back down in her seat as she ate her

tart. Lexie gave her a smile, sitting down her teacup before standing up.

"You know… I think I have the perfect dress," she said, going into the walking closet and disappearing for a few minutes. Halina and Shiri both crane their necks to see what she is doing and she comes back out with a large garment back, hanging up on the rack and unzipping it. Shiri stood, gasping at the white garment that tumbled out of the bag.

"That's mama's wedding dress…" Halina said in awe, standing as well to go over and examine it. It was even more beautiful in person than they had seen in their official portraits with a sweetheart neckline, off-the-shoulder sleeves made of three strands of pearls, a fitted bodice that flared into a ballroom skirt. It had a beautiful lace pattern, it was elegant and gorgeous.

"Oh mom… no, I can't wear mama's dress! It's too beautiful and I don't want to ruin it!" Shiri said, running her fingers over the lace.

"Your mama would want you to wear her dress. Why else would we keep it? I had hoped it would be your very own wedding dress but I think you will look every bit the queen you are in it. And we can have it adjusted to conceal the baby bump, maybe move the waist line up to an empire waist?" Lexie suggested, smiling.

"That sounds… perfect. It's perfect! Thank you!" Shiri squealed, jumping up and hugging her mom. Lexie hugged her back, squeezing her tightly.

"You're going to look beautiful. I think there's one more thing to complete the look. Julie?" Lexie called, the maid running over to her. "Can you go get the box that contains the Musicia Crown?" she nodded, running out of the room.

"Your mama, after our last official portrait, locked away this crown until the day you were to be crowned queen. She told me not to open it until you were ready and to only allow you to open it a few days before the ceremony. I think there is something in there

only you are allowed to see," Lexie told her, Halina bouncing on the balls of her feet in excitement.

"Oooh, this is so exciting! I wonder what mama left for you!" Halina squealed. Shiri went to go sit back at her seat, picking up her teacup and taking a sip.

"I'm sure it's nothing… unless it's something? What would mama leave me?" Shiri asked nervously, the other two sitting with her.

"Whatever it is, she left it with love," Lexie said, taking a sip of her tea as well. Julia returned with a large box, sitting it down on the table in front of Shiri before stepping away. Shiri sat down her cup, taking a deep breath as she stood towering over the box. She lifted the lid, setting it down in her seat and looking down into the box. The crown of Musica sat nestled on a cushion in the box, gleaming brilliantly under the lights and an envelope sat inside of it. She picked it up, seeing the familiar scrawl of her mother's handwriting on the front.

"Open it!" Halina encouraged, leaning forward in her seat. Shiri looked at her mom, who gave her an encouraging nod. Shiri took a deep breath before opening the envelope and pulling out the note, reading over it.

My Song,

If you are reading this note, that means the time has come for you to be crowned Queen of Musicia. It also means that I am gone and will not be able to stay by you on your big day. For further explanation, I have left you a hologram to view because I will not be able to explain anything well within a few pages. The chip is in the envelope, view it as you please.

With love, mama

Shiri pulled a small chip out of the envelope, holding it out in front of her as she stared at it. Her mama's last words were on this chip, the last thing she ever wanted to tell her was here. Shiri was

not there the night her mama died, she did not get closure for her death. This was her closure.

"What did it say?" Lexie asked nervously, staring at the chip.

"She felt a hologram for me to view… She wanted to explain why she would not be there for my coronation… she knew," Shiri said, sinking back down into her seat.

"She knew?! What do you mean she knew?!" Lexie exclaimed, taking the note from Shiri and reading over it.

"Mama knew? That doesn't make any sense…" Halina mumbled, fiddling with the tablecloth.

"We have to watch the hologram," Lexie concluded after reading the note, disbelief on her face.

–

After summoning Marmoris and Zimri, the entire family gathered in Lexie's sitting room, where she had set up the projector, an invention of Entrapta's. Marmoris and Zimri were both confused about the summoning but after a brief explanation from Halina, both took a seat on either side of Lexie, giving her silent support as Shiri inserted the hologram chip. She started it, going to sit in between Zimri and Halina as she gripped both of their hands.

It took a moment but then the image of Calliope popped up in the middle of the room. She had her brows furrowed and her tongue sticking out in concentration as she seemed to fiddle with something everyone couldn't see. Her stomach was round and large, pregnant with Nicaise. Lexie gasped, putting a hand over her mouth as tears shined in her arms.

" *Honey, do you need any help?* They heard their mom from the distance as Calliope laughed, shaking her head.

"No! I think I got it! I won't be long, I promise," Calliope said, turning to her back to the group on the couch for a moment.

"I remember that day… She hid this from me, I thought she was just recording something from a Princess Alliance meeting," their mom said sadly.

"Okay! Do you need anything before I go? I was heading over to the orphanage to help Scorpia today," Lexie said, appearing in the frame for a moment and wrapping her arms around Calliope.

"Stop worrying so much about me! Go help Scorpia, we'll be fine here. This isn't my first go around, you know," Calliope teased, leaning up to kiss her wife gently. Lexie kissed her back with a soft hum.

"You know I can't help but worry. The first two were so hard on you…" Calliope waved her off with a smile, giving her one more small peck before stepping away.

"We'll be fine! This won't take long and then I plan on taking a very long nap. Go enjoy your day with the kids."

Lexie sighed before kneeling down to kiss Calliope's belly softly. *"You be nice to mommy, okay? I love you both, I'll be home in a few hours,"* she said, getting back up and pecking Calliope gently before walking out of frame. The group listened, hearing the door close softly before watching Calliope sag, going to slump into a chair and putting her head in her hands.

Their mom let out a low whine as they watched the scene unfold. After a moment of silence, Calliope lifted her head back up, looking directly at them. Gone was the smile she had graced earlier, replaced by a grimace, looking older than she had in a while. She ran her hand through her hair, pulling it back away from her face with a sigh.

"Shiri… if you are watching this, it means that you are to be coronated as queen soon… it also means I am gone…" Calliope let out a soft sob, tears already spilling down her cheeks as she stared forward as if she could see her family before her. *"You're probably wondering why you are watching this… I've known for*

years that I would not live to see you become the queen you were always meant to be… I have a lot to explain…"

Calliope took another deep breath, straightening herself in her seat and allowing her hands to collapse in her lap. *"After the war, I was called to the Heart of Etheria by my mother, the previous queen of Musicia. I had no idea how to be a princess, about our history, our people, or our culture. I went wanting to learn everything I could to help us rebuild. Afterward, I asked her to tell me something about my future. She warned me about knowing the future, that it would only bring heartbreak… I didn't listen, I just wanted to know. That is when she told me that I would not live to see my eldest daughter be crowned as queen.*

I carried that knowledge around for years. I told some of the Princess Alliance the night before my own wedding/coronation after I had awoken from a nightmare. I begged them not to tell your mom, I didn't want her to worry… I thought I had more time, imagine my surprise when I became pregnant within six months of the ceremony. And then I found out I was having a girl and a boy… Don't get me wrong, my song, I love you dearly and I would not change a single thing about the life we have spent together. You and your siblings are the most precious things to me," she said as she rubbed her baby belly gently, lovingly.

"But you see your own mortality in the face of your child. Knowing one day that your children will have to bury you and praying you will never see the day where you have to bury your own child. I saw my mortality is you but… I also saw a beautiful future. I saw love and compassion. You were always a fierce child, you knew what you wanted from life and you took it in your hands. You remind me so much of your mom that way. She always knew what she wanted as well…

My song… there is not much comfort I can give you because I know you will still be grieving my loss. I make this hologram now because… I have had an impending sense of doom as of late. I have waited for the other shoe to drop most of your life, especially the older you got. When you turned seventeen and

gained your powers of the Heart… I've been holding my breath, waiting… my time is soon, I feel it and I am scared… Oh, gods… I'm so scared," Calliope let out another sob, putting her head back in her hands.

Lexie let out a sob as well, standing up as she stared at the image of her wife before her. "Why didn't you tell me?! I was right there! We could have done this together! You didn't have to be scared alone! You didn't have to do this alone!"

"Mom… she can't hear you…" Zimri said gently, taking his mom's hand and gently easing her back on the couch, wrapping his arms around her as she cried. Shiri clutched her chest, feeling guilt well within her. She was the reason her mama was dead…

"Please don't blame yourself," Shiri heard Calliope say and she looked up to see her mama staring at her as if she knew exactly where she would be. " *I am scared but I do not regret this… I do not regret you! You are the best thing in my life, you hear me? If I had to do this life over and over again, I would always choose you to be my child. If I have to die a million deaths so that you may live a life full of love and happiness, I would do so willingly and happily. That goes for all of you. Zimri, Halina, Nicaise… Lexie… If I had to live a million lifetimes, I would always choose you.*

So live, my song. Go on living and don't let anything or anyone stop you from being the best you can be. Keep loving fiercely and grab everything you want without any hesitation, without any regrets. Keep being independent and stubborn and strong-willed, like the strong woman who helped raise you. Do not let my death be for nothing. I have to die so that you may live… please live a beautiful life for me…"

Shiri's heart was pounding in her chest and she didn't feel the tears streaking down her cheeks as she watched her mama close her eyes, letting out a soft hum as she rubbed her belly as she sang softly.

Look to the stars

My darling baby boy

Life is strange and vast

Filled with wonders and joy

Face each new sun

With eyes clear and true

I'm not afraid of the unknown

Cause I'll face it all with you

Look to the stars

And gaze up at the moon

Even as these days pass

I'm always thinking of you

Face each new day

And keep your hope alive

I promise I'll be there soon

It won't be long till I'm with you

The hologram dissipated afterward, leaving everyone feeling numb and confused at the information they had received. Lexie sobbed between the boys, Zimri holding his mom as he had before when she had grieved for the love of her life. Shiri stared at the spot her mama disappeared from blankly, not hearing

anything around her. Halina tried to get her attention, shaking her sister's shoulder gently.

"She knew… she knew she was going to die… how did she manage to live every day knowing it could be her last?" Marmoris said quietly. Shiri turned her head to her brother-in-law, blinking softly.

"Her love for us was stronger than her fear of death… I understand it, now that I carry my own… I would do the same, die a thousand deaths if it meant my child could live…"

"She never wanted to hurt you, mom," Halina said, moving to kneel in front of their mom, putting her hands on her knees. "She knew you. She knew you would spend your time trying to keep her alive rather than living yourself. Mom, we miss her too. I hope I can have a love like you two shared one day."

"She was… the love of my life…" Lexie hiccuped, leaning into her son heavily. "It still hurts so much… I see her everywhere I turn… this was our home. We built a home here together but we always knew home was where the other was… this hasn't felt like my home in years since she's been gone and I need to leave…"

Shiri reached across Zimri to take her mom's hand, squeezing it. "You will. I promise. You don't have to stay here after I am crowned, you can go wherever you want. Wherever feels like home again… We love you and we support every decision you make, mom. You deserve everything and more."

"You are the strongest person we know," Zimri said, wrapping his free arm around Shiri as he looked down at Lexie. "Both physically, mentally, and emotionally. You lost so much and you keep going every day, loving others with everything you are. You are the best mom ever and we want you to be happy again. So do what you have to do, we can manage this place without you. Just don't be a stranger, please come see us every once in a while."

Lexie let out a soft laugh, sniffling as she wiped her tears away. "I was blessed with the most amazing children on Etheria. I am so proud of each and every one of you. You too, Mari, you are as much my child as my biological children are. And I will be around, I have a grandbaby to spoil but I can't stay here constantly anymore… Your mama gave me more time, there's something she needs me to do and I think that thing is to raise more children. We were orphans and then we lost a baby before we had you all… there are more children out there that need love."

"We love you, mom. We want you to be happy. I… I don't have anything I want to do here… I would love to go to the orphanage with you when you go," Halina said, looking up at her mom hopefully. Lexie nodded, smiling.

"I would love it if you would go with me. Learn how to run the orphanage so that you could take over one day?" Halina lit up, nodding eagerly at the offer.

"I'm going to miss having you sleep beside me, Hallie. The bed is going to be big and cold without you," Shiri gave a watery laugh, wiping her eyes as the tears tried to spring forward. Halina crawled over and placed her head into Shiri's lap, the older sister running her fingers through her hair.

"It's not forever. I'll still come home and sleep beside you. The bed is going to be lonely though…"

"Weekend sleepovers?" Shiri suggested.

"Always!"

Chapter End Notes

> Della's Moon Lullaby by Annapantsu (I love her songs so much! And yes, this is recycled from my one-shot; it was this or One More Moment (Ursa's Lullaby) by Reinaeiry)
>
> As always, kudos and comments!

Chapter 26

Chapter Summary

The Coronation, Shiri finds out about Finn

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 26

Musicia was buzzing with excitement the day of the coronation. If they thought the city went all out during the music festival, it was nothing compared to coronation day. The celebrations start earlier for the citizens since most can't be inside the palace during the ceremony but the entire thing is live-streamed throughout the city and the colonies of Etheria. The city was decorated to the max with flowers, jewels, and lights, music wafting happily down the streets as people were dancing and participating in various activities to celebrate Shiri's big day.

The coronation was taking place in the ballroom of the palace where the last one was held. The room was decorated in Musicia's colors, banners, and flowers decorating the room with rows of chairs lining an aisle runner down the length of the room and up towards the pedestal where the thrones normally sat. Today, only two perched center stage and the portrait of Calliope and Lexie on their wedding/coronation day sat perched on the wall behind it, smiling down at the room.

The Princess Alliance took up the first two rows of chairs, the younger royals being in the front since the elemental princesses were necessary for the ceremony. Some of them looked a little uncomfortable being there, no one has talked to the Musician royal family since the music festival or Princess Prom. It happened that Halina ended up sitting beside Shimmer with Archer behind her, making her squirm uncomfortably in her seat. Marmoris sat

on the other side of Halina, shooting her glances to see if she was okay.

As was Lexie, who stood upon the dais with the council member who would perform the ceremony. She was trying to stand tall and proud but her hands wouldn't stop shaking as she looked out at the crowd. Her eyes met Adora's briefly before turning away, lifting her head high and clasping her hands together in front of her to stop the shaking. She was still irritated about everything that had transpired during the last alliance meeting she had attended but today was not about her anger. Today was about her children.

Shiri took a deep breath from behind the double doors at the other end of the ballroom, the same doors she had come through over a month ago for the Princess Prom opening number. She knew as soon as she stepped through those doors, she would no longer be Shiri, Crown Princess of Musicia but Shiri, Queen of Musicia and Guardian of the Heart of Etheria.

She wore her mother's wedding dress, the waistline hemmed up to an empire waist, falling just under her breasts to help conceal the ever-growing child within her. She had put on a belly binder as a precaution, being careful not to tighten it too much. Her black curls had grown to her shoulders over the past few months, the white patch of hair has become more prominent after her brush with death and she had them pinned back into a small bun at the nape of her neck. A gold eyepatch covered her right eye, the Runestone of Protection and white gloves covered her hands up to her elbows, covering the scars on her wrists.

Zimri came up beside her in a matching white suit, his black locks with the white patch combed back and he flashed her a dazzling smile as he offered her his elbow. She took it gratefully, smiling back at him.

"Are you nervous?" he asked softly as they heard the music start playing. She nodded in confirmation.

“Are you?”

“Of course. But we can do this together. I got your back and you have mine, right?”

“As always. Make sure to keep smiling, okay?” she mumbled as the double doors opened and they were announced to the room. The music continued as they walked down the aisle together, arms linked. She had chosen to wear low heels but they were still hurting her swollen ankles, she was beyond grateful that her twin was keeping her upright as they walked. Zimri was smiling and nodding his head at the various visitors that were in attendance but Shiri refused to acknowledge anyone, eyes focused on the dias before her, on the two thrones.

It felt like an eternity but they finally made it to the bottom of the steps, Zimri releasing her arm but taking her hand instead to step up first and lead her up. The council member smiled at them as they made their way to the top, the both of them returning the smile as they turned to face the crowd, who had taken a seat after they made their way up the stairs.

“Distinguished guests, we are gathered here today to witness not only the end of an era but the beginning of a new, prosperous reign in Musicia. Today, I present Crown Princess Shiri and Crown Prince Zimri for the titles of Queen of Musicia and Co-Regent of Musicia. I ask if there is anyone among us who does not believe that these two are fit to rule our kingdom, to speak now,” the council member started, staring around the room for a moment. Shiri held her breath, waiting for someone to reply but no one dared to challenge them for the throne. The council member nodded in approval before proceeding.

“May you two please kneel?” they asked and Zimri took a hold of Shiri’s arm, helping her ease down into a kneeling position. It was embarrassing, her cheeks flushing pink from the extra attention and the confused looks she had vaguely noticed from the audience but she knew it would be hard for her to get down on her knees with her belly and the binder. When Zimri had her

settled down, he knelt beside her. The council member cleared their throat, giving Shiri a look as she rubbed her hands together nervously.

"My Lady, you must remove the gloves and eyepatch for this next part," they reminded her gently. She had thought it was stupid when she was told she could not wear these items during the actual crowning but something about tradition had been mentioned and her being able to see her kingdom clearly. She was self-conscious about her wrists and eyes and her family had fought for her to keep the items but the council refused to budge. She took a deep breath before slowly removing the gloves from her arms, holding them up for her mom to take. Her shaky fingers reached up and untied the eyepatch, removing it as well and handing it to her mom before she blinked the eye open, a small gasp emitting from the crowd as the blue runestone shone out.

She had seen it a couple of times in her mirror, it molded perfectly into her socket and looked just like an eye but solid blue and glowing slightly. If she focused her meditation correctly, she was able to use it to control her visions and see-through Etheria's memory bank without the inconvenience of blacking out. It was liking being able to see the present with her normal eye and everything else with the runestone. It gave her a headache sometimes.

The council member came up behind Zimri first, holding up the crown that their mom had worn all those years ago, the simple silver circlet with the failsafe insignia in front, each kingdom's runestone inlaid in each dot of the pendant.

"Prince Zimri, do you promise to uphold the values of the Kingdom of Musicia? To always serve its people and protect them with your life? To always put the kingdom before your own needs, for as long as you remain in reign?"

Zimri nodded. "I do, I promise to serve our people and our queen to the best of my abilities, for as long as I shall reign."

The council member placed the circlet onto his head, the insignia resting on top of his brow. "Then I pronounce you Co-Regent of Musicia, second only to the queen until the day she takes a spouse. May you always protect our people and find music in your life."

The crowd applauded respectfully as the council member made their way behind Shiri, taking the crown Calliope had worn- silver with the other kingdom's runestones inlaid around it, a replica of the Heart of Etheria glimmering brightly in the middle.

"Princess Shiri, I also ask of you, do you promise to uphold the values of the Kingdom of Musicia? To always serve its people and protect them with your life? To always put the kingdom before your own needs, for as long as you remain in reign?"

"I do. I promise to be a mighty and just queen, to always protect our people and envision a better future for them, for as long as I may reign," she agreed, feeling the crown settle on top of her head as the council member stepped back. Shiri held her arm out, palm extended upwards as the elemental princesses were summoned forward.

"I ask that the elemental princesses stand and step forward to accept our new queen."

They all stood, forming a line with Frosta leading the charge. Since her son was too young for any royal duties, it would be her second time accepting a new Musicia queen. She smiled as she stepped up the stairs, taking Shiri's in hers and giving her a small squeeze.

"It is such an honor to not only accept a second Musician queen in my lifetime but to accept my niece one. The Kingdom of Snows recognizes Princess Shiri as Queen of Musicia and Guardian of the Heart of Etheria," Frosta said, the Snows gemstone in the crown starting to glow as she stepped away to go to the bottom of the stairs.

Flora bounded forward eagerly, smiling wide as she took Shiri's hand. "The Kingdom of Plumeria recognizes Princess Shiri as Queen of Musicia and Guardian of the Heart of Etheria," she said, the Plumerian runestone lighting up as she stepped away. Shiri felt the energy vibrating through her as each princess stepped forward and the runestones lit up with each acceptance.

Sereia was next, smiling softly as she took Shiri's hand. "The Kingdom of Salineas accepts Princess Shiri as Queen of Musicia and Guardian of the Heart of Etheria."

Aster stepped forward, Flora's older sister, and smiled down at Shiri, taking her hand. "The Kingdom of Scorpion accepts Princess Shiri as Queen of Musicia and Guardian of the Heart of Etheria."

Shiri sucked in a breath as Shimmer stepped forward, no smile on her features as she took Shiri's hand. She gazed up at the Brightmoon princess, trying to gauge her thoughts as she received a tight squeeze to her hand, almost uncomfortable. "The Kingdom of Brightmoon accepts Princess Shiri as Queen of Musicia and Guardian of the Heart of Etheria," Shimmer said, stepping away as the last elemental runestone lit up, the replica Heart of Etheria starting to glow as well. It lit up the room, everyone shielding their eyes from the bright light as they heard a sharp gasp from Shiri.

When the light died and they opened their eyes, they looked forward to seeing their new queen standing on her feet, her hair had come undone from its bun and grown out to her lower back. Both of her eyes were shining white as she stared out over the crowd, unseeing as she felt the power of the Heart and Musician princesses before her course through her body. She flexed her fingers, on one hand, fire springing out of the tips as she did the same to the other, air springing out of that one.

"May I present the Queen of Musicia, Queen Shiri the Visionary!" the council member announced, the room exploding in applause as the white light withdrew from her eyes and she sagged slightly, Lexie stepping forward immediately to take a hold of her arm to

steady her as Zimri got to his feet to support her other side. Shiri shot them both a grateful smile, straightening back up immediately.

"We're going to sit soon, I promise," Lexie whispered, releasing her daughter so she could step forward. Shiri raised her arms to bring the room to silence.

"I would like to thank each and every one of you for the support and kindness I have received. While this is a day of celebration, it is also a day of sadness and mourning. Queen-Consort Lexie has dedicated her life to the service of Musicia, spending the better part of the years rebuilding our kingdom to its former glory after the war. It is also with a heavy heart that we mourn the last Queen Calliope, who was wise beyond her years and had more love to give than any one person could handle. Queen Calliope knew that she would live to see the day that I would ascend to the throne and she prepared me for that day, this day, where I would have to stand before you without her.

She dedicated every day of her life to this kingdom, even to her dying breath. I spent years avoiding the crown and my responsibility to my people. No more. With the help of my Co-Regent, we plan to lead Musicia into a new and brighter future. After the celebrations, when the real work begins, I will be reviewing every document associated with the kingdoms of Etheria: trade agreements, treaties, the colonies, and much more and will be meeting with each kingdom individually throughout the next year.

It is our intention, that by the end of my reign, may I be blessed a long and prosperous life, that the Kingdom of Musicia will become a self-sustaining kingdom. It has been proven by the other kingdoms time and again, from the war and recently, that when Musicia is in need of an ally, there is none to be found yet we are expected to jump to the aid of other kingdoms. It is our intention for Musicia to remove itself from the affairs of other kingdoms and for it to be acknowledged that Musicia is and has always been, the largest and most powerful kingdom in Etheria. Thank you."

The Princess Alliance were floored by the speech, the queens giving each other shocked expressions as applause echoed through the ballroom. Zimri took a hold of her arm again, leading them down the stairs and the aisle to head outside and greet the citizens.

_

The celebration was in full swing outside of the palace, Shiri having taken her seat on the outside throne on the performance dias, the seat elevated slightly on a small pedestal so she could look over the crowd. She has spent the good part of an hour meeting and greeting guests from the seat, most just congratulating her, kissing her hands, mentioning meetings that needed to be set up. She took it all in stride, smiling and agreeing with her guests, even accepting a few dance offers for later in the evening.

She had left her hair down, having missed the long curls she had sheared off in a fit of rage over a year ago. The hair was a sign of a new chapter beginning in her life, a healthy one where she took back control of her life, brought her kingdom to prosperity, and raised her kitten with all the love they deserve.

She had turned her head to the side to speak with Zimri, who was free to roam around and had brought her back some grilled fish and water since she was starving when she heard a commotion a couple of feet away from her. No one but her family could just walk up to her, guards posted around to direct the flow of visitors she had received.

"I need an audience with Her Majesty," she heard the familiar voice speak and turned to see Queen Glimmer glaring down the guard that had stopped her.

"Let her through," Shiri demanded, handing her items back to Zimri as the guard moved to allow Glimmer through, Shimmer not too far behind her as they stopped a foot away from the throne

and bowed. “It is good to see you, Queen Glimmer, Princess Shimmer. What can I do for you?”

Both women straightened, glancing at the other before Glimmer stepped forward. “Your Majesty, I would first like to congratulate you on your ascension to the throne. I know you will rule your people wisely.”

“Thank you, Queen Glimmer,” Shiri acknowledged with a nod, leaning forward slightly in her seat. She knew what was coming.

“Secondly, I would like to bring up my concerns around your plan to alienated Musicia from the rest of Etheria-”

“I’m not alienating my kingdom, I am making it self-sustaining,” Shiri corrected her firmly, crossing her hands in her lap as she steeled her gaze towards the older queen.

“I am still concerned about this plan and would like to urge you to reconsider. We can go over our treaties and the Princess Alliance agreement. I am and I am sure the other kingdoms are willing to renegotiate any agreements to better accommodate Musicia and its needs,” Glimmer concluded, reigning in her temper at Shiri’s interruption.

“Queen Glimmer, with all due respect, the agreements that are in place were mutual understandings between Musicia and Brightmoon that may have worked for the previous reign but will not work for mine. While Musicia has always kept up their end of the agreements, Brightmoon has neglected there's therefore any agreement that had been come to is null and void. It happened during the first Princess Alliance when our kingdom was nearly wiped off the face of Etheria and it happened again when Queen Calliope was murdered while trying to get the aid she had been begging for months. Unless you and the other kingdoms plan on real reform, I stand by making my kingdom self-sustaining so that we may never have to depend on the other kingdoms again.”

“Queen Shiri… I apologize for the tragedy that has befallen your family within the past few years. It was never Brightmoon’s intention to ignore the plea for aid. We would like to set up a meeting to properly discuss this matter, looking over previous agreements, and see if we can cause some serious reform. We want to have an open negotiation if you would be willing to hear us out,” Shimmer said diplomatically, stepping forward as well. Shiri paused for a moment before nodding.

“Very well. I can set up an open negotiation meeting for six months from now,” Shiri told them and Glimmer blanched, shaking her head.

“We cannot wait that long. Why not within the next two months? I want to start the negotiations as quickly as possible.”

Shiri sighed, clenching her fist. She wanted six months to settle into her role as queen and as a mother but she also knew that Glimmer was demanding and wouldn’t wait six months. Two months were cutting it close… too close to her due date, she would be heavily pregnant and she would not be able to hide it from the nosy queen.

“Fine. Two months from today we will start an open negotiation. If I am not satisfied with the results for Musicia, I will back out completely, understood?”

Both women nodded, bowing again before departing from the throne. Shiri leaned back in her seat with another sigh, rubbing her good eyes gently.

“Glimmer is a bit of a hard-ass, eh?” Lexie teased as she came up to her daughter, squeezing her shoulder gently. “You did wonderful with that, my song.”

“I’m going to be too pregnant… I won’t be able to hide it…”

“Then why keep hiding it? They’re going to figure it out when you have the baby in your arms.”

“You wouldn’t understand,” Shiri huffed and she was correct because it was something she didn’t understand completely herself. Something about hiding the pregnancy was comforting to her like she was able to have her child to herself, her little piece of Finn. It was selfish but she didn’t want to lose the peace of being one of the only people to know about her kitten.

“It’s your choice. You know I support whatever you decide. I suggest going to have a couple of dances? You did promise a few people,” Lexie reminded her and Shiri nodded, standing up. The crowd turned to watch her as she stepped down and walked out to the middle of the dance floor, willing and daring anyone to accompany her.

It was mostly silent save for the band warming up for the next dance as she looked around, meeting gazes that quickly looked away. Maybe no one wanted to dance with her after all… a throat cleared and she turned her gaze to Alejandro, who stood before her in a nice black suit, his hair slicked back and his grey eyes twinkling with mischief and he bowed and held out his hand to her as an offering.

She smiled gratefully, about to die of embarrassment from standing in the middle of that dance floor, and took his outstretched hand. She allowed him to pull her close as the waltz started and they began twirling around the floor. He kept the gloved hand securely in his, the other wrapped around the middle of her back as her free hand settled on his shoulder.

“Your Majesty. Can I say that it is an honor to have your first dance of the evening?” he smiled teasingly, she sensed no malice or underlying threat with his words. They were genuine, unlike the last time they had danced together even though he did not remember it.

“The honor is all mine. Who taught you how to dance? I wouldn’t think it would be something worth learning,” she teased back with a smile.

“I wanted to impress you for your coronation day. Your mom has been teaching me, surprisingly. She’s very kind when she wants to be…”

“You don’t remember this… but you used to be close to her, when you were a child… she ran the orphanage you were left at and there was talk of adopting… until my mama became pregnant with Halina. I don’t know exactly why the adoption fell through but it caused the chain of events that led to today…”

“I guess that explains why she has been trying to show me kindness… Thank you… for revealing this to me. I greatly appreciate it,” he told her as they continued to twirl. She winced slightly, feeling her ankles protest at remaining in the heels for so long. “Are you okay?”

“My ankles… damn pregnancy has them swollen to the size of sausages,” she laughed softly as the music came to an end. He frowned as they stopped, pulling away from the other.

“That simply won’t do. May I, Your Majesty?” he questioned, indicating to her feet and she raised an eyebrow in confusion but nodded. It was as if it had been planned because Halina was by their side in a second, holding a pair of flats as Alejandro knelt down, lifting the dress slightly to reveal her feet.

She flushed, realizing that people were watching them as he removed the heels gently from her feet. She placed a hand on his shoulder to steady herself as he placed the flats on her feet. They definitely felt more comfortable than the heels, she instantly felt relief flood through her legs. He stood up when he was done, handing the heels off to Halina before holding out his hand again.

“May I bother you for a second dance now that you can enjoy it, My Queen?”

She laughed softly, taking the hand and resuming their positions as the next song started playing. It was slower, a steadier beat that was not so intense on her feet but relaxing to sway back and

forth. He leaned closer to her, whispering softly into her ear so they would not be heard.

“How are you feeling? The baby, I mean…”

“We’re fine…” she whispered back, gazing down to the floor. “I’m exhausted, my ankles hurt, and all I want to eat is fish all the time even though I don’t really like fish… I’m already in love with them. Every time I feel them kick against my belly, my heart soars with happiness that I never thought I could feel again since… Finn…”

“I know I’m the reason you two are not together,” Alejandro admitted, causing her to look up at him in disbelief.

“That’s not… completely true…”

“Don’t sugarcoat it… I’ve heard some from your siblings and your mom. If it wasn’t for me, they would not have had to use you to bring me to justice. They had Etheria’s best interest in heart and I can see that they genuinely care about you.”

“How would you know that? You don’t know them.”

“I don’t know them but I do know that they have not taken their eyes off of you all evening. And the way they look at you is the way I see your mom look at portraits of your mama. Sad but in love,” Alejandro admitted and Shiri instantly looked around until she met the blue eyes that had haunted her dreams for months staring at her, boring into her soul like they always have. They gave her a small smile, nodding their head in her direction and she flushed, looking away quickly.

“Sereia looks at you that way…” she told Alejandro, head jerking over to the Salinean princess who stood on the edge of the crowd, watching them dance.

“I hurt her too. She would never accept me…”

“You will be surprised… she’s crazy about you. Give it a chance,” Shiri encouraged as the song ended and they stopped twirling but

didn’t pull away from each other.

“Don’t give up on them, Your Majesty. I’ve heard that a love like that is something you only get once in your lifetime and only some are lucky to find it so early.”

“You sound like my mama,” she laughs softly. “You’ve come so far… I never thought I would ever be able to be around you and feel genuinely happy. You’re like another brother to me and… I’m sure in another lifetime, you would have been my brother. This means, as your unofficial sister, I am encouraging you to go talk to Princess Sereia and put on those slick moves.”

He laughs before leaning forward, pressing a gentle kiss to her forehead and finally pulling away from her, her hand the last thing he lets go of. “I encourage the same as your unofficial brother. We’ll catch up later?”

“Of course,” she told him and he walked away from her. She turned back to catch Finn’s eyes again. They had never strayed from her but she could see the tension in their jaw from her interaction with Alejandro. It softened when they noticed her soft expression and they started towards each other, like magnets. Nothing was going to get in their way.

Except something did get in their way in the shape of Princess Flora, who excitedly whirled Shiri back onto the dance floor. Shiri inhaled deeply, composing herself before smiling up at the enthusiastic princess.

“You look very beautiful, Shiri! I love that dress, wasn’t it your mama’s? It looks kinda different though but I can’t quite place my finger on it,” Flora was telling her, twirling the older woman around but keeping a firm hold on her. Shiri had tried to give them some space, she didn’t want Flora to press against her baby bump on accident and reveal her secret but she forgot how strong the half scorpion woman could be.

“Uhh, my mom hemmed the waistline. I’ve been gaining weight recently and it would have been harder to take the dress out…”

“Ohh, that explains these chunky cheeks!” Flora teased, one hand reaching up to pat Shiri’s cheek. Shiri rolled her eyes, smiling affectionately at the oversized woman. Flora was eccentric in the best of ways and too kind for her own good. She always made their friend dynamic interesting, playing peacemaker amongst their group and encouraging guided meditations and drum circles to solve their problems.

But a drum circle wasn’t going to solve the problem she was facing now as she caught glimpses of blonde and blue on the edge of the crowd from around her dance partner. She needed to talk to Finn, she missed them. She wanted to try to fix this, she wanted to be with them.

“They miss you,” Flora says casually, noticing Shiri looking around. Shiri blinked up at her, giving her a sheepish smile.

“I’m sorry, I should be giving you my attention. How is your family, Flora?”

“They’re fine but that’s not what I want to talk about. Finn misses you. When are you going to put aside your childish pride and apologize?”

Shiri stopped the dance in the middle of the floor, taken aback by Flora’s response. She never talked towards people like this, why was she being so brash? If Shiri had fur, it would be bristling right now but she could feel a low human hiss building in her chest.

“It’s not childish. I do not appreciate your tone of voice, *Princess,”* Shiri emphasizes Flora’s title, pulling away and straightening herself. Flora’s eyes flicker with panic for a moment before sighing.

“I apologize, Your Majesty. That was brash. I am just trying to look out for my friends… they both seem miserable apart…”

Was Shiri miserable? Maybe. She missed waking up beside the furry heater, they always kept her warm. She missed the feel of their fur beneath her fingers and the rumbling purr they emitted when they were around her. She missed being scented by them, the smell of their shampoo filling her senses, the feel of their lips on her. She said it aloud before she could stop herself.

"I miss them too…"

"Then why won't you be with them?"

"It's not that simple anymore…"

"It is, you're not making it simple. You're making it messy and complicated when it doesn't need to be. Why are you so easy to forgive the man who tortured and ruined your family over the person who made one mistake but loves you unconditionally?"

"Because I know what to expect when it happens," Shiri clenched her fists, turning her head away from Flora. She saw Finn and she felt everything swell up inside her, everything threatening to spill out of her as she made her way to them. They felt like parallel lines, always close but never quite touching, sometimes curving close to each other but never intercepting.

She was in front of them, staring up into those blue eyes she loved so much, into the person who had her whole heart and all she wanted to do was bury her fingers into their fur. They stared as if they were the only two people in the room, drinking in the other like an oasis in a desert before both spoke at the same time.

"There's something I need to tell you."

Both blinked, surprised but knowing smiles crossing their faces. Shiri could feel her heart beating in her chest, she was holding her breath.

"You go first," she insisted, clearing her throat awkwardly as they nodded, tail swishing around behind them. She couldn't help but

notice how handsome they looked in their suit, the one they had worn to Princess Prom.

“I’m, uh, taking your advice,” they started, causing Shiri to tilt her head in confusion. “About following my dreams. I leave tomorrow to go explore the universe. I’ll be returning to Etheria every few months to visit my mom's but… I’m off to follow the stars…”

The world skidded to a stop as Shiri’s entire reality seemed to shatter. She was silent for one… two… three beats before she schooled her features into a mask of fake happiness, pressing her lips together in a forced smile.

“That’s… amazing. I am happy for you, Finn.”

“Are you?” they questioned. “There was something you needed to tell me…”

“It’s nothing. Nothing important. If you’ll excuse me… I do wish you the best on your travels,” Shiri said, moving quickly away from them and back towards the throne, to her family.

Lexie looks up from her conversation with Callista and Brio, a look of concern crossing her features as Shiri grabbed her arm, squeezing it.

“How much longer till this is over?” she whispered softly, only loud enough for the three adults to hear her.

“A few more hours. Are you okay? Is it the baby?” Lexie asked worriedly.

“I’m exhausted, I want to rest, please…”

“Come on, mini shot. I’ll escort you to your room,” Brio offered, taking a hold of Shiri’s arm. Lexie searched her eyes for a moment, trying to find something, anything but not seeing it, moving back to allow her second-oldest friend to escort her eldest inside. Shiri didn’t relax until the doors of the palace closed behind

her. If Brio had known what would happen next, he would have kept a better grip on his goddaughter.

She collapsed to her knees, a loud sob ripping out her throat as she quickly covered her mouth to stifle it. Brio drops down beside her, instantly wrapping his arms around her trembling body. He ran his fingers through her hair, humming softly to try to soothe the sobbing girl.

"They're leaving! I really fucked up, papa Brio! They're leaving for good!" she sobbed, arms wrapping around her hidden baby bump, her grief running deeper than just for herself.

Chapter End Notes

> This is probably my longest chapter by far! We are coming to the end of this book and I am sad to see it go! My first book, The Power in You, is currently being majorly edited and rewritten and I am still working on the One-Shots.
>
> Let me know if you would like to see a one-shot happen from this book or a third book be created!
>
> As always, kudos and comment!

Chapter 27

Chapter Summary

Shiri has the baby, Finn founds out, fluff and forgiveness ensues

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 27

"Please come to this meeting with me!" Glimmer begged Catra, practically chasing her around the Brightmoon Palace. It was two months to the day from Shiri's Coronation and Musicia had gone radio silent, no communication coming in and out of the city. It was concerning, to say the least. They had expected to hear from Lexie, but she had not shown up at the orphanage in the Scorpion Kingdom yet, having informed Scorpia that she would be delaying the move for a few more months to help Shiri settle in.

"I can't, Sparkles. My kid comes home today and I want to be with Adora when they land in port," Catra told her, searching the rooms in hopes to find Nala. The young magicat had been flighty for a few weeks, everything around her changing so rapidly.

"Please, Catra! Please! Shiri likes you! You could give me a big advantage by just being there! Besides, Bow is busy and Adora wants to wait for Finn as well."

"Ugghhh! Where is she?" Catra grumbled, opening up another door.

"Are you even listening to me?!" Glimmer demanded as Adora rounded the corner, carrying Nala in her arms. The young magicat had her head buried in her mom's neck, tail swishing in agitation.

“I found our little runaway,” Adora said, Catra waving Glimmer off to go to her wife and child.

“Catra! I swear to gods, you’re killing me!” Glimmer shouted, Adora raising an eyebrow as Nala eagerly went into her mama’s arms.

“I want to see my kid. I am going to the port with Adora.”

“Wait, what’s going on?” Adora asks, confused.

“I want Catra to attend the open negotiation in Musicia with me but she won’t even consider the idea!”

Nala’s ears perked up, moving her head up to look at Glimmer. “I want to go! I want to see Shiri!”

“No, sweetie… Finn is coming home to visit today, we need to wait for them at the port,” Catra told her, Nala hissing in agitation.

“I. Want. To. See. Shiri!” she demanded, ears flattening on the top of her skull. Adora and Catra shared a concerned look, their daughter never acting so agitated about visiting someone before.

“It’s not a bad idea… I can wait for Finn, the negotiation will only be a few hours and Nala can visit with Shiri some. You know Shiri loves her,” Adora said soothingly, noting how Catra’s tail flicked with agitation as well.

“See! Shiri loves you both so that means she will go a little soft in negotiation…” Glimmer said with hope. Catra looked at the three faces before her before sighing in resignation.

“Fine… Fine! I’ll go with you. But I am off the hook for the next week with you so I can spend it with Finn!”

“Done! Yay! Let’s go!” Glimmer said eagerly, grabbing Catra’s arm before she could protest and teleport away.

—

They sat in the meeting room for an hour and with each passing minute, Glimmer was getting more and more agitated. After the teleport, to which Catra had doubled over with dry heaves, they picked up Shimmer and headed to Musicia. They had been led into the meeting room, offered beverages and snacks, and told that the queen would be with them shortly.

Nala had wanted to run out of the room in search of her friend but Catra kept her tightly by her side, lightly digging her claws into the little girl's arm in warning every time she got too agitated. Shimmer was drumming her fingers against the table, bored and already over this meeting. Glimmer had started pacing half an hour in and would not stop.

"This is so unprofessional! The least they could do is inform us why it is taking so long! What is taking her so long? She's known about this meeting for months!" Glimmer ranted, gesticulating wildly with her hands.

"I'm sure something important came up. She'll come, Sparkles. Try to relax," Catra tried to soothe her friend, who was not in the mood to be soothed.

All heads turned towards the door as Zimri entered, carrying a stack of papers and accompanied by a maid with a tea cart. He flashed them a strained smiling, rounding the table to take his seat at the head.

"I apologize for the delay, ladies. I'm sure you're all hungry, I have brought afternoon tea with me. Julia? Could you?" he questioned, Julie nodding and going to set up the tea set at the table.

"Where's the queen? We had a scheduled meeting with her and she is over an hour later," Glimmer demanded with a huff, coming back over to the table to stare Zimri down. Zimri straightened in his chair, meeting her gaze.

"Queen Shiri has taken ill and apologizes for the inconvenience. I have been briefed on all the necessary documentation and have

her permission to begin negotiations. All final decisions will fall to her when she is well again.”

“That is bullshit! She knew the meeting was today and she is bailing on us! Where is she?!”

“Glimmer! You cannot accuse her of faking an illness, that is offensive and is only going to make the negotiation worse!” Catra reprimanded, standing as well.

“Queen Shiri has been feeling ill for a few days and did not wish to cancel this meeting, hoping she would feel better in time to attend. She knew you would be angry but sends her sincerest apologies. If you would like, we can reschedule this meeting for a later date-”

“No! I am having my meeting with the queen if it is the last thing I do!” Glimmer disappeared in a burst of sparkles, the room left stunned by her outburst.

Nala took the opportunity to pull away from her mom and bound out of the room, also determined to find Shiri as well.

–

It started a week ago, the nesting. It was instinctual, she couldn’t help it but she woke up one morning as her bed didn’t feel right and her room didn’t feel right and nothing felt ‘right.’ She had made her way into the nursery, where every Musicia prince and princess had lived at some point in their lives and it brought her comfort, seeing the baby objects around her, the plush pillows and stuffed animals and she started building the nest there.

But the nest still hasn't felt right, not even a week after building it. She had stolen blankets, pillows, and shirts from around the palace, filling her overwhelmed senses with the stench of her family but it still brought her no comfort. Alejandro had brought her a small mattress into the room to help make the floor nest bearable but it still didn’t feel right. She started feeling the pain within her belly two days ago and it was getting more intense.

After the physician had visited, they had informed her that the kitten had flipped and was preparing to enter the world. The baby had gone kicking her in the ribs every time it felt her frustration and she was sure they were thoroughly bruised by now. The contractions were becoming harder to ignore but were still about twenty minutes apart. She still had time but not enough. Not enough to make the nest perfect for her kitten.

She groaned as she felt the contraction hit her, her sitting on her hands and knees to rock back and forth, trying to ride out the pain. Alejandro had been trying to help guide her through it, rubbing her lower back and keeping her hydrated but it wasn't working. Everything was wrong, this was wrong and she could feel the panic start to bubble up as the pain subsided.

"You're doing great, Shiri. Keep breathing, your mom will be back soon," Alejandro encouraged her. She let out a strangled noise, her chest tightening. This is wrong… this is wrong… her instincts were screaming at her that this was wrong.

"I can't! I can't! It's not ready! I'm not ready! I-" she was starting to hyperventilate, unable to catch her breath.

"Hey, hey! It's okay! You can do this. You're ready. Breathe, okay?"

She shook her head, tears starting to stream down her face as the frustration at the situation took over. Strangled sobs left her throat, almost drowned out by her trying desperately to suck in a deep breath but unable to catch a good one. She faintly heard Alejandro calling for someone but her ears were ringing, black spots dancing across her vision. She was going to pass out if she didn't calm down.

She didn't hear the door open, she didn't see the person enter the room, followed by others but she felt it. The familiar sensation of fur against her skin. It grounded her some, bringing her out of the haze that had settled as she made herself sit back on her knees, wrapping her arms around the small, furry creature. Tears soaked

into their fur, the scent was off, it wasn't who she wanted to be by her but it was still familiar, still enough to settle her some.

"You're having a baby! That is so cool! Is it a boy or a girl? I hope it looks like me!" Nala said eagerly in her arms, wrapping her tail around Shiri's wrist. Shiri managed to suck in a deep breath but the panic didn't subside. She was still hyperventilating.

"Can we get an oxygen mask in here?!" she managed to hear Alejandro shout and she pulled away from Nala, hunching over to dry heave.

Warm hands on her face. She looked up through her tears to see Catra's concerned mismatched eyes staring at her.

"You're okay. This is normal. You need to calm down, you're going to cause the baby distress," she told her, leaning forward to press her forehead gently to Shiri's. The physician came in, carrying the monitor to dispense oxygen and check vitals.

"Hey, I'm going to need you to lay down, okay? Can you lay down so the doctor can check you?" Catra encouraged Shiri nodding and allowing herself to be eased back into the pillows. The physician placed the oxygen mask over her nose and mouth, fastening it to the back of her head and she was able to get a full breath of air into her lungs. Catra kept her hand clasped into the both of hers, Nala caressing her belly gently in fascination. The physician put a blood pressure cuff on her arm to monitor her blood pressure and heart rate before moving down to check how dilated she was.

"We're looking at about six to seven centimeters, Your Majesty. It shouldn't be much longer," they informed the group, everyone nodding as they moved away to allow them some space.

Shiri stared up at Catra, squeezing her hand tightly as she shifted to her side, curling around her expansive stomach.

"Why didn't you tell anyone?" Catra said softly, removing one hand to caress the younger girl's hair. Glimmer and Shimmer

approached cautiously, eyes wide before Nala hissed at them, crouching in front of Shiri protectively.

"It was never the right time… every time I wanted to, something would happen… until I got to this point…"

"Don't come too close," Catra warned, baring her fangs. "There are too many maternal hormones happening right now and I don't want to accidentally scratch out your eyes for coming too close to my grandchild."

"How do you even know it's your grandchild? It could be Alejandro's," Glimmer suggested, vaguely waving towards the man who was making sure Shiri was comfortable. Lexie opened the door as Glimmer said this, fists clenching angrily with Halina by her side.

"You can get the hell out of my palace, Glimmer," she said, striding in to stand toe to toe with the Brightmoon queen. "You are not welcomed to be here and insult my daughter."

"She didn't mean it, Aunt Lexie!" Shimmer said, jumping to Glimmer's defense and trying to get in between them. "She's stressed, the last couple of hours have been rough for her…"

"Lexie… I'm sorry, I didn't mean… I'm trying to protect my friends…"

"We're your friends too! That is your niece and she's currently in labor and uncomfortable! You will not stand here and make it harder than it already is for her. Don't make me kick your ass again."

"Please stop…" Shiri sobbed, another contraction racking through her body. She groaned, rolling to be on her forearms and knees, back arched with discomfort. "I can't do this!"

"Yes, you can!" Lexie encouraged, going over to her daughter and rubbing her back as she rode out her contraction. "You are not the

first woman to have a baby, my song. And you won't be the last, I promise. Just breathe."

Shiri pulled the oxygen mask away from her face, looking up at her mom and Catra. "This isn't right. It doesn't feel right! I need… the nest it's not…"

"What do you need?" Catra asks, moving her hair from her face. "More bedding for the nest? Water? Darkness?"

"Finn… I need Finn, I can't do this alone…"

"Glimmer! Call Adora, now!"

–

Finn had been gone off-planet for a few months and didn't realize how much they were going to miss Etheria. They probably would have come home anyways if their moms had not insisted on visiting every few months. They had spent the time exploring a new planet and being welcomed by the locals, everyone excited to meet the child of She-Ra who had visited them so many years ago.

They had also spent the time soul-searching and thinking about Shiri. That's all they ever did was think about her. When they laid awake at night, looking up at the stars outside of their window, they wondered if she was doing the same back on Etheria. They would think about her smile, how it lit up a room. They wondered what she was doing at different times of the day. Was she working on some paperwork, holed up in her office? Was she taking a stroll through the garden, brushing her fingers along the petals of the flowers she loved so much?

It made them realize how much they truly missed her, despite the pain they had suffered together. They planned on storming Musicia when they came back, sweeping her off her feet and never letting her go again. Of course… plans always change.

“Finn!” Adora waved, rushing over as they disembarked from the spaceship. She looked frantic and frazzled, which was unlike the strong and collected woman they knew and loved.

“Mom? Where’s mama? What’s going on?” they asked, immediately sensing something was wrong.

“She’s in Musicia. We need to head over there. Now.”

“Musicia?” they had planned on going over there but not so quickly. “What happened? Is it Shiri?”

Adora pursed her lips, hesitant to answer before a burst of sparkles appeared on the dock, Glimmer teleporting into the middle of them.

“Finn! Thank gods you’re back! We gotta go, now!”

“What’s going on?!” they asked, confused but Glimmer grabbed both them and Adora, disappearing again.

They appeared in the hallway of the palace of Musicia, Finn stumbling forward as they landed, heaving slightly. Their fur bristled as they stood up, noticing the small crowd outside the door of what used to be Shiri and Zimri’s nursery. Halina was pacing in front of the door like a sentry, Zimri leaning against the wall beside it with Marmoris, arms crossed. Shimmer was biting her nails, bouncing from foot to foot until she spotted the others appear. She beelined to them, wrapping her arms around Finn.

“She needs you, it’s getting worse…”

“What’s getting worse?” they asked, confusion lacing their voice. There was a sharp cry of pain from the other side of the door and Finn let go of Shimmer, rushing past her to go inside. The room was dim as they entered, closing the door behind them. They gazed across the room at the scene before them.

Shiri has curled onto her side again, sobbing and hyperventilating through the oxygen mask. Catra was by her head, keeping her

hair back as Lexie was pulling on one of her legs, trying to encourage her to flip onto her back gently. Nala was holding one of her hands, rubbing circles into the palm absentmindedly. Finn's gaze fell down to the large stomach Shiri was curled around, blinking in surprise and shock before they saw another figure behind Shiri, rubbing her lower back gently.

They saw red, seeing Alejandro so close to their mate. Their pregnant mate. She let out another sharp cry, squeezing Nala unconsciously as she arched her back in pain. Finn growled, tail swishing angrily as they stalked forward, eyes zeroed in on Alejandro. The older man looked up, raising his hands up in a peaceful gesture towards the agitated magicat before backing away from her. He knew better than to come between such an intimate moment.

"Hey, Finn's here…" Catra whispered against Shiri's temple. She looked up through hooded lids, breath hitching as Finn kept glaring Alejandro down, low growls still emitting their chest as they took the spot he previously occupied. Shiri could finally breathe as she felt their cheek rub against hers, a soft purr emitting from them. This felt right, this is what she had been missing.

"Hey… I missed you," Finn whispered gently and Shiri closed her eyes, allowing herself to finally relax for the first time in a week. Hell, maybe the first time in months.

"We need to get her on her back. She's ten centimeters dilated and the baby is starting to crown. She's refusing to push," Lexie told Finn with a frown. Finn took a hold of one of Shiri's hands, kissing the knuckles gently.

"Come on, love. You need to move. They want to come out and meet you," they coaxed.

"I was waiting… they want to meet you too… I didn't want you to miss this…" she said, inhaling sharply as another wave of pain hit her. "I need to push…"

She allowed them to roll her onto her back, Catra moving over to allow Finn to take her spot. They adjusted her so she was half sitting up and leaning her back against their front. Finn intertwined their fingers, squeezing her hands as Lexie spread her knees apart.

"Alright, next contraction I need you to push as hard as you can, okay?" she told Shiri, who nodded, head leaning back against Finn's shoulder.

"I got you, love. I'm not letting go, I promise," they told her, continually rubbing their cheek against any exposed skin they could touch, marking her, scenting her as theirs.

Shiri took a deep breath, squeezing their hands back as the next contraction rolled through her as she started pushing, gritting her teeth. She let out a small cry as her mother counted to ten before she stopped, panting. They did this a couple more times, Finn whispering encouraging words into her ear as she tried to push her child into the world.

She collapsed back after the fifth time, exhaustion and frustration coming over. "I can't… I can't do it… It hurts…"

"Hey, you can do this!" Lexie told her, squeezing her daughter's knee. "They're almost here. Don't you want to hold your kitten? It's the most amazing feeling in the world, holding your child for the first time… You have to keep pushing. Keep pushing for them."

"Let's get her up on her feet, let gravity help," Catra suggested, Lexie nodding as the two women and Finn helped Shiri shift up to her feet. Catra removed the oxygen mask and Shiri wrapped her arms around Finn's neck as they put their hands under her armpits, helping her remain upright. Catra hovered near her back, ready to help catch her if she fell while Lexie squatted underneath to catch the baby.

Shiri looked up, staring into Finn's eyes that stared back into her one brown and one blue eye. They pressed their forehead against

hers.

“Come on, love, one more push, okay? One more and then they will be here.”

She nodded, squatting slightly before pushing with the next contraction, letting out a small yell as the adults encouraged her loudly, urging her on until, finally, she felt the small body slip from her own. She let out an exhausted and thankful sob, her knees giving out and Finn gently lowering her back down. The tiny cries she heard from her child were the most beautiful music to grace her ears. They helped her adjust back against the piles of pillows, her body relaxing, and her breath evening out as she watched her mom clean up the tiny, squirming newborn.

“You did so well, my love,” Finn praised, kissing all over her face gently.

“My baby…” she mumbled, trying to blink away the exhaustion.

“She’s perfect,” Lexie said with a smile, coming back over and gently laying the newborn on Shiri’s chest. The newborn mewled, pressing into her mother’s skin as Shiri ran her cheek against the top of their head, scenting them as her own.

“Looks like heterochromia runs in the family,” Catra commented, looking at the multi-colored fur that graced her tiny frame, a mix of black, blonde, brown, and white patches, like a calico. From the little bit of mane she had, they could tell the coloring would be the same there as well. Her tiny tears were flattened against her skull, her short tail wrapped around her body.

“She does have two grandmothers with heterochromia. It should be no surprise she has it as well,” Finn said, tracing a gentle finger along the newborn's cheek, mesmerized by the tiny cherub face that looked so much like the woman they loved.

“I wonder if her eyes are two different colors,” Lexie said, smiling down at her daughter and granddaughter.

“What’s her name?!” Nala asked eagerly, jittering in her seated position on the floor beside the nest.

Shiri hadn’t heard anything that was said around her, completely mesmerized by the tiny being on top of her. Her daughter. Their daughter. It took everything in her to look away from the tiny kitten and glance up at Finn. Their eyes shone with so much unbridled love and affection as they stared down at their kitten. This is what she wanted, had always wanted.

“Shiri? Does she have a name?” she heard her mom ask, finally looking up to acknowledge her. She blinked, remaining quiet. She had a name. She had known this name for months, almost a year, even before she was pregnant.

“I’ll tell you when our entire family is in here to hear it,” Shiri told her, nuzzling her newborn. Finn grabbed a light blanket, pulling it up over her body to cover her and the baby. “I just want to rest now and bond with her…”

Everyone took the hint, Catra and Nala butting their heads against Finn and Shiri’s affectionately before heading towards the door. Alejandro had already disappeared after the birth and Lexie kissed her daughter’s forehead.

“I won’t be far. If you need anything, call for me,” she told her, Shiri nodding tiredly before her mom got up and left the room with everyone else, leaving the new parents alone.

“You look exhausted, you should try to sleep…” Finn said softly, stroking her hair gently as they watched their daughter. Shiri blinked sleepily, having already started to drift off.

“But we need to…”

“We can do that after you rest. I’ll just be outside if you need me…”

Shiri quickly grabbed their hand with her free one, looking up at them desperately. “Please… stay. She’s yours too…”

Finn nodded, settling back down beside her. She moved slowly, hissing softly in pain as she curled onto her side, cradling the baby into the crook of her arm. The kitten mewled, settling down with a large yawn. Finn adjusted the blanket around them, pressing into Shiri's back as they wrapped their arms around her, a hand stroking the baby's cheek gently.

Shiri let the exhaustion drag her under, relaxing under the steady breathing coming from Finn and their child.

—

She awoke a couple of hours later, confused and disoriented. She still felt tired, her body ached with aftershocks of birth and she went to go nuzzle back into her pillow before she realized that the baby wasn't in her arms and Finn wasn't behind her. She lifted her head slightly, gazing around the room until her eyes landed on the window.

It was night, the moon high in the sky and illuminating the image before her. Finn sat in the rocking chair by the window, holding their daughter who was wrapped up in a blanket and gurgling up at their parent. She heard faint whispering and shifted in a little closer so she could hear them.

"You are descended from some of the fiercest women I have ever met in my life. Your grandma Adora is She-Ra, the mighty Princess of Power. She transforms into an eight-foot-tall warrior lady, it is super cool. Your grandma Catra is like us, a magicat. She was a criminal warlord but now she is Commander of Brightmoon's Army. She's a badass, you get your heterochromatic eyes from her, my beautiful one. Your grandma Lexie is like your grandma Catra, which means you are going to be a handful when you are older. She's strong and runs her kingdom with a gentle but firm hand. Your grandma Calliope, you won't be able to meet her because she is no longer with us but she's where you get your beautiful fur from.

Your mommy is a lot like her, though she doesn't like to admit it. She doesn't want to be seen as soft and kind. All four of your grandma's helped save Etheria, so you have a lot to live up to. But if you end up being even half the woman your mommy is, you will do okay for yourself. There is no one better to be like than her. She's beautiful with a smile that lights up any room she goes into. She's strong, independent, and head-strong, like her mom. But she's kind, caring, compassionate, and devoted to the people she loves, like her mama. You are the luckiest kitten in Etheria to have a mommy like her."

Then Shiri heard something she had never heard from Finn before. She heard them start softly singing to their daughter.

She's imperfect but she tries

She is good but she lies

She is hard on herself

She is broken and won't ask for help

She is messy but she's kind

She is lonely most of the time

She is all of this mixed up

And baked in a beautiful pie

She is gone but she used to be mine

Her breath hitched slightly, heart thumping wildly in her chest as she listened to them. It was beautiful and emotional and raw… it was from their heart, from their very soul and they were baring it all to their child. Expressing how they felt for her, how frustrated and in love they were for her. How they missed her.

It's not what I asked for

Sometimes life just slips in through a back door

And carves out a person

And makes you believe it's all true

And now I've got you

And you're not what I asked for

If I'm honest I know I would give it all back

For a chance to start over

And rewrite an ending or two

For the girl that I knew

Who be reckless just enough

Who can hurt but

Who learns how to toughen up when she's bruised

And gets used by a man who can't love

And then she'll get stuck and be scared

Of the life that's inside her

Growing stronger each day

'Til it finally reminds her

To fight just a little

To bring back the fire in her eyes

That's been gone but it used to be mine

“Finn…” she said softly, tears lacing her voice but she knew they heard her. Their ears twitched at the noise and they lifted their head to look at her lying in the darkroom.

She is messy but she's kind

She is lonely most of the time

She is all of this mixed up and baked in a beautiful pie

She is gone but she used to be mine

“I want her to be mine again,” they whispered, tail lashing behind them nervously. Her head felt wet and she realized that the tears had split down her cheeks, over her nose, and onto the pillow beneath her. She sniffles, wiping the tears away with a nervous laugh.

“I was always yours, silly kitty. It has always been you…”

Finn seems to release the breath they had been holding since starting the song, their daughter had fallen asleep as their parent had sung to them. Finn stood slowly, keeping their kitten cradled gently in their arms as they made their way to the nest, Shiri shifting slightly to make room. They laid their daughter in between the two of them, both laying so close that their noses nearly touched, and their hands slowly intertwined over their sleeping child.

“I’ve traveled all over Etheria and have traveled through some of the universes, experiencing different planets, people, and cultures… but being with you is like walking into a house and feeling like I’m home. You have always been my home, my love. It took me leaving to realize that I don’t want to be anywhere you aren’t.”

“You’re not mad at me… for keeping her a secret?”

“Mad? A little… I don’t think it was fair I found out last and as you were having her but she’s here, she’s mine, and I’m not going

anywhere. I guess I understand why you did, a lot happened in the last six months, but it still hurts, I missed your entire pregnancy…"

"I'm sorry. I didn't mean for that to happen… It just did… every time I wanted to tell you, something would come up until you left and it just became easier to keep her to myself… I want to share her with you because she is yours," Shiri smiled softly, touching her nose against theirs softly. "Does she really have your mama's eyes?"

"Yes," Finn smiled back, removing their hand from hers to gently caress her cheek. "Kid won the genetic lotto with heterochromia. She has my blue eye and your beautiful brown one as well as her calico fur. She's unique, there is no one out there like her."

"Amora…" Shiri whispers softly, placing her hand over theirs.

"Amora?" Finn questions, rubbing their thumb across her cheekbone, just below her runestone eye.

"It means love… she was conceived from true love and she is loved by everyone around her… Amora is love."

"I love it. I love her. And I love you. I love you, Shiri of Musicia, with everything I am and will ever be. One day, when you are ready, I want you to be my wife and I want us to grow old together and watch our children grow old and have babies of their own. I want you to be the first thing I wake up to every morning and the last thing I see every night. I want to raise our daughter together. But only if you will have me."

"Are you asking me to marry you again?" she smirks slightly, causing a light blush to splatter over Finn and their ears to flatten against their head.

"Only if you want… I know it's soon and I don't want to force you to do anything you don't want to do but we love each other, we want to be together, I hope, and I mean we have a child together and well-"

Shiri leans over, pressing her lips softly against theirs to stop them from talking. They huffed slightly before kissing her back, her hand intertwined with theirs over her cheek. It was gentle, full of love, full of hope, full of promises they intended to keep to each other. They pulled apart only far enough to keep their lips brushing against the other.

“Is that a yes?” they whispered and Shiri laughed softly, pecking them again.

“Of course it’s a yes, silly kitty. I want to marry you but I want us to go to therapy first before we do anything.”

Finn sat up, looking around the room with a confused yet playful expression. Shiri rolled her eyes, pulling the baby to her chest as she watched their shenanigans.

“Don’t even say it, Finn-”

“Who are you and what did you do to my Shiri? Who is this healthy woman? What happened to drinking away our problems?”

“You’re such an ass!” she laughed, hitting their leg playfully. Finn groaned in fake pain, falling back over.

“You are cruel! How could you hit the parent of your child?! I am hurt!”

“And you’re dramatic as hell. Keep it down before you wake Amora, kitty.”

Finn turned back on their side, nuzzling softly into their daughter’s mane, content purrs rumbling through their chest. They glanced up at her through their eyelashes, giving a dopey smile she knew all too well from their mom.

“But I agree… the therapy… I want us to work through what has happened so that we are entering a healthy partnership when we get married. And so Amora can have two healthy parents who love each other with no underlying resentment.”

“Exactly… I don’t want this to come back up in the future… I want us to live a long and healthy and happy life together…”

“I think I just fell more in love with you,” they told her, wrapping an arm around her waist to pull their family close together.

“May we always find ways to keep falling in love with the other.”

Chapter End Notes

Song Creds: She Used to be Mine cover by Annapantsu

One Chapter Left! How could this be happening?! I want to thank you guys so much for encouraging me throughout this work! Your kudos and comments have really kept me going!

Be sure to kudos, comment, and check out my other works! I am in the process of brainstorming a third and final installment of this series! What would you like to see happen?? Stay tuned for more!

Chapter 28

Chapter Summary

Everyone meets Amora, an unexpected vision, an unexpected reunion, the new princess is presented

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 28

“Oh my gods, she's so cute!” Halina cooed, sitting on her knees in front of Shiri who was settled in the rocking chair by the window, cradling Amora in her arms. It had taken a couple of days for the new parents to feel comfortable enough to allow others inside the nursery to visit the baby. While they had a nest on the floor, they considered the entire room a safe space to bond with their kitten and talk through their problems together. It was not the therapy they needed but it was a start for now until they could leave the nest.

They were currently surrounded by both of their families, who were trying not to crowd as they got a good look at the kitten. Finn sat perched on an ottoman beside the rocking chair, ready to swoop in to rescue their mate and child if need be. They kept a sharp eye on everyone encircling them, tail swishing warily at all the people. Catra placed a hand on their shoulder, giving them a knowing smile.

“Its nerve wracking having so many people around your kitten, huh?” she told them, to which they nodded in agreement, holding back a small growl as Halina reached a hand up to place on Amora.

“Gently, Hallie. Don’t overstep Shiri’s boundaries with the baby,” Lexie lightly reprimanded her youngest daughter as she held her

youngest son on her hip, much to Finn's relief. Halina pulled back, giving her older sister a sheepish smile.

"I'm sorry. I just got excited, she's so beautiful. Look at her fur! It's so colorful!"

"Seems like she inherited something from all of her grandmother's," Zimri teased, noting the white, black, brown, and blonde patches all over the fur and mane.

"It's very beautiful coloring. Very unique, just like she is," Marmoris agreed, wrapping an arm around his husband's waist.

"Oh, does she have Catra's eyes?" Adora asked, leaning in close to her wife to peer down at her granddaughter. Finn nodded in affirmation, smiling over at Amora who mewled and yawned softly, causing a collective chorus of 'awwws' to ring through the room.

"One brown eye, like her mommy, and one blue eye like mine. She is definitely very unique," Finn agreed, leaning over to chuff softly at the infant. Amora blinked up at her parent, trilling softly back.

"Look at those eyes. One like the earth and one like the sea," Lexie said in awe, leaning over the back of the rocking chair to squeeze her daughter's shoulder lightly . " I am so proud of you. You made such a beautiful creature."

"What's her name?" Nala piped up, having climbed up into Adora's arms to get a better peek at the baby. Everyone nodded their heads in agreement, wanting to know the baby's name. Finn and Shiri shared a look, smiling.

"You tell them," Shiri encouraged, leaning down to kiss the baby's forehead gently.

"Everyone, please meet… Amora," they said, smiling at their small family. "She's the product of true love and she is loved by everyone in this room and beyond."

“It’s like Adora!” Adora said proudly, throwing Lexie a smug look that the other woman scowled at.

“Except there’s nothing lovable about you, you dumb sword lesbian,” Lexie told her playfully, Adora gasping in fake shock.

“You’re just jealous that they didn’t name their daughter after you, you dumb jock lesbian!”

“Can we stop comparing our dicks already? You both have very big dicks, let’s move on,” Catra said, rolling her eyes at the two. There was a knock on the door before it opened to reveal Glimmer, Bow, Shimmer, and Archer. Glimmer smiled timidly at Lexie, holding out a large box as a peace offering.

“I just wanted to apologize for the other day… and to bring a gift for the new parents, if I’m allowed,” Glimmer said softly and Shiri glanced up at her mom, whose jaw was tense. She turned back to Glimmer before giving her a soft smile, removing a hand from her daughter to extend out in invitation.

Glimmer stepped forward, taking Shiri’s hand gratefully as she squeezed it. “You are forgiven. Everyone was stressed and tension was running high. We said things in the heat of anger and I would like to rectify that. When I am better, I would like to reopen negotiations for Musicia and Brightmoon,” Shiri told her, watching the older queen's eyes light up happily.

“I would love that. And I would love it if you guys would accept this gift for the new princess,” Glimmer told them, presenting the gift. Finn took it from Glimmer, opening it up to reveal the contents inside.

Inside laid a pair of gold armbands, mimicking the design of the official crown of Musicia with the five elemental runestones and the Heart of Etheria runestone spaced out around the band and surrounded by tiny clear gemstones.

“Aunt Glimmer… these are beautiful,” Finn told her, smiling gratefully as they lifted the armbands up to examine them closer.

"They're big so that she can wear them when she is older. Archer helped create the bands and Shimmer embedded them with magic, each gemstone containing one use of magic from each kingdom. Just until she learns how to use her own magic."

"Her own magic?" Shiri questioned softly, feeling a shiver start to race up her spine. Her brows scrunched as she stared down at her daughter, who looked back up at her with those big, beautiful heterochromia eyes and trilled softly up at her mom. Shiri felt her body start to tense, a tension she had not felt in months since the Runestone of Power had replaced her eye. She had grown used to spacing out as visions danced across her eyes, thankful for not having to stop everything she was doing to endure the seizure-like trances.

This was familiar yet terrifying as she was holding her daughter in her arms and she could feel her arms tense around her child. Amora let out a high-pitched meow, a distress call that instantly alerted the other magicats in the room that something was wrong. Finn grabbed a hold of the baby, pulling her from Shiri's arms quickly as her jaw locked and her body slammed back against the rocking chair. Her hands grabbed hold of the arms of the rocking chair, locking onto them tightly as she was pulled into the vision.

There was fire everywhere. Everything was burning around her. Where was she? She glanced around, taking in her surroundings. The streets and buildings were familiar, cobblestoned roads and greenery everywhere. She faintly heard the remnants of the music that played in the speakers along with the marketplace. Musicia. Musicia was burning.

Why was it burning? She stood slowly, wobbling as people ran past her, screaming. She stumbled towards the direction they were running from. Towards the palace. Her family. Where was her family? Why was there fire coming from the palace?!

She stopped at the bottom stairs of the dais, smoke filling her lungs, the soot stinging her eyes. She could see a large figure through the smoke above her. It towered over everything around

it and her breath hitched as its head slowly revealed itself through the haze.

A large lizard head, blood-red with large fangs and gold slitted eyes that stared down at her. Two large, hold horns twisted behind its skull, its long neck extending out further as some of the smoke cleared to reveal more of its body. It stood on all four legs, large talons gracing each foot, one foot curled up around something. Gold spines up and down its spine and down its long tail and large, thick wings spread out behind it as it roared out, shaking the ground beneath her feet.

Her gaze landed back on its foot, the one wrapped around something and she gasped as it lifted it closer to its head, unwrapping its talons to reveal a person. No… not a person. A magicat. With colorful fur.

"Amora!" *She screamed, lurching up the stairs. This wasn't her small baby, this was a grown Amora in the talons of the beast. She was limp, almost lifeless and the creature had the audacity to look… sad? Remorseful? It let out a low groan, pressing its snout softly against the still magicat as Shiri made her way to the top of the stairs.*

Fire. Fire everywhere and smoke and soot. Everything was burning, even she was burning. Her lungs, her nose, her eyes, everything felt like it was on fire. But she was going to save her baby. She was going to save Amora from this beast… from this hellfire. She felt Bedelia's powers course through her veins as she lifted her hand, fire engulfing it…

And she lurched forward off of the rocking chair, arm raised to strike the closest thing to her. She let out a scream as her fist connected with something solid, flames engulfing her hand and it stumbled back with a groan. She blinked, focusing back on the present as she saw Archer hold onto his chest, standing protectively over Halina who she would have hit if he had not have jumped between them.

She glanced around the room, on high alert from the vision. Her pulse quickened in panic, her breath coming out shallowly. Where was the fire? Where was the beast? Amora? Amora… She whirled around quickly, eyes quickly narrowing in on her daughter who was wailing loudly in her parent's arms. Finn watched her warily as she approached them, tail swishing anxiously behind them as she lifted a shaky arm towards them.

"Hey, slow down, Song," Lexie said, stepping forward to block Shiri from Finn and Amora. Shiri growled at her mom, Lexie took aback by her daughter's reaction before lifting a placating hand. "Hey… It's okay. It's mom… you're going to scare your daughter if you try to take her while you're upset…"

Shiri knew this. Deep down, the logical part of her knew that she was scaring Amora. But her instincts were on high alert, her need to protect her child was in overdrive and everything was a threat to her kitten right now. She took a deep, shaky breath, trying to take away the tension in her body. Every muscle was coiled, ready to spring into action, to fight or flight.

"Can you extinguish your hands first? You're on fire right now…" Lexie reminded her and Shiri lifted her hands, finally realizing that the heat she was still feeling was her summoning Bedelia's powers to protect her kitten. She willed the magic away, trying to calm her racing heart and her instincts. But she could still see the fire… still see the blood-red scales…

"There you go," Lexie coaxed, taking a few hesitant steps forward. Shiri flinched back, baring her teeth like a cornered animal and it made Lexie stop, keeping her hands up to show she wasn't a threat.

"Back up, Lex. You're in between a mama and her kit and it's not going to end well for you," Catra warned her, grabbing Lexie's arm and pulling her out of the way. Shiri relaxed slightly when she could land her eyes on her baby again and she beelined for her family. Finn lets out a small trill as their foreheads bump together

and she can feel Amora relax between them, smelling her mom close to her.

"It's okay. You're okay… Let's sit down, yea?" Finn encouraged, leading her back to the rocking chair and helping her ease back down into the seat. Shiri glances out the window, the view of the city flashing to show it up in flames. She blinked and it was back to the gleaming layout it had been her whole life. She groaned, putting her head in her hands.

"Hellfire…"

"What?" Finn asked, taking their seat back beside her. Catra approached slowly with a glass of water. She looked up, gratefully taking the glass and drinking.

"Is Archer okay? Did I hurt him?" she questioned, peeking around Catra to try to see him.

"He's fine. Adora is healing him up. Just a superficial burn, he'll live."

Shiri nodded, biting her lip worriedly. Zimri came to the other side, kneeling down beside her gently. He was used to her visions, had seen her writhing on the floor from them, and knew this was not a normal vision. The way she was glancing at her daughter showed that it was something much worse.

"What did you see, Song?" he asked, taking her free hand gently. She sighed, squeezing his hand.

"Hellfire… The city was burning… the people were running… and there was a great beast on the dais holding… holding Amora. An older Amora… I think it was a dragon…"

"Dragon? I thought they went extinct after Mara died…" Adora said, brows scrunching in confusion.

"Are you sure it was a dragon, Song?" Lexie asked and Shiri huffed.

"I know what I saw! It was a great beast, a dragon with blood-red scales and gold horns! It was holding Amora in its talons and she wasn't moving! She's in danger!"

"We believe you. No one is saying that you didn't see it. We're just confused because dragons aren't supposed to exist anymore," Zimri reassured her, squeezing her hand again.

"Amora is safe right now and that is all that matters. You said she was older in the vision so if it comes true, then we have years to prepare for it. Also, you said she wasn't moving but that doesn't mean she was dead. Visions change because the future changes," Lexie said softly and Shiri clenched her fists, trying to control her frustration.

"Mama knew her future for years. She knew she was going to die, her future didn't change. Sometimes it doesn't change! Nothing you do changes your fate!"

The room went silent, everyone exchanging uncertain and uneasy looks with each other. Especially Adora and Glimmer, who had known for years about Calliope's fate when she had told them the night before her coronation. Shiri glanced at Finn, giving them a pleading look. They handed Amora off to Shiri, who clutched her daughter to her chest. She could feel her tiny heartbeat against her skin, the softness of her fur tickling her.

"That's enough visitation for today. Mommy and baby are tired," Finn told the group, standing up and kissing Shiri's forehead before escorting their family out of the room. Lexie kissed her daughter's head quietly before heading out, stopping to talk with Finn for a moment.

"Watch out for her. I'm down the hall if you need anything. And also…" she reached into her pants pocket, pulling it back out and placing an object into Finn's hand. Finn opened their hand, revealing the treble clef pendant. Their eyes widened, looking back up at Lexie.

“I can’t-”

“You can. It was always meant to be hers and I see so much love between you two, despite the differences. She needs someone strong to stand by her side through the hardships of motherhood and running a kingdom. You’ll make a great addition to the family,” Lexie concluded, kissing Finn’s cheek softly before leaving.

Catra and Adora both hugged Finn as Nala headbutted Shiri gently with a purr. Shiri smiled at Nala, nuzzling her cheek before the younger magicat hopped back over to her mom's, climbing up Catras back.

“We’ll see you at the presentation?” Adora asked, tilting her head. Finn nodded in confirmation.

“Gotta have all the grandparents there. When she gets more comfortable, we’ll allow more visits, I promise.”

“It’s no rush. I remember how your mama was when she had you and Nala. Maternal instincts are strong but something about magicats is stronger,” Adora told them, smiling down at her wife. Catra rolled her eyes.

“We’ll get those baby cuddles soon enough. Besides, we have a wedding to start planning soon?” Catra asked, raising an eyebrow.

“I’ll let you know when I know, mama,” Finn rolled their eyes. They gave them one last hug before Adora led Catra and Nala out of the room, Finn closing the doors behind them. Their shoulders sagged in relief at the emptiness of the room, starting to stress out from the number of people around the nest.

They turned back towards Shiri, who had lowered the top of her dress to nurse their daughter. Finn’s heart warmed at the sight, stomach fluttering happily. They were the luckiest magicat on Etheria to have such a beautiful woman and child. Their ears twitched as they heard her singing softly to Amora. Finn walked

towards them, watching as Amora needed against Shiri's breast contently, eyes starting to droop.

La La Lu, La La Lu

Oh my little star sweeper

I'll sweep the stardust for you

La La Lu, La La Lu

Little soft fluffy sleeper

Here comes a pink cloud for you

La La Lu, La La Lu

Litter wandering angel

Fold up your wings, close your eyes

La La Lu, La La Lu

And may love be your keeper

La La Lu, La La Lu, La La Lu

"Motherhood looks so beautiful on you, my love," Finn told her, kneeling down in front of the rocking chair to rest their head against her leg. She smiled down at them, removing one hand from her daughter to scratch behind their ears, eliciting a purr.

"I never thought I could love something so much in my entire life… besides you but that's different… this kind of love is so… primal and all-consuming. I would tear down kingdoms and destroy planets for this child."

"Don't get any ideas, supreme overlord Shiri," Finn teased, earning a flick in the ear that caused them to hiss. She giggled at them, causing their heart to leap in their chest. They clutched the

pendant a little tighter before relaxing, placing a gentle kiss on Shiri's knee.

"You know I love you, right?" Finn asked and Shiri rolled her eyes as their daughter finished feeding and she propped her onto her shoulder to burp her.

"And you know I love you. What are you thinking so intently about?"

"Us. Our future. I told you I never want to be apart again. We need time to heal and learn but I want to know that we're in this for the long run," Finn held out their hand, palm open with the pendant sitting in it. "Think of this more as a promise instead of an obligation. We don't have to get married any time soon, we can wait as long as we need. This is just to show that I promise to one day make you my wife when I have completely and fully earned your trust again. It's a promise that I will love you and our daughter unconditionally and that I will always be there for you both, no matter what. It's a promise to stay."

Shiri placed a free hand over the palm, smiling. "Then I take your promise and I give one back. That I will wear it proudly and happily for the rest of our lives together. I will work to be a better person, push past my pain and anger, and learn to trust you again. I promise to be a good wife to you one day and to always be a good mother to our daughter. And to any other children we have. I promise to always stay, no matter how tough it gets, no matter how much I want to crumble and fall apart because I know you will always be there to pick me back up."

Finn leaned up completely to kiss Shiri, cupping her face between their hands. She kissed them back, relishing in the feeling of having them so close again. So completely and fully hers. This was her dream come true.

_

Presentation day was when Musician Royals would present a new prince or princess to the kingdom for them to accept. Shiri remembers Halina and Nicaise's presentation days. The people of Musicia always make the new addition to the kingdom feel welcomed with a song and a show of unity. Nicaise's had been more somber since it had been a week after Calliope's funeral but the citizens had accepted the new prince with open arms, even taking turns to hold the infant so he could feel the vibrations of their singing through his tiny body. It had been a beautiful show of support and love for their family.

Shiri had decided to take a moment to herself in the throne room before they needed to go outside to the dais and face their people. She had not had her official portrait hung up yet, not quite ready to take down the last one her mama had ever had commissioned for their family. That's what Shiri was looking at now: that portrait of her family when it was complete. Well, it wasn't quite complete yet. It was now complete with the addition of her daughter and Finn but was missing her mama.

She placed a hand at the bottom of the frame, looking up at the vibrant blue eyes of her mama, who smiled out into the room. She could feel the tears welling up in her eyes the longer she looked, biting her lip. She wanted to speak with her mama again. She wanted to apologize for everything she had done, have Calliope wrap comforting arms around her again. Was there a Musician Princess who could lend powers like that to her?

Shiri took a deep breath, closing her eyes and concentrating as she reached into the past. Searched for a princess who could help her. Who could give her what she desired? Bedelia, Aria, Sonata then finally…

"Princess Dusana, the Spirit Seer, lend me your powers…" she whispered softly, feeling the familiar sensation of another princess' powers filling her veins. A gentle breeze blew through the room, sending chills up her arms as she whirled around to examine the room. Nothing. It was still an empty room with too many

memories. Sighing sadly, Shiri turned back to the portrait, frowning up at the smiling family above her.

“I just want you to be proud of me. I hope you are proud of me. I know I wasn’t the best daughter. I made mistakes and I lost my way. I was angry, hurt, and confused after you died. It happened so quickly… I didn’t even get to say goodbye. I just wanted to say goodbye…” she clenched her fist, squeezing her eyes shut as tears built. “I miss you, mama.”

Goosebumps pricked her arm as a hand covered her clenched fist, smoothing it back out. She turned back around, gasping at the sight of her mama standing just behind her, smiling happily at her daughter.

“You cannot even imagine how proud I am of you.”

“Mama!” Shiri there her arms around the older woman, who laughed as she embraced her back. Shiri had missed these hugs. The comfort, the safety, the warmth. Mama’s hugs were like no one else's. “I missed you!”

“As I have missed you, my sweet girl. You get more beautiful every time I see you.”

“Do you see me often?”

Calliope nodded, pulling back to put Shiri at arm’s length. “I watch over all of you. Try to talk to you as well. No one seems to listen to me but that was the same when I was alive.”

“I miss your nagging. I would kill to have you nag me about my room or my classes again,” Shiri gave a watery laugh, wiping her eyes.

“Trust me, I do nag you. You just don’t hear me.”

“Can I ask you something…?” Shiri said, sniffling.

“Of course, my song.”

“Do you hate me?”

Calliope’s eyes widened in alarm and confusion. She tilted her head as she examined her daughter's expression, downcast and ashamed.

“Why would I ever hate you, song?”

“For what I did… I wasn’t there when you died. I saw it happen and I tried to get back but you were already gone and I was so… angry. I was so hurt that I wanted others to feel what I was feeling. I hurt your friends, our family. I hurt myself. I tried to run from my responsibility, I drank too much, I partied too much. I put our kingdom and Etheria in danger by being with a man who didn’t love me… I would understand if you hate me…”

“Oh, Song…” Calliope sighed, taking a hold of her daughter’s hand. “I don’t hate you. I could never hate you. Am I disappointed? Of course, because you knew better but we do crazy things when we are hurting. I did things when I was in pain and sometimes we hurt the people we love when we lash out. No, if anything, I am proud of you. Look at where you are, look at where you started. the fact that you’re alive is a miracle. Just stay alive, that would be enough. Your daughter needs you.”

Shiri nodded, squeezing her mama’s hand. “She’s my everything. Is this how you felt when you had kids?”

“The bond between a mother and child is a powerful type of magic. I remember the day you were born. I was… terrified. I had lost a baby during the war and the stress of everything made me sick with you and Zimri. The labor was hard on me and your mom, who refused to leave my side. But then I held you for the first time, you were so tiny and fit so perfectly in my arms… I looked down at your little cherub face and I knew that I would die for you thousand times over.”

“You didn’t have to… why didn’t you tell anyone about the vision?”

“Remember what we said about the future not being set in stone? That is mostly true. Some things, however, are set in stone. Destinies are something that cannot be avoided.”

“Are you telling me that it was your destiny to die so I could take the throne?” Shiri asked incredulously.

“I’m saying that in order for you to live, I had to die. When you see your child's face, you see your own mortality there. You know that there will come a day where you will never see them again. Does that make sense?”

Shiri nodded again. “I never would have become the queen I am today if it wasn’t for the hardship of losing you. I needed to experience loss, pain, and anger in order to come to terms with my place in our destiny.”

“Now you’re getting it. When did you become so wise?” Calliope smiled teasingly.

“I learned from the best,” Shiri smiled back.

“Shiri? It’s almost time for the presentation, you need to go find Finn-” Lexie stopped as she entered the room, staring at the two in front of her. Nicaise was propped up on her hip, making soft babbling noises.

Calliope turned to face her wife, giving her a sheepish smile. “Hey, love…”

“How…” Lexie was speechless as she took a hesitant step forward. Nicaise frowned at his mom’s change in behavior, patting her arm to get her attention.

“Princess Dusana was a Spirit Seer…” Shiri explained, stepping forward to take Nicaise from her mom. Lexie allowed Shiri to take her son, arms falling limply to her side as she continued to stare at Calliope, who was squirming uncomfortably.

“I know what you’re thinking… and how could I have told you? How could I have worried you like that? You would have spent years trying to keep me alive! What kind of life would that have been for our family if we had to fear for my safety constantly? You would have insisted on us never having children but I wanted them and so did you! I don’t have any regrets about what I did! I kept it a secret to keep our family together and whole. W-what are you doing?” Calliope asked as Lexie kept taking steps towards her as she talked until she was toe to toe with her wife. She hesitated before cupping Calliope’s cheeks between her hands, forcing the shorter woman to look up at her and stop her rambling. Calliope’s breath hitched as she stared up at the dark brown eyes she had loved her entire life and death.

“You are as beautiful as the day I lost you,” Lexie whispered softly. Calliope choked back a sob, leaning up to pull her wife into a searing kiss. Lexie wrapped her arms around her wife’s small frame, pulling her impossibly close, trying to make up for the years already spent apart. When they finally pulled their lips away from each other, they pressed their foreheads against the others, staring into each other’s eyes.

“I miss you, Callie,” Lexie told her, nuzzling her nose against hers.

“I miss you too, Lex… so much…”

“What did you mean… about giving me more time?”

Calliope smiled, pulling away slightly to look at her better. “You still have so much left to do. I know your heart, Lexie. You have a heart for people, for helping them and loving them. It’s how you were able to love me and rebuild our kingdom. It’s why you were able to open an orphanage. There is so much left to be done. So many people to help, so many children to raise… I only wanted one thing when I died and that was for you to have more time to tell our story.”

“You have my word, my love. I will spend the rest of my life making sure they hear your story.”

"And yours. I want them to hear our story. The story of the lost princess and the Horde soldier who helped save Etheria and rebuilt a kingdom. And fell in love along the way," Calliope smiled sadly, pulling away from Lexie completely.

"Please… please don't go yet…" Lexie begged, grabbing a hold of Calliope's hands. "I don't want to do this without you. It should be you telling our story, not me."

Calliope looked at her wife, tears streaming down her face before looking up at her eldest daughter and youngest son standing off to the side, watching the scene unfold. Nicaise smiled happily, waving his chubby hand at the woman who birthed him but was unable to raise him.

"He's so beautiful… who better to tell him our story than his mom? He will grow up knowing that I am gone, but we love so strong that it did not die when I did. It only grew and that he is a product of that true love. All of them are. Lex… you are so strong. I would not have been able to continue if you had died first…"

"You would have sobbed yourself into an oblivion…" Lexie chuckled sadly. "I can't wait to see you again…"

"It's only a matter of time," Calliope told her, giving her one final kiss before disappearing completely. Lexie stood in the middle of the room, hands still outstretched as if she were holding onto her wife's hands, staring out at the place Calliope disappeared.

After a while, Shiri placed a hand against Lexie's shoulder, drawing her attention back to the present. "Mom? Are you okay?"

" I just… I miss her so much… thank you, Song, for letting me see her one last time," Lexie smiled sadly at her daughter, placing her hand over the others.

"You know you can see her anytime you want. I can summon her for you."

Lexie shakes her head quickly. “She wouldn’t want that… she wouldn’t want us living in the past. She would want us to move forward. As she said, there’s still so much to be done and our story to be told.”

Lexie took a deep breath before straightening up, looking around the room. “You hear that, Callie? I will tell our story! I will tell all our stories! And I will start with you, my love,” Lexie cooed, easing Nicaise off of Shiri’s hip. “You can’t hear my stories but I will make sure you know them. You will know who your mama was, I promise.”

–

Finn and Shiri stood at the top of the stairs above the dais, awaiting their signal to descend to the people below. Shiri wore a simple sundress in navy blue, Musicia’s traditional coloring, with her crown sat on top of her curls, which hung past her lower back loosely. Finn had an arm wrapped around her waist, dressed in white slacks and a buttoned-up gold shirt with the top few buttons undone, the traditional colors of She-Ra.

Shiri held Amora close to her chest, the infant magicat mewling at the new sensations around her. The new smells, sights, and sounds would be almost overwhelming to her if she had not been grounded by her mother’s calming scent. Finn used their free hand to scritch behind one of the baby’s ears, earning a happy purr in response.

“Are you sure you’re okay, love? The experience you had with your moms sounded… intense…”

“I’m fine. I’m… better than fine actually. I really needed to talk to her, I needed to know her thoughts about me… even after everything I did, she still loved me. That is more than I could ever ask for. I stand here today, proud to be her daughter.”

“She was lucky to have you as a daughter and our daughter is lucky to have you as a mom,” Finn said, hearing the signal for

them to start descending. Finn kept a hold of her waist as they headed down towards the dais. “May you be every bit the woman she was and may Amora be every bit the woman you are.”

“May she share your mind, my love. I hope she is every bit as quick-witted and intelligent as her pibling.”

They stopped at the edge of the dais that descended into more stairs, the citizens had gathered along the bottom of the stairs with the council members and colony representatives scattered around the stairs. Shiri spotted Haevyn and Circe standing off to one side as the representatives of Plumeria with Eira close by with baby Bylur in her arms, the representative of Snows. The other royal families were scattered around in the crowd. It was a tradition that the Musician citizens were the closest to the royal family and the new baby. On the dais with them were Finn’s moms, Catra and Adora as well as Nala along with Shiri’s mom, Lexie who held Nicaise, Zimri, Marmoris, and Halina.

Shiri stepped forward away from Finn as a hush fell over the crowd, all eyes turning to give attention to the young queen. “People of Musicia! Today is a joyous day for I present your newest princess, Amora, granddaughter of She-Ra and the first-ever Musician magicat princess!”

The crowd cheered and whistled, chanting “Long Live Princess Amora! Long Live She-Ra!”

Shiri looked down at her daughter, whose lip started to tremble and tears spring up in her eyes as the overwhelming amount of people and noise around her. As the cheering died down, a soft harmony picked up amongst the citizens, everyone vocalizing together as the representatives stepped forward. Shiri looked over her shoulder to motion to Finn to stop forward. They did, standing by her side again as Haevyn and Circe came up first, Haevyn placing a hand on Shiri’s shoulder and one on Amora while Circe placed a hand on Finn’s shoulder. Both were vocalizing with the crowd as, one by one, everyone placed their hands on the person

in front of them’s shoulders, creating a web of people down the stairs and street, ultimately being connected with the royal family.

Shiri smiled at Haevyn who smiled back and could feel the presence of their family behind them, their hands touching them to connect their family together. Shiri felt the first words of the song spring forward from her lips as she gazed down at her fussy child, small whimpers escaping her lips.

Baby mine, don’t you cry

Baby mine, dry your eyes

Rest your head close to my heart

Never to part, baby of mine

Finn leaned over and used their free hand to wipe the tears off of their daughter's cheeks, the baby gazing up memorized at their mother’s song before Finn continued it.

Little one when you play

Don’t you mind what they say

Let those eyes sparkle and shine

Never a tear, baby of mine

The crowd picked up the song, a soft glow starting to emit from everyone’s hands as they sang to the new princess, welcoming her to their city.

If they knew sweet little you

They’d end up loving you too

All those same people who scold you

What they’d give just for

The right to hold you

Shiri smiled as her daughter relaxed completely in her arms, curling up tighter against her breast and even letting out a content purr as she finished the song for her.

From your head to your toes

You're not much, goodness knows

You are so precious to me

Sweet as can be, baby of mine

The glow died away as the song came to an end and the citizens released one another, letting out another cheer as the head councilwoman stepped forward and everyone else stepped back onto the stairs.

"My Queen, what a blessing it is to see your smiling face amongst us once again along with the newest addition to your family. May Princess Amora grow in beauty and grace, may her heart always be pure and true, may she always find love in her life and a song in her soul! Each colony's representative would like to bestow a blessing upon your child if you would accept?"

"We accept any blessings for our child, councilwoman, and thank each representative in advance for their love and support for their princess," Shiri informed the crowd as Eira stepped forward first, placing a gentle hand upon Amora's back. Her hand glowed a soft blue color as she smiled at her niece and great-niece.

"From the Kingdom of Snows, may she always find fun and adventure in the dreariest of storms."

The light grew a little brighter as the blessing settled upon Amora and Eira stepped back, allowing Haevyn to step forward and repeat the process.

“From the Kingdom of Plumeria, may she always find the beauty in those around her.”

“From the Kingdom of Scorpion, may she always find strength at her weakest point.”

“From the Kingdom of Salineas, may she always find happiness in the unlikeliest of places.”

“From the Kingdom of Brightmoon, may she always find the light in the darkness.”

Finally, Lexie stepped forward into their line of sight, smiling down at her granddaughter as she placed a gentle hand upon the sleeping infant's back.

“And from the Kingdom of Musicia, may she always find a song in heart to guide her.”

Lexie stepped away as the light died away, the crowd cheering once again for the blessings placed upon their new princess. The councilwoman stepped forward, announcing continued celebrations in the city for the week but Shiri paid no mind to them. She watched her sleeping daughter as she leaned against her mate and future spouse, basking in the happiness of those around her.

While her heart ached for the future she had seen and for the past that had been taken from them, she was elated knowing that she had the unconditional love and support of her family around her. She didn’t have to be a visionary to know the beautiful future her daughter would lead.

“Stop thinking so hard, love. You’ll get wrinkles before you’re thirty,” Finn teased quietly into her ear, earning a soft smile back from their mate.

“I was just thinking of the future. Of her future. How blessed is she to be surrounded by so much love?”

“You picked an appropriate name for her then, Shiri. She will only ever know love and happiness as will we. I don’t need to have visions to know that.”

“May the love around her be the softest place she falls and the wildest thing she runs to.”

Chapter End Notes

PHEWW!! Guys... we did it! What a journey this has been!

When I started writing The Power in You in January, I did not plan to write a sequel until halfway through that fic. While I love the She-Ra universe, I knew I would not be content using previously created characters in the content I was looking to create.
Thus! The birth of our characters was born! I have absolutely loved writing in-universe, expanding the legend and lore, and intertwining your beloved characters from the show with my own creations.

For everyone who has kudos and commented and just kept me encouraged, thank you from the bottom of my heart! It really helped boost my morale.
Would you believe this final chapter is 22 pages long? I had to keep rewriting it to make sure it was perfect!

Now, I'm sure you're all wondering... is there going to be a third installment for Amora?
Well...
Nothing has been started but an outline is in the works for a third installment! Please keep an eye out for this when I do start writing it! It will be named *drumroll*

AMORA AND THE LAST DRAGON! EEEEEKKK!!!

Please! Go check out my other fics: The Power in You and The Power in You: One-Shots (which I will still be updating) and keep an eye out for collab work I am currently a part of!

Song Creds: La La Lu by Kiersey Clemons and Baby Mine cover from Voctave

As always! KUDOS and COMMENT! The more I get, the faster I'll type out a third book ;)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!